By Bronze and Balance

The Ash and the Porphyry · Book One

The Ash and the Porphyry

I. By Bronze and Balance (AD 156–161)
II. Two Suns in the West (AD 161–166)
III. The Auction of Trajan (AD 166–171)

The Ash and the Porphyry · I

By Bronze and Balance

A Novel of Antonine Rome

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Rome · Anno Domini CLVI–CLXI

By Bronze and Balance opens on the Ides of October in the nineteenth year of the Emperor Titus Aelius Hadrianus Antoninus Augustus Pius (AD 156) and closes in the spring of AD 161.

Sums of money are reckoned in Roman *quadrantes*, copper *asses*, brass *sestertii* (four *asses*), silver *denarii* (four *sestertii*), and gold *aurei* (one hundred *sestertii*). A day-laborer in the clay-yards earns three to four *sestertii* a day; entry to the equestrian order requires a census of four hundred thousand; a seat in the Senate, one million.

Set in EB Garamond on Royal Octavo pages.

"Mancipatio is an imaginary sale, and is a right peculiar to Roman citizens. It is performed thus: in the presence of not fewer than five Roman citizens of full age as witnesses, and another of the same condition who holds a balance of bronze and is called the scale-holder, the taker holds the thing and says: I affirm that this man is mine by Quiritary right, and let him be bought to me with this bronze and this bronze balance *and then he strikes the balance with the bronze..."*

— Gaius, *Institutes*, I.119

"Since there is no room in Rome for honest trades, nor any profit in sweat, let us leave our father's country while grey hair is new..."

— Juvenal, *Satires*, III

Persons at the Opening of the Chronicle

October, AD 156

At the Tiber Clay-Yards (*Figlinae Subortanae*)

Lucius Cassius Corvus, aged fifteen, freeborn Roman citizen (*ingenuus*) of the Crustumina tribe, son of a dead Sabine land-surveyor.
Lucida, aged fifteen, a Junian Latin (*Latina Iuniana*), daughter of a deceased Tyrian freedwoman dyer.
Gaius Ummidius Scaeva, a former Praetorian soldier; chief bailiff and rent-enforcer.

In the Subura, Argiletum, and Trans-Tiberim

Berenice (called *Beroe*), a Syrian cosmetic-chemist and midwife above the Argiletum fulleries.
Habinnas Barba, a Cappadocian freedman and master-baker (*pistor*).
Sura, a mute Gallic stable and oven girl.

On the Caelian Hill, the Courts, and the Markets

Publius Vedius Pollio, an equestrian financier, landlord, and syndicate contractor.
Quintus Servilius Priscus, a patrician consular senator.
Phileros, chief Greek archive-freedman (*tabularius*) in the household of Priscus.
Aulus Volusenus Niger, nephew to Priscus; a young patrician student of advocacy.
Tullia Crispina, a wealthy equestrian widow with shipping interests at Ostia.
Marcus Cornelius Fronto, consular senator from Cirta and Rome's foremost master of Latin rhetoric.
Quintus Junius Rusticus, Stoic philosopher and senator.

The Imperial House

Titus Aelius Hadrianus Antoninus Augustus Pius, Emperor of Rome, aged seventy.
Marcus Aurelius Caesar, his nephew, son-in-law, and working colleague, aged thirty-five.
Annia Galeria Faustina (*Faustina the Younger*), daughter of Antoninus and wife to Marcus Caesar.
Lucius Ceionius Commodus, younger adoptive son of Antoninus Pius, aged twenty-five.
Ceionia Fabia, elder sister to Lucius Commodus.

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PART ONE

The Blood of the Right-Hand Horse

October, AD 156 – March, AD 157

Chapter I

Ex Praediis

Ides of October, AD 156 · Corvus

Before the sun cleared the Sabine ridges, the river smelled of wet ash and dead lime.

Corvus crouched ankle-deep in the blue-grey trench at the lower edge of the clay-pit, four fingers of his left hand hooked around the cold brass plumb-bob in his tunic pocket, his right hand holding an iron kiln-rake steady across his knee. Above the reed-bank, mist hung thick enough to hide the ox-path from the drying sheds, though sound carried through river-damp as if across a cistern: the knock of a wooden trace-bar against an axle, the wheeze of a blown mule, and the flat iron cough of Gaius Ummidius Scaeva clearing phlegm into the sedge.

"Count the sheds first," Scaeva said up on the bank. His voice had the gravel of twenty years in the Praetorian cohorts before Publius Vedius Pollio bought his discharge and gave him a vine-stick tipped with four ounces of lead. "Do not fire the thatch until the tallies come out of the hut. The old bitch's executors want every stamped bipedalis accounted for before the auction on the Kalends, and I am not paying four sesterces a brick out of my own purse because you clumsy bastards burned the pine racks."

Beside Corvus under the overhang of cut clay, Lucida did not shiver, though her wool shift was soaked black to mid-calf and the October mud had hardened grey between her toes. She had their oilskin bag strapped flat against her ribs beneath an old fuller's cloak two sizes too broad in the shoulder. Her jaw was set slightly forward, her dark eyes fixed on the gap in the osiers where the towpath bent toward the Milvian Bridge. Under her left collarbone, hidden beneath coarse undyed wool, sat the dark mark shaped like an olive-pip; on her fingers, even in half-light, the nail-beds

showed purple-brown from the walnut-hull and alkanet dye she had boiled two nights ago for the barge-men's woollens.

She touched two fingers to Corvus's wrist: once for the man coming down the plank-walk, twice for the dog behind him. Not a word. When you had lived since seven years old within stone's throw of the kilns, speech near strangers was coin thrown into the Tiber.

Corvus shifted his heel half a Roman foot backward until his sole found the buried oak sleeper he had laid there in July when his father's grave-mound settled. Five feet from the sleeper to the pug-mill trough; eleven feet from the trough to the mouth of Number Three kiln, where they had banked brushwood and olive-pomace at the third watch so the residual heat would keep the green tiles from cracking in the frost. His father used to beat that habit into his knuckles with a boxwood measuring-rod whenever the wine turned sour in him: *Never enter a yard without knowing its paces, Lucius; a man who guesses distances dies poor or dies indoors.* Gaius Cassius Corvus had known the exact width of every ditch between Crustumerium and the third milestone, and still died face-down under forty cartloads of slumped winter marl owing three thousand two hundred sesterces on a waxed tablet, so the maxim had holes in it. The pacing stayed.

"Corvus's boy!" someone shouted up by the drying-racks. That was Rufus, the cross-eyed tally-clerk who had come upriver from the Emporium last month when the bailiffs changed. "Ho, Sabine! Bring out the wooden press-frame and the new consular dies! Scaeva says if the girl's inside, fetch her out by the braid!"

Nobody answered from the hut, because the hut had held nothing since moonset except an overturned stool, three cracked cooking-pots, and half a bladder of rancid lard rubbed across the threshold to turn the mastiff's nose.

Up on the bank the dog snuffled at the grease, whined once, and fell to licking the sill. A boot landed in its ribs. Through a rent in the fog Corvus saw orange pitch-light flare against wet reed-thatch: one of Scaeva's three hired river-men—the broad-bellied Syrian called Mousa who worked the Sandapila wharf when debts were slow—stooping with a sulfur-spill at a clay lamp to light a tarred twist of hemp.

"Empty," Mousa called back. "Straw's cold. The little cunt's bolted."

"Look behind the tile-stacks," Scaeva answered. "A Junian Latin without travel-seal doesn't sprout feathers between dusk and cockcrow, and

Vedius paid thirty gold pieces for the old dyer's reversionary chest. Find her, and leave her teeth in—she can still work an alum-vat."

Lucida's breath did not quicken against Corvus's shoulder; instead she reached into her girdle, drew out the curved neck-shard of a broken Spanish oil-amphora whose fracture she had honed the day before on sandstone until its edge could shave bristle off pork rind, and laid her thumb along the unglazed clay spine.

Corvus caught her elbow—not to stop her, only to angle them two paces left where the kiln flue breathed warm wood-gas across the trench and killed human scent. Inside the oilskin bag against her ribs lay four things worth both their lives and three men's necks besides: his own cedar birth-diptych (*tabula professionis*) proving Lucius Cassius Corvus, son of Gaius, of the Crustumina tribe, born free under the consulship of Titus Hoenius Severus and Marcus Peducaeus Stloga; a split terracotta master-impression from these very yards (*OPUS DOLIARE EX PRAEDIIS DOMITIAE LUCILLAE*); six waxed pine leaves recording four thousand roof-tiles and two-foot *bipedales* stamped three months ahead with next year's false workshop numbers; and the heavy round bronze *signaculum* die itself, cold as river-iron, stolen off Rufus's counting-table an hour before dawn while Rufus snored with his mouth open in sour Sabine wine.

Domitia Lucilla—mother to Marcus Aurelius Caesar, richest brick-mistress on the Tiber—had died before the spring floods dropped. For six months since, every sub-contractor, lease-farmer, and senatorial jackal along twelve miles of river clay had been tearing strips off the estate before the new trustees finished counting kilns. Scaeva's master Vedius Pollio had leased this strip through a straw-man, double-stamped imperial brick-loads for private Subura building sites, and meant this morning to burn the shacks, blame the dead surveyor's arrears for the missing tallies, and cart Lucida into Rome under an inherited patronal claim before anyone asked why dead men's kilns were still smoking.

Planks groaned overhead.

Mousa came down the slick timber gangway into the pit alone, holding the pitch-torch high in his left hand so sparks spat into the puddles, an ash-wood cudgel balanced in his right. He wore heavy hobnailed *caligae* laced halfway up scarred shins, no cloak, a leather apron stiff with dried river-silt.

At the foot of the plank he paused, squinting past the pug-mill where an iron chain hung from the capstan beam.

"Boy?" Mousa said, almost friendly, dropping into dockside Greek—the flat Antioch vowels Lucida's mother had used when bargaining over madder root. "Come out if you're under the shed. Scaeva's only hot about the bronze die. Give back the die and the girl, and he knocks fifty sesterces off your old man's bond. Where are you going to run in October without shoes? Rome? Rome eats country puppies before the third hour."

Corvus looked at Mousa's knees. When a heavy man stepped off wet pine onto greased blue brick-clay, his weight went onto his back heel to keep his hobnails from skating.

Corvus let Mousa take two steps past the capstan. Then he hooked the iron kiln-rake low—not at the skull, which made a noise and glanced off bone, but flat behind Mousa's right ankle—and hauled backward with both shoulders braced against the trench wall.

Mousa's heels flew toward the fog. He hit the clay on his tailbone with a wet *whuff* that drove the Greek back down his gullet, the pitch-torch spinning sideways into the puddle where it hissed black without quite dying. Before Mousa could roll onto an elbow and roar, Corvus was up out of the cut, swinging the five-foot surveyor's iron measuring-link he had coiled under the rake-head, bringing the knotted brass ten-foot ring down across the bridge of Mousa's nose and mouth. Cartilage crunched like a trodden snail. Blood jumped black in the dying red sputter of pitch. Mousa grabbed blindly for Corvus's ankle, fingers astonishingly strong, hooking wool and skin together; Lucida stepped in from the left without a sound, drove the pointed heel of her amphora shard straight through the meat of Mousa's forearm between radius and ulna, twisted once until his fingers sprang open, and snatched up his dropped cudgel before the groan cleared his split teeth.

Up on the bank the mastiff barked—twice, ragged, furious.

"Mousa!" Scaeva's voice snapped sharp from the drying-sheds forty paces uphill. Boots thudded on packed turf. "Tiberius! Down the ditch—someone's by Number Three!"

"Go," Corvus breathed—not even breath, just lip against Lucida's cold ear.

They did not run up the bank where three men with vine-sticks held high ground. They went straight through the low brick arch of Number

Three kiln's stoke-alley, ducking under the scorching sandstone lintel where banked olive-pressings glowed dull cherry behind loose firebricks. Corvus planted the heel of his iron rake against the dry key-brick holding the draught-damper, leaned all seven and a half stone of his starved fifteen-year-old frame into it, and popped the plug.

A lungful of white ash, choked carbon smoke, and dry olive-char belched backward out of the firebox straight into the trench mouth just as the mastiff bounded down the gangway ahead of the second bailiff. The dog hit the drifting ash-cloud and burst into frantic sneezing yelps; behind it Tiberius cursed by Hercules and shielded his eyes from stinging hot cinders.

By then Corvus and Lucida were out the leeward ash-vent, sliding belly-flat down the willow-root embankment to the Tiber's edge where an empty flat-bottomed reed-skiff—used by turf-cutters to mend fish-weirs—lay tethered by a rotten rushes-rope to an alder stump.

Lucida sliced the rush-knot with the bloody amphora shard before Corvus had both knees inside. He shoved off with the ash cudgel against gravel. Current took the stern immediately: autumn water swollen brown from three days' rain up in Umbria, carrying willow leaves, bloated sheep-gut from the upstream slaughter-yards, and rafts of yellow foam.

Fifty yards behind them on the bank, Scaeva burst out of the willow scrub, cloak thrown back, the stump of his missing left ear white with chill against his purpled cheek. He did not waste breath screaming threats; he dropped to one knee at the water's margin, squinted through thinning mist until he fixed Corvus's face and Lucida's dark braid clearly in memory, and raised two fingers to his own throat—a soldier's tally-mark, neat as chalk on a board.

Corvus dug the cudgel into the brown eddy to keep the bow pointed mid-stream toward the six stone arches of the Milvian Bridge looming out of the fog ahead.

Lucida sat cross-legged in the wet bilge opposite him, wiping Mousa's blood off her knuckles onto reed-straw, then checking the oilskin pouch under her shift. Her chest rose and fell fast, ribs visible at the open V of her coarse neck-hem, breath smoking white. For ten heartbeats she studied the smear of blood on Corvus's shin where Mousa's nails had torn him, then looked up into his face.

"You hit him with your father's ten-foot chain," she said in low Latin. "If you bent the brass ring, you'll cry about it until December."

Corvus checked the brass ring with his scarred right thumb. It had a fresh dent and one grey hair stuck in dark grease. "Ring's straight," he said. "His nose wasn't."

A sudden, fierce grin split Lucida's mouth—brief as flint-spark, gone before the shadow of the Milvian Bridge swallowed them in cold travertine gloom and spat them out on the Romeward side, where the Via Flaminia ran straight as a spear-shaft between painted marble tombs toward the smoke of a million cooking-fires.

* * *

They ditched the reed-skiff half a mile above the customs boom at the Navalia, because river-watchmen asked questions of barefoot fifteen-year-olds in unbranded boats, whereas nobody at a land-gate looked twice at two dirty country brats walking behind an Umbrian turnip-wagon on a holiday morning.

Or almost nobody.

Three hundred paces outside the Porta Flaminia, where the double file of senatorial tombs narrowed between dusty cypress hedges and roadside wine-booths, the tax-farmers of the *ansarium* market-toll had stretched a painted pine pole across half the paving stones. For three sesterces—one worn brass piece and two scarred dupondii unpicked from Lucida's hem with her thumbnail—an old freedman carter with a goiter swelling like a winter gourd under his chin had let them sling his spare willow turnip-baskets over their shoulders and walk beside his mud-caked ox-yoke.

"Keep your chins in the greens and let me do the cursing," the old carter muttered out of the side of his mouth as the queue inched toward the toll-table. His breath smelled of raw leek and rotten molars. "If the publican's clerk pokes the straw with his iron spit, don't flinch. Last month they found six bladders of untaxed Campanian perfume stuffed inside a dead sow's belly, and now every gate-bastard thinks he's Praetorian Prefect."

At the pine barrier sat a fat freedman *vilicus* under a striped awning, an abacus of grooved bronze across his knees, while two scarred Illyrian assistants in leather aprons thrust three-foot iron probing-rods deep into hay-

loads, oil-panniers, and wool-bales to make sure no silk, spice, or unrecorded slave-child entered Caesar's customs boundary gratis.

The nearer Illyrian stepped up to the goitered carter's oxen, spat betel-brown wine-lees onto the basalt flags, and rammed his iron rod twice through the heaped purple-top turnips. The tip grated against oak floor-boards. Then his pale eyes slid down to Corvus's torn shin—caked black now with river-silt over Mousa's nail-furrows—and across to Lucida, whose coarse fuller's cloak hung crooked over the flat bulge of the oilskin bag.

"Two asses on the roots, grandfather," the Illyrian said, resting the cold iron spit horizontally across Corvus's collarbone so he could not step past the ox-rump. "And what are these two? Untaxed field-stock going down to the Saepta dealers? Young Syrian bitch like that fetches sixteen hundred sesterces clean on the block if her teeth meet."

Corvus felt the blood drop out of his ears. If the clerk made them strip the fuller's cloak at the toll-table and found a thirty-pound bronze imperial brick-die stamped with Domitia Lucilla's dead name inside a runaway Junian Latin's shift, they would never even see the inside of the city wall; they would sit in ankle-irons in the Flaminian guardhouse before Scaeva finished his morning wine.

Before Corvus could reach for his citizen birth-tablet—which would only make a gate-clerk ask why a Crustumina citizen boy was hauling turnips barefoot beside an unsealed girl—Lucida shifted her basket off her hip, planted it straight down on the Illyrian's booted instep hard enough to make him grunt, and let go a burst of foul, singsong Sabine country-Latin thick enough to curdle goat's milk.

"Sixteen hundred sesterces? Tell him to pay you half on the nail, Lucius, and I'll ride into Rome in a cushioned litter instead of carrying this old skinflint's wormy turnips since the second watch!" She yanked down the collar of her rough shift half a thumb's breadth—not toward the oilskin bag, higher, showing the ugly purple-brown alkanet dye-stain smeared deliberately up her throat and ear-lobe like the weeping crust of fuller's scrofula—and coughed wetly toward the Illyrian's chin. "Go on, touch it, handsome! The fuller at Prima Porta docked my brother four asses yesterday because my neck-sores dripped into his white wool, and now the toll-man wants to marry me!"

The Illyrian snatched his iron probing-rod back as if her collar held scorpions, wiping the back of his hand across his mouth. Even the fat *vilicus* behind the bronze abacus waved two fingers in disgust without looking up from his wax roll.

"Two asses on the cart, take your rotten turnips and your scrofulous brats out of the road before you block Senator Bradua's outriders!" the *vilicus* barked. "Move the pole!"

The goitered carter flicked two copper asses into the wooden dish, cracked his goad over the near ox's horn, and rumbled through the stone arch of the Porta Flaminia. Twenty paces inside the gate, where the shadow of the old tufa wall gave way to roaring sun, the old man glanced sideways at Lucida's neck—where the purple-brown smear had already dried harmlessly into walnut-and-alkanet stain—and gave a wheezing, phlegm-thick chuckle deep in his gourd-throat.

"Scrofula," the carter said. "By Pollux. Girl, don't waste yourself on turnips. Buy a booth in the Vicus Tuscus; you'll own the street before your wisdom teeth come through."

"Keep the three sesterces, grandfather," Corvus told him, lifting both willow baskets back onto the tailboard as the wagon slowed behind a line of marble-sledges. "And if a one-eared man in a brown cloak asks at the gate-stalls whether you carried two passengers from the bridge, tell him we got off at the crossroads toward Tibur."

The old man squinted once at Corvus's bruised knuckles, once at the dent on the surveyor's brass ring peeping from Corvus's belt, and nodded without asking names. In Rome, curiosity was an expensive hobby for men with goiters.

It was past the fourth hour now. Sun had burned every shred of mist off the river-meadows, turning the sky over the Pincian gardens a hard, enameled blue that made every gilded bronze roof-ornament on the hills stab the eyes.

Corvus had seen Rome twice before from three miles off: a brown smudge of tile-smoke and white temple pediments beyond the river bends, never from inside its skin. Nothing his dead father had ever muttered over wine prepared a boy's ears for the noise.

Even with heavy freight wagons barred since sunrise, the Flaminian Way inside the tombs roared like a weir in flood. Thousands upon thousands of

feet moved inward toward the Campus Martius: fullers in chalk-stiff tunics stinking of stale piss, Syrian litter-bearers in scarlet headbands trotting eight abreast with cedar poles grooved deep into calloused collarbones, country *ingenui* down from Tibur in scratchy holiday wool, painted boy-prostitutes from the Vicus Tuscus shading depilated cheeks with green parasols, scarred veterans of Antoninus's Mauretanian levies spitting olive-stones at stray dogs, amulet-sellers rattling bronze phalluses on leather strings for luck at the races.

And around all of it, framing the surging grease and wool and garlic-breath of the crowd, stood stone on a scale that made Corvus's surveyor's eye ache behind his brow. Porticoes a quarter-mile long rested on columns cut whole from single trunks of grey Egyptian granite and blood-streaked Phrygian marble; giant travertine water-arches strode overhead on seventy-foot piers, sweating green moss at the mortar joints while whole rivers ran captive above men's hats; bronze four-horse chariots crowned triumphal arches nobody underneath even glanced up to read; and rising to their left on its turf mound beside the river stood the great cylindrical tomb of Augustus choked in dark cypresses, while downstream across the water gleamed the newer, bigger drum Hadrian had built for himself and the Antonines, bristling with marble statues white as peeled bone.

"Shut your mouth, Sabine," Lucida murmured at his shoulder as they slipped under a portico hung with faded red awnings, "or a pickpocket will drop three dice down your gullet and charge you rent."

Yet her own eyes were wide, darting not at the pediments—she cared nothing for dead emperors' roofs—but at the women's hems, the gold hair-nets glinting inside open litters, the fat sausages hissing in lard over portable iron braziers, the money-changers' folding tables where bright silver *denarii* with old Antoninus's laurelled nose stacked twenty high beside little brass balance-scales. Corvus watched her take the measure of a silk-sleeved freed-woman buying roasted thrushes for four asses apiece without blinking; he could almost hear the iron abacus clicking behind Lucida's forehead. *Four asses for three mouthfuls of bird-bone. Two hundred thrushes make a winter coat.*

Press of shoulders carried them out from beneath the colonnade onto the open turf edge of the **Campus Martius**, north of the Trigarium horse-

grounds, where eighty thousand people had wedged themselves forty deep along low pine barriers.

Corvus pulled Lucida up onto the stepped plinth of an old Republican boundary-altar warm in the midday sun so they would not go under the heels.

"Ides of October," a gap-toothed cobbler standing beside them said cheerfully, chewing roasted lupin-beans out of his tunic fold and spitting the skins onto the travertine. "First time in the City, country mice? Watch the right-hand trace-horse on the inner turn. My brother-in-law put eight sesterces on Polydamas's bays out of the Subura ward-purse. If the bay takes the outer rein and wins, we eat pork-udder tonight and nail the bastard's head above the Mamilian Tower before lamp-light!"

Out on the packed sand and turf course—no marble spina here like the Circus Maximus south of the Palatine, only ancient oak posts bound in bronze and a brick altar smoking with pine-resin and salt meal to Mars—four two-horse *bigae* stood trembling behind a stretched white chalked rope. Even at a hundred and twenty paces Corvus smelled horse-lather, crushed wormwood rubbed on wheel-hubs, and raw panic. The drivers wore short belted tunics dyed rust-red and leek-green, leather helmets strapped tight under their chins, curved knives tucked at their ribs to slice the body-reins if an axle splintered and dragged them.

A magistrate in a purple-bordered *toga praetexta* dropped a white linen *mappa*.

The rope snapped flat. Four pairs of chests lunged into leather collars at once; sand fountained backward in stinging arcs; eighty thousand throats let go a single tearing roar that vibrated inside Corvus's empty stomach.

Around the far post they went in brown dust, wheels hub-to-hub with three fingers of air between spinning iron tires. On the first turn an outside chestnut stumbled, slewed sideways, and took the trailing chariot-box across its hocks: wood cracked like dry pine in a kiln, a horse screamed high as a scalded girl, and the driver cut himself loose just in time to roll twice into the sand with his shoulder laid open to the red muscle while the remaining three *bigae* thundered past his heels without checking stride.

Lucida gripped the back of Corvus's tunic with one fist, leaning forward on bare toes, chin raised, lips parted. Not squeamish; she had watched oxen butchered since she could walk. What held her transfixed was the crowd on

the wooden benches opposite—men in narrow purple equestrian stripes and spotless white *togae* leaning over the rail beside scarred butchers and pimps, all howling the same filthy camp-Latin at the bay pair surging half a length clear on the final straight, the right-hand trace-horse stretching its dark wet neck, nostrils flared crimson, foam flying off its iron bit as it carried the left-hand yoke-mate home across the chalk line.

The crowd's roar changed pitch, from gambling frenzy to something older, thicker, half-drunk on sun and iron.

Attendants of the *flamen Martialis* ran out in tucked-up white wool kilts before the winning bay had even stopped heaving. Nobody garlanded it with roses to lead it back to oats. Two bull-necked *victimarii* naked to the waist caught its bridle-rings on either side of the smoking turf altar; a priest sprinkled salted *mola salsa* grit and sour wine between its twitching ears while the horse rolled white-rimmed eyes at the smell of old blood in the grass; a third man stepped in from the flank with an archaic leaf-bladed spear—Mars's spear—and drove two feet of iron straight behind the bay's shoulder into the great vessels above its heart.

The horse dropped to its foreknees with a sound halfway between a cough and a trumpet-blast, shuddered along its glistening ribs, and rolled onto its side in the sand. Before its hind hoof stopped kicking, a butcher's cleaver flashed once at the croup: the dripping tail was hacked free at the root and handed straight to a waiting relay of fleet-footed temple-runners, who sprinted southeast across the Campus toward the Forum Romanum, running flat-out so fresh hot drops would still fall from the hair onto the hearth of the Regia before the blood clotted.

At the altar, the broader cleaver fell three times through neck-bone.

Up came the bay's severed head by the forelock, garlanded hastily with a wreath of hard baked loaves—*that no winter bin go empty*—and before the priest had stepped three paces back, the pine crowd-barriers cracked down the middle like rotten laths.

Two walls of men surged onto the sand from opposite sides of the field: from the south and west, young bloods, shop-freedmen, and shrine-wardens of the **Sacra Via** wearing yellow ribbons twisted around their biceps, fighting to carry the horse's head back to nail on the King's House in the Forum; from the east, pouring out of the narrow Argiletum throat, three

hundred grease-armed fullers, cobblers, brick-carriers, and tavern-brawlers of the **Subura**, bellowing *"Turris Mamilia! Subura! Subura!"*

The gap-toothed cobbler beside Corvus vaulted off the altar-plinth straight into the press. Within five breaths the orderly holiday margin dissolved into a churning mill-race of elbows, cudgels, flying dust, and spilled lupin-sellers' trays.

Corvus caught Lucida's hand to pull her backward toward the Saepta colonnade—and stopped dead, cold water dropping straight down his spine.

Thirty paces left along the edge of the portico, standing three steps up on a travertine doorway above the crowd's shoulders so he could scan every young head bobbing toward the Argiletum exit, stood **Gaius Ummidius Scaeva**.

He had changed his mud-spattered cloak for dry brown wool; behind him waited two bull-shouldered urban runners wearing Vedius Pollio's braided leather wrist-straps, plus Rufus the cross-eyed tally-clerk, squinting frantically across the sunlit gap where turnip-carts and onlookers bottlenecked into the narrow street. Scaeva had figured it out before noon: two broke country rats with stolen brick-dies and a Tyrian mother's name could only go to earth in two places in Rome—Trans-Tiberim across the bridges, which he had already set men watching, or down the Argiletum into the Subura's warren. And he was standing directly over the throat of the funnel.

Rufus turned his crossed eye toward the Republican boundary-altar. For half an instant, sunlight flashed off the wet bronze *signaculum* corner pressing through the worn seam of Lucida's oilskin bag. Rufus's mouth opened; his arm lifted to point.

"Down!" Corvus snarled, yanking Lucida off the plinth not away from the riot, where the portico steps stood bare and open to Scaeva's runners, but **straight sideways into the sweating, howling wedge of Subura-men** surging east around the bleeding horse-head.

* * *

Inside the Subura phalanx there was no sky, only armpits, sour wine, fuller's-earth dust, flying spittle, and drumming hobnails.

A giant lime-burner with his nose broken flat across both cheeks had the bay horse's severed head hugged to his leather chest like a wineskin, loaves crushing into crimson horsehair while six Sacra Via ward-champions clawed over backs and skulls to wrench the bridle-strap out of his fists. Fists cracked against cheekbones; somebody went down under forty pairs of soles and was hauled up by his hair screaming curses by Bellona's tits; warm horse-blood smeared across Corvus's shoulder as the crowd-press slammed him and Lucida chest-to-back between two bellowing fullers reeking of fermented chamber-pots.

"Stay inside their elbows!" Corvus shouted into Lucida's ear, wrapping his left arm around her ribs over the oilskin bag while using his right shoulder like a wedge to keep them moving at the exact speed of the Subura vanguard as it battered southeast through the Pallacina alleys toward the Forum Transitorium.

Behind them, forty yards back and fighting cross-grain against five hundred furious ward-partisans, Scaeva's two wrist-strapped heavies tried to bull inward from the portico steps. One shoved a Subura cobbler aside by the face: a fatal mistake on the Ides of October. Three leather-aproned apprentices took him for a Sacra Via ringer and laid him flat across an overturned fig-barrow with three fists and an oak stool-leg before Scaeva could whistle them clear.

Still Scaeva came on along the higher shop-ledges, hopping from stepping-stone to threshold with the grim, unhurried economy of an old camp-sergeant who had hunted Dacian hill-runners through worse brush than this. Every time the alley widened where booksellers' stalls hugged the shadow of Minerva's colonnade, Corvus caught a glimpse of that scarred, earless profile gaining five paces along the wall-hugging flank.

Ahead rose the **Firewall**.

Corvus had heard barge-men talk of it over stew-pots; seeing it from the narrow stone canyon of the Argiletum made his chest contract. Behind the gleaming white Carrara marble columns of Augustus's Forum stood a sheer, windowless cliff of dark grey *lapis Gabinus* blocks, course upon cyclopean course rising a hundred Roman feet straight into the afternoon sky, banded by projecting travertine stringcourses like iron hoops around a giant's chest. Three smoky travertine arches pierced its base: the central *Arcus Pantani* choked solid now with the screaming tug-of-war over the horse's head, the

narrower postern step-way on the north jammed with fleeing peddlers, a donkey wedged sideways under panniers of cracked vinegar-jars, and two Sacra Via toughs ambushing stragglers on the wet flagstones.

Corvus's eyes measured the jam in one heartbeat: the main arch would not move ten feet in a quarter-hour; Scaeva was twenty paces behind the jammed donkey on the right-hand cobbles and closing fast, leaded vine-stick raised; to the left, under a dripping brick butcher's-vault bridged overhead by a timber balcony, ran a five-foot drainage alley choked with slick offal-water that curved past the Firewall's northern spur straight onto the Clivus Suburanus.

They dove for the drainage cut.

A Sacra Via youth—nineteen or twenty, perfumed hair, yellow ribbon knotted round a muscular upper arm, drunk on Falernian and holiday blood—lunged out of the doorway thinking Corvus carried a Subura ward-purse under his arm, and grabbed Lucida's fuller's cloak with both hands, ripping the coarse fibula-pin clean through the wool so the oilskin bag swung exposed on its leather strap across her breastbone.

"What's in the sack, sewer-girl?" the yellow-ribboned youth laughed, twisting the strap round his fist while kicking Corvus's cut shin hard enough to drop him to one knee on slick sheep-paunch. "Let's see what Subura thieves—"

Corvus drove his head sideways into the youth's groin, clamping teeth through fine white wool into inner thigh until the dandy shrieked high as a gelded pig. Above him Lucida did not pull backward against the twisted strap; pulling backward choked you. She stepped *in* until her forehead touched the youth's perfumed chin, brought her honed amphora shard up flat against the leather strap—not cutting *her* strap, dragging the jagged terracotta edge hard across the back tendons of his knuckles—and when his blood-slick fingers spasmed open, drove her bare knee into his cods and shoved him backward onto the cobbles beside the panicked donkey's thrashing iron hooves.

"Up!" she snapped, hauling Corvus off the slime by his collar with bruising strength before Scaeva cleared the overturned vinegar-panniers ten yards behind.

Together they sprinted beneath the dark vault of the Firewall spur, crossing in six strides out of white marble Caesar-Rome into the other city.

Light dropped by half the instant they cleared the arch. On either side of the climbing **Clivus Suburanus**, six- and seven-storey tenements bulged outward on rotting oak corbels over the street like cliffs about to kiss, blocking the afternoon sun to a thin blue knife-slit overhead where wet washing —menstrual rags, patched soldier-tunics, yellowed fuller-cloths—dripped slow grey beads onto passers-by. The smell hit like an open palm: boiling goat-tripe, fried garlic, charcoal smoke pouring black out of windowless third-floor shutters because poor folk had no flues, sour *posca*, warm whore-perfume of crushed iris and cheap tallow from curtained ground-floor *cellae* scratched with charcoal prices (*FELICLA · ASSES II*), and under everything the deep, ancient ammonia-and-shit breath of forty thousand packed bodies living six to a room above shops that never shut.

Behind them through the arch, a roaring wave of triumph erupted: the Suburamen had torn the bay horse's head clear of the last Sacra Via blockers and came pouring up the Clivus around Corvus and Lucida, tossing baked-loaf crumbs in the air, pounding copper kettles, kissing bruised knuckles, sweeping the two fifteen-year-olds twenty alleys deep into the tangled hillside maze past the Vicus Patricius turn before Scaeva could even fight his way through the celebratory crush at the arch-mouth.

Halfway up a narrow stepped lane behind a smoky coppersmith's forge, where hammer-blows on bronze cauldrons drowned all talk and greasy black soot hung in the doorway, Lucida yanked Corvus sideways into a dark stairwell stinking of pickled cabbage and cat-piss.

For a long time neither spoke. Outside on the bright narrow steps, men went streaming uphill shouting *"Mamilia! Mamilia!"* after the bleeding horse-head; a woman leaned out a fourth-floor shutter above them, emptied a bucket of grey lentil-water onto the cobbles with a warning cry of *"Aqua!"* half a heartbeat too late, and laughed coarsest Greek when a passing muleteer cursed her dead mother's womb.

In the dark under the stair, Corvus leaned the back of his skull against damp tuff-stone and slid slowly down until he sat on his heels. His shin throbbed hot where Mousa's nails had furrowed it, and dried bay-horse blood had stiffened the wool over his collarbone into black crust.

Lucida dropped down beside him on the bottom step, knees drawn up, untying the oilskin bag with steady, stained fingers. One by one she touched its contents in the gloom: cedar birth-tablet; six waxed pine tally-leaves;

heavy bronze *signaculum* die; and the cracked round terracotta master-impression from *Figlinae Subortanae*, already split three-quarters across its middle where it had hit the skiff-rib at dawn, bearing in raised backward letters around a carved pine-cone:

EX PR DOMITIAE LUCILLAE · PAETIN ET APRONIAN COS

She turned the cracked clay disc in both palms, braced her thumbs on either side of the fault-line, and snapped it cleanly in two.

Dust drifted onto her bare knees. She held out the right-hand crescent—*DOMITIAE LUCILLAE*—and dropped it into Corvus's palm, right over the pale half-moon scar on his thumb knuckle. The other half she slid flat inside her shift beside the remaining nine coins.

"Beroe's shop is above the third fullery past the Nymphaeum lane, if the old witch isn't dead," Lucida said, voice hoarse from dust and running, rubbing her nose with the back of her wrist. "My mother sent her two jars of Tyrian lees the summer before the cough took her. She'll rob us blind on straw-space, and if she smells silver she'll cut our purses while we sleep, so let me count out the asses before we knock."

Corvus closed his fingers around the rough baked clay until its broken edge bit skin. Outside the stairwell arch, two Subura street-whores in saffron shifts no thicker than onion-skin leaned against the coppersmith's doorpost sharing a clay cup of heated wine, laughing as one flicked a louse off the other's oiled shoulder into the gutter; farther up the hill, someone nailed Mars's dead war-horse above the tower beam to a thunder of stamping boots.

"Three thousand two hundred sesterces on my father's wax," Corvus said quietly, looking past the saffron shifts at the narrow strip of blue sky wedged sixty feet up between leaning tile-eaves. "And thirty gold pieces Scaeva says Vedius paid for your mother's chest."

"Six thousand two hundred, then," Lucida said, standing up and shaking turnip-dirt out of her skirt-hem with two brisk snaps. She looked down at him in the gloom—fifteen years old, barefoot, Mousa's dried blood blackening under her fingernails, eyes bright and utterly without self-pity. "Plus two pairs of shoes, and supper. Get up, Corvus. Nobody pays rent sitting on the bottom step."

Chapter II

Oil of Bitter Almonds

Sixteenth to Eighteenth of October, AD 156 · Lucida

Seventy-eight steps went up from the street door to Berenice's garret: the first fourteen travertine, worn hollow in the middle like soup-spoons by a century of hobnails; the next thirty-two brick laid on edge and slimy with cabbage-grease; the last thirty-two unplaned pine ladders nailed between timber stud-walls thin enough that a man farting on the fourth landing rattled the clay oil-lamps on the fifth.

Lucida counted every riser on the way up because in summer, when the Subura burned, stairs were the difference between cooked meat and cold air.

Behind her on the narrow pine treads, Corvus climbed with one hand braced lightly against the lime-washed wattle partition, favoring his crusted shin without letting a single board creak under his weight. Even half-starved after a night spent wedged behind empty pickle-jars under a baker's awning, he looked up at the blackened oak joists above their heads with that concentrated, slightly cross-browed squint he got around bad carpentry, already calculating which cross-beam had rotted at the tenon and which way the roof would pitch when an earthquake or an overloaded water-butt brought the top two storeys down into the lane.

At the top landing there was no passage, only a low fir door patched at the bottom with hammered lead sheet to keep rats from gnawing through, and an iron ring worn bright by greasy thumbs. Smells seeped through the warped jamb before Lucida's knuckle touched wood: pounded bitter almonds, boiled vinegar, burnt hartshorn, beeswax, and underneath them all the sharp, coppery tang of pennyroyal steeping in an earthen pipkin.

Her mother's smell. Not the whole of it; Lucida Tyria had smelled of crushed murex shells and sea-salt too when she could get Syrian stock up

from Ostia, before the fever shriveled her on a straw sack behind the brickyards. Still, the bitter almond caught Lucida high at the back of the nose hard enough to make her jaw clench.

She rapped twice, then once, the way fuller-boys knocked when bringing clean wool-fat up the back stair so the aedile's market-inspectors down on the Argiletum would not ask why an unlicensed woman was boiling medicaments under dry roof-tiles.

Chains did not rattle inside; a wooden bar lifted without noise. The fir door opened four fingers wide, blocked by an iron wedge kicked against the floorboard, and one black Syrian eye—bright and hard as wet obsidian—studied Lucida from hairline to muddy instep while its mate, clouded milk-white with an old cataract from nose-bridge to temple, stared serenely past Corvus's ear at nothing.

"We don't buy rags before the Kalends," Berenice said in flat Subura Latin, making to shut the door. She was past fifty, thin-necked as a plucked heron, grey braids bound tight in yellow linen to keep stray hairs out of her unguent pots, two front teeth missing on the left where a drunken legionary had hit her during Hadrian's games.

"Lucida Tyria sent you two pitch-sealed jars of Sidonian purple lees in the consulship of Glabrio and Homullus," Lucida said swiftly in the Phoenician-salted Greek of the Tyre harbour-quarter, slipping three stained fingers into the crack—risking broken bones if the old woman kicked the wedge—just high enough that Berenice's good eye caught the purple-brown alkanet crescents under her nails. "And you sent back four ounces of Chian mastic and a pewter syringe when her womb bled after me, and still owed her six denarii on the tallow weight."

The door stopped moving.

Berenice's good black eye dropped from Lucida's face to the open V of her rough shift, just below the left collarbone where the small dark birthmark sat like an olive-pip against olive skin, then flicked sideways to Corvus standing half a step down on the steep pine ladder with his jaw shut and his right hand resting casually near the heavy bulge under Lucida's fuller-cloak.

"Six denarii?" Berenice cackled, a dry sound like dry beans shaken in a bladder, and kicked the iron floor-wedge aside with a deformed big toe. "Your mother died owing every muleteer between Tyre and Puteoli, little crow, and her tallow was a third mutton-suet whipped with lime-water!

Come inside off the stair before the cobbler's wife across the air-shaft sells your faces to the ward-headman for two asses."

They stepped over the sill, and Berenice dropped the oak bar back into its iron brackets.

The *cenaculum* under the pantiles measured fourteen feet by eleven, sloped so low along the street eaves that Corvus had to duck his black head anywhere past the middle ceiling-beam. Light entered through a single unglazed dormer opening onto a lead rain-gutter where three clay pots of rue and savin shivered in the morning draught. Every square palm of wall-plaster and rafter space worked for its living. Dried poppy-heads, bundles of dried squid-bone for tooth-powder, bladders of goose-grease, cakes of red ochre from Sinope, and little blown-glass phials stopped with waxed linen hung from twine loops overhead. On a scarred marble slab salvaged from some broken tombstone sat a porphyry muller for grinding white lead, two bronze balances sensitive enough to weigh a dried lentil, and a charcoal brazier no bigger than a helmet over which a lidded clay pot breathed sour herbal steam.

Berenice did not offer them stools because there was only one stool, and she sat on it herself, spreading her patched brown tunic over bony knees while picking up an iron spatula to stir the pipkin.

"Shut your mouth if you're going to lie to me," she told Lucida in Greek, though she switched back to Latin on the next breath so Corvus understood he was being weighed too. "Tyria's girl. Fifteen now? Fourteen? And who's the long-shanked Sabine wolf-cub measuring my rafters with his eyes—your pimp, your brother, or the fool who knocked your belly up?"

"Corvus," Lucida said. "Gaius Cassius's son from the upper clay-pits. Freeborn, Crustumina tribe, clean birth-tablets. Nobody knocked my belly up, Beroe. Scaeva burned the shacks at Figlinae Subortanae yesterday before sunrise."

The iron spatula stopped halfway round the pipkin.

For three breaths the only sound in the garret was rain-water dripping into the gutter outside and the distant thump of fullers' poles six storeys down in the courtyard vats.

"Gaius Ummidius Scaeva?" Berenice asked softly.

"Missing half his left ear," Corvus said from by the low eaves, speaking for the first time. His voice was calm, pitched low so it would not carry

through the lath-and-plaster wall into the next garret where somebody was snoring off the holiday wine. "Carries a leaded centurion's vine-stick. Works for Publius Vedius Pollio."

Berenice set the spatula down on the tombstone slab, wiped her palms on her apron, and stood up. Short as she was, her head nearly brushed the hanging poppy-bundles. "Out," she said. "Take the back roof-plank over the bakery tiles and break your necks in somebody else's region. Do you know whose bailiff collects the ground-rent on the three fulleries downstairs, you pair of milk-blind kittens? Not Vedius in his own name—no, great men keep clean fingernails—a freedman called Hermippus who drinks Vedius's bath-water! If Scaeva smells you under my tiles, my jars go out the dormer window and I spend winter sleeping under the Pons Sublicius!"

Corvus took half a step toward the door, pride stiffening his shoulders like an iron rod—he had never begged roof-space from anyone since his father died—and Lucida stepped flat across his toes before he could touch the bar.

"Wait," Lucida said. She reached inside her shift, bypassed the nine small coins—nine coins wouldn't buy Berenice's silence for an afternoon—and brought out one single waxed pine tally-leaf from the six they had stolen off Rufus's table, holding it tilted just long enough for Berenice's sharp right eye to read the bottom stamp, not long enough to read the brick-counts. "Scaeva isn't hunting two runaway field-mice for sport, Beroe. He doesn't know whether we went downstream to Ostia, across into Trans-Tiberim, or north up the Via Salaria. What we need is six feet of dry floor behind your screen until the November rains start, two fullers' day-tokens so we earn bread without showing papers at the gate, and salt for Corvus's shin. What *you* need is someone fifteen years old with nimble fingers and no name in the Argiletum to carry white-lead pots and sealed rue-phials up the Caelian back stairs where everybody already knows your cataract from twenty paces off."

Berenice's good eye narrowed to a black slit. "My errand-girl Myrtale carries my Caelian baskets."

"Myrtale has six copper *asses* of cheap Syrian iris behind her ears; I smelled her lingering on the third landing talking to two off-duty *vigiles* on our way up," Lucida lied smoothly, having smelled iris oil on a fat girl leaning over the third-floor rail and guessed the rest from the blue ointment smudge on the girl's thumb. "A girl who gossips with night-watchmen on the stairs

while carrying pennyroyal to senators' daughters is going to put you both in the Esquiline lime-pit before Saturnalia. I don't talk to watchmen, I speak Greek, Latin, and enough Syrian to curse a mule, and I know how to grind *cerussa* wet so the lead-dust doesn't rot the lungs."

Behind her, Corvus said nothing at all, though Lucida felt the heat coming off his chest half a hand's breadth from her shoulder blade. He hated when she stepped into dirt to buy them room; she could feel his thumb rubbing that pale half-moon scar on his knuckle in the quiet. Let him hate it. Pride did not roof a garret.

Berenice stared at Lucida for a long count, then snorted through one nostril, reached out with horny yellow fingernails, and pinched Lucida's chin, turning her cheek toward the grey dormer light.

"Your mother had that exact lying mouth," the old woman muttered. "Sold lady Domitia's wardrobe-woman wild alkanet boiled in alum and swore by Astarte's dugs it was genuine double-dipped Sidonian shellfish, and never turned a hair while counting the silver. Sit down on the rush-mat, both of you, before that boy puts his skull through my tiles. Let me see what Vedius Pollio holds on your neck, girl. Did Tyria ever take you before the Urban Praetor's rod before the blood-cough killed her?"

Lucida dropped onto her heels on the worn rush-mat beside the charcoal brazier. Her wet wool shift stuck cold to her thighs.

"No," Lucida said. "Patron Aulus Lucidius signed a letter *inter amicos* at supper in Puteoli when my mother turned twenty-six, witnessed by five guests over mulled wine, and died of apoplexy before the autumn court session could confirm it by the rod. I was born four months after the letter."

Berenice clicked her tongue against her gap-teeth. Corvus knew the history already—they had turned it over fifty nights beside the kiln-ash like a sore tooth—yet hearing it spoken plain under a Roman roof made the walls feel narrower by half.

Under the *Lex Iunia Norbana*, a woman freed at supper among friends without the magistrate's rod was no slave: nobody could chain her ankles at a mill without cause or sell her naked off a wooden turntable in the Saepta. Yet she was no Roman citizen either. She was a *Latina Iuniana*, a Junian Latin. She might buy wool, bake bread, rent six feet of floor, pile up ten thousand silver denarii in an iron chest if her wits held out; and the hour her breath stopped, whether at sixteen of winter fever or seventy in silk sheets,

the Roman law reached into her bedchamber, swept every copper *quadrans*, kettle, cloak, and brick she had ever bled to earn back into her dead patron's estate as if she had never been anything more than a clever slave minding her master's purse. And because old Aulus Lucidius's spendthrift grandson had drunk away his Puteoli villas three winters back and forfeited his pledged strongboxes to **Publius Vedius Pollio**, Vedius now owned the waiting hand at the end of Lucida's life—and claimed sixteen hundred sesterces in unpaid *operae*—freedwoman's labor-days—from her dead mother's account right now while she was still breathing.

"Live free, die slave," Berenice said matter-of-factly, picking up a lump of chalky white lead carbonate with iron tongs and dropping it into a stoneware mortar with three splashes of sharp vinegar. "Half the rich freedmen in Trans-Tiberim walk round in rings heavy enough to sink a skiff and still piss vinegar every winter wondering how to buy out their patron's reversion before apoplexy catches them. Sixteen asses a week for the corner behind the wicker screen, paid every eighth market-day, *nundinae*, on the nail, four asses extra if you burn my charcoal after the second watch, and you grind two pounds of lead-cake every evening before supper gratis. Touch one glass phial on my shelf without asking, and I don't call Scaeva; I put three drops of cold-pressed *hyoscyamus* in your lentil-pot and roll you both into the Cloaca grate myself. Show me your copper."

Lucida did not smile, did not thank her—thanking a Subura landlady told her she had asked too little—and unpicked four tarnished copper *asses* and one brass *dupondius* from her wet hem, laying six asses' worth flat on the marble tombstone slab.

"Four days on account," Lucida said. "And tell us which fullery downstairs takes day-hands without asking tribe-tablets."

Berenice swept the bronze off the marble into her pouch with one dry thumb, then tossed Corvus a lump of coarse grey rock-salt and a rag soaked in sour wine-vinegar. "Wash that leg before it stinks up my rue, Sabine. Gaius Lucceius's vats in the second courtyard down. His lead-treader got his kneecap split with a fuller's pole in yesterday's horse-brawl, so he's three pairs of legs short on Senator Regulus's dinner-cloths. He pays twelve asses from the fifth hour to dusk for boys, eight for girls, and docks two for urine-splash if you drop a hem. Leave your heavy bundle behind the loose brick under my hearth-ash; if you think I haven't eyes enough to see thirty pounds

of stolen bronze pulling that girl's shoulder sideways, you're stupider than your haircuts."

Corvus looked down at the vinegar-rag in his hand, then across the brazier at Berenice's milky blind eye and glittering black one.

"If anything under that loose brick moves the width of a barleycorn while we're downstairs, grandmother," Corvus said very politely, wrapping the stinging vinegar cloth tight round his torn shin without a wince, "the Urban Prefect's clerks learn who sold abortive savin to Senator Bradua's niece before our ankles touch the first landing."

Silence dropped flat across the garret. Corvus didn't know Senator Bradua's niece from the Empress Faustina—he had plucked the name *Bradua* straight off the toll-collector's shout at the Flaminian Gate the day before—yet somewhere on the hills every rich family had a niece, and Berenice's good eye blinked once, slow as a lizard on hot stone, before breaking into a sharp, delighted wheeze.

"Oh, keep this one, little crow!" Berenice said, pointing her iron tongs at Corvus's chin. "He's got magistrate's teeth already—all bone and clean Latin while he steals your hearth-bricks! Go tread piss, both of you, before Lucceius hires street-Greeks."

* * *

One smelled Gaius Lucceius's *fullonica* before seeing the doorway, and three slick brick stairs down into the vaulted treading-hall was enough to coat the back of the tongue with salt ammonia for three days.

Along the street wall outside stood four sawn-off amphora necks bedded up to their bellies in mortar where every passing wine-drinker, mule-driver, and sausage-seller on the lower Clivus Suburanus stopped to relieve his bladder for free. Inside the dim brick arcade, rows of waist-deep terracotta tubs sunk flush into paved *opus spicatum* herringbone floors held that collected human piss aged seven days in the warm dark until its alcaline bite turned fierce enough to strip body-grease, banquet gravy, and lamp-soot out of forty-pound woollen *togae* and dining-couch covers.

Lucida hitched her coarse shift high into her waist-cord, knotted it tight between her thighs like a loin-clout so the hem could not drag, and stepped bare-legged into Tub Seven beside a sunken-chested Cappadocian

treader old enough to have grey wool on his breastbone despite lacking forty years. Three tubs over, where the heavier, rougher *synthesis* dinner-garments soaked in thicker grey Cimolian fuller's earth and double-strength chamber-lye, Corvus gripped the horizontal oak hand-rail braced along the damp brick wall and began the steady, punishing fuller's march: left knee high, heel driving down through sodden wool folds, twist the ball of the foot to force liquor through the warp, right knee high, heel down, twist.

Within half an hour the warm, greasy liquid bit into every scratch from the river reeds and briars like hot needles. Within an hour the ammonia vapor rising between Lucida's thighs made her eyes run clear water down her cheeks and turned the inside of her nostrils raw pink.

Nobody sang work-songs there; men who opened their mouths wide over aged piss-vats coughed blood by thirty. Sound in the arcade was purely mechanical: the rhythmic *sluck-thump, sluck-thump* of twenty-four bare heels churning wet wool; the hiss of cold aqueduct water rushing from a lead spout into the three wide masonry rinsing-basins across the court; the sharp *whack* of willow switches beating dried fuller's-chalk out of finished cloaks under the sun-arch; and the pacing hobnails of Lucceius's overseer **Sticho**, a pot-bellied freedman with gold rings in both ears and a split quince-wood rod tucked under his armpit, walking the dry brick coping between the vats.

"Lift your heels, Seven, don't dance on top of the cloth like a tavern-whore saving her ankles!" Sticho barked above Lucida's head, rapping the quince-rod once against her oak hand-rail close enough to sting her knuckles with vibration. "That's equestrian table-linen from the Carinae, not mule-blankets! Miss one lamp-oil spot on the border and you pay four asses out of your eight!"

"Oil spot's already lifting, master," Lucida murmured without looking up, eyes watering, driving her small hard heel straight into the corner seam where olive-grease and spilled mulled wine had stiffened the linen yellow. Never look an overseer in the earrings when fifteen and bare-thighed in his tub; men like Sticho kept two uses for quince-rods after the shutters went up if a new girl looked either defiant or frightened. Look dull, work clean, count every exit.

Across the steam-haze beside the rinsing-basins stood the **sulfur-cage**: a six-foot bell-shaped dome woven of osier switches smeared outside with wet clay, over which damp white *togae* were stretched tight while a shallow

iron pan of raw yellow Sicilian brimstone burned underneath, bleaching the wool dazzling snow-bright with choking blue fumes before the carders brushed up the nap with hedgehog skins and teasel-heads.

Tending three sulfur-pans at once was a girl smaller than Lucida—twelve, maybe thirteen, thin as a peeled willow wand, flax-pale northern hair hacked ragged above jutting collarbones, barefoot in grey ash. When a fuller-boy shouted to her to fetch fresh charcoal from the bin under the arch, the girl did not answer; when a rolling rinse-tub slopped icy water over her ankles, she made no sound at all, only sucked air silently past parted front teeth. Checking her mouth when she turned to lift a heavy damp *toga praetexta* onto the third wicker dome, Lucida saw the stub inside when the girl panted: tongue cut or burned short years back, or else born silent in some Gallic cattle-stead before the dealers drove her south.

Sticho had stopped by the rinsing trough to curse a Greek carder over torn fringe on a woman's palla, waving both stubby arms so his quince-rod clipped the wet shoulder of the overloaded third wicker dome.

One rotten osier rib snapped with a dry *pop*.

Ten pounds of wet woollen *toga* sagged inward toward the glowing iron brimstone pan. If burning sulfur caught dry-edged woollen nap on a magistrate's purple-bordered gown, forty denarii went up in stinking blue flame in ten heartbeats.

The mute flax-haired girl did not hesitate, because slave-children who let forty-denarius *togae* scorch got hung by their wrists from the beam and whipped with knotted ox-hide until their kidneys bled. She lunged sideways with both skinny arms, snatched the sagging wool clear of the blue flame with her right hand, and caught the tipping red-hot iron sulfur-pan on the bare inner skin of her left forearm to keep liquid burning brimstone from splashing across the skirt.

Skin seared with the wet, unmistakable *hiss* of fat hitting a griddle.

Even without a tongue the sound that tore out of the back of the girl's throat stopped six treaders mid-step: a thin, whistling animal screech that broke off into dry retching as the iron pan clattered onto the herringbone bricks, spilling blue-burning yellow crust harmlessly into the stone drain-channel while she clutched her smoking left arm against her belly, knees buckling onto wet brick. Molten sulfur stuck like burning pitch where it

touched flesh; a blue bead still sputtered pale flame half an inch below her wrist.

Corvus dropped off his oak hand-rail in Tub Ten before anyone else moved, not shouting, reaching straight for a bucket of dry fuller's clay beside the coping, because throwing water on burning brimstone spread the blister; Sticho spun round in purple-faced fury under his fuller-chalk, snatching up the saved *toga* with one hand and raising the split quince-rod high with the other to beat the kneeling girl across her hunched shoulder-blades.

"Clumsy Gallic half-wit! Half a pound of Sicilian sulfur down the gutter and soot on the purple border—I'll take the hide off your—"

"Hit her on the stones while her arm's still smoking," Lucida called out clearly from Tub Seven, vaulted already onto the brick coping with ammonia dripping down her bare shins, voice flat and brisk as an account-clerk's, "and she drops her chin onto that purple stripe you're trailing in the soot, master Sticho, and then you aren't explaining three asses of spilled brimstone to Gaius Lucceius—you're explaining why Senator Regulus's hem has blister-grease baked into Tyrian dye that fulling-earth won't ever lift!"

Sticho's raised arm checked half an inch in mid-air. His small, red-veined eyes jerked down: sure enough, in his rage he had let two palms of the damp purple *praetexta* border droop dangerously close to the black charcoal smear beside the overturned pan. He jerked the cloth up against his fat chest as if bitten.

Before he could recover his breath to turn the quince-rod on Lucida, Corvus was already on one knee beside the convulsing girl, smothering the last sputtering crumb of sulfur on her forearm under dry grey Cimolian clay, pressing firmly to cut air off the burn without rubbing skin loose, then lifting the pan back onto cold stone with the toe of his foot.

"Who asked the eight-as street-bitch to count my wool?" Sticho snarled, stepping across the drain toward Lucida, quince-rod twitching down toward her bare wet thigh. "Get back in Tub Seven before I dock both your tallies to nothing and throw you in the alley!"

Lucida did not flinch back—stepping back put your heel in the vat—and instead dropped into her most deferential, honey-quick workshop voice, palms open so he saw the old dye-stains under her nails. "Dock me if

I'm wrong, master! Look at the stripe under your thumb: genuine double-boiled purple goes black forever if vinegar or sulfur-ash hits it warm, unless you rub cold unwashed sheep's wool-grease along the white edge *first* to stop the bleed before rinsing. My mother dyed borders for Caelian houses twelve years. Give me a finger of raw lanolin from the carders' pot and clean vinegar, and I'll keep that border spotless *and* grease the mute's burn in the same turn so you don't lose a pair of hands before supper."

Sticho stared from the smudge near the purple hem to Lucida's stained cuticles, then down at the flax-haired girl crouched white-faced against the wall with her teeth clamped into her own knee to stop shaking. Greed and laziness wrestled visibly behind Sticho's sweaty brow: beating a mute slave cost nothing, except Lucceius skinned overseers who spoiled senatorial orders, and hiring another sulfur-tender before dark cost four asses.

"Five breaths," Sticho grunted, jabbing the quince-rod toward the carders' grease-crock under the arch. "Touch that border with dirty fingers and you leave your shift behind to pay the wool-bill. You—long-legs! Back in Ten, or you tread for love!"

Corvus caught Lucida's eye for half a beat as he rose from the brick, making sure Sticho's stick was down, before swinging smoothly back into Tub Ten without wasting a word.

Under the arch Lucida scooped two generous gobs of pale, rank-smelling unwashed sheep's *oesypum*—raw lanolin skimmed from first-boil fleeces, worth its weight in bronze up on the hills once Beroe perfumed it with rose-leaves and sold it back to matrons in alabaster pots as Athenian skin-balm. With a clean linen scrap and three drops of cold water she lifted the soot speck off the white wool a finger-breadth shy of Senator Regulus's purple stripe, easy as wiping dust off an apple, handed the unblemished *toga* to the hovering Greek carder, and dropped onto her heels beside the mute girl in the shadow behind the charcoal bin.

Up close, the burn along the inside of the girl's skinny left forearm ran five inches from wrist-bone toward elbow: angry blistered red round the edges, dead parchment-white at the center where the hot iron lip had kissed deepest, dusted grey with Corvus's clay. When Lucida rinsed the loose grit gently off with diluted cold vinegar, never breaking the risen water-blisters, the girl's whole ribcage locked rigid as plank-oak, grey eyes huge and dry in a soot-streaked face, waiting to be slapped for crying.

"Hold onto my ankle if you need to bite something," Lucida whispered against the flax hair, laying thick, chilled sheep's wool-fat cleanly across the raw skin and binding it loose with a torn strip of bleached rag ripped silently from the bottom of Lucceius's scrap-pile while Sticho's back was turned. She slipped an extra walnut-sized lump of stolen lanolin inside her own waist-knot for Corvus's shin that night. "Don't let them put cow-dung or cobwebs on it after the shutters close, hear me? Dung rots a burn green in three days. Keep the sheep-fat wet. What do they call you?"

The girl stared at Lucida's mouth, then lifted her unburned right hand and traced four quick, practiced Roman letters in the spilled fuller's-chalk on the brick floor between their knees. No illiterate cattle-child after all; someone had taught her tallies once before she hit the Subura vats.

S · U · R · A

Lucida rubbed her palm across the chalk before Sticho turned back down the coping, tapped two fingers against her own breastbone—*"Lucida,"* mouthed clear and slow so the girl could read lips—then pointed one chin-nod toward Tub Ten where Corvus's dark head rose and fell in steady, relentless rhythm above the steaming vat: *"Corvus."*

Sura looked from Lucida's face across the steam to Corvus, then down at the clean wool-fat bandage soothing the fire in her arm. Very deliberately, she touched two fingers of her right hand to her parted front teeth and blew a tiny, nearly inaudible double whistle—*whit-whit*, low as a hedge-thrush in thorn-bush—pointing one flick of her eyes toward Sticho's boots turning at the far end of the row.

Lucida was back chest-deep in Tub Seven, heels churning wet Carinae linen in stinking chamber-lye as if she had never left the rail, two heartbeats before Sticho's shadow crossed the tub.

At dusk, when the bronze tintinnabulum by the street gate clanged end-of-shift and legs came out of the vats wrinkled dead-white and raw-spotted to the groin, Sticho counted out twelve copper *asses* into Corvus's palm and seven—docking one out of pure spite "for vinegar-rag"—into Lucida's. Nineteen asses for half a day's skin burned in other men's piss: four sesterces and three quarters. Five loaves of coarse plebeian bread and a ladle of boiled chickpeas, with nine asses left toward next market-day's straw.

As they passed the doorway into the darkening lane, Sura crouched in the courtyard ash scraping cold brimstone crusts back into an iron pan with

one hand; without lifting her flax head, she let go that tiny two-note thrush breath between her teeth as Lucida's shadow touched her bare shoulder.

Outside on the Clivus, lamp-lighters were reaching tarred tapers up to the bronze hooks beside the *popina* counters, where cauldrons of grey pulse and salt-pork rind bubbled over olive-stone embers. Before climbing the seventy-eight steps back to Berenice's mortar, they washed their burned legs to the knee at the public travertine basin at the corner of the Vicus Cuprius, standing in icy Marcia-water overflow beside two tired Syrian litter-porters rinsing mule-sponges. For four copper *asses* Lucida bought two scored round loaves still warm from a cellar oven and a twist of pickled sprats wrapped in fig-leaf, testing every loaf on the heel of her palm before paying so the baker could not palm off morning stale-crust on dusk light. They ate walking, tearing bread half-for-half without looking down, slicking salt fish-oil off their thumbs, stepping wide around the dark wet patches beneath overhanging windows—already moving like people born inside the wall rather than outside it.

* * *

Nobody who had never lain awake on the sixth floor of a Subura *insula* after sunset understood what Rome weighed.

All day long, while the sun stood above the hills, Caesar's old municipal law kept heavy freight-wheels outside the gates so senators' litters and advocates' chalked *togae* could pass without having an axle crush their insteps. The instant darkness fell, every gate from the Flaminia to the Ostiensis burst its dam at once.

Lying on thin barley-straw behind Berenice's tattered reed screen, back pressed flat against Corvus's warm spine so the single coarse fuller's cloak covered four shoulders instead of two, Lucida felt the whole timber skeleton of the tenement shudder and groan like a leaking grain-ship in winter swells. Six storeys straight down in the black canyon of the Argiletum, iron-tired ox-wagons hauling twenty-ton Luna marble drums for Antoninus's temple repairs, pine roof-trusses sixty feet long, casks of Baetican oil, and clanking carts of night-soil rumbled axle-to-axle over basalt paving stones. Torch-glare from the drivers' link-boys swept red across Berenice's smoky ceiling joists in rhythmic flashes; teamsters cracked leather whips and screamed

obscenities in Oscan, Greek, and camp-Latin whenever two hubs locked on the narrow turn beneath the Firewall; every heavy jolt sent a dry trickle of old lime-mortar pattering like mice inside the hollow wattle wall beside Lucida's ear.

Across the room by the open dormer, Berenice sat wrapped in an old ragged wolf-pelt, holding a heated tile of smoking henbane-seeds under a funnel to her broken left jaw for the autumn tooth-ache. Autumn rain had begun to slant cold off the Esquiline, hissing faintly when stray drops hit her little brazier.

"Awake, Sabine?" Lucida whispered without turning over, feeling the steady, wide rise of Corvus's ribs behind her shoulder-blades. Even washed at the street fountain, both of them still smelled faintly of ammoniac fuller's-earth under sheep-fat and boiled chickpeas.

"Counting carts," Corvus murmured back, breath warm against the damp nape of her neck. "Nineteen stone-sledges in the last quarter-hour heading toward the Campus, all pulled by triple yokes. Somebody's laying heavy foundations north of Hadrian's portico before the winter frost locks the lime-pits."

Lucida turned inside the narrow cloak-fold until they lay nose-to-nose on the straw: three inches between their chins in the dark, the way they had slept in kiln-sheds and reed-huts whenever January wind came off Soracte, except here in Rome every inch of air felt denser, charged with iron and strangers' breath. In the red flicker passing across the rafters from a torch-wagon six floors below, she saw the dark purple bruise under Corvus's left eye where the Sacra Via dandy had grazed him, and the pale line of his mouth.

She reached down between them, found his right hand where it rested over the hidden floor-brick—even half-asleep he had moved their straw pallet directly over the loose hearth-tile hiding the bronze *signaculum* and his cedar birth-diptych—and rubbed warm stolen sheep's lanolin into the raw ammonia cracks between his fingers with slow, firm strokes.

Corvus let his breath out quietly through his nose. His fingers curled once around hers, rough skin catching rough skin.

"You shouldn't have stood up to Sticho over the mute girl," he said, so low Berenice by the dormer could not hear over the wagon-thunder. "If he'd swung that quince-stick at your ribs while I was three tubs off—"

"Then you'd have broken his kneecap with the clay-bucket and we'd be sleeping in the rain tonight," Lucida whispered back, pressing her thumb flat over his lips for half a heartbeat before he could lecture her. "I got us three ounces of clean sheep-fat, kept all eight asses bar one, and made an ally by the courtyard door who can whistle faster than Scaeva walks. Don't play bailiff with me, Lucius Cassius. Save the speech for the Forum."

His mouth twitched under her thumb—not quite a smile, something tighter and warmer. He shifted his hand up from hers, hooked one knuckle gently behind her braid to pull a stray wet strand of hair out of the grease on his shin, and left his palm resting flat against the base of her throat, right over the hollow where her pulse beat, half an inch above the invisible olive-pip mark under her shift. Neither of them pulled back. His palm was hot from fuller's-lime and fifteen years of knowing every bone in her face; for three wagon-passes below, neither spoke, listening to rain-water gurgle down the lead gutter outside.

"Tomorrow I go down past the Firewall to the Temple of Saturn," Corvus said into the dark. "Before the fourth hour, while the notice-boards are quiet. If my father's three-thousand-sesterce bond was bought up by one of Vedius's debt-collectors alongside your mother's chest, my name is already chalked on an agent's slate. Better I find the slate before the slate finds us."

"Go dirty," Lucida told him instantly. "Don't wash your tunic at the trough first. A boy in a washed tunic reading treasury boards looks like an heir or a debtor; a boy carrying a broken charcoal-hod looks like furniture."

Over by the dormer, Berenice lifted her jaw off the smoking henbane funnel, spat black saliva onto the wet lead gutter outside, and turned her one glittering obsidian eye across the dark garret toward the reed screen where their four bare feet stuck out from under the fuller's cloak.

"Whispering sums at fifteen," the old woman rasped over the rumble of timber-wagons shaking the floor-planks. "Listen to the pair of you—brick-mice planning which side of Caesar's cheese to gnaw first! Take an old Syrian's word before you wear out your knees on the stairs, children: Rome has two doors up out of the mud—the knife and the bronze scale. And neither one of them was built wide enough for two abreast."

Berenice pinched out her tallow wick between calloused thumb and forefinger, plunging the garret into pitch-black smelled through with bitter almond, burnt henbane, and cold October rain.

Behind the screen, Lucida reached inside her shift until her fingertips touched her half of the broken terracotta brick-stamp, sharp-edged and dry against her ribs; with her other hand she gripped Corvus's wrist under the rough cloak and held on hard until the wagons below blurred into sleep.

Chapter III

The Dead Man's Wax

Nones of November, AD 156 · Corvus

Frost sat white along the travertine flutes of Saturn's eight great columns, though down on the paving stones of the Clivus Capitolinus a thousand warm sandals had already trodden the rime into grey paste.

Corvus stood four steps up beside a broken bronze water-spout, balancing a cracked willow hod of pine-charcoal on his left shoulder so soot darkened his neck and collarbone, eyes moving steadily down the row of whitewashed pine notice-boards (*alba*) propped along the podium wall below the treasury doors. Just as Lucida had foretold three weeks back, nobody looked twice at a dirty fifteen-year-old hod-carrier pausing to blow on cold knuckles. Clerks in clean woollen sleeves pushed past his elbow carrying sealed canvas coin-sacks up toward the iron-barred doors of the *Aerarium Saturni*, where the Roman people's bullion and brass laws slept behind six-inch oak and triple locks; litigious country landlords squinted at auction notices through watering eyes; two Syrian money-changers sat cross-legged under the portico arch below, ringing suspect silver *denarii* against flat touchstones of black Lydian basalt.

Corvus read fast, left to right down the red-and-black painted columns without moving his lips.

His father had taught him block-capitals at six with a pointed stick in wet brick-marl, and cursive merchant-hand at nine off old tax-receipts so somebody sober could check the lime-tallies before the bailiff came round. Halfway down the fourth whitewashed board—headed *DE NOMINIBUS TRANSACTIS ET PROSCRIPTIS*, defaulted personal bonds called in on the Kalends of November—Corvus's gaze hooked on three lines brushed in cheap black lamp-ink:

C · CASSIVS · C · F · CRVST · CORVVS · AGRIMENSOR · DEFUNCTVS HS · MMM · CC · EX CHIROGRAPHO · CVM VSURIS CENTESIMIS PETIT · HERMIPPVS · P · VEDII · POLLIONIS · DISPENSATOR

Corvus did not move his shoulder under the charcoal-hod. Only his right thumb inside his torn tunic pocket slid once across the pale half-moon scar on his knuckle.

Hermippus, steward of Publius Vedius Pollio.

The very freedman Berenice had named on their first morning as ground-collector for the three Argiletum fulleries under their floorboards. Corvus's dead father had borrowed those three thousand two hundred sesterces at twelve percent a year not from Vedius, from a squat Tiburtine cattle-broker called Numerius who smelled of fried onions and bad teeth; which meant Vedius's counting-house had been sweeping the upper Tiber valley with a fine-toothed iron comb since the clay-shacks burned, buying up every small paper claim connected to Figlinae Subortanae at six sesterces on the ten so that if dead Corvus's son ever poked his head above ground inside a Roman court or tribe-roll, Hermippus could clap a judgment-summons on his collar before he drew breath.

Under the Twelve Tables men used to chop a defaulted debtor into weighed pieces and divide his ribs among creditors; in gentle old Emperor Antoninus's Golden Age they merely hauled a penniless *humilior* heir who had not formally abstained from his father's insolvent estate before the magistrate, stripped his cloak, and set him working off principal and interest in a chained brick-gang until his spine folded. And to abstain formally before the Urban Praetor required appearing in person under one's full citizen name, where Scaeva's runners waited beside the scribe's bench with a rope.

Neat as a survey triangle. Three sides, no way out.

"Boy," an irritable Greek voice snapped behind his left heel. "Are you selling that charcoal to the treasury rats, or waiting until Jupiter melts it with lightning? Move your basket off the third step; you're blocking Senator Priscus's clients."

Corvus stepped half a pace sideways onto the worn plinth, dipping his chin like any dull street-carrier, and let six morning clients in damp chalked

togae troop past him up the treasury stair behind two men who did not hurry for anyone.

The elder was fifty-five or close to it, tall, stoop-shouldered as an iron crane, iron-grey beard cropped two fingers short of the jawbone in the severe military cut of Trajan's old legates. He wore the broad purple senatorial *laticlavius* stripe down a tunic of unbleached Sabine wool and a *toga* hemmed conspicuously higher above the ankle than fashion liked, advertising to the entire Forum that **Quintus Servilius Priscus** wasted neither Syrian dye nor idle cloth. Between thumb and forefinger he carried three dry fennel seeds from a little horn box, cracking one between yellow back molars against morning bile.

Half a step at his left elbow walked the Greek who had spoken: fortyish, clean-shaven twice a day until his hollow cheeks shone blue-olive in the cold, wearing an ink-spotted dark grey *paenula* cloak open at the throat, where a greased leather cord suspended three flat bone wax-scrapers (*scalpra*) of varying widths that knocked softly together like surgical blades whenever he turned.

They stopped four feet from Corvus's charcoal-hod while the treasury porter unlocked the inner grate for a clerk. Neither looked at Corvus; in Rome a hod-boy was a post with ears that didn't count.

"Hermippus filed counter-tallies yesterday evening with the trustees' arbiter," the Greek—*Phileros*, Priscus called him a breath later—was saying in low, rapid Attic Greek, holding open a four-leaved boxwood tablet. "All stamped *Opus Doliare ex Praediis Domitiae Lucillae*, consular year of Silvanus and Augurinus, certifying that the Subortanae kilns delivered only eleven thousand two-foot bricks between April and the September rains because the clay-vein flooded."

Senator Priscus cracked a second fennel seed between his teeth. His eyes, pale grey and flat as slate roof-tiles, scanned down across the Forum pavement toward the white marble portico of the Basilica Julia where court-curtains were already going up. "Flooded in July, Phileros? The Tiber dropped so low at Prima Porta this August you could wade across dry-ankled carrying a sucking-pig. Where did the missing forty thousand bricks go?"

"Into three new six-storey *insulae* going up behind the Vicus Patricius under Hermippus's building lease, beyond doubt," Phileros replied dryly.

"Proving it before Rusticus's trust-auditors is another dish of fish. The bailiff at Subortanae—a former guard-sergeant named Scaeva—swore affidavit before an aedile's notary that a runaway Sabine surveyor's brat burned the tally-shed on the Ides of October and bolted with the workshop master-roll and one bronze consular die. Without an original pre-fire kiln leaf or a witness from the trench, Hermippus's sworn numbers stand."

Priscus spat dry fennel husk onto the travertine step two inches from Corvus's bare big toe.

"Vedius Pollio steals dead Domitia's clay while Marcus Caesar is still wearing black wool for his mother," Priscus muttered in Latin hard enough to drive nails, "and uses the profits to buy Spanish horses for young Lucius Commodus's stable-boys. Find me that runaway Sabine brat or find me a mason who laid those stolen bricks, Phileros, before the winter court-recess closes the audit."

"If Scaeva finds the boy first," Phileros murmured, bone wax-scrapers knocking under his chin as the iron treasury gate swung wide, "you'll need a dredge-hook at Ostia to take his deposition, patron."

They passed inside the bronze doors of Saturn.

Corvus stood motionless beside the broken water-spout for twenty full breaths after their clients vanished into the vault gloom, staring straight ahead at the gilded milestone (*Milliarium Aureum*) across the road where every highway of the Empire began, until his heartbeat slowed from a gallop back to a walk.

Burned the tally-shed himself, Scaeva had sworn.

And Senator Quintus Servilius Priscus—a consular patrician whose word could squash Hermippus's debt-collector like a bedbug under a sandal—wanted one pre-fire Subortanae kiln leaf bad enough to set his chief Greek *tabularius* hunting river-mud for it.

Corvus shifted the cracked willow hod onto his other shoulder, stepped carefully over Priscus's spat fennel husk without smudging it, and walked east toward the Forum Transitorium to earn his six copper asses before noon.

* * *

Behind Minerva's narrow colonnade, wedged into an upstairs brick gallery above a noisy wheelwright's yard and an importer of dried Damascus plums, **Sextus Pompeius Festus the Younger**—no relation to the lexicographer except by stolen pretension, a plump Sicilian Greek in a violet-bordered pallium smelled through with quince-pomade—taught sixteen rich boys at two thousand sesterces a head how to wave their right hands like Cicero while accusing imaginary stepmothers of poisoning imaginary generals.

Corvus got six copper *asses* a morning there—half what he earned treading piss at Lucceius's fullery in the late shift, and worth ten times the difference—to carry hot charcoal up to the three iron tripod-braziers, sweep plum-stones off the mosaic floor, and plane the previous day's ruined metaphors smooth on forty boxwood wax tablets with a warmed iron *spathula* while the Sicilian paced between two plaster busts of Demosthenes and Hortensius.

Kneeling in the cold draught beside the back pillar with a stack of scarred tablets across his thighs, Corvus kept his eyes down on the beeswax and drank every syllable in the room like stolen Falernian.

For nineteen mornings he had memorized everything Festus threw at those sixteen bored, perfumed skulls: the five parts of a forensic oration (*exordium, narratio, partitio, confirmatio, peroratio*); Hermagoras's doctrine of *status*—whether the fight turned on *coniectura* (did the hand strike?), *definitio* (what did law call the blow?), or *qualitas* (was the blow lawful?); how to drop the voice a fifth at the end of a *membrum* before driving home the *cretic-trochee* cadence (*esse videatur*) that made grey-bearded Centumviral judges nod in their woollen mufflers without noticing a witness had lied about the date. Half the patrician boys yawned behind oiled knuckles, scratched caricatures of charioteers into their wax margins, or whispered bets on Saturday's gladiators while Corvus, scraping their blunders smooth with a hot iron knife, stored every rule away behind his forehead beside his father's land-tables.

That morning's *controversia* was property law, drawn straight from the Urban Praetor's Edict because Senator Priscus's nineteen-year-old nephew **Aulus Volusenus Niger** was slated to sit second bench next spring in his first Centumviral inheritance cause and needed drilling before he embarrassed his uncle's house.

Volusenus stood on the low cedar dais in the center of the gallery, throwing back the spotless, chalk-whitened fold of his *toga* over his left shoulder so sunlight flashed off the heavy red carnelian *quadriga* signet ring on his fourth finger. He was tall, broad-hipped, handsome in a soft, heavy-lipped patrician way, smelling ten feet off of Cosmus's cinnamon-myrrh hair-oil; two slave *pedisequi* sat on folding stools behind him holding his spare handkerchiefs and a silver flask of warm honey-water for his throat.

"*Iudices!*" Volusenus declaimed, voice booming pleasantly off the brick barrel-vault while the wheelwright's iron tire-hammer clanged underneath. "Look upon my client's ancestral boundary! Before the November floods came down from the Sabine hills, fifty *iugera* of rich willow-meadow lay north of the river bend under Caius's plough, marked by terminal stones consecrated to Jupiter Terminus since King Numa's reign! Overnight the raging Tiber tears away ten *iugera* in a single block—oak trees, boundary-cippus, vine-props standing whole—and welds that soil against Maevius's downstream bank! Maevius claims windfall by *alluvio*! Yet what says natural equity, judges? Does a thief who catches my cloak when the wind blows it off my shoulders become master of the wool?"

Four boys on the front bench clapped politely; Festus the Sicilian pursed plum-stained lips, wagging one ringed finger gently to mark rhythm.

"Good fire in the chest, Aulus Volusenus, crisp metaphor on the wind-blown cloak," Festus purred, "though when you argue before the Fourth Spear next spring, give the jurists one grain of black-letter bone under the sauce! Suppose Maevius's advocate cites Sabinus and Gaius against you, claiming river-bank additions pass *iure gentium* the instant mud touches mud—how do you compute the lost boundary line once the river shifts its bed?"

Volusenus twisted his carnelian *quadriga* ring halfway round his finger, waving an airy white hand that had never held anything heavier than a dice-box. "Simple arithmetic, master! You sight straight south from the old hill-stone to the opposite willow-stump at ninety degrees, halve the chord of the river-bend by length alone, and demand ten *iugera* back by *vindicatio* on the spot, trees and all, from the day the mud touched!"

Down by the back pillar, Corvus's warmed iron *spathula* stopped mid-scrape across a wax leaf.

He told himself to shut his teeth. He had six copper *asses* coming at noon, his shin was almost healed under Lucida's stolen sheep-fat, and nobody paid charcoal-boys to know Gaius from turnip-tops. Yet hearing a man in a thousand-sesterce tunic halve a curved river-arc by a single straight chord—an error Gaius Cassius Corvus would have beaten out of an eleven-year-old boy with a thorn-switch in freezing rain—made Corvus's right thumb rub hard against his scarred knuckle before his brain caught his tongue.

"Then Maevius keeps all ten *iugera* and laughs you out of the Basilica before lunch," Corvus said to the wax tablet on his knee.

He had not meant to pitch it loud; only the wheelwright's hammer downstairs paused between blows at that exact instant, leaving the vaulted gallery dead quiet except for pine-charcoal popping in the brazier.

Sixteen oiled heads turned as one toward the back pillar.

Festus blinked as if a terracotta floor-tile had suddenly quoted Homer. Up on the cedar dais, Volusenus's heavy patrician jaw flushed dull brick-red from collar to ear-tip.

"Did the coal-bucket squeak?" Volusenus asked the front bench, drawing an obliging titter from two equestrian cousins. He stepped to the edge of the dais, squinting down past his own chalked hem at Corvus kneeling among wax-shavings in a patched fuller-stained tunic with soot smeared across one collarbone. "Stand up when you look at your betters, gutter-rat. What did you mumble?"

Corvus set the iron *spathula* neatly across the charcoal rim so it would not scorch the mosaic, wiped both palms down his thighs, and stood up. He was half a head shorter than Volusenus, three stone lighter, barefoot on November stone; he kept his eyes fixed level on the clasp of Volusenus's tunic rather than dropping them to the floor, and his blinking stopped dead.

"Two mistakes, master," Corvus said in clean, unhurried Latin, clipping the broad Sabine *o* flat the way he had practiced listening to Festus's best scrolls for three weeks. "First in law: sudden avulsion—*vis fluminis* tearing away a whole recognizable block with standing oaks—is not gradual *alluvio* at all. Under Gaius and Julian's Edict, Caius still owns the soil *until* those oak roots strike new living fiber into Maevius's subsoil. Claim from the day the mud touched and you concede incorporation, which kills your own *vindicatio*."

Behind the doorway curtain at the head of the outside stair, unnoticed by the sixteen boys staring at Corvus's bare feet, a man in a dark grey *paenula* cloak had paused with a bundle of sealed scroll-cases under his arm: **Phileros**, come up from the Forum Transitorium to collect young Volusenus for his uncle Priscus's midday walk. Three bone wax-scrapers hung motionless at his throat as his sharp Greek eyes locked onto Corvus's profile.

Festus the Sicilian's mouth had fallen slightly open. "And—and the second mistake, boy?"

"Geometry," Corvus said, pointing one soot-darkened finger at the invisible river on the mosaic floor between himself and the dais. "Halving the straight chord of a parabolic river-bend cheats your own client of nearly a seventh of his meadow: the *segmentum* between arc and string. A licensed *agrimensor* never sights from a shifting willow-stump; he backs up onto dry *ager arcifinius* above flood-mark, sets his *groma* cross-staff on two fixed *rigores*, drops perpendicular offsets every twenty *actus* into the old dry channel, and sums the trapezoids. Otherwise your opponent calls one ten-denarius land-surveyor after lunch and proves your claim-formula over-demanded by half a *iugerum*—*plus petitio loco*—which forfeits the entire suit without appeal."

Dead silence hung under the brick vault. Downstairs the wheelwright's hammer started clanging again: *clink, clink, clink*.

One of the equestrian cousins in the second row let out an involuntary snort of laughter behind his hand before choking it off.

Volusenus came off the cedar dais in two long strides, cinnamon hair-oil reeking hot as he reached Corvus's pillar. Corvus saw the blow coming two heartbeats early—Volusenus dropped his right shoulder like an untrained tavern brawler—and every muscle in Corvus's legs coiled to step inside the swing and drive his forehead up under the patrician's soft chin the way he had broken the yellow-ribboned dandy at the Firewall arch.

Halfway through shifting his weight, Corvus stopped himself cold.

Strike a senator's nephew in front of sixteen citizen witnesses and two slave footmen, and the Urban Prefect's lictors peeled the skin off a fifteen-year-old *humilior*'s ribs with elm rods before sunset, Crustumina tribe or no Crustumina tribe.

So Corvus locked his heels flat on the mosaic and took it.

Volusenus did not even use his fist; he slashed sideways with the heavy brass-butt end of his eight-inch ivory writing-stylus, catching Corvus hard across the left corner of his mouth. Teeth punched through inner lip; hot salt blood filled Corvus's tongue instantly. The impact knocked his temple back against the plastered brick pier, sending stars skittering white across the bust of Demosthenes.

"Six asses to scrape wax, dung-beetle, not to bark law at men whose threshold you aren't clean enough to piss against!" Volusenus panted, wiping a tiny fleck of Corvus's spit-blood off his ivory stylus onto Corvus's soot-streaked shoulder before turning on Festus. "Keep kennel-sweepings out of the hall, Greek, or my uncle hears what kind of insolence two thousand sesterces buys here! Get my cloak, Dama!"

Festus fluttered both plump hands in theatrical horror, already reaching for a switch to shoo Corvus toward the back buckets so the class wouldn't walk out. "Out to the ash-yard, boy—go rinse your mouth at the cistern and don't show your nose upstairs until they've gone—"

Corvus spat a dark red mouthful neatly into the cold ash-pan beside the brazier—not onto Festus's mosaic, because someone else would only get beaten cleaning it—picked up his iron *spathula*, laid it straight alongside the scraped boxwood stack, and walked out onto the open brick stair-landing without touching his split lip.

Volusenus and his two footmen pushed past him going down, laughing loudly now about some dancing-girl from Gades to cover the awkwardness.

Phileros lingered two steps behind them on the landing, pretending to tighten the leather strap round his scroll-cylinders until Volusenus's white *toga* cleared the wheelwright's archway below. Then the Greek archive-freedman looked sideways at Corvus standing against the parapet with blood beading dark down his chin.

"Plus petitio loco," Phileros murmured in Greek soft as pumice on papyrus. "Where does a barefoot charcoal-carrier with a Crustumina burr learn Julian's rule on over-claiming by survey-trapezoid, boy?"

Corvus looked straight at the three bone wax-scrapers hanging at Phileros's throat, recognizing the exact curve of the narrowest blade: treasury clerks used that bevel to lift spoiled seals cleanly off pine leaves without scarring the grain underneath.

"My father carried a *groma* before he drank it," Corvus answered in Greek just as quiet, tasting iron on his teeth. "And Festus leaves his *Institutes* unrolled on the lectern while he eats plums."

Phileros's thin eyebrows lifted the thickness of a coin. His gaze traveled slowly down from Corvus's split mouth to the soot on his collarbone —noting instantaneously that the soot sat only on top of old yellow fuller's-ammonia bleaching along the wool hem—and dropped lower still to the pale half-moon scar across Corvus's right thumb knuckle: the exact diameter of a round two-inch clay *signaculum* handle when hot bronze kicked sideways in the press.

Neither of them said *Domitia Lucilla*. Neither of them said *Hermippus*.

Down in the yard Volusenus shouted impatiently for his uncle's clerk.

"There is a fried-fish and wine stall called the Three Cranes in the crooked lane behind the Vicus Cuprius," Phileros said conversationally, tucking his scroll-case back under his elbow. "The Syrian behind the counter waters his Veientine less after the second watch, because the *vigiles* corporal drinks in the back booth. If a surveyor's son happened to want forty sesterces for an old pine shingle before frost cracks it, without any one-eared camp-dogs sniffing the stair, a man might sit there tonight until the oil-lamp burns half down."

Phileros trotted lightly down the brick steps into the noon glare without looking back.

Corvus leaned both forearms on the cold brick parapet, spat once more into the wheelwright's sawdust twenty feet below, and counted the heartbeat thudding in his cut lip.

* * *

He did not tell Lucida where he was going when dusk fell.

That was the part that sat cold as unslaked lime behind his breastbone while he waited for Berenice and Lucida to turn toward the back dormer over their evening mortar of white lead. Telling Lucida would have meant Lucida coming down the Vicus Cuprius fifty paces behind him in the rain with her honed amphora shard tucked in her waist-cord; and if Phileros turned out to have sold the meeting to Hermippus or Scaeva after all—unlikely, since Senator Priscus hated Vedius's guts, yet freedmen took coin

with both hands—then Lucida walking into the Three Cranes would put Lucida straight back into Vedius Pollio's property-chest while Corvus got his ribs broken in an alley.

Whereas if Corvus went alone carrying *one* secondary pine leaf—Number Four out of the six stolen tallies, recording only nine hundred *tegulae* roof-tiles carted from Kiln Two in August before the big double-stamping fraud even peaked—and left the bronze *signaculum*, his cedar birth-diptych, and the other five leaves hidden safe under Berenice's hearth-brick with Lucida upstairs, then the worst Scaeva could take off Corvus's carcass that night was one sliver of pine and seventy-six pounds of Sabine bone.

"Lucceius's Greek carder says a bookseller down on the Argiletum wants two boys to shift damp papyrus crates out of a leaking cellar after the first watch," Corvus told Lucida casually as he knotted a strip of rag round his ankles against the November mud. In the dim tallow-light behind Berenice's screen he kept the left side of his face angled away from the wick; when Lucida had glanced at his swollen lip coming up from the fullery an hour back, he had told her a wet timber slipped on Festus's stair. "Pays six sesterces flat if we finish before the third watch."

Lucida paused with the porphyry muller in both wet white-lead-streaked hands, studying his shoulder-blades across the smoky garret. Her dark amber eyes narrowed half a hair—fifteen years together meant she heard the slight over-smoothness in his vowels whenever he rounded off a corner—then dropped to his bruised knuckles.

"Leave your fuller's cloak dry here and take Beroe's oiled goat-hide cape," Lucida said after two breaths, nodding toward the peg by the door. "If you catch chest-pleurisy hauling wet crates in November rain, medicine costs more than six sesterces. Wait—come here."

Before he could duck out the fir door she wiped lead-paste meticulously off two fingers onto a clean rag, stepped close enough that he smelled bitter almond, sharp vinegar, and warm girl-skin rising off her collar, and touched one cold fingertip just below his split lip: not pressing the cut, only tilting his chin half an inch toward the lamp so she saw the clean, straight cut an ivory stylus-butt left, nothing at all like rough pine timber.

She said nothing about timber. Her eyes held his for three beats, giving him room to speak if he chose, and when he kept his jaw shut, she pulled the oiled goat-hide hood up over his wet black hair with a single brisk tug.

"Back before the third watch horn blows," Lucida murmured in low Greek so Berenice wouldn't hear. "Or I come looking with a butcher's hook, Sabine."

"Before the third watch," Corvus promised, and went down the seventy-eight dark steps feeling dirtier than eight hours in Lucceius's piss-vat had ever made him.

Rain fell thin and sleet-sharp across the Subura, turning horse-dung and fuller-sludge on the cobbles into black grease. Heavy freight-carts had the main Clivus choked hub-to-hub, oxen steaming under wet hides while link-boys cursed drowned torches, so Corvus threaded the narrow stepped cut-ways behind the coppersmiths' stalls, counting every turn, checking shadows behind water-spouts, ducking twice into dark doorway niches until he was dead certain nobody followed his heels.

The **Popina of the Three Cranes** sat wedged below street-level at the elbow where a vaulted sewer-spur gurgled down toward the Forum Transitorium: three chipped red cranes painted on wet stucco beside a counter of masonry into which four steaming dolia jars were sunk up to their rims, ladling hot watered wine spiced with cheap wormwood, boiled sheep's trotters, and salted lupin-beans to wet carters and night-watchmen.

In the low back room behind a greasy felt curtain, two clay triple-spouted oil-lamps hung on iron chains above three scarred beech tables. Four off-duty *vigiles* of the Fourth Cohort in brown undress tunics rattled knucklebones (*tali*) in a horn cup by the charcoal pan, helmets stacked under the bench; in the far corner booth, back flat against solid tufa wall where neither street door nor privy-passage could surprise him, sat **Phileros** alone behind a pewter jug of dark red Veientine and two clay cups.

Corvus slipped wet goat-hide off his head, shook rain onto the sawdust, and slid onto the narrow bench opposite without waiting to be asked.

Phileros did not look at Corvus's hands; he looked past Corvus's left ear at the felt curtain for five slow counts to make sure no shadow stopped behind the wool, then pushed the second clay cup across scarred beechwood.

"Drink it while it's hot," Phileros said in low Latin. "The Syrian boils cassia-bark twigs in it to hide the vinegar, yet it keeps the river-damp out

of the lungs. Volusenus told his uncle over dinner that a half-wild Sabine fuller's-boy corrected his *alluvio* geometry in front of Festus's whole upper bench, and demanded Festus flog you out of the quarter."

Corvus wrapped cold fingers round the warm clay cup without drinking yet. "And what did Senator Priscus say?"

"Senator Priscus told his nephew that a patrician who gets beaten on Julian's Edict by a charcoal-boy should read more Gaius and wear less cinnamon oil," Phileros replied dryly, allowing one corner of his shaved mouth to twitch. "Then he told me to find out whether you stole your Latin along with your brick-wax, Lucius Cassius Corvus, son of Gaius, of the Crustumina tribe."

Corvus's fingers did not tighten on the clay cup; only the grey-green eyes went flat and still over the steam. So Phileros had gone straight back to the Temple of Saturn after lunch and cross-checked *Crustumina* against Hermippus's November debt-board in half an hour. Good. Better dealing with a sharp knife than a dull hoe.

"Hermippus chalked three thousand two hundred sesterces against my dead father's name on Saturn's fourth board," Corvus said evenly. "Bought off Numerius the cattle-broker since the Ides of October so Vedius Pollio can clap irons on me if I step near the Praetor's tribunal to file abstention —or near Senator Priscus's auditors to testify how many bricks came out of Subortanae."

"Three thousand two hundred principal, plus four hundred eighty accrued *centesimae* interest," Phileros corrected mildly, nibbling a salted lupin-bean and slipping the skin neatly onto the table edge. "Hermippus registered transfer of the *chirographum* eight days ago through Aulus Castricius's bank in the Basilica Argentaria. Thorough fellow, Hermippus. Though careless in small countryside matters, such as letting a drunken tally-clerk named Rufus sleep beside six pre-stamped kiln-leaves on the night of the fourteenth."

Across the low room the four *vigiles* roared as someone threw a *Venus*—all four knucklebones landing different faces up—and copper *asses* clattered across wet wood.

Phileros leaned two inches closer across the table. Up close he smelled of cedar scroll-oil, gall-ink, and bitter wormwood wine. "Put what you brought flat under your palm on the bench, boy. If it carries Rufus's own

cursive tally-mark and the pre-dated workshop stamp before the September rains, forty sesterces in clean silver sit in my belt-pouch right now."

Corvus reached inside his tunic—not to his waist, behind his left armpit where he had strapped the single pine leaf flat with a strip of rag—and slid Leaf Four face-down onto the scarred beechwood, keeping four fingers planted firmly over the corner.

"Forty sesterces in silver," Corvus said quietly, "buys you a look, Phileros. Not the wood."

Phileros stared down at Corvus's soot-grained knuckles, then up into Corvus's cut mouth. "Don't play forum-usurer before your beard grows, boy. Scaeva's runners asked for a Sabine fifteen-year-old and a dark Syrian girl at two Trans-Tiberim bathhouses yesterday afternoon. By next *nundinae* they work up the Argiletum stair by stair. Forty sesterces buys you bread to walk to Campania."

"Walk to Campania and Scaeva rides us down on hired mules before Bovillae," Corvus said, thumb rubbing once, slow and deliberate, across his white half-moon knuckle-scar as the cold stress-lock clicked shut behind his eyes, pushing him straight past caution into the bigger bet. "Besides, one August tile-leaf doesn't break Hermippus's affidavit before Rusticus's trust-arbiters. Hermippus simply says Rufus mis-dated one wet rack of roof-tiles and docks Rufus's wages. To prove forty thousand stolen *bipedales* went straight out of dead Domitia Lucilla's clay-pits into Vedius Pollio's private Subura tenements, Senator Priscus needs three things: this leaf to show the double-count started in summer; an eyewitness who stood in Number Three trench and knows which barge-masters hauled the unrecorded night-loads downstream; and somebody small enough to crawl inside those new Vicus Patricius walls before plaster goes on and read the backwards consular stamps baked into the mortar-courses."

Phileros stopped chewing his lupin-bean. For five full breaths neither man blinked in the red lamp-smoke.

"And what," the Greek asked very softly, "does this small, dirty miracle-worker imagine Senator Quintus Servilius Priscus pays for all three?"

"Forty sesterces silver on the table tonight for Leaf Four," Corvus said without drawing breath. "Second: Senator Priscus's outer notary enters a pending *in integrum restitutio* petition on behalf of a minor under twenty-five—Lucius Cassius Corvus, aged fifteen—staying execution on

Hermippus's bought *chirographum* for six months while my minority status is examined, filed inside a batch of forty routine estate stays so Hermippus's clerk doesn't spot the name until December. Third: a stool in your outer vestibule four afternoons a week scraping Priscus's spoilt wax and copying court-pleadings, at three sesterces a day, where Scaeva's street-dogs cannot lay a finger on Senator Priscus's household runner without answering to the Urban Prefect."

Phileros gazed at him for so long that grease congealed white round the rim of the sheep's-trotter bowl on the next table. Then the Greek let out a silent breath through his nose, reached into his leather belt-wallet, and laid **ten silver denarii**—forty sesterces, heavy Antonine silver with Peace holding an olive-branch on the reverse—in a neat vertical column beside Corvus's scarred thumb.

"Sixteen sesterces a week: four afternoons at four sesterces, starting the day after tomorrow at the eighth hour, back service-gate on the Clivus Scauri," Phileros said, raising Corvus's wage by one sestertius a day without being asked—not from kindness, because four sesterces bound a boy under formal *locatio operarum* household hire whereas three left him casual street-labor. "You wash your feet at the gate-trough before touching my vestibule floor, you never speak to Senator Priscus unless Senator Priscus speaks to your sandals first, and if you ever quote Gaius aloud in front of young Volusenus inside our walls, I feed your tongue to the kitchen eels myself. Take your hand off the pine."

Corvus swept the ten silver denarii off the beechwood with his left hand while lifting his right off Leaf Four in the same clean motion.

Phileros tilted the thin waxed pine tablet three inches toward the oil-lamp, never wide enough for the dice-playing *vigiles* across the smoke to glimpse, checked Rufus's cramped numeral strokes and the faint red clay thumb-smear at the bottom margin with a connoisseur's squint, and slid it smoothly inside his scroll-case.

"Where are the other five leaves and the bronze die, Sabine?" Phileros asked pleasantly, reaching for his wine-cup.

"In dry earth outside the walls where rivers don't flood," Corvus lied without a flicker. "When the stay on my father's debt-bond bears the Praetor's seal in December, we dig again."

Phileros drank two swallows of spiced Veientine, set the clay cup down, and studied Corvus's cut mouth with something halfway between professional disgust and cold kinship. "How old did you say you were—fifteen? By forty you'll either sit on the Praetor's bench in white wool or hang in iron chains off the Gemonian Stairs, boy, and I wouldn't lay two copper *asses* either way. Drink your vinegar before the watch changes."

Corvus drained the hot bitter wine in three gulps—it burned down his empty gullet into his ribs like liquid charcoal—tucked six of the ten silver denarii tight inside the split hem of his inner waist-band where even Berenice wouldn't feel them, and kept **four silver denarii**—sixteen sesterces, still nearly three times the six sesterces he had promised Lucida—loose in his cheek-pouch and fist as he stepped back out into the freezing November rain.

Halfway up the black canyon of the Clivus Suburanus, hugging the wet travertine base of a baker's archway while three chained timber-wagons groaned downhill showering mud from locked iron brake-shoes, Corvus stopped under a sputtering shrine-lamp to the *Lares Compitales* and stared down at the four wet silver coins resting in his palm.

Tell her all of it upstairs, said the voice that had shared every crust and frost-bite with her since they were seven years old hiding stolen figs behind Kiln Three. *Put all ten silver pieces in her lap, tell her Phileros has Leaf Four, tell her Senator Priscus's back gate opens day after tomorrow on the Caelian Hill.*

Then he remembered Lucida's fierce, proud chin lifting in Berenice's garret when she heard Vedius Pollio owned her deathbed; remembered how fast she had stepped onto the fuller's coping between Sticho's rod and Sura's burned arm; knew, as surely as he knew the width of that alley, that if Lucida learned tonight that Senator Priscus was hunting Vedius's Subura tenements and brick-leases, she wouldn't stay crouched behind Berenice's reed screen grinding white lead while Corvus carried briefs. She would walk straight down toward the fire to cut her own piece out of Vedius's hide before anyone could treat her as cargo to be rescued.

Six months, Corvus told the rain dripping off the shrine-eaves. *Let me get the Praetor's stay sealed on my father's debt and save two hundred sesterces from Priscus's vestibule first, so when Scaeva comes up the stair we have iron*

under our feet. What she doesn't know until December cannot get her killed in November.

Down toward the Forum the bronze *bucina* horn of the *Cohortes Vigilum* sounded the third watch of the night: long, brazen, mournful across a hundred thousand wet tile roofs.

Corvus slipped the six hidden denarii flat against his hipbone, climbed the seventy-eight dark steps two at a stride before Lucida could come down the lane with her butcher's hook, and pushed open Berenice's fir door.

Berenice was already snoring harsh and regular through her broken teeth under the wolf-pelt by the dead brazier. Behind the reed screen a single tiny night-wick floated in olive-dregs; Lucida sat cross-legged under the fuller's cloak, hair down in a thick black river over her shoulders to dry, her honed amphora shard resting bare across her knee while she stitched a torn seam in Corvus's spare wool ankle-wrap with bone needle and waxed hemp.

The instant the oak bar dropped back into its brackets, her shoulders loosened half an inch—she had been counting steps on the ladder since the horn blew—and she looked up at his soaked face.

"Late by twelve steps, Sabine," she whispered, setting the amphora shard silently aside on the straw and holding out a dry coarse towel warmed against her own belly under the cloak. "Bookseller's cellar flood?"

"Worse—two crates of rotten Egyptian papyrus split in the mud, and the old miser made me stack every roll dry by lamp-light before he unlocked his cash-box," Corvus whispered back, dropping to his knees on the straw and opening his right fist so **four bright silver denarii**—sixteen sesterces, more silver than either of them had held in one palm since before her mother died—caught the tiny yellow oil-flame between them. "Paid sixteen sesterces instead of six because the other boy bolted when the rain turned to sleet, and wants me back four afternoons a week sorting Greek scroll-tags."

Lucida's breath caught: tiny, sharp, genuine joy lighting her dark eyes gold in the wick-glow as she touched one silver head of Antoninus Pius with a lead-roughened fingertip. Sixteen sesterces was three weeks of garret straw, charcoal for cold nights, real leather soles under both their feet before December frost split their heels, and five days free of Lucceius's burning piss-vats.

"Sixteen," she breathed, looking straight up into his face with fierce, unguarded pride, reaching up with both warm hands to rub sleet-water out

of his black hair while staying careful not to brush his split left lip. “I told Beroe you’d own half the street before spring. Come under the wool—your ears are cold as river-stones.”

Corvus stripped off the wet outer tunic, careful to fold his inner waistband flat underneath where the six unmentioned silver coins and Phileros’s Caelian gate-hour sat cold as lead weights, and lay down facing her on the narrow barley-straw. Lucida tucked the coarse cloak tight behind his freezing shoulder-blades, pressed her bare feet between his shins to warm them, and blew out the floating wick.

In the pitch dark above the rumbling stone-wagons, Corvus felt her breathing slow against his collarbone, trusting every syllable he had put into her palm; and for a long time after she slept, he lay with both eyes open toward the invisible rafters, listening to November rain beat on the pantiles and tasting salt blood where Volusenus’s ivory stylus had cut his mouth.

Chapter IV

White Lead and Rue

Saturnalia, Eighteenth of December, AD 156 · Lucida

On the second day of the Saturnalia, while half the Subura staggered blind-drunk down the steps in conical felt liberty-caps roaring *"Io Saturnalia!"* and rattling legal dice on every butcher's block from the Firewall to the Esquiline, Corvus began coughing rust onto the barley-straw.

At first dawn it had sounded only like the dry bark he brought home from the Caelian cisterns whenever Phileros kept him copying wax until dusk in an unheated vestibule. By the third hour, when Lucida knelt beside the wicker screen with a clay bowl of hot barley-gruel, he could not sit upright without catching his left ribs in both fists as if an iron spike had been driven between the fifth and sixth bones. His skin burned dry as kiln-brick under her palm; his lips were cracked dark at the left corner over the fresh white scar Volusenus's stylus had left in November; and when the spasm doubled him sideways, what came up onto the unbleached rag was thin, frothy, and streaked the color of corroded bronze.

Berenice stood over the screen chewing roasted pine-nuts out of an apron pocket, one milky eye aimed at the rafters, one black eye fixed on the rag in Lucida's hand.

"Pleurisy," the old woman said without emotion. "Side-fever. My second husband took it hauling snow-sacks down from Alba in Hadrian's tenth year. Drowned in his own chest-water on the fifth night and left me four brass pots and a lame mule."

"He isn't drowning," Lucida said, dipping a linen strip into cold vinegar-water and laying it flat across Corvus's forehead. Under the wet cloth his grey-green eyes were too bright, pupils wide, tracking shadows on the sloped pantiles that weren't there. "What cuts the phlegm?"

"Cretan hyssop boiled in squill-vinegar, hot linseed poultices changed every hour, and three bronze cupping-horns laid under the shoulder-blade by somebody who knows where the lung-vein runs without cooking the meat," Berenice answered, ticking items off horny yellow fingers. "Asclepiades the Greek down by the Temple of Peace has clean bronze bells and real Egyptian squill. Charges five silver denarii to climb six flights in Saturnalia week, plus two denarii for the syrup. Have you got twenty-eight sesterces sewn in your shift, little crow?"

Lucida knew to the single copper *quadrans* what they had.

Under the loose hearth-brick lay the bronze *signaculum* die and the five remaining Subortanae pine tallies—untouchable, because trying to peddle imperial brick-tallies on Saturnalia morning without Corvus's tongue would bring Scaeva down on their necks before noon—plus **eleven sesterces and two asses** left out of Corvus's Caelian copying-money after buying winter shoes, charcoal, and December straw-rent. Not knowing Corvus still had twenty-four sesterces stitched secretly inside his inner waist-band—the soaked tunic rolled tight under his aching head as a pillow—Lucida counted eleven sesterces against twenty-eight and came up seventeen short.

Behind the screen Corvus caught her wrist with dry, scorching fingers. Even half out of his head with side-pain, he had heard the sum.

"Leave the Greek," he rasped, every word sawed short by the knife under his ribs. "Linseed meal costs… four asses at the oil-stall. Boil that. Don't go out on the Clivus while the… fullers are drunk."

"Shut your teeth and breathe shallow, Sabine," Lucida told him, prizing his hot fingers gently open and tucking his arm back under the wool cloak so the draught off the dormer wouldn't strike his sweat. She stood up, stepped past the wicker screen to Berenice's marble tombstone slab, and looked straight into the old woman's good black eye. "Whose basket goes up the hills tonight?"

Berenice stopped chewing pine-nuts. Slowly she reached up to the top shelf behind the dried squid-bones and lifted down a square willow hand-basket lined in oiled purple linen. Inside sat three stoppered alabaster pots of *cerussa*—the velvety, dead-white lead-carbonate face-cream patrician women plastered over freckles and wine-veins—two little horn boxes of Syrian alkanet lip-red, and, buried underneath a false bottom of dried

lavender stalks, **two thumb-sized phials of thick green glass** stopped with red beeswax over bladder-skin.

Rue-oil, black hellebore root, and Cretan savin, boiled down three-to-one. Five drops in mulled wine brought on a late moon-bleeding with cramps hard enough to make a woman bite wood; twenty drops emptied a three-month womb before morning—or stopped the mother's heart if her kidneys were weak and she drank the sediment.

Under the old Sullan statute on *venena*—poisons and secret drugs—a *humilior* caught selling an abortive draught that killed or sickened a citizen's wife didn't go before a polite civil arbiter; she went down into the Tullianum or out beyond the Esquiline Gate to feed crows.

"Myrtale went off at dawn with a trumpeter from the Castra Misenatium wearing his master's dinner-shoes," Berenice said low. "Up on the Caelian Hill, behind the arches of Claudius's aqueduct, stands the town house of **Lucius Ceionius Commodus**—old Aelius Caesar's boy—where his elder sister **Ceionia Fabia** keeps her winter *oecus*. Her chief tire-woman, a freedwoman named Dorcas with a mole on her nostril, ordered the three white-lead pots for the lady's Saturnalia masque tonight, and the two green phials for a chamber-maid who let one of young Lucius's chariot-friends lift her tunic in November. Twelve silver denarii on delivery. Ten for my box; two—eight sesterces—for the legs that carry it, plus whatever door-silver the tire-woman throws if you keep your eyes on the tiles and come back before the second watch."

Eight sesterces plus eleven made nineteen—still nine sesterces short of Asclepiades's twenty-eight.

"Give me three denarii out of the twelve," Lucida said flatly, picking up the porphyry muller to finish smoothing the third alabaster pot's paste with two practiced figure-eight turns, "and lend me the fourth against two weeks' lead-grinding, or take the basket up the Caelian ice yourself with one eye while forty thousand drunks throw torch-butts in the alleys."

Berenice hissed like an old goose, hand flying to her belt-pouch as if wounded. "Four denarii! Sixteen sesterces for an hour's walk? By Astarte, your mother bred a horse-leech!"

"My mother bred a girl who doesn't drop green glass in front of aediles," Lucida answered, wiping white lead off her knuckles with vinegar-tow so not a speck remained under her fingernails to poison bread later. Behind the

screen Corvus coughed again—a wet, tearing hitch he tried to muffle into his forearm so she wouldn't hear—and Lucida's jaw went hard as river-flint. "Sixteen sesterces, paid directly into Asclepiades's hand the instant I walk back through that door with your nine denarii, Beroe. Deal or carry?"

Berenice glared from Lucida's chin to the muffled cough behind the reeds, spat a pine-nut shell into the charcoal pan where it flared yellow, and shoved the willow basket against Lucida's ribs.

"Lose one pot or let a *vigiles* corporal look under that lavender," Berenice whispered, "and don't bother climbing back up my seventy-eight steps, girl. Put on Myrtale's clean brown shawl over your head—and take the iron bodkin out of the wool-box. Saturnalia makes swine out of senators and senators out of swine; neither sort keeps its hands to itself after dusk."

* * *

Rome at Saturnalia dusk looked like a city sacked by comedians.

All down the Clivus Suburanus and up the paved rise toward the Carinae, every shop-shutter had been painted with red ochre garlands and hung with little clay figurines—*sigillaria*—sold for two asses apiece at street-corners as holiday gifts. Slaves walked five abreast down the middle of the basalt road wearing their masters' cast-off *synthesis* dinner-robes in scarlet, saffron, and leek-green, woollen *pileus* caps cocked over oiled curls, bellowing tavern catches at passing equestrians who, for five licensed days of December, had to grin and shout *"Io Saturnalia!"* back instead of calling lictors. At every fountain-basin men crouched ten deep round chalked gaming-boards, throwing ivory dice openly under the noses of sleepy urban watchmen; outside a butcher's stall near the Meta Sudans, two drunken fuller's boys were holding a squealing piglet over a brazier to singe its bristles live while a ring of painted Syrian flute-girls pelted them with walnut shells and snowballs scooped out of shaded garden ditches.

Lucida walked briskly along the wall-shadow with Myrtale's brown woollen shawl pulled forward over her dark braids, the willow basket hooked securely on her left forearm, her right hand inside her shawl closed round seven inches of three-sided iron mattress-bodkin.

Twice before she cleared the Colosseum valley men stepped into her path: first a towering German bodyguard from some senator's escort,

reeking of spiced beer and mutton-fat, who caught a corner of her shawl laughing something thick in Rhine-Latin until she slipped out of the pin-fold, rapped the flat of her basket hard against his wrist-bone, and vanished behind four passing mule-litters; then, darker up the winding garden walls of the **Caelian Hill**, two teenage patrician boys in untied dining-slippers chasing a shrieking bath-girl with soot-blackened pinecones.

Up on the Caelian, the Subura's roar dropped below like surf under a sea-cliff.

Here high brick garden walls topped with broken glass and overhanging cypress boughs enclosed whole private acres of winter green. Lead water-pipes sang softly inside roadside shrines; torches burned clean olive-oil scented with frankincense in iron brackets beside bronze-studded postern gates—no smoky tallow or rancid *amurca* here—and through high clerestory windows glazed with translucent sheets of split Cappadocian *lapis specularis* drifted the shimmer of twenty-branched bronze candelabra, lyre-strings, and high, cultivated laughter.

At the service postern of the *Domus Ceionia* behind Claudius's great rusticated stone arches, Lucida showed the little lead tally-token Berenice had given her to a sleepy Cappadocian gate-porter wearing a gilt paper crown crooked over his bald pate.

"Dorcas's girl with the face-pots," the porter grunted, waving her down a whitewashed subterranean *cryptoporticus* warm from the bath-furnaces underneath. "Second spiral stair on the left, past the pastry-ovens. Don't cross the main peristyle or the steward docks Dorcas's wine-jar—the young master's got twenty Greens charioteers and six senators' sons drinking snowed Setine in the *triclinium*."

Lucida climbed the narrow travertine service-stair into warmth such as her skin had never felt in December.

Under the mosaic floors ran hollow brick *hypocausta* flues carrying clean wood-heat from invisible slave-stoked furnaces below, turning the very stone under Lucida's cheap leather soles gentle as May sunlight. Yet five paces down the serving-corridor behind the dining-hall curtains, she saw how Caelian warmth was stoked.

In a tiled scullery alcove off the pantry—four paces from silk-hung archways through which silver platters of stuffed dormice, sea-urchins packed in snow, and roast wild boar nested in dates were gliding out on the

shoulders of garlanded boys—a fifty-year-old under-steward with a leather gag-strap wrapped round his own fist had a twelve-year-old Bithynian cup-bearer bent bare-backed across an upturned wine-amphora. The boy wore a holiday *pileus* liberty-cap still pinned absurdly to his curls; blood ran in four neat red ribbons down his pale ribs where a three-tongued whalebone whip (*scutica*) was coming down in rhythmic, practiced silence because he had chipped the lip of a murrhine dipping-ladle. Every time the whalebone bit, the under-steward shoved a vinegar-sponge against the boy's open mouth so no cry would spoil the holiday equality in the *triclinium* twelve feet away.

Halfway through the curtain-slit beyond the pantry, a corpulent grey-haired senator in a gravy-spotted *synthesis* lurched out onto the peristyle tiles, dropped to one knee beside a chased silver basin held by a kneeling girl no older than Sura, and stuck a flamingo feather down his own throat to bring up three cupfuls of purple Setine wine and half-digested thrush breasts so he could go back in for the mulled oysters; wiping his beard on the kneeling girl's clean hair-braids when she wasn't quick enough with the towel, he pinched her small breast hard enough to make her wince, belched *"Io Saturnalia, little mouse!"* and waddled back toward the lyre-music.

Lucida did not slow her step, did not stare, did not let her nostrils twitch at the mixed stench of warm vomit, roast boar-fat, myrrh smoke, and fresh blood on wet whalebone. She filed the layout of the pantry, the silver-closet lock, the three exits, and the face of the vomiting senator behind her eyes the way Corvus filed roof-joists, and tapped twice at the cedar door at the end of the women's corridor.

A sharp-nosed Greek freedwoman of forty with a black mole beside her left nostril—**Dorcas**—yanked the door open, snatched Lucida inside by the elbow, and shot the bronze bolt.

The dressing-chamber smelled like a summer garden locked inside an ivory box: crushed Campanian roses, cinnamon-leaf *malabathrum* worth three hundred denarii the pound, warm beeswax, and clean linen dried over myrtle-charcoal. Polished bronze mirrors four feet high stood propped on carved griffins' paws; clothes-presses spilled sea-purple Coan silks, saffron gauze, and pearl-sewn slippers across cushioned stools.

In the corner behind an embroidered screen, huddled small on a low footstool with both arms wrapped tight around her belly, sat a weeping

sixteen-year-old slave-hairdresser (*ornatrix*) with a split lower lip and dark finger-bruises shaped like a man's grip high on her bare upper arm.

And in the center of the mosaic floor, seated upright in a high-backed chair of inlaid tortoiseshell while a second girl brushed out a heavy river of pale red-gold hair that fell below her shoulder-blades, sat **Ceionia Fabia**.

Lucida had expected some soft, painted palace doll. One glance killed that dead.

Ceionia Fabia was perhaps twenty-eight or twenty-nine, long-boned and straight-spined as a cavalry spear: daughter of Hadrian's dead first heir Caesar Aelius, sister to golden **Lucius Ceionius Commodus** whose drunken laughter echoed faintly across the courtyard from the men's hall, and—as every bathhouse gossip in Rome knew—betrothed at seven years old by Emperor Hadrian's own word to **Marcus Aurelius**, before old Antoninus Pius tore up the match to give Marcus his own daughter Faustina instead. Fabia had a pale, high-cheekboned face without a grain of white lead on it yet, eyes the cold grey-green of winter olive-leaves, and in her right hand she twirled a six-inch Roman hairpin (*acus*) of tempered gold set at the butt with a square-cut Scythian emerald, its point honed fine enough to pierce leather—the tool patrician mistresses kept handy to stab clumsy hair-slaves in the forearm when a curl fell crooked.

"That isn't Berenice's fat Greek slut," Ceionia Fabia said in low, clipped patrician Latin, never turning her head—watching Lucida strictly inside the tall polished bronze mirror.

"Myrtale took holiday fever, Domina," Lucida said smoothly, dropping her eyes the exact required two inches below Fabia's mirror-gaze while lifting the purple linen off the willow basket so Dorcas could inspect the three alabaster pots. "Berenice sent me so your house wouldn't wait. I ground the *cerussa* myself three times in rainwater and Chian vinegar; there isn't a grain of coarse grit in a hundred-weight."

Dorcas uncorked one alabaster pot, rubbed a smear of white cream between thumb and forefinger, sniffed for rancid pig-lard, grunted grudging approval, and reached hastily under the false lavender bottom for the two green glass phials.

"Wait," Ceionia Fabia said.

Dorcas froze with both green phials in her palm.

Fabia dismissed the girl brushing her red-gold hair with one flick of two fingers—*"Out into the passage, Phryne, shut the double doors"*—waited until the outer latch clicked, and only then turned in her tortoiseshell chair to look directly at fifteen-year-old Lucida.

"Come two paces into the candles, girl. Take that dirty wool off your hair."

Lucida let Myrtale's brown shawl slide back onto her shoulders and stepped to the edge of the Nilotic mosaic medallion, hands loose and empty outside her cloak—leaving the iron mattress-bodkin hidden in the shawl-fold.

Fabia's winter-olive eyes traveled from Lucida's thick blue-black braids down to the purple-brown dye-shadow ingrained along her cuticles, the calluses on her outer palms from Beroe's stone muller, and the cheap, newly patched leather shoes Corvus's November silver had bought.

"Syrian?" Fabia asked.

"My mother came from Tyre, Domina. Freed *inter amicos* by Aulus Lucidius at Puteoli. They call me Lucida."

"A Junian Latin," Fabia observed—not guessing, knowing every rung of Rome's human ladder by instinct. She tapped the square emerald butt of the six-inch gold pin once against her own chin. "Do you know what is in those two green bottles Dorcas is sweating over, Lucida?"

A stupid girl said *No, Domina, I only carry baskets*, which insulted a Caelian lady's intelligence and proved you lied under pressure. A greedy girl named the herbs to show how much blackmail she held, which got her dropped down an abandoned cistern in the Viminal gardens before sunrise.

Lucida looked straight at the mosaic hippopotamus under Fabia's hem. "Berenice told me the phials held bitter-almond water for winter chilblains, Domina. My mother told me when I was eight that a dyer's daughter who smells savin and pennyroyal through red beeswax has a blocked nose from October until May."

For three heartbeats the quiet in the warm, rose-scented room was absolute, broken only by the bruised slave-girl hiccuping behind the embroidered screen and a sudden distant roar from the men's *triclinium* across the peristyle where someone had smashed a wine-jar in applause for a charioteer's toast.

Slowly, Ceionia Fabia smiled—only with the corners of her thin, unpainted mouth, never reaching her eyes. She rose from the tortoiseshell chair, silk *stola* whispering over heated stone, walked right up to Lucida until her emerald-pinned fingers rested half an inch below Lucida's chin, and pricked the point of the six-inch gold *acus* lightly—just deep enough to dent skin without drawing blood—into the hollow of Lucida's throat, directly above the hidden olive-pip birthmark.

Lucida did not blink, did not swallow against the gold point, did not tighten a finger toward her shawl. Compared with Mousa's nails in river-mud and molten Sicilian sulfur hissing on Sura's bone, a patrician lady's hairpin in a warm room was theater—deadly theater if you flinched, coin if you stood still.

"Chilblain water," Fabia murmured, close enough that Lucida smelled honeyed Setine wine and crushed myrtle on her breath. "Good. Because my brother Lucius's friends drink carelessly in winter, and Senator Priscus's moralizing Stoic spies love counting kitchen scandals in our house whenever old Emperor Antoninus coughs at Lorium. If one word of chilblains ever walks down the Argiletum stairs, little Tyrian, I won't send watchmen after half-blind Berenice; I'll buy your dead patron's reversion off whoever holds it, open your ribs in my own cellar, and salt the meat. Understand me?"

"Clearly, Domina," Lucida said against the gold point. *(Filing away two names like hot gold coins dropped straight into her pocket:* ***Senator Priscus*** *—the name she had never heard Corvus speak, yet now locked forever in her ear alongside* ***Antoninus at Lorium*** *and* ***Fabia's brother Lucius****.)*

Fabia drew the needle-point back from Lucida's skin, turned smoothly to her dressing-table, and picked up not Dorcas's household copper purse, a little embroidered silk bag of personal gaming-money.

"Pay Berenice her twelve denarii, Dorcas," Fabia said over her shoulder, tossing **two extra silver denarii**—eight sesterces of clean holiday door-silver—straight through the candle-light.

Lucida caught both coins in one palm before they touched mosaic.

"Don't send the fat Greek next month," Fabia added, sitting back down before the bronze mirror and sliding the six-inch emerald pin through her twisted red-gold coil with one deft stab. "Send the girl with the blocked nose."

* * *

Coming down off the Caelian ridge after the first watch horn was twice as dangerous as climbing up at dusk, because by the second hour of darkness Rome's holiday wine had turned sour in forty thousand stomachs.

Lucida did not carry Berenice's nine denarii and her own two door-coins together in one fist. Before she stepped ten paces outside the *Domus Ceionia* kitchen postern into the frosty laurel lane, she knelt beside a dry boundary-stone, tucked Fabia's two personal silver denarii under her heel inside her right boot-lining, slipped Berenice's twelve denarii deep inside the knotted waist-string under her woollen apron, and set off at a flat, silent trot down the stepped cut toward the Velia and the **Templum Pacis**.

At the bottom of the Clivus Pullius, where pine-resin torches smoked black in iron wall-rings outside a three-arched wine-thermopolium, holiday riot blocked the cobbles wall to wall. A mule-cart loaded with Sabine firewood had lost an iron lynch-pin in the ruts; round the tilted axle two rival gangs of fullers' apprentices and butcher-slaves in scarlet liberty-caps were pelting each other with turnip-tops, greasy knuckle-bones, and blazing pitch-brands while an exhausted seven-man patrol of *vigiles* stood back under a portico awning letting them break their own heads so long as nobody set a timber shop-front alight.

Lucida flattened her back against a limestone baker's pier to slip behind the tilted cart, willow basket tucked tight against her ribs, right fist closed round the three-sided mattress-bodkin inside her shawl.

"Whoa there, little sigillaria-doll! Pay the bridge-toll in kisses or walnuts!"

Out of the torch-smoke lunged **Gaius Sticho's younger cousin Rufio**, an eighteen-year-old fuller's lout from the next alley over, stinking to heaven of vomited Falernian dregs and boiled sheep-trotters, his felt *pileus* crooked over one swollen eye. He did not recognize her under Myrtale's brown hood; he saw only a narrow fifteen-year-old waist and a purple-lined Caelian delivery basket that smelled rich with crushed lavender and sweet almond paste. His thick, lime-cracked left hand clamped straight onto her basket-rim while his right grabbed for the front of her shawl.

Shout, and four more fullers turned round to join the sport. Pull backward, and the willow handle tore open across the cobbles.

Lucida stepped *inward* under his raised elbow, exactly as Corvus had drilled her with a split reed behind the Tiber brick-clamps when they were twelve, drove her hobnailed boot-heel straight down onto the arch of Rufio's bare sandal-foot until cartilage popped, and pressed the needle-sharp triangular point of the seven-inch iron bodkin half an inch through his woollen tunic right above his bloated bladder.

Rufio froze with his mouth open, hot wine-breath steaming white against her eyebrow.

"Take three fingers off that willow rim before I count two," Lucida whispered under the roar of the street-brawl, keeping her elbow tucked low so not a bystander two paces off saw the iron buried in his belly-wool, "or you piss red wine through three holes until April, fuller."

Rufio's fingers sprang wide off the basket as though the willow were white-hot iron. Before he could curse or bellow for his mates, Lucida spun behind two rearing firewood-mules, vaulted a slick gutter of butcher's slush, and cut sharp left into the quieter colonnaded shadow behind Vespasian's **Temple of Peace**, where spice-merchants and Greek surgeons kept narrow vaulted *tabernae* beneath high brick arches.

Three bronze cupping-bells hung on an iron bracket above the fourth shuttered arch, lit by a single green-flamed tallow cresset.

Inside **Asclepiades of Pergamum**'s twelve-foot surgery, Saturnalia had filled every pine bench along both plastered walls with broken holiday meat. A cross-eyed Thracian *retiarius* trainee from the *Ludus Matutinus* sat straddling a blood-blackened oak stool having seven bronze skin-clips pinched shut across a torn shoulder while biting down on a folded leather strap; beside the door a drunken litter-bearer groaned over three dislocated fingers set in split reed splints; on the back marble table an apprentice boy pounded dried Egyptian squill bulbs and toasted linseed in an iron mortar, filling the low brick vault with sharp, vinegary steam that smelled of garlic, cautery-iron, and old blood.

Asclepiades himself—bald skull gleaming wet under the hanging bronze surgical lamp, oiled leather apron dark from chest to knee, clean short-paired fingernails moving swift and steady as a weaver's shuttle—snipped the knotted linen thread off the Thracian's shoulder with bronze shears and barked without turning round:

"No more broken noses tonight! Go stick your faces in the Meta Sudans snow-trough and come back on the Kalends with silver!"

"It isn't a broken nose, medicus; it's red side-fever on the fifth rib, three watches in, coughing bronze froth," Lucida said clearly from the doorway, stepping straight past the groaning litter-bearer to lay **two bright silver denarii**—Fabia's Caelian door-money from her boot—ringing flat onto the corner of his clean instrument-tray. "And five more silver denarii sit Upstairs on Berenice's marble slab the instant your bronze bells touch his back."

Asclepiades wiped his bronze shears on a boiled linen cloth and turned keen, pouchy grey eyes onto her face. He looked at the clean Caelian silver first, her mud-splashed hem second, and the steady set of her jaw third.

"Berenice the one-eyed Syrian up the Argiletum steps?" Asclepiades grunted. "Since when does that old scorpion spend twenty-eight sesterces on anybody's lungs? Is it a customer who swallowed her hellebore?"

"It's a sixteen-year-old Sabine clerk whose lungs earn thirty sesterces a week when they aren't full of water," Lucida lied smoothly adding a year and doubling Corvus's wage so the Greek saw a repeat-paying client rather than dying fuller's trash. "We have eleven sesterces plus Berenice's four denarii waiting upstairs right now—twenty-seven sesterces in silver and brass, plus these eight makes thirty-five. Take twenty-eight for the climb, the cupping, and a full pint horn of squill-oxymel, and leave me seven for Cretan linseed and oak charcoal. Wait until morning and he drowns, and you get nothing out of the corpse-cart."

Asclepiades's mouth twitched once at the corner. "Seventy-eight stairs on Saturnalia night with every landing slick with vomit, girl. Thirty-two sesterces."

"Twenty-eight," Lucida countered without moving an eyelash, laying two fingers back near the two silver denarii on his tray, "and I carry your bronze-box and linseed sack up all six flights myself while my hands are warm, and send every Caelian tire-woman who asks Berenice for tooth-tincture straight to your arch instead of Euelpistus down by the Forum."

Mentioning **Euelpistus**—Asclepiades's hated Cilician rival three streets west—did what begging never could. Asclepiades snorted through nose-hairs grey with cautery smoke, swept both silver denarii off the tray into his belt-wallet, and jerked his chin at the apprentice.

"Pack the three small bronze *cucurbitulae*, the scarifier, a pint flask of three-year squill vinegar boiled with Attic honey, and four pounds of crushed linseed meal in the felt satchel, boy, then bolt the shutter! Let's see whether this Tyrian mule climbs stairs as fast as she counts silver."

Twenty breaths later they were climbing the pitch-black Argiletum staircase two steps at a time—Asclepiades swinging his shuttered horn lantern ahead to kick sleeping drunks clear of the landings, Lucida hauling his twenty-pound felt instrument bag and Berenice's willow basket up behind him until sweat ran stinging salt into the corners of her mouth. Upstairs she slapped Berenice's twelve Caelian denarii onto the tombstone slab, collected her agreed sixteen back before the old woman's claw could close over the fourth coin, added eleven sesterces from under the loose hearth-brick, and counted the remaining five silver denarii straight into the Pergamene surgeon's clean palm.

By the third watch of the night, Berenice's smoky fourteen-by-eleven garret smelled like a legionary hospital tent.

While Berenice held the double-spouted tallow lamp close and Lucida pinned Corvus's shivering shoulders steady on his right side across the rush-mat, Asclepiades touched burning spirit-soaked lint inside three bell-shaped bronze cupping-glasses (*cucurbitulae*) and clapped them hard along the taut, sweating skin beneath Corvus's left shoulder-blade. Vacuum sucked purple flesh half an inch up into each hot bronze dome as the flame died. Corvus's teeth ground together hard enough to crack enamel; his right hand locked round Lucida's bare forearm until four white nail-crescents sank into her skin; not one cry came past his shut jaw.

"Strong ribs for a starved field-rat," Asclepiades muttered, tapping the middle bronze bell with a fingernail before releasing the suction with a wet *pop* and wiping dark congested blood-blisters clean with warm vinegar-wine. "Fluid hasn't turned to white pus yet; catch him two days later and you'd be hiring flute-players at the Libitina grove. Three spoonfuls of this squill-and-honey oxymel every watch when the cough rises; keep scalding linseed-and-fenugreek poultices strapped across the left ribs until the skin goes lobster-red; water boiled with barley, no wine at all, and don't let him chill between midnight and cockcrow when the sweat breaks, or the lung collapses inward."

Asclepiades packed his bronze bells into oiled felt, pocketed his silver, and went clumping down the dark pine ladders into the fading Saturnalia uproar below.

At the fourth watch, the dead black iron hour before winter dawn when even drunken fullers had collapsed in doorways and the street wagons had thinned to single night-soil carts, the crisis broke.

First came the shaking rigor: teeth chattering so violently Corvus couldn't swallow the sharp squill-syrup off the horn spoon without biting wood, ribs hitching in shallow, tearing gasps under the steaming linseed rag while cold December wind knifed through Berenice's unglazed dormer cracks. Their single fuller's cloak and Corvus's dry tunic piled on top weren't heavy enough; Berenice was dead asleep under her wolf-pelt across the garret with raw wool stuffed in both ears against tooth-ache; and they had only one measure of charcoal left in the pan, barely keeping the poultice-pot warm.

Lucida did not hesitate. She unpinned her outer brown woollen shift in the dark, stripped down to her thin linen chest-band and loin-cloth, crawled directly under the fuller's cloak onto the narrow barley-straw, and pulled Corvus's freezing, trembling length tight against the bare front of her own fifteen-year-old body: chest to his unpoulticed right ribs, thighs locked over his icy shins, both arms wrapped hard round his wet neck so his forehead buried itself into the warm hollow beneath her left collarbone, right over the dark olive-pip mark.

For half an hour he shook like a wet hound pulled out of January ice, muttering broken scraps of Sabine Latin and surveyor's numbers into her skin:

"Eleven feet to Number Three... tell Lucida, no, tell Vespera the plank's greased... forty thousand bipedales, Phileros, count the stamps backward..."

Lucida stiffened half a breath in the dark at the name *Phileros* and *forty thousand bipedales*, because Corvus had never told her about any Greek named Phileros or forty thousand bricks; he had told her he was sorting papyrus scroll-tags for an old bookseller on the Argiletum.

Her hand paused behind his burning wet hair. Down near his rolled outer tunic under his elbow, her bare knee brushed something hard and flat stitched inside the split waist-band: six round silver edges, unmistakable to fingers that counted copper in the dark every night.

He kept back six denarii, she thought in the pitch dark, listening to the rattle in his inflamed lung half an inch from her breastbone. *And he isn't working for a bookseller. He walked straight into some senator's brick-audit behind my back to keep me off the board.*

Hot salt anger made her back teeth ache for ten breaths; right behind it came animal dread as another racking cough convulsed his ribs against hers and hot sweat burst out across his neck, temples, and chest all at once, drenching both their skins wet as river-water.

The fever was breaking.

She grabbed the warm linen towel without letting cold air under the cloak, wiped his streaming face and throat dry so the chill wouldn't strike inward as the Greek warned, tilted two horn-spoonfuls of sharp squill-honey between his parted lips when his jaw relaxed, and pulled him straight back against her bare ribs, tucking the rough wool tight under both their chins.

His breathing slowed, still shallow and catching slightly at the bottom of the left lung, yet steady now, dry and temperate under her cheek instead of kiln-hot. Half-conscious between sleep and waking, Corvus shifted his bruised right hand until his scarred thumb found her shoulder-blade under the cloak.

"Vespera?" he whispered hoarsely, using the child-name nobody inside Rome had ever heard. "Thought I heard… Caelian bells."

"Go back to sleep, liar," Lucida whispered into his damp black hair, holding him tighter against her skin while grey winter light began to smear the dormer gutter outside and frost formed white along the rue-pots. Neither did she tell him about Ceionia Fabia's gold emerald pin at her throat, nor the bruised slave-girl weeping behind silk screens, nor whose Caelian silver had just bought the breath moving in and out of his lungs. Rome was already teaching both of them how to count with one hand under the table; yet as dawn broke grey over the Subura tiles and Corvus's heart beat slow and solid against her ribs, she swore by her dead mother's salt that whatever doors waited ahead, no plank, sickness, or senator would take him into the dark without her.

Chapter V

Twenty Digits of Lead

Nineteenth Day Before the Kalends of February, AD 157 · Corvus

Water that had left the snow-fed springs above Sublaqueum forty-five miles east two days earlier hit Corvus's groin like an axe-blade the instant he let go of the iron ladder-rungs.

For three breaths his healed left lung locked tight inside its dry linen rib-binding, refusing air while January cold drove straight through oiled mutton-tallow smeared over his calves and thighs. Above his head, through a round two-foot travertine inspection shaft cut into the paved service-lane behind Claudius's brick arcade, a pale coin of grey winter sky showed **Phileros**'s shaved chin peering down beside an urban water-castellarius whose keys jingled on a brass ring.

"Keep the horn lantern clear of the weir-lip, Sabine!" Phileros called down in Greek, voice echoing hollow and metallic off twenty feet of vaulted *opus signinum* waterproof cement. "You have until the turncock opens the morning street-sluice at the second hour—half an hour at most before the surge-head rises three feet and washes you down into the Colosseum drain! Measure the third bronze collar on the south wall and call up the stamp!"

Corvus hooked his left elbow round an iron cramp driven into the encrusted pink mortar to steady himself against the current, held the horn-paned tallow lantern high in his teeth by its leather bail, and felt under his belt for his dead father's folding brass *pes Monetalis*—twelve Roman inches subdivided into sixteen *digiti*, polished bright with brick-dust the night before while Lucida slept.

Around his waist roared Rome's hidden bloodstream.

Up in the sunlit squares men praised marble nymphs and spouting bronze Tritons without ever asking how nine aqueduct rivers stayed tame

inside brick skin. Down here in the distribution *castellum*—a vaulted three-chambered settling tank twenty-eight feet long by fourteen wide, coated half an inch thick in petrified brown calcium sinter (*crustae*) deposited over a century since Emperor Claudius brought the water in on hundred-foot arches—there were no nymphs at all: only deafening white turbulence, freezing spray smelling cleanly of mountain limestone, and three horizontal rows of round bronze outlet-nozzles (*calices*) mortared straight through the southern travertine breast-wall at exact legal heights so public street-basins drank first, licensed bathhouses second, and private senatorial mansions third whenever summer drought dropped the head.

Senator Priscus's Caelian peristyle fountain and bath-cistern had lost half their pressure since the Kalends of January. Priscus's household plumber blamed winter frost cracking mortar up at the seventh milestone; Phileros—who trusted plumbers slightly less than Carthaginians—had paid the district *castellarius* eight silver denarii before sunrise to lift one sealed manhole stone and drop a skinny fifteen-year-old who knew gauges into the tank before the water-office clerks came on shift.

Corvus waded four slow paces south along the slippery limestone floor, feeling with bare numbed toes for broken glass or fallen iron clamps, leaning forty degrees forward into the rush pouring over the middle stone baffle.

At eye-level along the wet south breast-wall projected seven green-patinated bronze *calices*—mandatory nine-inch tubular collars of hard bronze, which Roman water-law required rather than soft lead at the tank exit because crooked plumbers could hammer a soft lead mouth wider with a wooden drift-pin overnight to steal double Caesar's grant, whereas cast bronze held its bore and carried the *curator aquarum*'s punched magistrate mark.

Corvus wiped slimy green water-weed off Collar Three—Senator Priscus's own licensed pipe—with his thumb and laid the brass caliper-jaws across the inner lip.

Five *digiti* diameter: a clean *quinaria*-and-a-half household grant, unobstructed bar a finger-ring of hard chalk crust inside the rim. Nothing wrong with Priscus's nozzle. Why, then, was the water-level dropping six inches below Priscus's intake lip every morning before dawn?

Shivering hard enough now that the leather lantern-strap vibrated between his molars, Corvus took the horn lamp in his left hand and waded six

paces further east into the darker corner behind the sediment-pillar, where turbulent eddy-foam hid the lower masonry courses.

There, set four inches *lower* in the travertine wall than any private grant had legal right to sit—level with the public *lacus* street-fountain outlets so it drank full head even when upper pipes sucked air—protruded two bronze collars stamped in neat official letters:

EX · INDVLG · IMP · CAES · T · AEL · HADR · ANTONINI · AVG · PII · CALIX · XX

Twenty square digits apiece—already a princely commercial bath grant.

Corvus laid his brass rule across the mouth of the nearer bronze *calix*. Exact twenty-digit bore at the front lip, honest as Cato.

Then Corvus did what a plump sixty-year-old water-inspector standing dry on top of a ladder never did: he blew warm breath onto his blue right fingers, plunged his bare arm up to the shoulder straight into the roaring black mouth of the bronze collar against the suction—fighting the terrifying pull that wanted to wedge his wrist solid inside nine inches of cold metal—and walked his scarred thumb-knuckle inch by inch past the inner bronze flange where the lead *fistula* pipe took over inside the masonry wall.

Nine inches in, right where the cast bronze collar ended hidden inside four feet of concrete pier, **the wall vanished around his fingers**.

No narrow twenty-digit lead tube met the bronze back-ring. Instead someone had hollowed a concealed masonry pocket inside the core of the wall, soldered a flared bell-chamber directly behind the honest nine-inch bronze sleeve, and branched *two* monstrous lead *fistulae*—wide enough that Corvus could spread thumb to little finger without touching opposite walls, **fifty-digit pipes (*quinquagenariae*)** at least!—angling downward through the foundation rubble so Venturi suction pulled triple volume screaming out of the public tank without altering the visible front bore by a hair's breadth!

Even better: lead pipe-makers stamped the owner's name in raised letters along every ten-foot soldered seam before rolling the sheet. Corvus stretched two raw fingertips three inches further down the icy lead belly inside the wall-cavity, eyes shut tight against blinding spray, reading backward raised Latin capitals by skin alone the way he used to read unbaked brick-stamps in fog:

P · VEDII · POLLIONIS · BALN · ET · FVLLON

Of Publius Vedius Pollio—Baths and Fulleries.

Overhead a sharp double clang rang against the iron manhole rim: the *castellarius* striking his wrench in panic.

"Up, boy! Out of the tank!" Phileros's voice barked down the shaft, urgent now. "The turncock's crossing the archway from the Claudia spur —if he lifts the main gate-board while you're against that south wall, the head will pin your ribs flat to the bronze!"

Corvus yanked his right arm backward out of the suction—skin scraping raw red across the sharp inner edge of the bronze flange as rising pressure bit—snatched his brass rule into his belt, and lunged four surging strides through chest-deep white water as a deep subterranean boom shook the vault behind him: the upper sluice-gate lifting!

A solid green wall of Sublaqueum snow-melt burst over the primary stone weir, raising the chamber depth two feet in three heartbeats and spinning Corvus's heels clean off the slimy floor. His left hand missed the wet bottom rung; freezing water closed over his mouth and nose; then his scarred right fist hooked the second iron cramp by blind muscle memory, his bare toes jammed into a mortar-joint, and he hauled himself hand-over-hand up the iron shaft while foaming water roared four inches under his heels and Phileros dragged him out by both sodden armpits onto frosty basalt cobbles.

"Shut the stone!" the bribed *castellarius* hissed, dropping the three-hundred-pound travertine disc back into its recessed collar with an iron crowbar and kicking loose horse-straw over the wet rim ten paces before two municipal water-slaves came whistling round the brick arch with grease-buckets.

Backed flat into a recessed garden doorway out of sight, Corvus bent double with both hands braced on blue-mottled knees, coughing river-spray silently into his sleeve so his left lung wouldn't tear open again, water streaming off his ragged tunic onto January frost.

Phileros threw a dry coarse mule-blanket over Corvus's shaking shoulders and squinted sharply down at his bleeding right forearm where the bronze *calix* rim had barked three inches of skin.

"Well?" Phileros whispered. "Chalk-crust in our collar?"

Corvus straightened slowly inside the mule-blanket. His teeth wanted to hammer like castanets; he clamped his back molars together until the jaw-muscle bunched hard under his ear and shook his wet head once.

"Our collar's clean," Corvus rasped. "Twelve feet east, set four inches below legal private datum, sit two twenty-digit imperial collars soldered inside a hollowed wall-pocket onto twin fifty-digit lead *fistulae*. Drawing off public head day and night. Stamped *Publius Vedius Pollio—Baths and Fulleries*."

Phileros went wholly, marvelously still in the grey alley shadow. Even his three bone wax-scrapers stopped swinging against his cloak.

"Fifty-digit lead behind a twenty-digit bronze face," Phileros breathed, almost reverently. "Under the *Lex Quinctia de Aquaeductibus*, piercing or enlarging a tank-conduit behind the *calix* carries a hundred-thousand-sesterce public fine, summary tearing-up of every pipe on the culprit's land by the water-curators, and forfeiture of the corrupt *castellarius* to the mines."

"Don't spend the hundred thousand yet," Corvus said through blue lips, wrapping the scratchy blanket tighter round his chest. "If Senator Priscus sends the water-curators down that manhole tomorrow morning, Vedius Pollio pays fifty gold pieces to a night-mason tonight, fills the wall-pocket with quick-setting *pozzolana* mortar before dawn, and swears some dead plumber laid an old blind junction there under Hadrian. Take me inside to a brazier and give me a dry tile. I'll show Senator Priscus where the stolen water surfaces—and how to catch Vedius with the tap open."

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For six weeks Corvus had seen nothing of **Senator Quintus Servilius Priscus**'s Caelian mansion except the paved service-vestibule inside the Clivus Scauri back gate, where junior copyists sat on backless pine benches rubbing chillblained knuckles over waxed boxwood leaves while kitchen-mules clattered past to the turnspits.

Today Phileros marched him—barefoot, hair plastered black to his skull, wrapped in a horse-smelling mule-blanket over a soaked Subura tunic—straight past the astounded *atriensis* into the winter heart of the house.

Even an austere Stoic consular's house on the Caelian Hill made Berenice's sixth-floor garret feel like a badger-hole dug under a root. No

gaudy gilded ceilings or Syrian porphyry columns like the Ceionian palace two streets west: Priscus's *domus* was old Republican peperino stone, tall black-and-white geometric floor mosaics laid so true that Corvus's eye could not find a sixteenth-inch dip across forty feet, and dark wax ancestor-masks (*imagines*)—consuls and censors smoked brown by two centuries of hearth-fires—staring out of cedar wall-cupboards along the *alae* with hollow painted eyes.

In the glass-screened southern *peristylium*, where winter sun warmed clipped boxwood hedges and a dry marble fountain-basin sat pointedly silent in the center of dormant rose-beds, two men walked slowly side by side along the colonnade flagstone.

One was **Senator Priscus**, chewing dry fennel seed in his short unbleached *toga*. Beside him walked a slightly shorter man of fifty-six or fifty-seven wrapped in a coarse dark philosopher's *abolla* without gold clasp or ornament, ink-stains ingrained deep into the side of his right middle finger, iron-grey hair thinning across a broad, scarred Stoic brow: **Quintus Junius Rusticus**—grandson of Arulenus Rusticus whom Domitian had executed for loving liberty too loud, teacher and closest living conscience to **Marcus Aurelius Caesar**.

Standing three paces behind them holding a silver tray of untouched warm water-cups waited **Aulus Volusenus Niger**, clean-shaved and oiled in cinnamon myrrh, twisting his red carnelian *quadriga* ring—whose patrician jaw dropped half an inch when he recognized the half-drowned hod-boy from Festus's rhetoric gallery dripping grey aqueduct-water onto his uncle's spotless mosaic.

"Uncle," Volusenus said sharply, stepping forward to block the colonnade, "this is the insolent fuller's brat Festus threw out in November for barking in class! Phileros, have you lost your wits bringing street-filth onto the winter pavement?"

Senator Priscus did not look at his nephew; he looked at the widening dark ring of Sublaqueum water spreading round Corvus's blue bare feet, and at the three-inch raw scrape bleeding slowly down Corvus's right forearm.

"Did Festus throw him out for barking false law, Aulus, or true law?" Priscus asked flatly.

Volusenus flushed dull red to the roots of his oiled curls and shut his mouth.

Junius Rusticus stopped walking. True to everything Forum clerks whispered of him, Rusticus looked first at Corvus's bare calloused feet on the cold stone, second at the thin linen pleurisy-bandage showing through his torn wet neck-hem, and last into Corvus's grey-green eyes.

"Get the boy near the charcoal pan before you question him, Quintus," Rusticus said quietly—his voice surprisingly gentle, dry as old parchment, wholly free of senatorial boom. "A witness whose teeth chatter gives crooked numbers."

A slave dragged a heavy three-legged bronze brazier glowing with oak-charcoal two paces from the colonnade step. Corvus did not sit—nobody sat unbidden before two consular senators—and did not hold his numbed hands greedily over the coals either, because sudden heat on frozen fingers made them swell shut; instead he knelt on one knee beside the brazier where radiant warmth could reach his bound ribs slowly, took a broken terracotta garden-tile and a charred stick of willow-coal from Phileros, and waited until Priscus nodded.

Phileros gave the two senators a thirty-word summary in crisp Greek: Collar Three clean, two twenty-digit imperial collars four inches low in the east corner, hollowed masonry pocket behind the bronze, twin fifty-digit lead *fistulae* stamped with **Publius Vedius Pollio**'s bath and fullery mark.

Priscus's slate-grey eyes gleamed cold and hungry. "A hundred thousand sesterces statutory penalty under the *Lex Quinctia*, Junius—plus criminal *stellionatus* fraud on Caesar's grant! We lay information before Lollius Urbicus before the tenth hour and have the curators' crowbars in that wall by sunset!"

"Wait, patron," Phileros murmured, glancing down at Corvus's bent black head. "The boy says sunset loses the bird."

Priscus frowned down at Corvus. "Speak Latin, boy, and keep it brief. Why shouldn't the curators break that wall before dark?"

Corvus laid the broken terracotta tile flat across his thigh. Now that the cold lock had clicked behind his eyes, with two consular senators, Phileros, and sneering Volusenus all watching his scarred right thumb push black willow-charcoal across red clay, every trace of shiver vanished out of his wrist.

"Because the manhole sits in a public lane watched by two fuller's porters who take Vedius's copper, Senator," Corvus said cleanly. "Send municipal crowbars into the *castellum* alone, and before they chip through two feet of hard *opus signinum* mortar to expose the hidden lead bell, Vedius's night-gang cuts the receiving pipes fifty yards downhill inside his own private cellar, plugs the stub with quicklime, and swears in court that those fifty-digit *fistulae* are dead Hadrianic storm-drains he never drew a pint from. Without proving live flow *into* his cisterns at the same moment the tank is opened, your *Lex Quinctia* fine turns into a six-month boundary argument before hired arbiters."

Junius Rusticus leaned forward half an inch inside his coarse dark cloak, ink-stained finger resting against his beard. "How do you prove live flow inside a rich equestrian's locked cellar without a magistrate's search-warrant, which Roman law grants for stolen goods, rarely for water?"

Corvus drew three sharp black lines across the red clay tile: one high tank on the Caelian crest, two plunging pipes dropping eighty vertical feet down the northern slope toward the Subura trough, and a tiny square at the bottom.

"You don't enter his cellar at all, Senator," Corvus said. "Water going into a bathhouse or fullery has to come *out* into the public street-sewer, and public sewer-grates belong to the aediles, requiring no private warrant. Two fifty-digit pipes running under twenty-two feet of head discharge roughly fourteen *quinariae* a watch more than Vedius's honest twenty-digit license allows. Tomorrow at the first hour, before bathers muddy the street drains, drop two pounds of crushed red Sinope ruddle-chalk or boiled alkanet dregs straight into the east corner of the Caelian *castellum* right in front of those two collars, while two sworn witnesses stand three hundred paces downhill at the sewer-outfall behind Vedius's Argiletum fulleries with a water-jar and a sand-glass. Within ninety breaths red water pours out of Vedius's private outflow grate at triple licensed volume, proving live connection, destination, and stolen cubic measure in one stroke before a single mason lifts a hammer."

Nobody spoke under the sunlit colonnade. Out in the winter garden a blackbird hopped onto the dry marble fountain-rim, pecked vainly at frost, and flew off over the cypresses.

Up behind his uncle's elbow, Volusenus had stopped twisting his carnelian ring; his heavy mouth wore the sour, baffled look of a man watching a street-dog open an iron strongbox with its teeth.

Senator Priscus cracked a fennel seed loud in the quiet, then looked sideways at Rusticus. "Gaius Cassius Corvus's boy," Priscus said; Phileros had told him the dead surveyor's name already. "Fifteen. Phileros has been paying him sixteen sesterces a week in the back vestibule to scrape wax."

"You have been overpaying for wax-scraping and underpaying for hydraulics, Quintus," Junius Rusticus said dryly. Yet when Rusticus looked back down at Corvus kneeling beside the glowing coals, there was neither warmth nor amusement in the Stoic's deep-set eyes, only a long, searching, almost sorrowful gravity, as though he were reading the last page of a scroll whose opening chapter pleased Priscus. "Your father surveyed land around Crustumerium, Lucius Cassius?"

"Until the clay-pit took him two summers back, Senator," Corvus answered.

"And you have already petitioned through Quintus's notary for a minor's stay against your father's bond, which Hermippus, steward to this same Vedius Pollio, bought up in November," Rusticus observed calmly. Not a question. "Be careful, boy. There is nothing wrong in defending your father's name or measuring crooked lead with a straight brass rule. Only I have watched clever hungry boys come up out of the country into Roman houses for thirty years. When you discover at fifteen that four lines of charcoal on a broken tile can pull down a man worth six million sesterces, it is very hard at twenty to remember why laws were written for anything except pulling men down."

Corvus kept his eyes steady on the Stoic's ink-stained hand. Inside his ribs, where December's pleurisy still left a dull hot stitch whenever he drew deep breath, he thought of Mousa's fingernails tearing his shin in the fog, of Volusenus's ivory stylus splitting his mouth while sixteen perfumed boys laughed, of Lucida stripping down to her thin linen chest-band in freezing dark to keep his lungs from drowning because they lacked nine sesterces for charcoal. It was very easy, Corvus thought silently behind polite grey-green eyes, for a man whose grandfather owned three villas and a seat in the Curia to warn barefoot boys against loving crowbars.

"A brass rule doesn't pull straight walls down, Senator," Corvus said aloud, voice respectful and flat as planed oak. "Only crooked ones."

Priscus barked a short, dry iron laugh, the first time Corvus had ever seen his patron's teeth, and turned to Phileros.

"Move him out of the service-vestibule into the inner *tablinum* copy-bench, Phileros. Thirty-two sesterces a week, eight denarii silver, plus a clean winter tunic, woollen socks, and shoes from the household chest so he stops bleeding river-lime over my mosaic. Keep him off the public court-lists until June while the Subortanae brick-trust brief ripens; I don't want Vedius's thugs recognizing their runaway trench-witness before we drop red chalk down their pipes. And Aulus," Priscus glanced coldly back at his frowning nephew, "take this boy's tile upstairs and learn why Julian's Edict beats cinnamon hair-oil before the May docket opens."

Volusenus bowed stiffly from the neck, took the charcoal-marked garden tile out of Corvus's cold hand with two fingertips as though touching a dead rat, and stalked indoors without looking down.

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Next morning before the sun cleared the Praetorian ramparts, Corvus stood hidden inside the hooded woollen cowl of a Caelian fuller's porter thirty paces down the Argiletum drain-alley, holding a clear blown-glass Sidonian flask in one hand and a brass thirty-breath water-clepsydra in the other.

Beside the arched stone sewer-outfall where **Publius Vedius Pollio**'s largest commercial bath-and-fullery block discharged its waste into the vaulted *Cloaca* spur stood **Phileros**, two grey-bearded equestrian *recuperatores* from the *curator aquarum*'s roll wrapped to their noses in heavy Gallic cloaks, and a public notary holding a fresh three-leaved boxwood *testatio* open on his forearm. Nobody had knocked on Vedius's bronze street-doors; nobody had shown a warrant. Up on the Caelian crest three hundred yards south, Priscus's chief mason was standing over the lifted travertine manhole with a four-pound linen sack of pulverized Pontic Sinope ruddle—the blood-red iron-oxide earth carpenters snapped along chalk-lines—mixed thin in two buckets of warm brine so it wouldn't clump in cold current.

"First horn," Phileros murmured, watching the pale grey sky brighten behind a baker's smoke-stack. Up on the ridge a white linen kerchief dropped from the mason's raised arm.

Corvus unplugged the pin-hole of his brass timing-cup.

Forty breaths. Sixty breaths. Out of the two-foot iron-barred outflow arch beneath Vedius's foundation stones poured clear, steaming overflow water—already running four inches deep across the channel floor, far too brisk for an honest twenty-digit night trickle. One of the shivering equestrian witnesses stamped his boots on the frost and muttered into his beard that Phileros had dragged them out of warm beds on a Greek's pipe-dream.

Corvus did not look up from the iron grate. "Seventy-eight," he counted under his cowl. "Eighty-four."

At the eighty-seventh breath a faint rusty pink cloud bloomed round the iron bars.

Two heartbeats later the entire two-foot outfall surged thick, arterial **ox-blood red**, staining the frosted basalt channel scarlet from wall to wall and splashing red foam across the stone curb as fourteen stolen *quinariae* of Sublaqueum snow-water carried two pounds of Pontic iron-earth roaring straight out of Vedius Pollio's private bath-cisterns into the public street!

Both equestrian witnesses swore aloud by Hercules and bent low over the grate. Moving fast while the surge ran brightest, Corvus stepped down onto the wet inspection ledge with his hood pulled well forward over his scarred lip, plunged the clear glass Sidonian flask straight into the roaring scarlet spout behind the iron bars, corked it tight with red wax, and held it up to the grey dawn light beside his measured clepsydra line while the public notary's iron stylus flew across the boxwood leaves recording hour, outfall width, five-inch flow depth, and unbroken crimson discharge.

Before the notary had finished pressing the second witness's bronze signet into warm beeswax, a side door in the plastered bathhouse wall burst inward—some early furnace-slave down by the drain-sumps had seen blood-colored water swirling past his boots and run screaming upstairs that the nymphs were bleeding—and out onto the frosted cobbles shuffled **Hermippus**.

Vedius Pollio's chief steward had come down so fast he wore fleece-lined house-slippers under an unbelted squirrel-fur pelisse, an ivory ink-case still hooked by habit to his thumb, two cudgel-men in green-trimmed tunics

crowding out behind him until they saw the purple-bordered equestrian stripes under the two witnesses' cloaks and checked their sticks halfway out of their belts.

Corvus stepped smoothly two paces backward behind Phileros's shoulder, face shadowed deep inside his coarse porter's cowl, watching through a three-inch wool slit as Hermippus's sharp Smyrniot eyes took in the scarlet gutter, the sealed glass flask in Corvus's hand, the public notary's triple-leaved *testatio*, and Phileros's polite, corpse-pale smile.

For two breaths Hermippus's grey goat-beard worked without sound. Unlike street-thugs such as Sticho or Mousa, Hermippus could multiply hydraulic cross-sections and statutory *Lex Quinctia* fines in his head as fast as Phileros.

"A burst fuller's madder-vat in Number Two court, worthy sirs," Hermippus tried smoothly in Attic-polished Latin, spreading both ink-calloused palms. "Winter frost splits terracotta dye-tubs every January; my bailiff was just sending for mortar—"

"Save the madder-vat for country magistrates, Hermippus," Phileros interrupted gently, tapping the wet waxed *testatio* with one bone scraper. "Sinope iron-earth settles in salt water within six hundred breaths; boil madder-root and it turns purple with alum, whereas iron-earth turns black with oak-gall. Two sworn witnesses on the Caelian crest watched four pounds of Sinope earth go down the municipal *castellum* shaft directly over your master's two twenty-digit collars eighty-seven breaths before it painted your sewer-arch red. Shall we walk up to the *curator aquarum*'s tribunal at the third hour so municipal crowbars can open that masonry pocket behind the bronze, or does Publius Vedius prefer to hear Senator Priscus's arithmetic in private before noon?"

Hermippus stared at the glass flask of red water, then once, narrow-eyed, toward the tall cowled porter's boy standing silent behind Phileros's elbow; Corvus kept his chin down and his scarred right thumb tucked inside his sleeve.

"My patron dines at home until the fifth hour," Hermippus said softly, every trace of oily warmth gone out of his throat. "If Senator Priscus's secretary cares to hold his notary off the *curator*'s steps until the sixth, plumbers will have the old Hadrianic masonry junction on the Caelian crest sealed flush with hydraulic lime before dusk."

"Have your plumbers bring thirty pounds of lead solder and close *both* concealed fifty-digit branches back to honest twenty-digit pipes while Senator Priscus's mason watches inside the tank," Phileros replied pleasantly, "and bring your own seal-ring to the Clivus Scauri at the fifth hour."

Corvus expected cheering back inside Senator Priscus's *tablinum* at noon—expected lictors, public exposure, a hundred-thousand-sesterce hammer brought down square on Vedius Pollio's skull.

Instead, sitting quietly at his new pine copy-bench in the warm inner alcove behind a lattice cedar screen while grinding fresh lampblack ink, Corvus heard Hermippus come and go in less than half an hour, leaving behind neither public prosecution nor silver fine.

When Hermippus's furred slippers had shuffled out the front vestibule and Priscus walked back into the *tablinum* alone with Phileros, the old consular held two items in his lean, blue-veined hands: the sealed glass Sidonian flask of settling red iron-silt, and a fresh, privately witnessed *cautio* signed with Hermippus's own emerald scarab acknowledging a "disputed Hadrianic conduit error" on the Caelian spur and waiving all counterclaims on the neighboring garden wall-support!

Priscus unlocked his iron-bound cedar *armarium* behind the ancestor-masks, set both the glass flask and the waxed *testatio* carefully on the middle shelf beside three bound bundles of *Figlinae Subortanae* brick-stamps, and turned the heavy Laconian key twice.

Corvus looked up over his reed pen, unable to stop the question rising into his throat before prudence caught it:

"You aren't laying the hundred-thousand-sesterce fine before the water-curator, Senator?"

Phileros sucked his teeth sharply in warning; Priscus raised one hand to let the boy ask.

"Suppose I fine Vedius Pollio a hundred thousand sesterces this afternoon, Lucius Cassius," Priscus said, leaning one lean hip against the locked cedar chest and cracking a dry fennel seed between yellow back molars. "Where does that hundred thousand go under the *Lex Quinctia*? Into the public *aerarium Saturni* to patch road-gravel, while Vedius writes off two weeks' Ostian grain-interest, hires three better plumbers next winter, and knows my cupboard is empty. Leave that red bottle sitting behind Laconian iron with two equestrian seals on the neck, however—where criminal

stellionatus carries infamia and expulsion from the equestrian jury-panels whenever I choose to take the cork out—and how loudly do you think Publius Vedius Pollio barks when my brick-trust audit reaches Lollius Urbicus in June, or when his Caelian friends round young Lucius Commodus try buying votes in the next water-commission?"

Corvus stared at the locked cedar door.

Up in the sunlit garden yesterday Junius Rusticus had warned him against loving sharp knives that pulled crooked walls down. Today, inside the dim shadow of smoky consular masks, Quintus Servilius Priscus had just taught him something ten times colder and ten times more useful: **great men in Rome rarely pulled a crooked wall down when they could put a prop under it and own the man sleeping downstairs**.

"A spent arrow kills once," Corvus said slowly, testing the geometry aloud on his tongue. "A cocked bow commands the road all year."

Priscus gave a thin, wintry nod. "Finish copying Julian's third title on *negotiorum gestio* before the eighth hour, boy, then take your advance silver and get yourself decent lodging off that fuller's stair. My clerks don't sleep over poison-shops."

At the eighth hour—scrubbed clean, his raw forearm bound in pine-resin linen, wearing the unpatched dark grey Caelian woollen *tunica* and laced calfskin *calcei* over dry woollen socks, with **thirty-two sesterces** of advance silver plus his saved **twenty-four sesterces** from the waist-band making **fifty-six sesterces** jingling solid at his hip—Corvus walked down out of the Caelian trees into crisp afternoon sun.

Before climbing Berenice's stair, he stopped two streets west on the **Vicus Cuprius** where a clean, stone-vaulted cobbler's *insula* let dry second-floor rooms with real wooden window-shutters, a private iron door-bolt, and an honest terracotta smoke-flue for sixteen sesterces a month. He paid January's sixteen sesterces down on the cobbler's bench, pocketed the heavy iron key, bought half a roast kid's shoulder with rosemary and two honey-sesame cakes hot off a baker's shovel, and paused on a sunlit landing where a gap between two butcher's roofs gave a clear sightline down toward the crowded pantiles of the Argiletum.

He touched the clean grey wool over his chest, then reached inside his collar until his scarred right thumb met the rough, broken edge of his half

of the *Figlinae Subortanae* clay brick-stamp hanging on hemp cord beside his skin.

Tonight he wouldn't hide a single coin in his waistband. Tonight he would climb those seventy-eight steps wearing real shoes, drop the heavy iron key to their own bolted door straight into Lucida's stain-shadowed palm, and carry their straw pallet out from behind Berenice's poison-shelves before dusk. He tucked the warm roast kid tighter under his elbow and started briskly down into the smoke.

Chapter VI

The Pear-Knife

Fourth Day Before the Nones of March, AD 157 · Lucida

Behind the great vaulted warehouses of the Emporium rose a mountain nobody had built by plan: a hundred feet high, half a mile round the skirt, composed entirely of fifty million smashed Spanish olive-oil amphorae stacked shard upon curving terracotta shard and dusted white every week with stinging quicklime so the rotting oil soaked into the clay wouldn't poison the southern wind across the Aventine.

Men called it **Mons Testaceus**—Potsherd Hill—and at fifteen Lucida loved it better than all the marble temples in the Forum, because marble temples only took copper out of poor folk's pockets, whereas broken Spanish clay paid thirty percent on a morning's walk if a girl got down to the travertine river-wharf before the customs clerks finished their breakfast pulse.

She stood on the slick limestone quay below the **Porticus Aemilia** in the raw March wind, wearing a stout brown woollen cloak pinned with brass and real hobnailed calfskin boots—bought out of Corvus's steady Caelian copying-silver—watching eight river-haulers (*saccarii*) swing fat, globular two-hundred-pound Baetican oil jars off a flat-bottomed Ostian tow-barge onto a bed of river-sand.

Every jar carried black brush-painted *tituli picti* on its neck naming the net oil weight, the Guadalquivir estate, the shipper, and the Corduba fiscal control mark. Once the state *annona* measurers decanted clean oil into sunken warehouse *dolia* inside the horrea, they smashed the empty clay bellies on the spot with iron mauls—because oil-soaked terracotta turned rancid in summer heat and couldn't be refilled—and mule-carts hauled the shards up the switchback ramp onto Potsherd Hill.

Except three jars out of every hundred cracked slightly along a lower rib during the tow upstream from Ostia behind straining ox-teams, weeping thick golden-green oil into their straw rope-jackets. State clerks refused "weepers" as short-weight; barge-masters hated carrying leaky clay back to Ostia; and **Gaius Baebius**, a squat Gaditane barge-skipper with a gold hoop through one nostril and salt-eczema on both wrists, had learned since February that the dark-eyed Syrian fifteen-year-old waiting by Bollard Twelve paid cash silver on the barrel-head without haggling past two breaths.

"Four weepers out of sixty-eight from Hispalis, Tyrian," Baebius grunted in Punic-accented Latin, kicking aside wet straw so Lucida could squat and press her thumb against the hairline crack in the fattest amphora's hip. "Top two-thirds clean green virgin pressing; bottom third cloudy with bilge-damp. Twenty-four sesterces the four, and bring your own skins before the wharf-wardens clear the berth at noon."

Lucida dipped her little finger through the unsealed bung-hole, touched one drop of cold Spanish oil to her tongue, and spat neatly into the brown Tiber. Good Guadalquivir fruit, pressed before frost, without turnip-seed adulteration; only the bottom palm-breadth smelled faintly of pitched pine hull.

Decanted carefully through clean linen before noon, those four cracked jars would yield nine *congii* of sweet upper oil—worth twenty-eight sesterces straight to Berenice and two Caelian bath-attendants for perfumed body-unguent bases—plus five *congii* of dark sediment and *amurca* dregs that the axle-wrights and Subura lamp-fillers bought for twelve sesterces cash. Forty sesterces out of twenty, less two sesterces for donkey-hire.

"Eighteen sesterces," Lucida said, standing up and wiping her oiled finger across the leather tongue of her own boot to feed the calfskin. "Number Three is split four inches up from the spike; half its bottom third is river-water already, Baebius, I can see the grey line sweating through the biscuit. Eighteen cash silver on the bollard right now, and my carter clears your sand before the fifth hour."

Baebius squinted at the damp ring on Jar Three, swore lazily by Melqart's balls, and held out a scarred palm. "Twenty. Five denarii flat, or I let the lime-boys smash 'em and write the loss off on the shipper's bond."

Lucida counted **five silver denarii** out of her inner belt-pouch into his palm—leaving **seventy sesterces** (17 denarii and 2 sestertii) tucked safe in-

side her bodice alongside the two hundred ten sesterces she and Corvus kept locked in their new iron-strapped cedar cash-box upstairs—and chalked her mark (*L · T*, sideways like a mason's square) across all four wet clay shoulders so no wharf-thief would roll them off while she fetched the donkey-cart.

For seven weeks now—ever since January when Corvus walked into their new second-floor shuttered room off the Vicus Cuprius wearing Priscus's clean grey wool and carrying thirty-two sesterces a week in copying pay, while Ceionia Fabia's tire-woman Dorcas doubled Lucida's Caelian cosmetic orders—life had felt almost dangerously wide. No more sleeping with rats gnawing lead under Berenice's poison-shelves, though they still rented storage-space from the old woman and kept their mouths shut about her jars; no more treading seven-day piss bare-thighed under Sticho's quince-rod; meat twice a week in their lentil-pot, dry firewood when Tramontana wind blew off the Sabine snows, **two hundred eighty sesterces** saved clean toward their first thousand.

Even the quiet ledger of small secrets sitting between her and Corvus since winter—she knowing he worked for **Senator Priscus** rather than any Argiletum bookseller though waiting for him to trust her enough to say the name aloud himself when Priscus's June embargo lifted; he knowing she carried alabaster pots into Caelian houses without knowing **Ceionia Fabia**'s emerald pin had pricked her throat—had seemed only like two coats worn against winter cold, harmless so long as both hands still put their silver into the same cedar box at night.

Then from behind the dusty white skirt of Monte Testaccio came two short, piercing thrush-notes blown hard through parted front teeth:

Whit-whit! Whit-whit!

Lucida spun round on the limestone quay so fast her woollen cloak slapped the mooring-bollard.

Running flat-out down the crushed-terracotta cart-track between two lime-wagons came twelve-year-old **Sura**.

Her flax hair stood wild with sweat and white fuller's-chalk; she had run all the way from the lower Subura across the Forum Boarium barefoot, slicing her left heel open on potsherds without slowing a stride; her madder-dyed linen burn-wrap had come half-undone down her scarred left forearm, and in her right fist she clutched a broken piece of slate and Lucida's own **iron-strapped cedar cash-box** from their locked second-floor room!

Lucida met her behind stacked oil-barrels out of Baebius's earshot, catching the panting, heaving child by both shoulders before she pitched face-first into the amphora grit.

"Breathe first," Lucida ordered low, dropping to one knee to shield Sura with her cloak while checking down the wharf-road for brown-cloaked runners. Nobody behind the lime-carts yet. "Did fire break out? Who broke our shutter?"

Sura shook her flax head violently, gulping air through her scarred tongue-stub with wet, whistling gasps, shoved the intact cedar cash-box safely against Lucida's knees—she had climbed down the outside courtyard drain-pipe into their room the instant boots hit the lower stair to save their two hundred ten sesterces before bolting!—and held up the smeared slate.

Scratched in frantic, jagged capitals with a lump of tailor's chalk were five words:

ONE-EAR · TOOK BEROE · HORTI VEDII · NOW

Ice water went straight from Lucida's throat into her soles.

Scaeva.

She flipped the slate over; on the back Sura had drawn a rough quince-rod and an ear-ringed stick-figure pointing uphill, followed by: *STICHO SOLD ME · RAN.*

Lucida's mind put all four pieces together in three heartbeats with sickening, crystal precision. Gaius Lucceius's fullery owed ground-rent to **Hermippus**, steward to **Publius Vedius Pollio**. When winter fuller-work slowed in February, Sticho and Lucceius had settled arrears by signing over small chattels—including a twelve-year-old mute Gallic sulfur-girl—and while Hermippus's clerks audited the fullery block's sub-tenants floor by floor from ground-vats to roof-pantiles, Scaeva had recognized old one-eyed Berenice's Tyrian ledger-marks from Puteoli, kicked in the sixth-floor fir door, and found where dead **Lucida Tyria**'s fifteen-year-old Junian Latin daughter had gone to ground!

Only two blessings stood between them and ruin right this instant: first, they had moved Corvus's cedar birth-diptych, the heavy bronze *signaculum* die, and the five remaining Subortanae brick-tallies out from under Berenice's hearth-brick six weeks ago, burying them deep inside an oiled amphora neck under a loose flagstone in a disused stable-arch near the Baths of Titus that neither Berenice nor Sticho knew existed; second, **Corvus was**

shut safely inside Senator Priscus's inner Caelian *tablinum* until the ninth hour copying June briefs, where Scaeva had not yet linked him to Berenice's stair!

If Lucida bolted right now for Ostia with Sura and their two hundred eighty sesterces, Berenice—sixty years old, half-blind, terrified of the Esquiline crossbeam for her green savin-phials—would spill everything she *did* know before dusk: Corvus's full name (*Lucius Cassius Corvus, Gaius's son, Crustumina*), his tall Sabine frame, the Vicus Cuprius room where Corvus would walk home whistling at the ninth hour straight into Scaeva's leaded vine-stick!

Whereas if Lucida walked through Vedius Pollio's garden gate *herself* before the seventh hour—alone, clean-shoed, carrying silver—Scaeva stopped tearing up the Vicus Cuprius looking for her, Berenice kept her mouth shut about the Sabine boy, and Corvus stayed invisible behind Priscus's wall!

Lucida gripped Sura's chin firmly until the trembling girl locked grey eyes onto her lips.

"Listen to every word," Lucida said slowly and distinctly. "Take this chalk. Do *not* go back to the Vicus Cuprius room—Scaeva's dogs will be sitting on our bed-straw by noon. Go sit by the public goat-trough thirty paces outside the Clivus Scauri service-gate on the Caelian Hill—the big grey peperino house with six cypresses over the back wall. Wait there until Corvus comes out at the ninth hour. Write on your slate: *DO NOT GO HOME. VEDIUS HAS BEROE. WAIT BY TITUS'S ARCH AT DUSK.* If I am not at Titus's arch by the first watch horn, tell Corvus to take the buried jar and go straight to Phileros without looking back for me. Show me you understood."

Sura tapped four quick fingers against her own chest, drew an arch in the air, then caught a corner of Lucida's brown cloak in one fierce, dirty fist, shaking her head in silent terror while pointing at the cedar cash-box: *Don't take the silver to him—he'll steal it and chain us both!*

"A Junian Latin isn't a runaway slave, little thrush; he can't chain me without a magistrate's writ unless I run," Lucida lied calmly—knowing perfectly well what rich equestrians did behind high garden walls before magistrates ever heard a scream, yet refusing to leave Sura hunted as a runaway fullery-chattel or Corvus walking blind into an ambush. She pried open the cedar cash-box with her belt-key, dumped all **two hundred ten**

sesterces—two gold *aurei* and two silver *denarii* plus small silver—straight into her own deep leather belt-pouch on top of her seventy sesterces, handed Sura the empty wooden box plus four copper *asses* for bread, kissed the flax crown of the mute girl's head once hard, and stood up.

"Go to the Caelian gate, Sura. Run along the open streets where watchmen stand, never the narrow cuts. Wait for Corvus."

Sura swallowed once, tucked the empty box under her burned arm like a legionary's shield, and vanished up the bright travertine steps toward the Aventine slope without looking back.

Lucida retied her dark braids smooth in a brass puddle-reflection, wiped every smudge of Spanish olive oil and potsherd dust off her boots with dry straw so she looked like a brisk fifteen-year-old Caelian tradeswoman rather than dock-prey, slipped her honed Spanish amphora shard out of her boot-top to drop it down a sewer-grate—because walking into Scaeva's hands carrying a concealed blade gave Vedius instant legal excuse to call the *vigiles*—and turned north toward the Esquiline gardens.

* * *

Publius Vedius Pollio kept his winter town-gardens high on the sunny southern brow of the Oppian spur, three hundred feet above the smoky stink of the Subura tenements whose ground-rents paid for his snow-pits, yet close enough that when the wind blew south off the Viminal he could watch his own roofs from a heated glass gallery without smelling a single chamber-pot.

Two scarred Cappadocian gate-keepers in green-trimmed tunics searched Lucida's cloak-seams and boot-tops roughly inside the lodge—finding nothing sharper than her brass cloak-brooch and the heavy leather purse at her belt, which **Gaius Ummidius Scaeva**, stepping out of the guard-room picking dried mutton from his molars with a bone toothpick, weighed appreciatively in one palm before handing back to his belt—no, wait: dropping straight onto a silver salver carried behind him!

Scaeva smiled down at her with genuine, almost paternal satisfaction, the white gristle-stump of his missing left ear gleaming in the garden sun.

"Didn't even cost me shoe-leather past noon," Scaeva said pleasantly. "Told Hermippus when we hauled the one-eyed Syrian witch downstairs

that Tyria's little bitch wouldn't bolt while her dye-pots were still warm. Where's the long-legged Sabine brat who broke Mousa's nose with an iron chain at Number Three kiln?"

Lucida looked straight at the missing half of Scaeva's ear without blinking. "Dead of winter pleurisy before Saturnalia, bailiff. Coughed black blood five days in a doorway off the Campus and went into the Esquiline lime-cart with forty others. If you want his bones to beat for Mousa's nose, bring a shovel."

Scaeva studied her pupils for five slow counts, hunting the tiny flutter a liar gave when naming a live accomplice dead; Lucida thought steadily of the rust-colored blood on Corvus's rag in December and gave Scaeva flat, cold amber glass.

"Pity," Scaeva grunted, only half-convinced yet lacking any thread to pull while Berenice kept silent. "Saved me four ounces of lead on my stick. Walk ahead along the boxwood path, girl, and don't step on the crocuses; the master's mourning today."

Mourning, Lucida thought, half-expecting black cypress boughs hung for a dead wife or child.

Instead, inside a circular winter *heliocaminus*, a sun-trap pavilion paved in warm yellow Numidian *giallo antico* marble and walled to the south with tall bronze-framed panes of clear *lapis specularis* drinking the March sun, **Publius Vedius Pollio** reclined alone in a tunic of undyed Coan silk beside a tiny silver bird-cage inside which an emerald-green Indian parakeet lay stiff on its back with both scaly claws curled in the air.

On the wet marble floor ten feet below his couch knelt old **Berenice**, wrists tied loosely in front of her apron with hemp twine, a fresh purple swelling high on her left cheekbone where Scaeva's knuckle had introduced itself, her one good black eye darting warning lightning at Lucida for half a heartbeat (*I told them nothing about the boy!*) before dropping back to the stone.

Vedius Pollio was forty-eight or fifty, plump-jowled without fatness in the shoulders, skull shaved smooth and rubbed with oil until it shone like warm ivory, forearms depilated smooth as a bath-girl's and smelling across ten feet of warm air of crushed bitter almonds and snow-water. On a low citrus-wood table worth a farm in Sabinum stood a silver bowl of pale green winter Crustumian pears packed in clean mountain snow, and between his

soft, manicured right thumb and forefinger gleamed a tiny folding fruit-knife with a handle of carved mother-of-pearl and a two-inch blade of surgical Noric steel.

He did not look up until he had pared one unbroken spiral of green peel from stem to blossom-end without nicking the white flesh underneath.

"Twelve thousand sesterces I paid an Alexandrian skipper at Puteoli for that bird last May, Scaeva," Vedius said, his voice astonishingly light, musical, almost melancholy, like a tragic flute-player resting between acts. "It could say *Ave Caesar* in Latin and *Drink, pretty boy* in Greek whenever Lucius Ceionius Commodus came to supper. Yesterday evening some careless furnace-slave let coal-damp leak through a cracked flue-tile under the aviary, and this morning: stiff as dried salt-fish."

"Should I have the furnace-slave flogged at the whipping-post, master?" Scaeva asked dutifully by the door.

"Flogging makes noise and ruins working backs," Vedius sighed, slicing a thin crescent of cold pear onto his tongue and chewing thoughtfully. "Dock the whole furnace-gang half their tallow-ration until June and sell the oldest one to the Ostian salt-pans; cold porridge teaches masonry care much better than leather. Now: is this Aulus Lucidius's little Puteoli legacy?"

Lucida stood upright three paces from the yellow marble step, hands folded still against her brown skirt, chin level.

Vedius turned dark, moist, intelligent eyes from the dead parakeet onto her face, appraising bone-structure, clean wool cloak, stout boots, stain-shadowed cuticles, and finally the heavy leather belt-pouch Scaeva had laid beside the snow-bowl.

"Fifteen," Vedius murmured, consulting no wax tablet, carrying ten thousand debtors and chattels straight inside that oiled ivory skull. "Daughter of Lucida Tyria, freed *inter amicos* at supper without the Praetor's rod. Scaeva wanted to cart you back up to Figlinae Subortanae in ankle-loops this morning to tread clay-slurry and work off the sixteen hundred sesterces in unperformed *operae* your consumptive mother died owing old Lucidius's estate, plus, let us say, four hundred sesterces damages for Mousa's punctured forearm and one missing workshop *signaculum* die."

"I know nothing of any workshop die, Dominus," Lucida said evenly, "and your river-man Mousa tried to drag a free Junian Latin woman into the reeds before dawn without magistrate's warrant or witness."

Scaeva took half a menacing step forward; Vedius raised two depilated fingers an inch off his knee, stopping the ex-Praetorian cold, and smiled at Lucida with genuine pleasure.

"Listen to the phrasing, Scaeva! *Without magistrate's warrant or witness!* Six months inside the Aurelian customs-posts and the ditch-sparrow talks like Julian's clerk!" Vedius sliced a second crescent of pear and pointed the wet two-inch silver blade straight at Lucida's breastbone. "Tell me how you earned the two gold *aurei* and seventy-odd silver sesterces sitting in that leather pouch since October, Lucida. And don't insult my afternoon by saying fullers' vats; fullers' girls have split heels and eight copper asses."

Lying about Corvus had cost nothing because Scaeva had no paper trail; lying about her own trade to a man whose steward owned half the Argiletum shop-fronts and dockside warehouses would get her stripped and sent back to the clay-trenches as worthless liar-stock within five breaths.

"Cosmetic lead-grinding and Caelian unguent deliveries for Berenice through January, Dominus," Lucida answered crisply. "And since the Kalends of February, buying cracked Baetican weeper-amphorae off Gaditane skippers at the Emporium sand-berths before the *annona* maulers smash them: decanting nine *congii* of clean upper oil for bath-unguents at three sesterces the *congius*, selling five *congii* of bottom *amurca* to wagon-wrights and lamp-boilers, clearing eighteen to twenty-two sesterces net on twenty invested."

Vedius Pollio stopped chewing mid-pear.

Slowly he lowered the mother-of-pearl folding knife onto the rim of the silver snow-bowl, leaned one plump elbow on his silk cushion, and looked at Lucida for the first time not as runaway livestock, as a balance-sheet.

"Scaeva," Vedius said softly without turning his head, "how much does a fifteen-year-old girl earn me treading wet marl at Subortanae before winter marsh-fever kills her?"

"Three sesterces a day less two asses barley-meal," Scaeva rasped unhappily. "Call it six hundred sesterces a year."

"Six hundred sesterces a year, and dead at nineteen leaving two rags and a tin spoon," Vedius murmured, shaking his oiled head at the sheer vulgarity

of soldiers' economics. He looked back at Lucida, eyes shining soft and brown as velvet over iron spikes. "Whereas under the wise *Lex Iunia Norbana* of our ancestors, Lucida, so long as you remain a Junian Latin without citizen *ius Quiritium*, every oil-skin you decant, every lease you sign, every silver denarius you stack inside a cedar box over the next forty years comes home intact into *my* strongroom the afternoon your heart stops, provided I don't let clumsy bailiffs break my little golden goose in a brick-ditch first."

Cold sweat prickled silently down the hollow between Lucida's shoulder-blades, though her face gave nothing away. She had gambled walking through his gate that Vedius loved silver better than spite; watching him peel a third slice of pear while pricing her entire future life down to her burial shroud made her stomach turn colder than Mousa's cudgel ever had.

"Therefore," Vedius continued musically, "we make a civilized Roman arrangement. Old Berenice here goes back up her seventy-eight stairs with both eyes still in her skull, paying Hermippus double monthly shop-rent, forty sesterces on every Kalends, for the privilege of keeping her smelly little green bottles out of the Urban Prefect's fire. And *you*, Lucida, stay right here in Rome trading all the cracked Spanish oil-jars your clever Tyrian nose can smell, paying my steward Hermippus **eighty sesterces on the Kalends of every month** toward your mother's commuted *operae* and patronal respect, reporting your dwelling-street every quarter, never leaving the first milestone without Hermippus's lead seal. Miss one Kalends payment, or try creeping round a magistrate's clerk to beg re-manumission behind my back, and I auction your live *operae* contract to the sulfur-brothels behind the Circus Flaminius for ten years. Do we understand each other?"

Eighty sesterces every Kalends: twenty silver denarii a month bled straight off her wrists into Vedius's snow-bowl forever, plus every coin left at her death!

Still, Berenice lived, Corvus remained wholly unknown and untouched up on the Caelian Hill, and Lucida walked out free into the sunlight with her two hundred eighty sesterces minus the first month's eighty.

"We understand each other, Dominus," Lucida said, bowing her head two inches. "Take March's eighty sesterces out of my pouch on the table now, and give me Hermippus's receipt."

"Oh, the pouch on the table?" Vedius asked mildly, blinking as though reminded of a trifle. "Two hundred eighty sesterces, Scaeva counted. Eighty

pays March's tribute, certainly. Which leaves two hundred, fifty silver denarii. Tell me, Scaeva: what did Hermippus value that runaway mute Gallic sulfur-slut from Lucceius's fullery at when Sticho signed her over against rent arrears this morning?"

Lucida's heart slammed once against her ribs like a dropped stone.

No. Sura was supposed to be sitting safely up by the Caelian goat-trough waiting for Corvus!

Outside on the gravel boxwood path boots scuffled, and one of Vedius's green-trimmed Cappadocian gate-keepers shoved **Sura** sideways through the bronze pavilion doors by her twisted thin arm, Corvus's empty cedar cash-box still clutched crushed against her chest, blood smeared dark from her cut bare heel across the yellow Numidian marble.

Sura hadn't been caught running *away* Scaeva's second hound had spotted her fullery chalk-burn two streets below the Clivus Scauri before she ever reached Priscus's gate and intercepted her crossing the Colosseum valley. Sura's huge grey eyes met Lucida's in sheer anguish, terrified Lucida would think she had betrayed the message, and shook her head twice while tapping her empty mouth: *Slate smashed in the gutter before they grabbed me!*

"Two hundred sesterces on Lucceius's arrears sheet, master," Scaeva answered grinning, planting one heavy hand on Sura's flax skull to force her onto her knees beside old Berenice. "Damaged goods, no tongue and a five-inch sulfur-scar on the left arm, useless for house-service. Hermippus marked her down to go to Rufus's basement donkey-mill in Trans-Tiberim tonight to push the blind sweep-bar."

Every fuller's girl in Rome knew what Rufus's basement mill meant for a seventy-pound mute twelve-year-old: chained by an iron neck-ring next to mangy asses in pitch-black flour-dust eighteen hours a day until lungs clotted solid before fourteen.

Vedius Pollio did not even glance down at Sura's bleeding heel on his yellow marble; he looked exclusively at **Lucida's face** over the rim of his tiny silver pear-knife, testing with exquisite connoisseur's curiosity whether his new fifteen-year-old ledger-asset had a soft spot he could map and squeeze later.

"Fifty denarii," Vedius murmured softly. "The exact balance sitting in your leather pouch after March's eighty sesterces, Lucida. Keep your two

hundred sesterces, good seed-capital for Spanish oil, and Scaeva sends the damaged Gallic piece across the river to push mill-timber tonight. Or leave the entire pouch on my snow-table, and Hermippus writes you a clean *chirographum* bill of delivery: not *mancipatio*, naturally, we'll save the five citizen witnesses for pricier cattle, call it *traditio* of a defective kitchen-scullion for two hundred cash, and you walk out owning one mute pair of hands and not a single copper *as* for supper. Entirely your commercial judgment."

Do not look at Sura. Look at Sura and he raises the price to three hundred on credit to put chains on next month too.

Lucida kept her amber eyes cold and flat on the mother-of-pearl handle of Vedius's knife, pretending to calculate flour-wages against oil-margins in her head for four slow counts, giving the fat equestrian the exact hard-nosed merchant hesitation that kept Sura's price at two hundred rather than letting him see her heart breaking behind her ribs.

"A mute girl eats four asses of barley a day and never blabs bath-unguent formulas to competitors," Lucida said crisp and dry as salt-cod. "Give me Hermippus's waxed bill of sale stamped with your house-ring, Dominus, and keep the two hundred, leather pouch included, provided you throw in six yards of coarse binding-cord so she carries Berenice's pots home."

Vedius laughed aloud, a clear, delighted ripple that shook his silk collar, folded the tiny silver pear-knife shut with a sharp *snick*, and tossed Lucida's belt-pouch into Scaeva's hands.

"Write the *traditio* tablet on the portico bench, Scaeva, and stamp it with the steward's ring! Oh, we are going to make each other wonderfully rich before you turn forty, little Tyrian, provided you don't catch winter pleurisy like your clumsy country friend!"

* * *

Twenty breaths later, outside the iron-spiked gate of the *Horti Vedii* where cold March wind whipped dust off the Esquiline cobbles, the bronze postern clanged shut behind the three of them: old Berenice limping on swollen ankles muttering Syrian curses under her breath, Sura clutching the stamped wax sale-tablet against her chest while silent hot tears cut twin clean tracks down her soot-streaked cheeks, and fifteen-year-old Lucida standing

in the middle of the road without one copper *quadrans* left between her boots and the sky.

Except down on Emporium Bollard Twelve sat **four cracked Spanish amphorae already paid for at dawn**, chalked *L · T*, waiting to be smashed by the harbor wardens if nobody cleared the sand before sunset!

Lucida reached down, wiped Sura's wet cheeks roughly dry with the corner of her clean wool cloak, then knelt right on the cold basalt flags to bind Sura's bleeding heel tight in a strip torn off her own linen undershift.

"Stop leaking salt, little thrush; salt costs money," Lucida said fiercely against Sura's flax hair, feeling her own hands finally shake for three heartbeats now that Vedius Pollio's brown velvet eyes could no longer see them, before clamping both fists shut until the tremor died. "Berenice, go back up your seventy-eight steps, bolt your door, and pack every jar you want kept out of Hermippus's reach. Sura, limp slow behind me as far as the Velabrum cooper's yard so you can watch the skins while I haul."

She left her brass cloak-brooch in pledge with a squint-eyed Velabrum cooper who knew her face to borrow a two-wheeled oak hand-barrow and six clean goat-skins, then ran the empty barrow clattering down the river-road at a dead flat sprint while the March sun sank red-gold behind the Janiculum mills.

The harbor maulers already had their iron hammers raised two berths away when Lucida skidded onto the wet sand at Bollard Twelve!

Working side by side by dying river-light—Lucida tipping each two-hundred-pound Baetican clay belly carefully over a wooden cradle with braced thighs while bandaged Sura held folded linen strainer-cloths taut across the funnels—they drew off nine clear, fragrant *congii* of green Guadalquivir virgin pressing before bilge-water clouded the spout, and five thick *congii* of dark *amurca* dregs into separate tarred buckets.

She had no donkey to haul oil up the hills tonight; she sold wholesale right off the quay-curb by the first smoking dock-torches. Seven *congii* of clear green oil went straight to the bath-steward of the *Balnea Surae* coming down the Aventine steps with empty mule-panniers for **twenty-one sesterces** silver and brass; two *congii* she kept back for Caelian cosmetic base worth double once scented; the five buckets of *amurca* axle-grease went to the Ostian ox-carters' yard across the road for **eleven sesterces** copper; and she redeemed her brass cloak-brooch from the Velabrum cooper for one

sestertius barrow-hire, walking away into the March dark with **thirty-one sesterces** clinking in a knotted corner of her apron and two *congii* of sweet oil slung over her own aching shoulder!

By the time the first watch horn blew across the Forum Romanum, however, a second crisis remained: Sura had never reached Priscus's gate, which meant **Corvus had walked straight home to their Vicus Cuprius room at the ninth hour**—to find either Scaeva's watchers or an empty room with its cedar cash-box gone!

Heart hammering in her throat, Lucida led limping Sura up the shadowed travertine pavement of the **Via Sacra** toward their emergency fallback point: the single tall Pentelic marble vault of the **Arch of Titus** crowning the Velia saddle.

Inside the deep, unlit coffered shadow beneath the carved relief of Titus's soldiers carrying the seven-branched golden candlestick out of burning Jerusalem, a tall figure in dark grey Caelian wool stepped silently out from behind a travertine pilaster with a heavy iron crowbar balanced ready in his scarred right fist.

Seeing Lucida's dark braids and limping Sura behind her in the moonlight, Corvus lowered the iron bar with an audible rush of held breath that misted white in the cold air. Slung over his left shoulder in a knotted sack were their two spare tunics, his surveyor's brass gauge, and the unearthed clay amphora-neck holding his cedar birth-diptych and the bronze *signaculum* die!

"Vicus Cuprius had two fuller's boys sitting on the wine-step across from our cobbler's door asking who rented the shuttered room," Corvus said low and fast, catching Lucida's free elbow in a grip hard enough to bruise just to make sure she was solid flesh and unhurt. "I saw Sticho's cousin Rufio spit when he spotted the cobbler, went in over the back bakehouse roof instead of the street door, cleared our clothes out in ninety breaths, and dug up the stable-arch jar on the way here. Where's the cedar box—and what happened to Sura's foot?"

Here, standing three inches from Corvus under the carved marble spoils of Judea while Sura leaned exhausted against cold travertine holding her stamped *traditio* tablet, came the parting of two roads.

Tell Corvus the whole truth, that **Publius Vedius Pollio** himself had held a silver pear-knife across a snow-bowl from her throat, confiscated

two hundred eighty sesterces, and bound her under an **eighty-sesterce monthly Kalends tribute** plus quarterly patronal inspection, and what would Corvus do? Either he would tear open Senator Priscus's locked cedar cupboard prematurely to hurl the Subortanae brick-dies and Caelian water-flask at Vedius before June—destroying his own patronship and getting both of them crushed—or he would insist on paying her eighty sesterces out of his thirty-two-sesterce weekly clerk's wage, chaining his freeborn Crustumina rise to her Junian ankle-iron forever!

No. Her mother's defective manumission was *her* ledger to break, with *her* hands.

Lucida lifted the empty iron-strapped cedar cash-box from Sura's arm and tapped the stamped wax *traditio* tablet beside it.

"Hermippus audited Lucceius's fullery block for ground-rent arrears at noon," Lucida said—every word true so far as it went, trimmed clean as pared fruit. "Scaeva raided Berenice's garret hunting runaway Subortanae stock; Berenice told him you died of pleurisy in December, so your name is clean off his slate. Only Sticho signed Sura over to Hermippus's mill-broker for two hundred sesterces arrears, and our Vicus Cuprius lease-trail burned behind us. I used two hundred out of the box through an Esquiline broker to buy Sura's *traditio* outright before Rufus chained her in Trans-Tiberim, paid eighty to clear Berenice's shop-arrears and shut Sticho's mouth, and turned Baebius's four Spanish oil-jars down on the quay into thirty-one fresh sesterces before dark."

Corvus looked down from Lucida's calm amber eyes to small, trembling Sura—who held out the waxed *traditio* tablet timidly with her burned left arm so the tall Sabine boy could read Hermippus's seal for himself—and every hard, suspicious line round Corvus's mouth softened at once.

He knelt on one knee on the cold Via Sacra paving-blocks to bring his eyes level with the twelve-year-old mute girl's face.

"You climbed down the drain-pipe to fetch that cedar box out before Rufio's gang got upstairs, didn't you, Sura?" Corvus asked quietly.

Sura nodded twice, grey eyes wide in the moonlight.

"Then two hundred eighty sesterces was cheap," Corvus said simply, standing up and hoisting Sura's oil-skin off her narrow shoulder onto his own broad back alongside the clothes-sack. "We don't leave our own in blind mills. Come on—Phileros knows an old Cappadocian baker over

behind the Forum Piscarium who lets dry loft-rooms above his brick ovens where fullers' dogs don't poke their noses, and ovens mean free heat through March."

A Cappadocian baker with brick ovens, Lucida repeated silently inside her skull as she fell into step between Corvus and limping Sura down the moonlit slope of the Sacred Way, feeling the thirty-one copper and silver coins clink steady against her thigh. Twenty-seven days until the Kalends of April brought Hermippus's hand back out for eighty sesterces; somewhere inside three hundred miles of Roman statutes there *had* to sit a road out of the *Lex Iunia Norbana* that didn't ask Publius Vedius Pollio's permission, and starting tomorrow morning among the flour-mills, she intended to find its price.

PART TWO

Chalk and Flour

May, AD 157 – October, AD 158

Chapter VII

Four Spears in the Marble

Sixteenth Day Before the Kalends of June, AD 157 · Corvus

Inside the Basilica Julia, four lawsuits were screaming at one another across four hundred feet of polished marble floor while thirty idle fishmongers on the outer steps played knucklebones over carved circles in the stone.

Corvus stood behind the third cedar bench of the Second *Hasta* with twenty-two pounds of bound boxwood tablets bruising his left collar-bone, sweating inside his clean grey woollen tunic, counting the hired clappers in the gallery overhead.

There were twenty-four of them today, arranged in two neat wedges along the upper travertine balustrade where their shouts would bounce hardest off the coffered timber roof: unshaved freedmen and out-of-work fuller's porters in borrowed chalk-whitened togas, watching neither the forty-five Centumviral judges sweating on their curved wooden tiers nor the frantic junior advocate down by the water-jar, watching only a fat Greek *mesochorus* in a yellow scarf standing behind the third fluted pilaster. Whenever the defence speaker **Gaius Sulpicius Rufus** paused to touch hisperfumed handkerchief to his upper lip and drop his voice a fourth into tragic vibrato, the fat Greek lifted two fingers; instantly all twenty-four *laudiceni* roared *"Bene! Pulchre! Belle!"* in ragged unison, earning three silver denarii apiece plus a basket of cold pork at sunset without understanding six words of Republican land-law between them.

Beside each of the four separate tribunals—screened clumsily from its neighbors by heavy purple-dyed sailcloth curtains hung between giallo antico columns, through which the bellowing of three rival advocates leaked like bulls fighting in adjacent stalls, stood an ancient, iron-butted ashwood spear wedged upright in a bronze floor-socket.

Sub hasta. Under the spear.

Senator Priscus had told Corvus why on their walk down the Clivus Scauri at dawn: because before Romans had praetors or wax tablets or Greek rhetoric-masters, a citizen took land with seven feet of iron-tipped ash, and the Centumviral Court kept the spear standing in the marble to remind soft men in perfumed wool what lay underneath every boundary-deed if the ink washed off.

Right now the spear of the Second *Hasta* was being twisted six inches deep into Senator Priscus's ribs.

Out in the open semi-circle before the judges' dais stood Priscus's junior pleader **Aufidius Bassus**, a thirty-year-old senator's son with weak lungs and wet pink ears, flanked on the bench by **Aulus Volusenus Niger**—who had prepared the boundary-schedule and spent the entire morning admiring the drape of his own wide purple *latus clavus* stripe in the polished African marble dado instead of checking the opposing *codex*.

Across the chalk line stood **Gaius Sulpicius Rufus**, retained at forty thousand sesterces, everyone in the Forum knew whose gold sat behind the straw litigant—by **Publius Vedius Pollio**'s land-company to swallow sixty *iugera* of prime irrigated market-gardens along the Via Salaria four miles north of the Colline Gate, belonging to an orphaned Sabine widow under Priscus's protection.

"Worthy judges of the Second Spear," Sulpicius Rufus purred, strolling three languid paces toward the front bench with one manicured hand tucked inside his *sinus* fold as Caesar Augustus stood on silver coins, "my learned young friend Aufidius has wept very prettily for half a clepsydra over his client's grandfather's pear-trees. Let us all dry our cheeks and read stone instead of poetry."

Up in the gallery two fingers rose; twenty-four hired throats chuckled dutifully on cue.

Sulpicius took a fresh, triple-sealed municipal extract out of his clerk's hand and held the dangling bronze signets toward the presiding *decemvir*'s nose.

"Certified yesterday afternoon at the fourth hour from the *tabularium* of the *curatores riparum et alvei Tiberis* and the rural census roll by **Marcus Tullius Dama**, sworn *scriba librarius* of the third decury! Let the court-herald read Line Nine: *From the old oak stump beside the Salarian ditch,*

running east four hundred twenty Roman paces to the terminal boundary-stone of red Fidenae tufa incised with the decumanus cross, acquired without force, stealth, or revocable leave since the consulship of Torquatus and Atticus! Nine full harvests over the two-year *usucapio* period for Italian soil, judges! Not one foot of the widow's pear-orchard lies west of that red Fidenae stone!"

Aufidius Bassus went the color of boiled turnip, turning helplessly back toward Volusenus on the front bench. "Aulus, you told me the Salarian boundary ran from the *grey* stone at the willow-sluice! Where did he get a certified municipal extract naming red Fidenae tufa?"

Volusenus fumbled wildly through four unbound papyrus rolls on his knees, cinnamon-oiled curls bobbing, knocking an ink-horn sideways onto Phileros's sandal. "There wasn't any red tufa entry when my slave checked the index-tags on Tuesday! Somebody filed a supplemental extract!"

Behind the third bench, fifteen-year-old Corvus stopped counting clappers in the gallery.

Four miles north of the Colline Gate, between the Salarian ditch and the river-meadow.

Corvus shut his eyes for three heartbeats inside the deafening marble roar of four courts, a hundred shuffling litigants, and twenty-four hired clappers, until all of Rome dropped away behind his eyelids and he was twelve years old again, walking twenty paces ahead of his father Gaius Cassius Corvus in wet April grass with a red-and-white painted sighting-rod balanced plumb between two chapped hands while larks rose singing out of the Salarian clover.

Red Fidenae tufa at four hundred twenty paces east of the ditch?

Fidenae lay two miles *further north* up the Tiber ridge, where volcanic ash had cooled soft and rusty-red full of black scoria lumps. Down in the low alluvial flat at the fourth milestone, four hundred twenty paces east of the Salarian ditch—the river-silt overlay **grey *cappellaccio* ash-stone and blue potter's marl**, soft enough that no honest *agrimensor* since King Numa had ever planted soft volcanic tufa in wet river-meadow, because three winter frosts split porous red tufa into gravel! Rural surveyors planted **hard white Tiburtine travertine** or charred oak stakes ringed with broken amphora-bottoms (*testae*) underneath when marking wet Salarian bottomland!

Even sharper: why would a thirteen-year-old municipal boundary-roll from the consulship of Torquatus and Atticus, AD 143, fourteen summers back—describe a stone in the exact geological vocabulary of a town clerk who had ridden past the red quarries at Fidenae once in a litter without ever digging a post-hole in flood-clay?

Up on the dais the presiding *decemvir* tapped his ivory wand against the curule chair-arm, looking down with open boredom as a bronze attendant plugged the clepsydra spout for the sixth-hour midday recess.

"The court rises until the eighth hour," the *decemvir* announced over the hubbub. "Unless Counsel for the petitor produces unimpeached counter-record impeaching the sworn municipal extract of Scriba Tullius Dama when the water runs again, I shall instruct the panel on completed *usucapio*."

Up in the gallery all twenty-four *laudiceni* erupted into thunderous, three-denarius cheering as Sulpicius Rufus swept his chalk-bright toga round one shoulder and strolled out toward the shady portico of the Vicus Tuscus surrounded by fawning juniors.

Behind the purple canvas curtain Senator Priscus stood slowly up from the *advocati* bench, lean jaw set like grey peperino, not even looking at stammering Aufidius, looking straight down at his nephew Volusenus.

"Sixty thousand sesterces of a dead equestrian's orchard, Aulus," Priscus said quietly, "and you sent a ten-sesterce bath-slave to read index-tags instead of opening the municipal *codex* with your own eyes."

"Uncle, Tullius Dama is a twenty-year sworn *scriba* of the third decury!" Volusenus protested, red to both ear-tips. "Nobody impeaches a decurial scribe's certified seal in ninety breaths—we'll have to withdraw before peremptory judgment and sue on the warranty!"

"Withdraw before judgment," Phileros murmured dryly while blotting Volusenus's spilled ink off his ankle with a rag, "and half Sabinum hears by market-day that Quintus Servilius Priscus's house cannot hold sixty *iugera* against Vedius Pollio's straw-buyers."

Corvus shifted the twenty-two-pound bundle of boxwood tablets onto his hip and stepped half a pace forward out of the junior clerks' shadow.

"Tullius Dama forged Line Nine after the third hour yesterday, Senator," Corvus said low, pitching his voice beneath the clatter of wooden benches being reset by court-slaves.

Volusenus whirled on him, furious at having a witness to his own dressing-down. "Shut your ditch-mouth, hod-boy, before I have Phileros dock a month's wool! You haven't even seen Dama's master-roll!"

"Let him finish, Aulus," Priscus said without raising his voice. "Speak, boy. How do you know when the line was written without seeing the book?"

"First, because red Fidenae tufa rots to porridge in three winters if you bury it in wet Salarian flood-clay four hundred paces off the ditch; every Sabine surveyor plants white Tiburtine travertine over charcoal and smashed tile on that flat," Corvus said cleanly. "Second, look at Sulpicius Rufus's certified wax copy lying on Aufidius's stool: Dama wrote *ad terminum tofi rubri Fidenatis*, fifteen Latin words crammed into a single marginal clause at the tail of the boundary-string without naming the *subruncivus* witness-marks underneath. In a bound municipal *codex* of waxed pine leaves or heavy linen-rag charta from fourteen years ago, there isn't room mid-column to insert fifteen new words unless the scribe scraped out a shorter closing formula—like *ad fossam veterem*, and wrote small over the hollow, or pasted a fresh marginal strip before sealing the extract."

Phileros's pale eyebrows lifted a quarter-inch. "The municipal *tabularium* annex behind Castor shuts its iron grilles for two hours at noon while the decurial clerks eat sausages and get shaved, patron. Even your senatorial ring won't open the master-chest before the eighth hour—when our clepsydra runs out."

Corvus looked past the towering marble piers toward the sunlit opening of the **Vicus Tuscus**, down which fat, round-shouldered men in scribes' tunics with iron key-rings at their belts were already waddling toward the shade-awnings and fried-fish stalls.

"We don't need the iron chest opened before the eighth hour," Corvus said. "Show me which back belongs to Marcus Tullius Dama, Phileros, and lend me Volusenus's silver pocket-mirror and four silver denarii."

* * *

The **Vicus Tuscus** smelled at midday of three thousand years of money, frankincense, and wet human hair.

Connecting the south-west corner of the Forum Romanum straight down toward the cattle-markets and river-wharves, the narrow basalt street squeezed Syrian silk-drapers, Etruscan bronze-statuette sellers, money-changers ringing silver denarii on touchstones, and open-fronted barbers' booths cheek by jowl beneath projecting wooden balconies that shut out all save a single blinding white ribbon of May sky overhead.

Forty paces past the high podium of the Temple of Castor, inside whose vaulted concrete basement basement bankers kept senators' strongboxes under armed watch—Phileros slowed beside a seller of boiled lupin-beans and touched two fingers lightly to his own chin toward a striped blue-and-white awning across the gutter.

Under a painted wooden sign showing Mercury holding bronze shears and a gilt comb sat **Marcus Tullius Dama**, fifty years old, triple-chinned, his gold-washed decurial scribe's ring gleaming plump on his left little finger while his heavy iron archive-keys rested right on his own lap beneath a coarse linen *involucre* tucked tight under his jaw.

Glycon the Samian—a wiry, pock-marked Greek barber with six spare iron razors (*novaculae*) warming in a brass pan of hot water and olive-oil emulsion at his elbow, because Romans shaved without tallow-soap, softening tough bristle with steamed towels and warm oil before scraping skin bare with curved Noric steel honed on oil-stone—had just tilted Dama's pudgy neck backward against the oak headrest and laid the gleaming three-inch crescent blade flat below Dama's right ear.

Beside Dama's stool on a three-legged tripod sat the scribe's leather *theca calamaria*, his personal pen-and-scraper case, which no corrupt record-clerk ever left unguarded back at his desk—next to a half-eaten fig pastry and a cup of watered Sabine wine.

"Sixty breaths before Glycon finishes the jaw-line," Phileros murmured into his sleeve, fading politely behind an incense-seller's rack so his famous Caelian face wouldn't spook the quarry prematurely. "Don't touch his person, striking an apparitor on court-day is *vis publica*. Make him open his own mouth."

Corvus walked straight across the sunny basalt cobbles into the striped blue shadow of Glycon's booth, sat down casually on the empty waiting-stool two feet from Tullius Dama's knees as though waiting his own turn for a two-as hair-trim, and flipped Volusenus's polished silver pocket-mirror

once in his scarred right hand so a sharp white coin of noon sun flashed squarely across Dama's half-shut eyelids.

Dama grunted irritably under the steamed oil-cloth without daring to jerk his head while Glycon's curved iron razor hissed *scritch-scritch* down the soft roll of fat above his carotid artery.

"Careful round the windpipe, Glycon," Corvus said conversationally in crisp, slightly burred Sabine Latin, leaning both elbows on his knees and looking admiringly at the leather pen-case on the tripod beside Dama's wine-cup. "My uncle up at Fidenae used to say red volcanic tufa looks very firm in dry weather until a little spring water gets under the crust—then the whole stone crumbles right under your iron."

Under the linen cloth Tullius Dama's plump toes curled rigid inside his slit leather shoes. His watery brown eyes rolled sideways toward the lean fifteen-year-old boy on the waiting-stool.

"Hold your jaw still, worthy scribe, or I nick the mole!" Glycon clucked, lifting the oily steel half an inch to wipe grey stubble onto a piece of tow-rag.

Corvus didn't raise his voice above the sizzle of fried sprats next door; he reached out one bare finger, without touching Dama's person by a hair —and pointed half an inch above the split reed nibs sticking out of Dama's open leather pen-case on the tripod.

"Look at your third reed pen, Master Scribe," Corvus said pleasantly. "Freshly cut oblique nib, still stained purple-grey three fingers up the shaft with oak-gall and copperas *atramentum librarium*, the permanent acid record-ink your decury uses only on linen-charta master-rolls, never on carbon-soot everyday papyrus, because copperas eats weak reed unless you mix it thick. And look under the thumbnail of your right hand resting on those iron keys: two tiny curls of yellow beeswax mixed with old pine-dust from scraping an archive *tabula* seal before re-amping it, plus a grey smudge of pumice-flour round the quick where you rubbed ten-year-old linen-rag fibers smooth at dusk yesterday so fresh copperas wouldn't feather into the erased trough."

Every drop of pink drained out of Tullius Dama's jowls behind the gleaming oil.

Glycon paused with the curved iron *novacula* poised two inches off Dama's Adam's apple, glancing shrewdly from the boy to the sweating official, then tactfully stepped three paces outside his own awning to spit

into the gutter and watch the sky—having shaved enough Forum clerks over twenty years to know when a four-denarius tip walked in to buy deaf ears.

Corvus dropped **four silver denarii** quietly onto Glycon's empty shelf, paying for the barber's deafness—then leaned six inches closer to Dama's ear while Dama sat pinned helpless in his wet linen bib like a trussed capon.

"Here is what happens at the eighth hour when the iron grilles behind Castor open, Marcus Tullius," Corvus murmured, grey-green eyes flat and quiet as winter cistern-water. "Senator Quintus Servilius Priscus, who sits on the senatorial commission auditing municipal archive rolls this June—walks straight to Chest Seven with two *decemviri* beside him and holds Sheet Fourteen of the Torquatus-and-Atticus Salarian roll up against afternoon sunlight, with Volusenus's silver mirror reflecting straight up through the back of the linen fibers. Thinned pumice-scraped rag shines bright white from behind like a greased lantern-horn; fresh oak-gall copperas stays greenish-brown for forty-eight hours before air turns it dead black like fourteen-year-old ink; and red Fidenae tufa doesn't exist within two miles of the Salarian river-flat. Under the *Lex Cornelia de Falsis*, altering a public municipal roll for silver carries deportation to Gyaros and confiscation of every sesterce in your strongbox, assuming you're wealthy enough to count as *honestior*. If the court rules a third-decury clerk *humilior*, they break your legs on the Esquiline."

Sweat burst out in fat beads through the olive oil on Dama's forehead, trickling salt into his mouth.

"Who—who the Hades are you?" Dama whispered hoarsely, terrified even to swallow against his tight collar. "Hermippus's broker swore Priscus's nephew hadn't opened the Salarian chest since March!"

Hermippus's broker. There sat the name, clean out of Dama's own trembling teeth without a thumbscrew laid on him.

"Priscus's nephew didn't," Corvus agreed calmly. "Gaius Cassius Corvus's son did, whose father drove every white travertine *terminus* along that Salarian ditch before you knew which end of a *groma* pointed north. Now listen carefully, because the seventh-hour sun just touched Castor's third column and you have thirty breaths left with both legs unbroken."

Phileros stepped smoothly out from behind the incense-seller's rack across the lane, already holding an opened two-leaved boxwood *testatio* and a dipped iron stylus like a priest arriving with extreme unction.

"You don't scream *forgery* against yourself in open court, Master Dama," Phileros said gently, laying the tablet right across Dama's knees on top of the linen barber-bib. "Self-accusation is messy and delays supper. Instead, like a conscientious twenty-year servant of the Roman People, you realized over your midday lupin-beans that yesterday's rush copyist accidentally transcribed a rider from the *upper Fidenae hill-lot* on Sheet Twelve onto the *lower Salarian meadow-lot* on Sheet Fourteen—leaving an uncertified blot on the working copy which you now formally correct under your own decurial ring before judgment! Sign five lines of clerical erratum right here while your right cheek is still unshaved, give back Hermippus's twenty gold pieces tonight if he wants them, and keep your house on the Aventine."

Dama's fat right hand shook so badly as he took Phileros's stylus that the first stroke skidded sideways across the black wax; he steadied his wrist against his iron key-ring, scratched the five-line *emendatio* naming the true **white Tiburtine stone at the old willow-sluice**, and pressed his gold-washed decurial ring deep into the warm sealing-grooves while three passing equestrian money-changers called in off the curb witnessed the cord for two sesterces apiece.

Corvus picked Volusenus's silver mirror off his knee, tucked it into his belt, and nodded politely to Glycon at the curb.

"Mind the mole under his right ear, master barber," Corvus said. "The worthy scribe has very delicate skin."

* * *

Back inside the roaring marble belly of the Basilica Julia at the eighth hour, Senator Priscus did not trust stammering Aufidius or preening Volusenus with the kill; he rose in his own short, unchalked Republican toga, walked three slow paces to the *cancelli* rail as the bronze attendant pulled the plug from the clepsydra, and laid Marcus Tullius Dama's wet-sealed clerical *emendatio* silently before the presiding *decemvir* alongside two grey chunks of Salarian river-marl Phileros had sent a mule-boy galloping four miles out the Colline Gate to dig fresh from the ditch.

He spoke for less than a quarter of a clepsydra, six dry, unornamented Latin periods that sounded like oak beams dropping into mortise-slots—never raising his voice once, forcing all forty-five Centumviral judges and

even Sulpicius Rufus's twenty-four hired clappers to lean forward straining their ears in dead silence.

Across the aisle **Gaius Sulpicius Rufus** listened with a faint, connoisseur's smile, touched two fingers courteously to his brow in surrender when Dama's own seal was verified, and didn't bother wasting a breath defending a burned clerk, though as Sulpicius turned to gather his scrolls, his dark Bithynian eyes slid past red-faced Volusenus and rested for three long, measuring heartbeats squarely on the tall, black-haired fifteen-year-old standing behind the third bench with an iron stylus tucked behind his ear.

Forty-one wooden voting-tablets out of forty-five came out of the bronze urn marked **A** (*Absolvo / Action Approved*) for Priscus's widow before the ninth hour struck.

Out under the shady northern arcade afterward, while the weeping Sabine widow kissed Priscus's toga-hem, Priscus turned to his nephew.

"Aulus, go pay Aufidius his Viaticum and return your silver mirror to this boy—no, keep the mirror, boy, you used it better than my sister's son did. Phileros: **forty-eight sesterces a week** starting on the Kalends of June, and send him twice a week at the tenth hour to old Antonius Gnipho's freedman for vocal chest-breathing so he doesn't swallow Sabine vowels when he turns seventeen and argues *cognitor* suits for me."

Volusenus stood rigid between two fluted marble columns as his uncle walked ahead toward his litter. Before following, the nineteen-year-old patrician stepped close enough to Corvus that cinnamon beard-oil and sour sweat mingled six inches from Corvus's scarred lip.

"Enjoy the forty-eight sesterces, mud-lark," Volusenus whispered, twisting his red carnelian *quadriga* ring until his knuckle whitened. "My uncle collects clever street-dogs every five years until one bites the wrong ankle, then he drowns them in the Tiber himself."

Corvus looked calmly down two inches into Volusenus's flushed face —because between December's fever and May's sun Corvus had shot up another palm-breadth in bone and shoulder, already overtopping Priscus's plump nephew, and smiled solely with the white scar on his left lip.

"Watch your ink-horn on the steps, Aulus," Corvus said pleasantly. "Marble's slippery when you don't read the stone underneath."

An hour before sunset, carrying two fresh loaves of white *siligo* wheat-bread and a waxed copy of **Gaius's *Institutes*** lent overnight from Phileros's

chest, Corvus ducked through the smoky, fish-smelling colonnade behind the **Forum Piscarium** and climbed the outside brick stair above **Habinnas Barba**'s half-idle *pistrinum*.

Down in the cavernous stone bakery courtyard below, only one of Barba's four hourglass-shaped dark grey volcanic lava mills (*molae asinariae*) was turning—dragged round and round in creaking circles by a single rib-sprung blindfolded mule while old one-eyed Cappadocian **Barba**, white from shaggy eyebrows to split knuckles with coarse bran-flour, coughed dry mill-dust into an empty sack and cursed the state *annona* inspectors in broken Greek.

Up in their dry, warm brick-vaulted loft directly over the cooling bread-arch, partitioned neatly in two with clean unbleached sailcloth so thirteen-year-old **Sura** had her own corner mat and chalk-slate—**Lucida** knelt barefoot in a sleeveless summer linen shift beside four fat Spanish oil-skins, balancing a miniature bronze steelyard (*statera*) on one steady forefinger while tallying numbers on a scraped wax board.

Heat rising up through the terracotta floor-tiles from Barba's afternoon baking had curled dark damp tendrils loose from her braids against the nape of her neck and brought a sheen of salt-glow across her bare olive shoulders. At fifteen and eight months she had lost the last pinched hollow of Subortanae starvation; her collarbones were long and clean above firm, high breasts bound snug under linen, her wrists supple and strong from lifting fifty-pound oil-measures every dawn at the river.

She glanced up as Corvus's shadow crossed the open shutter, caught the bright triumph still humming behind his grey-green eyes before he said a word, and set down her bronze steelyard.

"Priscus won his Salarian pear-trees," Lucida guessed at once, breaking off the warm heel of his *siligo* loaf and tossing half over the sailcloth screen to Sura, who caught it one-handed with a soft chirp.

"Forty-one tablets to four," Corvus said, sitting cross-legged on the warm tiles opposite her and dropping twelve silver denarii, his new forty-eight-sesterce weekly scale—ringing onto her counting-board. "Caught Hermippus's bribed scribe with wet copperas under his razor in a Vicus Tuscus barber-stall. Starting next month Priscus is putting me with a voice-master after hours so I can plead minor *cognitor* claims at seventeen."

Lucida whistled low between her teeth, eyes shining genuine fierce pride for him, then dropped immediately to the fat papyrus roll tucked under his belt. "What's the scroll? More aqueduct fines?"

"Better," Corvus said, unrolling the first fresh column of **Gaius's *Commentarii***—the brilliant provincial teacher whose crystal-clear four-book lectures on Roman civil status every Forum clerk was copying this spring, toward the open west window where red sunset slanted across the tiles. "Look at Book One, Column Nine, Vespera. Phileros let me bring the status-sheet home overnight because I told him I needed the *tutela* rules. Read from *Item Latino tribus modis*—on the ways a **Junian Latin** wins full Roman citizenship (*ius Quiritium*) *without* asking the old patron to walk before the Praetor's rod!"

Lucida went still as carved amber. Every muscle in her bare shoulders locked; she slid across the warm terracotta tiles until her bare knee pressed solid against Corvus's thigh, leaning over the papyrus so close her dark hair brushed his cheek, smelling of Spanish virgin olive oil, warm wheat-crust, and clean sweat.

Her stain-shadowed forefinger tracked slowly down the neat Latin capitals while she read aloud under her breath:

"First, by imperial beneficium *directly from Caesar… Second, by bearing three children after marrying before seven citizens under the* Lex Aelia Sentia *—too slow and puts a husband over your purse… Third, six years in the night-watch* vigiles*—men only… Fourth, building a sea-going ship of ten thousand* modii *to carry state wheat for six years… Fifth, spending half an estate over a hundred thousand sesterces building a new house in Rome…"*

Her finger stopped dead at Line Twenty-Six.

"Item ex edicto divi Traiani: si Latinus in urbe triennio pistrinum exercuerit, in quo in singulos dies non minus quam centenos modios frumenti pinserit, ad ius Quiritium pervenit."

Slowly Lucida translated the dense legal Latin out loud into plain street speech, testing every bolt in the iron lock:

"Likewise by the Edict of the Deified Trajan: if a Junian Latin operates a mill-bakery in the City for three continuous years, in which he—or she, Latinus *covers women in commercial edicts, doesn't it, Corvus?"*

"Ulpian and Gaius both say masculine commercial terms include *Latinae* wherever bodily military service isn't required, yes!" Corvus confirmed, heart quickening at the sudden blaze in her eyes.

"—grinds and bakes not less than ***one hundred modii of grain every single day*** *for three continuous years, that Latin arrives at full Quiritary Roman citizenship!"*

Lucida lifted her head from the scroll and stared straight down through the cracks of the floorboards—straight down into old **Habinnas Barba**'s smoky stone courtyard below, where three out of four massive volcanic lava mill-stones sat silent under cobwebs for want of capital and grain-credit, while one blindfolded mule crept round in the dusk!

One hundred *modii* a day, roughly sixteen hundred Roman pounds of wheat ground and baked every twenty-four hours—for **one thousand and ninety-five unbroken days**. Complete that statutory run registered on the Urban Prefect's mill-roll, and on the morning of Day One Thousand Ninety-Six **Publius Vedius Pollio's patronal reversion shattered to dust**, no eighty-sesterce monthly tribute (which Corvus still knew nothing about), no slave-shroud waiting at death, full citizen *ius Quiritium* won by flour and fire!

"Four lava mills downstairs," Lucida whispered, eyes narrowed to bright golden slits as her merchant brain began multiplying mule-shifts, firewood loads, and sack-tallies faster than an abacus. "One *mola asinaria* working double donkey-shifts grinds twenty-eight to thirty *modii* in twenty-four hours. Run all four of Barba's stones day and night, and this courtyard clears **a hundred ten *modii* a day** with ten *modii* margin for cracked axles!"

Corvus stared at her in half-awed alarm. "Vespera, buying grain, eight strong mill-asses, firewood, and kneaders to run a hundred *modii* a day takes eight or ten thousand sesterces working capital before the state *annona* grants subsidized wheat! All we have saved in the new box since March is four hundred twenty!"

"Four hundred twenty in May," Lucida said softly, laying her warm palm flat over Gaius's Latin lines as though claiming title by spear-point herself. Down below, Barba's iron oven-door clanged shut in the red gloom, sending a wave of dry oak-heat up around their bare ankles. "Give me until summer ends to turn Spanish oil into fuller's alum and Caelian salve, Sabine

—and don't return this scroll to Phileros until I've copied every single word of Trajan's Edict onto my own wax."

Chapter VIII

A Hundred Modii

Fourteenth Day Before the Kalends of September, AD 157 · Lucida

Every chip of grey volcanic stone flying off **Habinnas Barba**'s iron pick smelled of struck flint and burned hair.

It was the fourth watch of an August night hot enough to melt beeswax on a shelf, and down in the sunken basalt courtyard behind the Fish-Market three of Barba's four hourglass-shaped lava mills stood dismantled on oak timber balks. Naked to the waist, sixty-two years old, his barrel chest matted with coarse white curls clotted grey by forty summers of airborne flour-paste, the old Cappadocian straddled the upturned bell of Number Two *catillus* with a horn oil-lamp gripped between his knees, pecking fresh diagonal furrows across worn grey Orvieto stone with a double-ended iron *marra*.

Every fifth blow stopped him short while his ribs hitched in a long, dry, whistling wheeze—*pistrinum* lung, which killed mill-bakers slower than quicklime killed potters and left them spitting stiff white dough-pellets into rags every morning before dawn.

Lucida sat three paces off on an upturned brine-keg in her oldest sleeveless linen shift, dark braids bound tight inside a twisted yellow head-cloth against mill-dust, Sura asleep curled like a barn-cat on clean empty grain-sacks behind her, adding up Barba's greasy beechwood tallies by the light of a second tallow wick.

"Stop pecking the skirt of that stone so deep, Barba, or you'll shred the bran into powder and turn tomorrow's second-grade loaves brown as horse-turds," Lucida said in plain Subura Greek without looking up from his charcoal columns. "Look at your July brushwood bill instead. Who sold

you forty bundles of Sabine Broom-faggots at nine asses the bundle when river-drift alder was landing at the Tiber steps for six?"

Barba lowered his iron pick, spat a grey gobbet onto the dry basalt flags, and glared across the lamp-flame with his one clear black eye, the left having clouded milky white ten winters back when a hot oven-flue blew oak-splinters into his face.

"Alder smokes wet and sours the brick dome, girl," Barba growled, voice scraping like two millstones running empty. "You know olive-dregs and ladies' face-paint; don't teach a man who baked army biscuit for Arrian against the Alans how to heat hearth-tile! Why aren't you upstairs sleeping like honest folk?"

"Because upstairs feels like the inside of a boiled sheep's stomach tonight, and because if somebody doesn't read these tallies before the Kalends of March, neither you nor I will have a roof over this courtyard next spring," Lucida answered calmly, turning the split beechwood board round on her knee so her charcoal-blackened finger pointed straight at the bottom notch-row. "Let me read your own winter death-warrant back to you, old man, and tell me where my arithmetic limps."

Barba's good black eye narrowed under flour-crusted brows; he didn't tell her to go upstairs.

"You hold a five-year ground-and-oven *conductio* lease on this courtyard, four Orvieto donkey-mills, two twelve-foot domed brick ovens, and the stone kneading-troughs from **Gaius Munatius**, who mortgaged the reversion last autumn to **Hermippus**—steward to Publius Vedius Pollio," Lucida said, keeping her voice level over that hated name. "Your lease carries a renewal option on the Kalends of March at four thousand eight hundred sesterces a year *provided* your ovens stay enrolled on the Urban Prefect's active *pistrina* list grinding at least fifty *modii* a day. Drop below fifty *modii* for six consecutive months, or default on two quarters' rent, and Hermippus forecloses the equipment-pledge, four lava mills worth two thousand sesterces apiece, two brick ovens worth six thousand—for a song, chains twelve cheap Gallic debt-slaves to those sweep-bars, and throws you out on the Forum Piscarium cobbles to beg fish-heads."

Barba's scarred thumb rubbed slowly along the iron bevel of his stone-pick. "I buried two mill-asses of glanders in April, girl, and state *annona* clerks won't issue subsidized African wheat below a hundred *modii* daily

capacity. Private grain-jobbers at the Porticus Minucia charge four sesterces and a half the *modius* on thirty-day credit, and half the sacks they dump at my gate are three inches deep in black chalk-dust and dead grain-weevils!"

Lucida rose off the brine-keg, walked over to the open sack of private "Campanian" wheat leaning against Trough One, plunged her bare arm straight down to the elbow into the warm grain—never skimming the clean top layer, and brought up a fistful from the bottom seam.

She spread the kernels across the flat oak balk directly under Barba's lamp.

"Four and a half sesterces a *modius* from **Numerius Vettius**, wasn't it?" Lucida asked softly. With one fingernail she separated seven hollow, pin-holed hulls chewed empty by *curculio* beetles, three grey pellets of dried river-clay sized to pass a coarse sieve and add dead weight on the steelyard, and two shriveled black seeds of bearded darnel (*lolium*)—the dizzying weed that made cheap Subura bread-eaters stagger blind with *temulentia* headaches! "Numerius Vettius borrows his warehouse silver at one percent a month from **Hermippus's own freedman**, Barba! Every short-weight sack of weevil-husks Vettius sells you on credit bleeds twelve percent off your flour-yield while choking your sieves, deliberately starving your daily output below fifty *modii* so Hermippus takes your four lava mills free in March!"

For ten slow breaths the only sound in the stifling courtyard was the restless stamp of Barba's surviving one-eared mule inside the dark stable-stall and the distant splash of the Fish-Market fountain outside the gate.

Barba stared down at the grey clay pellets and black darnel seeds on the oak beam, his jaw working inside his flour-stiffened beard until the tendons stood out like harness-ropes along his neck.

"Filthy Smyrniot jackals," the old Cappadocian whispered in Greek, raising the four-pound iron stone-pick three inches as though Vettius's skull lay on the beam, then letting it thud dull against the wood as another dry wheeze rattled his chest. "Knowing who poisons the well doesn't buy clean wheat, Tyrian. To throw Vettius out, buy five sound Reatine mill-mules, hire four free night-kneaders, and pay cash on the Ostian barges for clean Sicilian hard-wheat until our daily grind hits **a hundred *modii***—where the *annona* prefect has to grant us state quota wheat at three sesterces flat, takes **eight thousand sesterces** hard silver! Have you got eight thousand sesterces hidden under your little mute girl's straw?"

"I will have eight thousand sesterces on that kneading-table before the middle of February," Lucida said, meeting his solitary fierce eye across the tallow-smoke without blinking, "on three conditions written into a sworn *societas* contract and registered at the Urban Prefect's mill-office."

Barba snorted chalk out of his moustache. "Listen to fifteen years old talking eight thousand sesterces! Let's hear the three hooks inside the dough."

"Sixteen next month," Lucida corrected crisply, "and every copper of my silver will ring clean on a touchstone. First: we register the *pistrinum* jointly at the Prefecture of the *Annona* with **Habinnas Barba and Lucida, freedwoman's daughter**, named side by side as co-*exercitores* personally superintending a minimum daily grind and bake of **one hundred five *modii***—five *modii* safety cushion above Trajan's hundred-modius citizenship threshold, for **three unbroken years**, one thousand and ninety-five days without a single unbaked dawn, even on holidays or floods."

Understanding lit Barba's good black eye at once; every baker in Rome knew Trajan's Edict, because half the rich freedmen in the *corpus pistorum* had climbed out of Junian Latin twilight across four lava millstones.

"Ah," Barba grunted, scratching his sweaty collarbone with chalky knuckles. "Trajan's three-year shoe! That's why you've been counting my oven-bricks since May instead of peddling perfume in deep shade! And Hook Two?"

"Hook Two: **I control all grain purchasing, fuel contracts, and wholesale bread-tallies** you control stone-dressing, yeast-leavening, and oven-heat. Not one sack crosses that threshold until my bronze grain-thief probes the bottom seam. Hook Three: out of net monthly silver after rent, fodder, and loan-amortization, we split fifty-fifty—and if you die of that rattle in your chest before my thousand and ninety-fifth day finishes, your half of the lease and equipment passes to me for six hundred sesterces burial-honors in your *collegium* columbarium rather than falling intestate to any outside creditor."

Barba stared at her across the upturned volcanic bell for a long, rasping count of five, then slapped his heavy, scarred palm hard against the grey Orvieto lava so dust puffed white between them.

"Blunt as a butcher's cleaver!" the old soldier-baker barked, almost grinning through broken yellow teeth. "My *collegium* is **Aesculapius and**

Hygia out past the Porta Capena—sixty honest craftsmen, decent Falernian at the February death-suppers, and a dry brick niche where rain doesn't rot your urn. Bring me eight thousand clean sesterces before Hermippus's bailiff knocks in February, little Tyrian, and by the Mountain Mother of Comana we'll grind a hundred and ten *modii* every dawn till Caesar signs your citizen tablet himself!"

* * *

Eight thousand sesterces in six months could never come out of cracked Emporium amphorae alone, especially while **eighty sesterces** (20 denarii) had to walk secretly every Kalends into Hermippus's back rent-office off the Subura to keep Publius Vedius Pollio's silver pear-knife folded shut.

By August Lucida had cleared four separate March, April, May, June, July, and August Kalends tributes—four hundred eighty sesterces bled silently off her private side-ledger without Corvus ever suspecting a coin was missing from their shared loft savings-box, which already held **one thousand one hundred sesterces** of his steady Caelian clerk's silver and her declared oil-margins. Yet eleven hundred sesterces left nearly seven thousand still to find before February, which was why, at the blazing sixth hour of that same August day while half Rome snored behind wet shutters, Lucida climbed the laurel-shaded steps of the **Caelian Hill** carrying a double-walled cork snow-pail wrapped in damp felt.

Inside the airy north-facing summer *diaeta* of the *Domus Ceionia*, where marble wall-channels trickled chilled Aqua Claudia water behind green Karystian pillars to beat back the Dog-Star heat, **Ceionia Fabia** was not alone today.

Sprawled sideways across a green silk couch near the open colonnade, naked above a loose linen loin-cloth, twenty-six-year-old **Lucius Ceionius Commodus** was tossing hard green unripe figs into the air for a sleek white Laconian greyhound to snap mid-leap while two bath-slaves scraped glistening olive oil and yellow sand off his broad, muscled calves with curved bronze *strigiles*.

Seen ten paces off in harsh midday light without banquet torches, the younger adopted son of Emperor Antoninus Pius looked like an expensive Greek bronze of Apollo somebody had left overnight in a tavern: thick,

sunlit golden-brown curls dusted deliberately with fine gold mica-powder by his barber, lazy heavy-lidded eyes full of easy physical good humor, a wide sensual mouth that smiled even while sweating, and not one cruel bone visible in him—only the terrifying carelessness of a young prince who had never once since his cradle picked up anything he dropped himself.

Seated upright on a plain camp-stool in the shade six feet away, wearing a coarse, ink-spotted white woollen tunic despite the ninety-degree heat, dark curly beard trimmed square, pale sunken hollows under dark, chronically sleepless eyes—thirty-six-year-old **Marcus Aurelius Caesar** was correcting marginal notes on a tax-petition from Asia while sipping tepid plain water out of an earthenware mug.

Lucida knelt silently beside Dorcas behind the pierced marble screen at Fabia's elbow, unpacking the cork snow-pail: crushed Praenestine rose-petals, blanched bitter-almond milk, and four grains of powdered Egyptian alum whipped over packed Alban snow to close summer sweat-pores under white lead without caking.

Through the carved marble vine-leaves of the screen, six feet from her ear, imperial Rome talked with its shoes off.

"Drink half a ladle of snow-mulsum before your liver dries into parchment, Mark," Lucius drawled lazily, bouncing up on one oiled elbow as the greyhound gulped a third fig whole. "Even old Father Pius took off his wool belly-band at Lorium Tuesday! What's that scroll, more Bithynian town-councillors whining they spent their aqueduct money on a marble theater?"

Marcus Caesar didn't look up from his reed pen, though the corner of his bearded mouth twitched faintly—genuine, tired affection for a younger brother ten years lighter in the saddle than himself.

"Smyrna grain-shipping exemptions, Lucius," Marcus said, his voice thin from a chronically weak chest, exquisitely precise in every Latin consonant. "If our father grants fifty rich ship-owners immunity from municipal liturgies without checking tonnage, forty smaller bakers in Smyrna pay double tax before winter. Did you read Julian's opinion on the Ostian *navicularii* I sent round yesterday?"

Lucius groaned melodramatically, flopping flat back onto the green silk cushions with one muscular forearm flung over his eyes while the slave finished scraping his ankle. "I read six columns before **Volucer** threw an off-fore shoe at the Green training-track, and the Syrian vet wanted to poultice

the frog with turpentine instead of Attic honey and burned vine-ash! Ask me whether turpentine dries a stallion's hoof-wall brittle in August, Mark—there's useful statecraft! Besides, Quintus Servilius Priscus and your gloomy friend Rusticus read enough Julian for ten emperors; why keep dogs and bark yourself?"

Behind the pierced marble screen **Ceionia Fabia**'s narrow shoulders went hard as green Karystian stone under Lucida's cooling rose-sponge.

Marcus did set his reed pen down at that. He looked quietly across at his sprawling adoptive brother for three breaths.

"Because dogs guard whoever feeds them, Lucius," Marcus said mildly, "not whoever sleeps longest on the couch. Father asked twice on the Kalends why you missed the Latin receptor hearings to sit in the *Trigarium* paddock with Vedius Pollio's horse-leech."

Vedius Pollio.

Lucida's sponge did not pause by a fraction of a hair across Fabia's pale freckled collarbone, though her ears drank every syllable straight down into cold storage. **Vedius Pollio** wasn't merely entertaining Lucius Commodus with twelve-thousand-sesterce green parakeets; Vedius was worming straight into the young prince's chariot-stables while Senator Priscus and Junius Rusticus, *Corvus's Caelian masters!*—built walls around austere Marcus!

Lucius laughed easily, rolling off the couch to clap Marcus affectionately on one thin wool-clad shoulder, leaving a shiny smear of olive oil on the heir-apparent's clean tunic which Marcus didn't rebuke—and whistled his greyhound to heel.

"Tell Father I'll sit through three solid hours of Umbrian drainage ditches on Thursday without yawning once, provided you let me bet twenty gold pieces on *Volucer* for the September Circus!" Lucius called back brightly, striding off toward the cold plunge-bath with bath-slaves trotting behind him.

A moment later Marcus gathered his Smyrna scrolls, bowed gravely toward his adoptive cousin-by-marriage Fabia behind her screen, and walked out with the slightly stooped, tense-shouldered gait of a man carrying Rome's entire tile roof on six bruised vertebrae.

Only when both princes' footsteps had faded down opposite colonnades did Ceionia Fabia speak.

"Men think crowns are lost in Senate speeches," Fabia hissed softly to her own bronze mirror while Lucida dabbed snow-chilled alum water beneath her jaw. "Crowns are lost because one brother smells of ink and boiled turnips in August while the other lets usurers like Vedius Pollio sell his head-groom rotten Bruttian pitch at triple price! Look at me, Tyrian."

Lucida lifted her eyes into the polished silvered bronze mirror. Over eight months of fortnightly visits, never chattering, never spilling a syllable of December's green phials, always bringing salves cleaner and fresher than old Berenice's greasy thumbs ever compounded—fifteen-year-old Lucida had become the one outside pair of eyes prideful, sidelined Fabia allowed behind her curtain.

"You buy bulk Spanish oil and Syrian gums down on the river-wharves without middle-brokers, don't you?" Fabia asked sharply.

"Direct off Gaditane and Tyrian hulls before warehouse-factors add forty percent, Domina," Lucida answered at once.

"My brother Lucius spends six thousand sesterces a month out of his private allowance on stable-embrocations, Cyprian laurel-berry oil, white wax, pine-rosin, crushed fenugreek, and Chian turpentine—for the twelve prize four-horse teams he backs at the **Factio Prasina** barracks in Campus Martius," Fabia said, green emerald earrings swinging bright against her pale neck. "Right now Vedius Pollio's freedman supplies those stable-chests and skims half into Lucius's betting-tab so Vedius holds my brother's chits! Can you compound clean, unadulterated Green-stable hoof-and-tendon salves in fifty-pound terracotta jars for **three hundred sesterces a month** cash out of *my* steward's chest, cutting Vedius's horse-broker clean out of the *Trigarium* back gate without putting my name on the wagon?"

Three hundred sesterces a month—clearing easily **one hundred forty sesterces net profit every thirty days** above ingredients, almost double her entire secret eighty-sesterce Kalends blood-tax to Vedius, paid straight out of Vedius's own rival's purse for stealing Vedius's stable-racket!

"Give me the Syrian vet's exact weight-ratios on a blank wax leaf, Domina," Lucida said, pulse singing bright and fierce behind serene amber eyes, "and forty-pound stoneware jars sealed in green pitch will sit inside the *Trigarium* stable-gate on the Nones of September at two hundred eighty sesterces, saving your chest twenty sesterces a month to buy the head-groom's silence."

Fabia's thin unpainted mouth curved into genuine, wolfish satisfaction. "Dorcas: count her **thirty silver denarii** advance for jars and Cyprian laurel-oil right now! And don't let Vedius's cross-eyed bailiffs see whose mule drops those pots at the stables, girl, or both of us lose a horse."

* * *

By the eleventh hour of that burning August afternoon, with **one hundred twenty sesterces** of Fabia's bright advance silver tucked safely inside her stitched bodice-hem and her mind already calculating how Green-stable supply plus a burial-club loan could raise Barba's full eight thousand before winter, Lucida met Corvus on the stone steps of the **Pons Aemilius** and led him across the Tiber up the roaring green flank of the **Janiculum Hill**.

High along the ridge Emperor Trajan had brought an entire cold mountain river—the **Aqua Traiana** from Lake Bracciano thirty miles northwest, bursting down the steep eastern slope through stepped masonry mill-races (*euripi*) that drove twenty thunderous overshot oak water-wheels one below another from crest to river-bank.

Compared with Barba's stifling, airless Subura donkey-courtyard, the Janiculum mill-slope at sunset felt like standing inside a waterfall. White spray leaped ten feet off mossy black oak paddles turning steadily in stone chutes; cold mist smelled of crushed mountain fern, wet pine timber, and sweet fresh-ground wheat; and deafening deep wooden rumble vibrated right up through boot-soles into shin-bones so nobody ten paces off could overhear a word spoken beside the race.

Corvus had walked straight from Antonius Gnipho's freedman's voice-school near the Circus Flaminius, still carrying his brass *pes Monetalis* and wax notebook; for half an hour he crouched absorbed along the slick stone wheel-pit of an unlocked municipal mill, timing the bronze lantern-pinion teeth (*tympanum dentatum*) that geared one slow ten-foot oak water-wheel into a spinning three-hundred-pound upper *catillus* at quadruple a donkey's speed!

"Look at the iron spindle-step (*rynd*), Vespera," Corvus shouted joyfully over the white roar, grey-green eyes bright with spray, pointing with wet ink-stained fingers at the iron cross-bar supporting the spinning upper stone. "Raise that iron wedge half a *digitus* with one tap of a hammer and

you get coarse army groats; drop it a sixteenth-inch and one water-wheel grinds **sixty *modii* in twelve hours** without feeding a single mule barley! When we have capital in two years, we don't buy more Subura donkeys—we lease a forty-foot drop on this race!"

"Trajan's citizenship edict requires operating the *pistrinum* inside the City administrative roll, and every water-slot on this hill is locked up twenty years deep by senators' freedmen," Lucida called back, unlacing her dusty calfskin boots on a broad, sunlit slab of warm travertine beside the lower tailrace pool where clear cold overflow swirled knee-deep over smooth pebbles before plunging down toward Trans-Tiberim. "Subura donkeys win my citizen shoe first; Janiculum water-wheels make us rich second! Take off your hot *calcei*, advocate, before you blister your heels."

Corvus laughed, a rare, unguarded sixteen-almost-sixteen boy's laugh that wiped eight months of Caelian watchfulness clean off his scarred mouth—pulled off his calfskin shoes and woollen socks, rolled his grey tunic-hem above scarred brown knees, and dropped down onto the warm travertine ledge beside her, plunging both hot, dusty feet straight into the churning emerald-white foam.

Both of them gasped aloud at the icy Bracciano shock, kicking cold spray across each other's shins like twelve-year-olds in the Tiber shallows before the clay-pit took their parents.

Golden-red August sun slanted low over the umbrella-pines crowning the Janiculum crest behind them; spread out across the wide bend of the Tiber below lay the whole tremendous marble-and-brick beast of Rome, a million souls emerging onto flat roofs and riverside steps to breathe evening air, gilded bronze roof-tiles of Capitoline Jupiter blazing like a shield set on fire, grey smoke rising from ten thousand supper-hearths in the Subura valley where they had walked in barefoot ten months ago with eleven copper coins and a broken clay disc.

Lucida leaned back on one bare brown forearm, letting the cold mountain tailrace tug round her ankles, eyes half-closed against the red glare.

"You've got white *siligo* flour all behind your right ear from Barba's loft," Corvus said beside her.

Before she opened her eyes, he scooped a palmful of cold clear Bracciano water out of the race and reached naturally across—just as he had wiped fuller's lime or river-mud off her face a hundred times since they were seven,

touching wet fingertips behind the shell of her right ear to rinse the dried flour-dust out of the damp dark curls along her neck.

Except neither of them was seven anymore, and it wasn't winter fever in a freezing garret where death stood over the straw.

Water trickled cold from Corvus's scarred right thumb down the sun-warmed skin of Lucida's neck, following the curve of her throat straight into the hollow above her left collarbone—over the tiny brown olive-pip mark, and sliding in one bright drop beneath the damp linen edge of her sleeveless summer shift between her breasts.

Corvus's thumb stopped dead against the hot pulse beating in the side of her throat.

Lucida opened her eyes six inches from his face.

Over the past six months on Caelian mutton and steady bread Corvus had grown four inches past her crown; dark razor-stubble shadowed his hard Sabine jaw above his open collar; the pale stylus-scar at the corner of his mouth caught the red sunset; and his grey-green eyes were staring down not at her ear at all—at the damp linen clinging tight to the swell of her breasts as her breath caught, and then straight up into her parted mouth.

Under his wet thumb she felt his hand, steady enough to shave wax under two consular senators' noses or hold a glass flask inside a roaring sewer **—tremble once against her skin**.

Heat that had nothing to do with the August sun went straight through Lucida's belly down to the soles of her wet feet in the icy race, sharp and dizzying enough that her fingers curled involuntarily against the warm travertine stone between their thighs instead of pushing his wrist away. Half an inch closer and his scarred mouth would have been on hers, salt spray and flour-dust and sixteen summers breaking open together over the roar of the wheels.

Instead Corvus jerked his wet hand back off her throat as though her skin had burned his fingers, splashing water across his own knee, his jaw locking tight while dull dark color surged up under his sun-browned cheek-bones.

Neither of them spoke for five thunderous revolutions of the giant oak wheel above their heads.

"Sun's touching the Aventine," Corvus said hoarsely at last, staring straight ahead across the river while reaching blindly for his dry calfskin

shoes without looking at her shift. “Barba bolts the Fish-Market gate at the first watch if we don’t cross before dusk.”

“Then lace your boots faster, Sabine,” Lucida said, making her voice brisk and dry over the wild, traitorous hammering still kicking underneath her breastbone, bending forward to pull her own leather laces tight so her dark braids fell forward hiding her hot cheeks.

All the way down the steep stepped lane to the bridge they walked six careful inches apart without brushing elbows once, yet every time the evening river-wind blew Corvus’s clean grey wool sleeve within a hair’s breadth of her bare forearm, Lucida felt the exact shape of his scarred right thumb burning cold and wet against her throat, and wondered with a sudden sharp twist in her chest how two people hiding half their ledgers from each other were going to survive turning seventeen under the same low roof.

Chapter IX

Gout and Plautus

Day Before the Ides of November, AD 157 · Corvus

Marcus Cornelius Fronto, greatest living master of Latin eloquence in the inhabited world, lay propped on seven goose-feather cushions inside Maecenas's heated Esquiline conservatory cursing his own left knee in three dialects of Punic, Greek, and archaic Umbrian.

"Tell me, Victorinus—no, don't touch the footstool, if a fly lands on that woollen bandage my shin-bone splits like dry chestnut!, tell me why the immortal gods give smooth, unswollen ankles to every mule-driver in the Subura while turning an ex-consul's joints into bags of hot gravel!"

Standing quietly by the glazed terracotta *hypocaust* wall-flues with Senator Priscus's oilskin scroll-cylinder tucked under his left arm, seventeen-year-old Corvus watched the famous Numidian senator wince, hiss between magnificent white African teeth, and immediately dictate two lines of an exquisite letter to Emperor Antoninus Pius describing his knee-pain through three rare metaphors out of Plautus's *Pseudolus*.

Outside the tall mica panes, mid-November sleet blew slantwise across the high brick rampart of the **Horti Maecenatiani**, rattling dead plane-leaves over the ancient Servian agger where Horace and Virgil had once walked under Augustus. Inside Fronto's circular winter study, boxwood braziers and hollow tile walls kept the air hot as Cirta in June, thick with the competing smells of boiled henbane poultice, cedar book-oil, roasted Libyan figs, and five hundred priceless Republican papyrus rolls stacked in open pigeonholes round the room.

Corvus had turned seventeen five days earlier—wearing a plain unbordered tunic on workdays saving his white citizen *toga virilis* for Forum mornings, his shoulders had broadened enough hauling water-buckets and

archive-chests that Phileros had let out his winter seams twice since autumn. For five months now he had spent two evenings a week after Caelian hours barking Demosthenes with round smooth river-pebbles under his tongue at old Gnipho's freedman's school; today Priscus had trusted him alone with a sealed packet of Cato the Censor's *Origines* excerpts Fronto wanted checked for an upcoming extortion speech before the Senate.

Before Fronto's secretary could take Priscus's cylinder from Corvus's hand, bronze folding-doors opened at the garden end of the conservatory and cold November rain-wind swirled in around **two imperial purple cloaks at once**.

Every secretary and pupil in the hot room dropped stylus and stood bowed—except crippled Fronto himself, whose lined, olive-dark Numidian face broke into radiant, almost fatherly delight as both adopted sons of the Emperor crossed the mosaic together to kiss his swollen knuckles.

"My two eyes!" Fronto cried out, forgetting his knee completely until he shifted half an inch and yelped *"By Hercules's club, kiss the cheek carefully, Mark, the elbow's full of scorpions today!"*

Corvus stepped half a pace back against the cedar book-presses, keeping his head respectfully inclined while missing nothing through lowered lashes. Up until today he had seen **Marcus Aurelius Caesar** and **Lucius Ceionius Commodus** only thirty yards off across crowded Forum basilicas or riding behind lictors in purple *trabeae*. Here, eight feet away across warm mosaic, stood the future of sixty million souls.

Marcus Caesar, thirty-six, dark beard lightly silvered at the chin-corners, wearing a plain, rain-dampened equestrian cloak over coarse unbleached wool—knelt right down beside his old teacher's footstool without caring for the henbane grease on the carpet, testing the heat of Fronto's flannel knee-wrap with gentle, ink-stained fingers and asking quietly whether the Pergamene physician had tried warm sulphur-water sponges before sleep. Tucked securely inside Marcus's belt-fold rode two battered, leather-bound Greek codices whose title-slips Corvus could read upside down from eight paces: **Arrian's *Discourses of Epictetus***, lent him by **Junius Rusticus**.

Behind Marcus strolled twenty-six-year-old **Lucius Commodus**, shaking bright November raindrops out of his gold-dusted curls like a wet retriever, smelling wonderfully across ten feet of hot room of Syrian spike-nard, crushed mint, and wet stallion-leather, carrying in his own ringed

hands a covered silver dish of braised Phasian pheasant nested on warm spelt-groats.

"Mark brings you cold water and Epictetus for your gout, Magister," Lucius said, setting the steaming silver dish right on Fronto's dictation-desk and lifting the lid so rich juniper gravy perfumed the entire study. "I brought a bird fat enough to grease both knees from the inside out, straight off my cook's spit! Eat three mouthfuls before your doctors starve you into a Stoic ghost like my brother here."

Fronto sniffed the juniper steam blissfully, then spotted the battered Greek *Epictetus* codices sticking out of Marcus Caesar's belt, and his mobile face fell into genuine, theatrical heartbreak that held real iron underneath the play-acting.

"Still chewing dry Cilician thistles from Quintus Junius Rusticus's mule-bag, Caesar?" Fronto groaned, tapping Marcus's leather notebook sorrowfully with one bandaged forefinger. "Twenty years I polished your tongue until you could make six hundred senators weep or march with twelve Latin words, and now Rusticus teaches you that eloquence is vanity, purple wool is dead sheep's hair smeared in shellfish blood, and an Emperor ought to write crabbed Greek maxims to his own liver at midnight! Tell me plain, Mark: when rebellious legions on the Danube or greedy tax-farmers in Syria need governing one day, will you read them syllogisms from Chrysippus? Even Jupiter thunders in rhythm; he doesn't mumble!"

Marcus smiled—a tired, luminous, slightly sad smile that crinkled the dark hollows beneath his sleepless eyes, and laid one thin hand warmly over his old master's bandaged wrist.

"Rusticus teaches me not to lie to myself while thundering, Magister," Marcus answered gently. "And today I didn't come to argue Zeno; I brought back your Cato roll—Wait: is that Quintus Servilius Priscus's seal over by the third press?"

Six pairs of eyes, Fronto's, Marcus Caesar's, lazy Lucius Commodus's, and three secretaries'—swung all at once onto seventeen-year-old Corvus standing flat against the cedar pigeonholes.

Corvus did not flinch, swallow, or shuffle his calfskin shoes. Inside his skull the cold surveyor's bolt slid cleanly shut: chin level, shoulders square, hands still on the oiled leather cylinder.

"Excerpts from the Fifth Book of Marcus Porcius Cato's *Origines* and the speech *De Sumptu Suo*, Caesar," Corvus said clearly, his deep voice, drilled five months over river-pebbles to strip away street-hiss without flattening its crisp Sabine bone—carrying clean as struck bronze across the warm room. "Copied and verified twice against Senator Priscus's Tusculan manuscript at the sixth hour."

Fronto blinked sharply through gout-tears, tilting his grey-curled Numidian head like an old hunting-eagle hearing a familiar mountain cry.

"Wait a breath," Fronto said, waving off the secretary who stepped forward to take the tube. "Don't hand it to Victorinus, unroll Column Two yourself, boy! Whose voice-school taught you to drop your diaphragm before initial *C* without hissing the *S*? And where did you get those vowels —Nomentum? Reate?"

"Crustumerium and Sabinum originally, Senator," Corvus answered, breaking the red wax seal cleanly with his scarred right thumb and drawing out the fresh papyrus roll without rustling the dry margins. "Old Antonius Gnipho's freedman has drilled my breathing since June."

"Sabine!" Fronto crowed, slapping his unbandaged right thigh hard enough to make Lucius grin around a mouthful of pheasant-wing. "Cato's own rocky turnip soil! Listen to this, Mark, listen to what real pre-Greek Latin sounds like before your Stoic dialecticians boiled all the marrow out of our nouns! Boy: read from Cato's *On His Own Expenses*, where the old Censor tells his corrupt enemies how his secretary reads out his clean account-book and then refuses to rub it out! Don't chant it like an Asianic flute-girl—read it as if four rich thieves were trying to send you to exile!"

Lucius Commodus leaned back against a porphyry pillar picking pheasant-meat delicately from small white bones, amused at watching a seventeen-year-old clerk thrown cold before two Caesars and Rome's supreme rhetor. Marcus Caesar folded both ink-stained hands quietly inside his coarse woollen sleeves, watching Corvus's eyes with calm, grave attention.

Corvus looked down once at the iron-black column his own reed had copied three hours earlier, Cato's famous *praeteritio* where the eighty-year-old farmer-statesman acts out ordering his clerk to read, stop, scratch out, no leave it in—then lifted his eyes off the papyrus straight at the empty marble floor between Marcus and Lucius, letting memory hold every syllable.

"I ordered the boy to fetch the tablet where my speech was written down," Corvus began, keeping his voice low, dry, conversational—exactly as Senator Priscus had spoken six sentences over the Salarian orchard in May. *"Read out, I told him, what I spent on public banquets! Wait—don't read that; they don't care a fig whether I drank water at home. Read the paragraph where I refused bribes in Spain! No—rub that line clean off the wax too; they hate hearing what didn't stick to my fingers!"*

Then Corvus dropped his voice three notes deeper into his chest, not shouting, *cutting*, letting the hard Sabine *r*'s and *t*'s strike like a mason's chisel squaring Tiburtine stone:

"Never mind—put the scraper down! Read every single figure from the top of the column to the bottom, if they force me! Better a citizen's honest ledger sound ugly to thieves today than stand blank when his children ask how he kept his house!"

Dead quiet fell inside the hot conservatory, broken only by November sleet ticking sharp against the high mica windows.

Lucius Commodus had stopped chewing his pheasant-wing halfway to his mouth. Marcus Caesar looked sideways at Fronto, a faint flush of reluctant pleasure warming his pale Stoic cheeks despite himself.

Fronto let out a long, theatrical sigh of pure bliss, sinking back into his seven cushions.

"Hear the bone in those verbs, Mark?" Fronto murmured. "*Dele istuc... noli delere... recita ab initio!* Not one painted Greek adjective, not one perfumed circumlocution—pure iron nails driven straight through oak! What is your name, Sabine?"

"Lucius Cassius Corvus, Gaius's son, of the Crustumina tribe, Senator," Corvus answered, rerolling the scroll cleanly without his scarred thumb trembling once.

"Seventeen?"

"Five days past, Senator."

"Tell Quintus Servilius Priscus with my love," Fronto said, waving two bandaged fingers toward his desk-clerk, "that his seventeen-year-old copyist reads Cato cleaner than half the praetorian candidates snoring in the Curia! Victorinus: put Lucius Cassius Corvus down on the back-bench stool for Thursday sixth-hour declamations whenever Priscus can spare him, gratis, mind you, I don't charge Sabine turnip-boys fees so long as they bring me

words out of Cato and never once say *essentially* or quote Chrysippus in my house!"

Corvus bowed deep enough to hide the fierce, sudden blaze behind his grey-green eyes. **Marcus Cornelius Fronto's own Thursday declamation bench**—where sons of consuls paid ten thousand sesterces a year just to stand near the door and hear the old Numidian dissect a courtroom proem!

Marcus Caesar paused beside Corvus on his way to the colonnade door a quarter-hour later, dark sleepless eyes resting for two quiet breaths on Corvus's scarred right thumb-knuckle and clean, mended grey tunic.

"Junius Rusticus spoke of a young surveyor's son at Quintus Priscus's house who measured water-pipes on the Caelian in January," Marcus Caesar said softly, remembering a single clerk's story ten months later out of ten thousand petitions! "Hold fast to Cato's clean ledger, Lucius Cassius. Sharp tongues are common in Rome; clean hands are rare."

"I will remember, Caesar," Corvus said, bowing low as imperial purple brushed past his elbow into the rain.

* * *

Out in the vaulted travertine carriage-porch of Maecenas's Gardens, where twenty red-cloaked German speculatores and torch-bearers stamped mud off their hobnails waiting for the two princes' litters, dusk was already falling thick and yellow-grey with freezing sleet.

Corvus lingered two paces back inside the dry brick door-jamb wrapping Priscus's empty leather scroll-case under his coarse winter cloak while Lucius Commodus paused laughing under the porch-arch to toss his leftover silver pheasant-dish to a hunchbacked Greek pantomime player waiting among his hangers-on.

Right behind the pantomime player, stepping nimbly down out of a gilded four-mule litter carried by tall Cappadocians in green-trimmed tunics, came **Publius Vedius Pollio**, accompanied by goat-bearded **Hermippus** holding a waxed umbrella over his master's oiled ivory skull!

Corvus drew one silent step backward behind a stacked pile of pine hypocaust-logs inside the shadowy porter's arch, pulling his dark wool hood low across his brow. Four paces away—close enough that Corvus smelled

bitter almond hand-balm cutting right through wet mule-hair, Vedius bowed low over Lucius Commodus's extended ringed hand.

"My Lord Lucius! Your Syrian head-groom tells me *Volucer* ran six laps under twelve hundred breaths on wet sand yesterday—though some mysterious new supplier has started dropping green-sealed laurel-salve jars at the *Trigarium* gate behind my poor factor's back!" Vedius purred musically, smiling to show there was no malice in the world between sporting gentlemen. "Still, if the horse runs faster, we all win gold in April! Will you honor my Caelian heated bath after tomorrow's hunt?"

"Bring snow-pears and leave your gloomy water-lawyers at home, Publius, and I'll bring Petronius Mamertinus!" Lucius laughed, swinging agilely into his dry curtained litter as horns blew and the joint imperial escort clattered out through the Esquiline arch.

Standing under the dripping porch-eaves waiting for his own Cappadocians to turn his litter round in the narrow puddle, Vedius Pollio's velvet smile vanished the instant Lucius's purple curtains disappeared into the sleet.

"Find out before the Kalends whose cart drops those green-pitched forty-pound stoneware jars at the *Factio Prasina* gate, Hermippus," Vedius said softly, his light flute-player's voice flat as cold mutton-fat now. "Nobody undercuts my stable-factors with Lucius's grooms by accident; somebody on the Caelian is trimming my feathers."

"Scaeva already has a fuller's boy watching the Campus Martius haywharf, master," Hermippus murmured, consulting a damp pocket-wax leaf under the umbrella. "At least the dockside accounts came in clean on the Kalends—including your little Tyrian oil-filly from Subortanae. Twenty silver denarii down on the nail every month since March without missing an hour, and quiet as a mouse."

Little Tyrian oil-filly from Subortanae. Twenty silver denarii down on the nail every month since March.

Behind the stacked pine hypocaust-logs, seventeen-year-old Corvus stopped breathing completely.

For four heartbeats the wet courtyard, the clattering Cappadocian mules, and the sleet hissing down the gutter vanished into a white, roaring tunnel inside his ears.

No. Hundreds of Syrian girls worked oil-stalls down by the Emporium —No: *from Subortanae*! There had been **one** Tyrian girl at *Figlinae Subortanae*!

Eighty sesterces every month since March. March—the exact afternoon Scaeva raided Berenice's garret, when Lucida met him under the Arch of Titus with an empty cedar cash-box, swearing she had paid two hundred to buy Sura through a third-party Esquiline broker and eighty to clear Berenice's rent, and that Vedius had lost her trail completely!

Eight months, March, April, May, June, July, August, September, October, November—**six hundred forty sesterces** she had bled secretly out of her own fingers into Hermippus's palm every single Kalends behind his back, letting Corvus drop his forty-eight weekly sesterces proudly into their loft box and lecture her on Gaius's *Institutes* while Publius Vedius Pollio held an iron leash round her neck every thirty days!

Corvus's right fist clamped so hard around the pine log-bark in the dark that a dry splinter drove half an inch under his scarred thumb-nail without his feeling a sting. Only eighteen months of hard Caelian schooling kept him from lunging four paces out of the wood-shadow with his bare hands at Vedius's plump throat, where four Cappadocian litter-guards would have broken his skull on the cobbles in ten breaths and undone both their lives forever.

Vedius climbed smoothly into his gilded curtains; the Cappadocians hoisted the poles; the green-trimmed tunics vanished south toward the Oppian crest.

Corvus pulled the bloody pine splinter slowly out from under his thumb-nail with his teeth, spat it into the mud, and stepped out into the freezing sleet.

* * *

He did not take the short cut straight down the Clivus Suburanus to Barba's warm bakery loft—not yet, not while rage and humiliation hammered so hot behind his temples that he would have kicked the loft door open and shouted Vedius's name across Sura's pallet where half the Fish-Market might hear.

Instead he walked blindly east along the muddy outer bank of the ancient Servian rampart toward the **Porta Esquilina**, letting icy November sleet soak through his wool hood until his skull cooled back into stone.

Outside the triple travertine arches of the Esquiline Gate, past the old potter's burial-pits Maecenas had covered with garden soil, out where gravel cart-ruts forked toward Tibur and Praeneste between tall brick tombs and smoking lime-kilns—a knot of twenty shivering onlookers stood round four sputtering pitch-cressets in the mud.

Corvus slowed two paces off the gravel shoulder, rain dripping off his eyelashes.

Three muscular public executioner's slaves (*carnifices*) in filthy red-dyed leather aprons, forbidden by ancient custom to live inside the sacred *pomerium* wall lest their breath pollute citizens—had thrown a stripped, shivering man of about thirty flat on his back across a notched seven-foot oak crossbeam (*patibulum*) lying in the sleet beside an upright scarred post permanently planted in concrete beside the highway.

Around the condemned man's neck hung the whitewashed wooden *titulus* board naming his crime in two-inch black brush letters so every traveller riding into Rome could read Caesar's peace:

C · MALLIVS · SP · F · LIBRARIVS · OB · FALSAS · TABVLAS · EX · LEGE · CORNELIA

Gaius Mallius, freeborn bastard's son, clerk—for forged public tablets under the Sullan Statute.

Not a runaway slave. **A freeborn Roman citizen**, *Spurii filius*, no rich grandfather, no four-hundred-thousand-sesterce equestrian ring on his finger, counted among the *humiliores* whom second-century imperial rescripts punished with the *summum supplicium* once reserved strictly for slaves and rebels!

"Hold his left elbow flat on the notch, Dama—he's jerking!" the head *carnifex* grunted around an iron spike gripped sideways in his teeth, kneeling casually across Gaius Mallius's bare ribs in the mud as a butcher knelt on a calf.

Mallius wasn't shouting heroic speeches; he was weeping through broken teeth, pissing himself hot into the freezing sleet, begging in educated Forum Latin, better Latin than Volusenus Niger spoke!—for someone to

fetch his cousin at the Porticus Minucia with six hundred sesterces before the hammer fell.

Clank.

Three flat, businesslike blows of a six-pound iron maul drove the five-inch square-shanked iron spike straight between the radius and ulna just above Mallius's left wrist into the wet oak *patibulum*.

The scream that tore out of Mallius's throat wasn't human speech anymore; it rose thin, ragged, and high as a hare caught in iron teeth, cutting clean across the hiss of sleet and the jingle of a rich merchant's covered carriage rolling briskly past through the gate ten feet away without a single curtain parting.

Clank. Clank. Clank. Right wrist nailed fast; four ropes hooked under the crossbeam; four *carnifices* heaving on pulleys to hoist the writhing white body eight feet off the mud until the mortise dropped with a wet *thud* onto the upright post—leaving Gaius Mallius hanging three yards above the highway gravel to take two winter days dying of cramp, sleet, and slow suffocation, for the exact crime **Marcus Tullius Dama** had escaped in May with a five-line clerical correction, and one-hundredth of the fraud **Publius Vedius Pollio** committed every morning before breakfast while eating snow-pears with Emperors' sons!

Sixteen-year-old Corvus stood alone at the edge of the torchlight with freezing mud over his calfskin ankles, forcing his eyelids wide open until every jerk of Mallius's nailed wrists burned permanent acid into the back of his brain.

Why had Lucida hidden Vedius Pollio's eighty-sesterce monthly chain from him for eight straight months?

Not because she loved lying to him. Because at seventeen **Lucius Cassius Corvus was still an ant below the four-hundred-thousand-sesterce line**, a forty-eight-sesterce-a-week clerk whom Vedius Pollio's friends could have nailed beside Gaius Mallius in the Esquiline sleet if Corvus swung first and missed!

Standing in the red smoke of the pitch-cressets while Mallius moaned high overhead in the dark, Corvus reached inside his wet tunic-collar and gripped his half of the broken *Figlinae Subortanae* clay stamp until its jagged edge bit hard into his scarred palm.

Junius Rusticus could keep his gentle Stoic sermons about clean poverty; Cato could keep his turnips.

In Rome there were only two nations under heaven: **men worth four hundred thousand sesterces who wore the narrow purple stripe and gold ring**, whom no magistrate on earth could flog or nail to wood, and **meat**.

"Four years," Corvus said aloud into the sleet, so low not even the nearest bystander heard him over the torches. "Before I turn twenty-one, I wear the gold ring—and I take every brick, pipe, and sesterce Publius Vedius Pollio owns."

When he climbed the outside brick stair to Barba's warm loft an hour later, soaked through and pale as chalk, Lucida looked up immediately from counting Green-stable jar tallies beside the charcoal pan, set down her stylus in alarm, and came straight across the warm tiles with a dry wool towel to rub his icy hair.

"Where were you in this sleet?" she scolded softly, pressing both warm, olive-oil-scented palms against his freezing cheeks to test for fever. "Did Fronto keep you till the second watch?"

Corvus looked down six inches into her fierce, watchful dark amber eyes, knowing every single secret silver coin she had paid on the Kalends since March to keep Scaeva away from his throat, and deciding in that exact heartbeat, with a coldness Senator Priscus himself might have admired, **not to tell her he knew** until he was rich and dangerous enough to cut her chain off in a single stroke without asking her leave.

"Fronto put me on his Thursday bench gratis," Corvus said quietly, wrapping his cold fingers briefly round both her warm wrists before letting go. "And Marcus Caesar knew my name."

Chapter X

The Supper of the Dead

Ninth Day Before the Kalends of March to the Kalends of March, AD 158 · Lucida

Dead bakers smelled much cleaner than live ones: dry bone-ash, withered violets, and three-year-old Setine wine poured straight down terracotta pipes into their skulls.

Two miles south of the Porta Capena along the **Via Appia**, where tall cypresses hissed in the wet February night wind above marble roadside tombs, forty-eight living craftsmen of the **Collegium Aesculapii et Hygiae** reclined three abreast on stone masonry couches built directly over the subterranean *columbarium* vaults of their guild-brothers.

All round the plastered brick walls above their heads rose eight honeycomb tiers of arched niches, five hundred pigeonholes in all, each holding two lidded alabaster or grey clay ash-urns under a neat painted marble *titulus* plaque: *Marcus Ulpius Eros, baker, lived fifty-two years; Gaius Iulius Dama, harness-maker, freedman, never sued a neighbor.* Stuck into the mortar beside every third niche burned a tiny terracotta oil-lamp set out for the **Feralia**, last night of the nine-day February *Parentalia* when Roman families fed their ghosts lest hungry shades walk the streets howling before spring.

Before anyone touched the roast sucking-pig or warm chickpeas steaming on pine trestles down the center of the vault, **Gaius Salvius**—seventy-year-old *quinquennalis* president of the burial guild, a retired armorer of the Second Parthica whose bald skull bore a silver-plated dent from a Dacian club, walked solemnly to a lead-lined funnel set flush in the mosaic floor and tilted a full two-quart bronze pitcher of spiced honey-wine down into the earth below.

"Drink warm under the grass, brothers, and grudge us not our bread above," Salvius chanted in rough camp Latin, while forty-eight scarred freedmen rapped bronze cups twice against stone couches and answered *"Salvete, Manes!"*

Standing back near the vaulted stair-foot beside wheezing **Habinnas Barba**, seventeen-year-old Lucida kept a modest dark blue woollen *palla* drawn respectfully over her braided hair—as custom required at rites of the dead, while holding under her left arm an iron-strapped oak coffer heavy with **two thousand four hundred sesterces** in clean silver denarii and four gold *aurei*.

Six months of waking before the third watch to decant Spanish oil on frosty quays, boiling Cyprian laurel-berry and Chian turpentine over back-yard braziers until her knuckles blistered to fill **Ceionia Fabia**'s forty-pound Green-stable stoneware jars, paying Hermippus his cursed eighty sesterces silently on every single Kalends without touching Corvus's Caelian savings —all of it sat inside that twelve-pound oak box against her ribs.

And she was still **five thousand six hundred sesterces short** with eight days left until the Kalends of March handed Barba's four lava mills to Hermippus.

Down on the middle couch a squat vinegar-boiler wiped pork-grease off his beard and squinted through lamp-smoke toward the stair.

"Who's the girl with the money-box behind your elbow, Habinnas?" the vinegar-boiler called across the hall. "Guild bylaws fine any brother twelve sesterces who brings tavern-women down to the *Feralia* wine before the lamps go out!"

Forty-eight pairs of wine-flushed eyes turned toward the steps. Half of them belonged to old Eastern and Gallic freedmen who had bought their own freedom coin by copper coin over thirty years and trusted young women roughly as far as they could throw an ox-cart.

Barba cleared the dry flour-rattle from his throat and thumped his oak staff once on the mosaic. "No tavern-woman, Vibius! Daughter of a Syrian purple-dyer from Puteoli, co-lessee on my Fish-Market *pistrinum* starting next week, and she brought sixty gold pieces' worth of clean silver to put on the guild table beside an offer for our *arca communis* chest, if President Salvius gives her half a cup of sand to speak!"

Groans and suspicious mutters rippled along all three masonry *triclinia*. Up at the head couch beside the bronze statuette of Aesculapius with his gilded serpent-staff, old **Gaius Salvius** chewed a mouthful of crackling slowly, eyeing seventeen-year-old Lucida from mud-free boots to dark blue veil.

"Our burial endowment holds sixty-four thousand sesterces donated by Lady Salvia Marcellina in memory of her husband, Habinnas," Salvius rasped. "By imperial *senatus consultum* and our bronze foundation-tablet on that wall, capital sits locked at five percent a year on first-rank Italian farm mortgages—never lent out on shaky Subura bakehouses where one knocked-over oil-lamp turns six thousand sesterces to charcoal! Why waste good pork-heat listening?"

Lucida stepped two paces forward out of Barba's shadow into the open ring of terracotta tomb-lamps, letting the blue *palla* slip back off her crown just far enough that forty-eight hard-headed tradesmen saw neither cosmetics nor coy Caelian silk, only clean-braided black hair, work-broadened wrists, and steady amber eyes that didn't blink at five hundred dead men's urns.

She set her oak coffer down on the stone altar-step, unlocked the iron padlock, and tilted the lid open toward the torches so four gold *aurei* and five hundred silver *denarii* gleamed white and yellow in the vault.

"Because your five-percent Italian farm mortgage on Marcus Fulvius's olive-grove out at Velitrae hasn't paid silver since October when autumn hail stripped his trees," Lucida said clearly, voice pitched low enough not to echo off the brick barrel-vault, "and because I didn't walk two miles down the Appian stones tonight to borrow five thousand six hundred sesterces from your *arca communis*."

Salvius stopped reaching for his wine-cup. "If you aren't borrowing five thousand six hundred sesterces, girl, what are you asking?"

"I am offering to **sell this guild forty thousand two-pound loaves of clean Sicilian *panis secundus*** delivered across twenty-four months—starting on the Kalends of March, paid half in advance," Lucida answered.

Along the couches three bakers and two tavern-keepers sat bolt upright, wiping wine off their chins to do rapid street arithmetic on their fingers.

"Every master in this vault feeds between four and twelve apprentices, fullers' boys, muleteers, or forge-slaves every morning," Lucida continued,

walking slowly three paces down the open mosaic aisle between the couches without touching a dish. "In the Subura and Velabrum today you pay **two copper *asses* the two-pound loaf** for Numerius Vettius's chalk-and-darnel sweepings bread that leaves your boys dizzy by noon—forty thousand loaves costing your households **five thousand sesterces a year**, ten thousand across two years! Advance my Fish-Market *pistrinum* **five thousand six hundred sesterces** out of your idle chest tomorrow before three guild *curatores*, secured first-lien behind no prior mortgage on four Orvieto lava mills, five sound Reatine mules, and two twelve-foot brick ovens, where my own **two thousand four hundred sesterces** sits in first-loss position underneath your silver, wiped out down to my last *quadrans* before this guild loses one brass *as*!"

"And what interest do we eat on five thousand six hundred sesterces?" demanded Vibius the vinegar-boiler, leaning over his cushion.

"Better than five percent paper, master vinegar-maker," Lucida shot back cleanly. "You redeem guild bread-lead tokens at Barba's counter every dawn at **one *as* and a *semis***—one and a half *asses* per full-weight two-pound Sicilian loaf instead of two *asses*, saving your forty-eight workshops twenty-five percent on daily slave-bread until every sesterce of principal is worked clean off! *Plus*, on all four annual *collegium* feast-days, *Cara Cognatio*, Violet-Day, Rose-Day, and the Emperor's birthday—Barba and I deliver **two hundred fresh white poppy-seed *siligo* loaves and four jars of honeyed wine gratis** to this vault for the living and the dead, adding twelve percent effective yield a year without violating one syllable of your charter against risky usury, because commercial advance-bread purchase for members' *sportulae* sits explicitly authorized in Column Three of your own bronze wall-tablet behind President Salvius's left shoulder!"

Every neck in the burial hall craned round toward the engraved bronze guild-charter bolted into the brick behind Salvius's couch, where three literate harness-makers squinting by torchlight read out *"ex reditu panes et vinum diebus sollemnibus dividantur"* and burst out laughing aloud!

"She read the bronze while we were pouring wine down the funnel!" somebody roared from the back couch, slapping his knee.

Old Gaius Salvius didn't laugh yet. He stood up slowly from the head couch, walked his stiff soldier's legs down the mosaic aisle until he towered

six inches over seventeen-year-old Lucida, and looked down from her open box of gold and silver to her stain-shadowed thumbs.

"Clever tongue, dyer's daughter," Salvius rumbled. "Now answer an armorer's question without legal grease. Habinnas here has been coughing white paste into his beard for three winters; if his lungs stop in July, who keeps four donkey-mills turning a hundred *modii* every night against Hermippus's thugs—sixteen-year-old arms?"

Lucida did not drop her gaze a hair's breadth from the silver plate dented into the old legionary's skull.

"Every morning for the next **one thousand and ninety-five mornings**, President Salvius," Lucida said, quiet enough that men ten paces off stopped chewing to hear, "if Barba's ovens drop *one single modius* below a hundred between midnight and midnight, Trajan's citizenship count resets to nothing and a fat equestrian up on the Oppian Hill takes the clothes off my corpse when I die. Your guild stands to lose five thousand six hundred sesterces if those stones stop; **I lose my throat and my name**. Which of us do you think sleeps past the third watch?"

For five heartbeats Salvius stared straight into her amber eyes, measuring iron against iron, recognizing down in the bone of a sixteen-year-old girl the exact grim siege-discipline that kept frontier cohorts digging ditches in sleet—then turned toward the forty-eight couches and raised his scarred right arm.

"All brothers favoring twenty-eight hundred *denarii* advance bread-contract with Habinnas Barba and Lucida Tyria's daughter, subject to morning inspection of the four stones by Curators Vibius and Plautus—lift your right hands!"

Forty-five greased, flour-cracked, scarred freedmen's hands shot up into the torch-smoke toward the five hundred silent urns overhead.

Barba let out a hoarse Cappadocian war-whoop that dissolved halfway into a coughing fit, pounding Lucida's shoulder hard enough to stagger her an inch against her oak money-box; and for one warm, dizzying breath amid the smell of roast pork and dead men's violets, Lucida pressed her palm flat against the cold stone altar-step to steady her knees, eight thousand sesterces whole and clean in her hands without touching a coin of Corvus's Caelian future!

* * *

Within seventy-two hours—moving with the silent, ruthless speed of water filling a dry sluice before Hermippus's clerks realized their March foreclosure lamb had grown horns, Lucida spent almost every silver piece.

On the fifth day before the Kalends, flanked by Curators Vibius and Plautus from the burial guild and a public *tabellio* notary hired outside the Forum of Peace (never using Senator Priscus's clerks lest Corvus hear of her side-loan too soon, though Corvus rejoiced wildly upstairs that evening when she told him Barba's burial-guild had backed their *pistrinum*!), she counted **four thousand eight hundred sesterces** across Landlord Gaius Munatius's table—redeeming Barba's equipment-pledge in full and locking in a fresh five-year notarized *conductio* lease before Hermippus's factor even walked up the steps!

On the fourth day before the Kalends she walked down to the muddy cattle-pens of the **Forum Boarium** in pouring rain, bypassed three slick auctioneers trying to palm off broken-winded Campanian nags painted round the hocks with soot, and paid **one thousand nine hundred sesterces** cash to a Sabine drover from Reate for five iron-hooved, raw-boned three-year-old hill-mules that tried to bite her sleeve off when she checked their teeth.

On the day before the Kalends she unloaded **three hundred fifty *modii*** of clean, flint-hard amber Sicilian wheat directly off an Agrigentine coastal hull at the Emporium, probing every bottom sack-seam personally with a three-foot hollow bronze sampling-spear until neither clay-pellets nor weevils came up in the groove—and stood beside freshly shaved Habinnas Barba inside the marble-columned registry hall of the **Praefectus Annonae** near the Porticus Minucia while a bored imperial freedman clerk dipped his reed in red cinnabar heading-ink and inscribed Sheet Nineteen of the Region VIII bakers' roll:

PISTRINVM PISCARIENSE · EXERCITORES HABINNAS BARBA LIB · ET LVCIDA LAT · IVN · QUOTIDIE MOD · C+ INITIVM TRIENNI EX EDICTO DIVI TRAIANI : KAL · MART · ORFITO ET PVDENTE COSS · [AD 158]

Kalends of March, in the Consulship of Sextus Sulpicius Tertullus and Quintus Tineius Sacerdos—First Day of Three Years.

That night nobody in the Fish-Market bakehouse slept at all.

At the loud brass blast of the midnight third-watch horn from the Forum watch-post, Sura dragged the heavy oak bar across the courtyard postern, lit all six iron wall-cressets with pine pitch, and chalked across a freshly planed black slate bolted beside Oven One in neat four-inch capitals Corvus had taught her to square with a ruler:

ANNVS I · DIES I

Four blindfolded Reatine hill-mules leaned stout leather breast-collars simultaneously into four oak sweep-beams. Sixteen hundred pounds of Orvieto lava groaned, bit hard Sicilian kernel, and settled into a deep, continuous subterranean rumble, *grrrm-grrrm-grrrm*—that shook fine white *siligo* mist off the rafters like indoor snow.

Four hired free night-kneaders, broad-backed Marsian countrymen paid six sesterces a night plus two loaves so nobody chained human necks in Lucida's courtyard—worked rhythmic wooden paddles inside the circular stone kneading-tubs while Barba tended two roaring twelve-foot brick domes heated white with dry Sabine oak, sliding six-foot iron peels loaded with cross-scored two-pound round loaves (*panes quadrati*) in and out through shimmering waves of four-hundred-degree air.

Upstairs Corvus had stayed awake until the fourth watch helping haul sixty-pound wheat-sacks from the storeroom into the upper mill-hoppers before washing flour off his forearms to snatch two hours' sleep ahead of his own dawn *toga* preparations on the Caelian; down in the red heat Lucida worked stripped to a short knee-length baker's linen tunic bound tight under the ribs with hemp cord, bare feet planted wide on warm flour-slicked basalt, weighing every tenth batch personally on the certified municipal steelyard while entering sack-numbers in duplicate wax so no *annona* inspector on earth could challenge a single *sextarius* of her first hundred *modii*.

By the first pale streak of March dawn over the Fish-Market tiles, Sura stood on a wooden flour-tub cheering silently with both flour-white fists in the air as she chalked the final morning tally underneath *DIES I*:

MODII · CVIII

One hundred and eight modii. Eight clear *modii* above Caesar Trajan's line, and three hundred twenty warm, fragrant brown Sicilian loaves already

stacked in willow panniers waiting for the forty-eight burial-guild runners lining up outside the bolted oak street-shutter!

"Unbar the front shutters, Sura!" Barba wheezed triumphantly, leaning on his long iron ash-rake with sweat cutting clean dark rivers down his flour-plastered chest. "Smell that crust, little Tyrian, not one grain of Vettius's dizzy-weed in forty baskets!"

Sura heaved up the iron drop-bar and folded back the wide street-shutters onto the noisy dawn cobbles of the **Forum Piscarium**—and stepped violently backward with a sharp hiss through her teeth.

Blocking the middle of the open archway in front of the waiting guild-apprentices stood **Gaius Ummidius Scaeva**, flanked by two bull-necked fullers' bailiffs carrying iron-shod ash cudgels low against their thighs.

Scaeva wore a heavy brown woollen military *paenula* damp with March river-fog; in his left hand he swung a hollow brass Kalends tally-tube from Hermippus's rent-office, and his single right ear twitched as his pale pig-eyes swept past the steaming willow bread-baskets to take in **all four lava mills thundering behind five sleek new Reatine mules**, four paid Marsian kneaders, and forty sacks of prime Sicilian grain stacked dry under canvas!

Upstairs in the loft directly over the arch, Corvus was still asleep for another half-hour before leaving for the Caelian, *thank every god in Syria*, because if Corvus looked out that upper shutter right now and saw Scaeva standing in their doorway, sixteen months of careful insulation blew apart in three breaths!

Lucida did not glance upward toward the loft beams once. Without hurry she wiped white dough off her palms onto her hemp apron-cord, walked to the low wooden counter dividing the shop-front from the cobbles, and took eighty sesterces—two gold *aurei* wrapped cleanly in oiled linen for her secret March Kalends patronal blood-tax, out of her inner pocket, sliding them silently under a folded bread-cloth toward Scaeva's hand so neither Barba nor the guild-boys behind him saw gold change palms.

Except Scaeva did not pick up the cloth.

Instead he planted one heavy hobnailed boot up onto Barba's clean stone threshold-sill, leaning across the bread-counter close enough that boiled garlic and sour wine blew into Lucida's face.

"Keep the two yellow chicks warm a breath, Tyrian," Scaeva rasped low in camp Latin. "Hermippus sent his clerk down to Munatius's house yesterday noon to take over four cold millstones on defaulted paper—and found **eight thousand sesterces** silver already stacked on Munatius's table and your name painted wet in red cinnabar down at the *Annona*! Where does a sixteen-year-old Junian slit who walked out of my master's garden twelve months ago without a copper *as* find eight thousand sesterces, unless she's holding back eighty percent of her dockside takings from her patron's ledger, or fronting stolen silver for some Caelian senator?"

Behind Lucida, old Habinnas Barba took two slow, silent steps closer to the glowing mouth of Oven One, his knotted hands shifting six inches down the shaft of his eight-foot iron ember-shovel.

"Tell my bailiffs to unhook two of those fat new Reatine mules right now as supplementary bond until Hermippus audits your silent partners' names," Scaeva ordered, jerking his scarred chin toward his two cudgel-men, "or we tip those bread-baskets into the fish-gutter and shut your shutters before Day One hits noon!"

Unhook two mules today, and tomorrow's grind dropped to sixty *modii* —killing her three-year citizenship run on its very first morning!

Lucida didn't raise her voice, didn't back away from Scaeva's garlic breath, and didn't call upstairs. Instead she reached behind the counter, lifted a heavy stamped lead customs-and-household seal hanging on green-dyed linen cord from a forty-pound sack of surplus bruised winter barley-bran left over from her **Domus Ceionia** stable-compoundings, and dropped the two-inch lead disc *clank* onto the oak board right beside Scaeva's fingers.

Stamped deep into the lead in crisp imperial-family capitals shone a prancing horse flanked by:

EX · HORREIS · CEIONIAE · FABIAE · C · F

From the Granaries of Ceionia Fabia, Consul's Daughter—sister to **Lucius Ceionius Commodus**, the exact golden prince whose ringed hand Publius Vedius Pollio spent twelve thousand sesterces on green parakeets trying to kiss!

Scaeva's eyes dropped to the lead stamp; his scarred jaw froze half-open.

"Eight thousand sesterces came from forty-eight sworn brothers of the *Collegium Aesculapii et Hygiae*, whose three *curatores* are standing six feet

behind your heels waiting for their morning bread under imperial *senatus consultum* charter," Lucida said softly, so clear and venomous only Scaeva heard every word, "and our surplus bran and linseed-pressings go under contract to **Lady Ceionia Fabia's Caelian steward** for her brother Lord Lucius's *Factio Prasina* race-stables! Go ahead, bailiff: lead two mules out of a registered *annona* bakery carrying Ceionia Fabia's seal on the Kalends of March so I have to walk up the Caelian steps at the third hour and explain to Lord Lucius why **Publius Vedius Pollio**'s thugs stopped his stallions' hot bran-mash six weeks before the April Circus! Let's see whose ears Vedius slices off before supper—mine, or the fool who cost him his seat in Lucius's box!"

At the same instant she nodded once, half an inch—to Barba.

Old Barba thrust his eight-foot iron shovel deep into the glowing belly of Oven One, swung out ten pounds of hissing, white-hot oak coals, and dumped them in a blazing red ribbon straight across the stone gutter **three inches in front of Scaeva's greased boot-toes**, "clearing the ash-pit," as bakers lawfully did at dawn—sending scorching heat and flying orange sparks straight up Scaeva's shins!

Scaeva cursed, jerked his hobnailed foot backward off the threshold out of the white-hot coals, glared murderously from the smoking *CEIONIA FABIA* lead seal to the muttering crowd of burly burial-guild smiths and fullers gathering behind his cudgel-men with empty bread-panniers, and snatched the folded bread-cloth holding his regular eighty sesterces off the oak counter.

"Hermippus will verify every single name on that burial-club roll before the Ides," Scaeva snarled low across the glowing embers. "Set one toe outside your lane, little bitch, and Ceionia Fabia's horse-bran won't save your hide."

He spun on his heel and shouldered out through the Fish-Market crowd with his two cudgel-men behind him.

Immediately Barba swept the cooling coals calmly into the stone quench-trough, spat once into the steam, and started counting warm two-pound loaves smoothly into the burial-guild runners' baskets as if one-eared Praetorian killers visited every morning before breakfast.

Behind the high stone kneading-trough out of sight of the street, seventeen-year-old Lucida stood still for five breaths, staring up at Sura's chalked slate on the smoky wall (**ANNVS I · DIES I — MODII CVIII**, one

thousand and ninety-four mornings still to survive!), then plunged both bare arms straight past her elbows into two hundred pounds of warm, rising wheat-dough, kneading hard with locked shoulders until the hot living gluten swallowed every tremor in her hands.

Chapter XI

Rehearsal in Chalk

Eighteenth Day Before the Kalends of July, AD 158 · Corvus

"Nine Roman inches," Corvus whispered, pressing his folding brass *pes Monetalis* flat against the damp red brick-course at the back of the Vicus Sandaliarius cobbler's court while June dawn turned the narrow strip of sky overhead the color of skimmed milk. "Look at the mortar-joint right above your left ear, Vespera. Below your ear it's grey Hadrianic lime mixed with coarse black river-pozzolana; above your ear it's soft pink crushed-tile dust troweled smooth last winter to hide where Carvilius knocked through the party-wall and stole nine inches by forty feet of my client's oil-cellar!"

Seventeen-year-old Lucida leaned her shoulder lazily against the opposite fuller's lintel, chewing a warm sesame crust from her third-watch baking —Day One Hundred and Six on Sura's wall-slate back at the Fish-Market without a single morning under a hundred and six *modii*, and eyed the whitewashed plaster wall with professional disdain.

"Your client Sextus Pompeius is an idiot if somebody stole forty feet of his cellar and he didn't notice till May," she observed, flicking a sesame seed off her bare brown wrist. "Even a blind mole notices nine inches missing off a wine-vault."

"Pompeius lives in Tibur growing roses and only came to town when his ground-floor cobbler complained damp was rotting shoe-leather through the partition," Corvus said, running his scarred right thumb eagerly along the faint vertical hair-crack where new plaster met eighty-year-old *opus testaceum* brick. Three months ago on the *Liberalia* in March he had laid aside his boy's tunic and put on the white citizen *toga virilis*—stored neatly rolled right now inside an oiled cloth bag on Sura's shoulder so Subura mud wouldn't spot the fuller's chalk before the third hour, and his voice

had settled over winter into a clean, resonant baritone that still jumped half a beat faster whenever Lucida worked an alley beside him. "Here's the catch: **Spurius Carvilius**—who fronts three shoemakers' blocks on this lane for Hermippus's syndicate, filed a sworn *stipulatio* yesterday claiming that cellar-strip was conveyed to him three years ago by *mancipatio* from Pompeius's dead uncle, and plastered solid from Carvilius's side for two winters so his bailiffs never even set foot in there! Unless we prove active possession *from Carvilius's courtyard* before the Second *Hasta* sits at the fourth hour, the praetor refuses our summary *interdictum uti possidetis* and locks Pompeius into a three-year title suit!"

Lucida's amber eyes gleamed bright in the grey alley-light. All winter and spring they had moved on parallel tracks—she buried knee-deep in Sicilian wheat, burial-guild bread-tokens, and Caelian salve-pots; he buried in Gaius, Fronto's Thursday declamations, and Priscus's Caelian briefs, each keeping quiet cupboards locked from the other. Out here in wet dawn brick-shadow before Rome woke up, hunting a crooked wall together with thirty breaths to spare, five years of shared ditch-craft clicked back into gear so effortlessly Corvus felt drunk on plain air.

"Wait," Lucida said, stepping two light paces across the cobbles to press her ear—not her eye, her *ear*, a baker's trick for checking hollow brick oven-domes, flat against the "solid" whitewashed plaster five feet left of Corvus's mortar-seam, then rapping once with her brass belt-buckle.

Thock. Solid two-foot brick pier.

She slid two paces right, directly underneath an innocent-looking wooden shrine of the *Lares Compitales* hung with dried garlic braids, and rapped again.

Thunk. Hollow pine board skimmed over with a quarter-inch coat of wet lime-stucco on split reed lath, cut round the edges with a fine knife and painted over to look like continuous wall!

"Solid brick for two winters, my ass," Lucida murmured delightedly, showing small white teeth in the grin nobody on the Caelian ever saw. "There's a three-foot wooden cellar-door right behind those garlic braids, Sabine—and look down at the basalt flagstone two inches under the sill: dried olive-lees and fresh hobnail scratches curving toward Carvilius's back wine-shop! His bailiff **Geta** rolls untaxed Campanian wine-skins through

that 'plastered' cellar every morning before the aedile's market-clerks walk the Sandaliarius!"

Corvus stared at the hairline cut hidden behind the hanging garlic, calculating court procedure at lightning speed. "If I bring two witnesses into Carvilius's private passage to pry that plaster-door open with an iron bar, Sulpicius Rufus screams *vis*, unlawful force breaking a neighbor's shrine—and gets my evidence thrown out! How do we make Geta walk *out* through his own 'nonexistent' wall in front of sworn citizens before the third hour?"

Lucida turned her head and whistled two soft thrush-notes up the alley: *Whit-whit.*

Fourteen-year-old **Sura** trotted silently out from the corner arch carrying Corvus's toga-bag on one arm and two cracked terracotta bail-pots of spoiled crimson **Rubia madder-root dye-sludge**, bought for two copper *asses* off a neighboring wool-dyer's scrap-heap—in the other.

"Take your two citizen witnesses across the street into that pastry-cook's doorway where they have a straight sightline down this passage," Lucida told Corvus briskly, already uncorking both clay pots of thick, blood-crimson madder paste, stuff so mordant with alum that one splash dyed white leather or skin indelible scarlet for three weeks. "Wait till the second-hour mule-carts rattle down from the Argiletum. When Geta hears glass smash and smells smoke outside his untaxed wine-stash, let's see whether he walks round the front street or kicks open his 'two-year solid brick wall' in white shoes!"

Ten breaths after Corvus had stationed two respectable equestrian shoemaker-guild wardens inside the opposite pastry-booth with hot honey-fritters in their hands, Lucida and Sura went to work with shameless, breathtaking precision.

First Lucida poured both gallons of thick crimson alum-madder sludge smoothly across the sunken basalt threshold directly outside the hidden reed-and-plaster door, dusting a thin veil of grey street-ash over the top so in dim alley shadow it looked like ordinary dry cobble-dirt. Next Sura lit a fistful of damp, oily fuller's tow inside a broken roof-tile right below Carvilius's upper storeroom grating so acrid black smoke billowed straight through the cellar air-vent, while Lucida hurled an empty four-as green wine-flagon *crash* against the brick pier and yelled at the top of her lungs in shrill Greek street-panic:

"Fire in the oil-vault! Fetch the vigiles' hooks before the wine-skins burst!"

Both girls vanished like smoke round the cobbler's water-butt before the last green glass shard stopped spinning.

Five heartbeats. Eight heartbeats.

From behind the hanging garlic braids of the sacred *Lares* shrine came the sharp *clack* of an interior iron bolt shooting back—and **out burst Carvilius's bailiff Geta** straight through the middle of the "solid two-year masonry wall," swinging a brass water-bucket in both hands and wearing freshly pipe-clayed white leather *campagi* boots!

Both boots landed ankle-deep *splat* in two inches of alum-mordanted crimson madder-paste.

Geta skidded, cursed by Priapus's yard, stared wildly down at his ruined scarlet boots and no fire, only a smoking handful of damp rag on a tile—and looked straight across the twelve-foot lane into the polite morning smiles of two sworn equestrian guild-wardens and seventeen-year-old Lucius Cassius Corvus sketching the open hidden doorway and Geta's bright red footprints onto a three-leaved boxwood *testatio*!

"Good morning, Geta," Corvus called across the cobbles as Geta slammed the plaster-faced door shut in horror, leaving a three-foot rectangular black gap framed in broken stucco and four bright scarlet footprints leading straight inside! "Wear those boots to the Basilica Julia at the fourth hour; the Centumviral judges love bright colors!"

Back round the corner by the fuller's arch, where Lucida leaned doubled over with silent laughter pressing both fists against her ribs while Sura beamed from ear to ear, Corvus caught Lucida by both elbows and lifted her clean off her flour-dusted boots for half a turn before setting her down—and then stopped smiling as he glanced down at the wax copy of Carvilius's *mancipatio* deed tucked in his belt.

"Wait a second," Corvus muttered, cold grey-green focus snapping back behind his eyes as he read the five citizen witnesses listed along the bottom edge of Carvilius's alleged purchase-tablet from three years ago: *M. Lollius, C. Vibius, L. Petronius,* ***D. Atilius****, Q. Fabius*. "Vespera, doesn't that old drunk actor who sings bawdy Atellan farces in a goat-wig outside the Sandaliarius wine-shop call himself **Decimus Atilius**?"

Lucida wiped tears of mirth off her lashes and squinted at the fourth name on the wax. "Decimus Atilius 'Long-Nose'—used to dance *mimus*

naked at the *Floralia* under Hadrian before rheumatism stiffened his hips. Drinks free sour wine at Carvilius's counter every noon for signing his name on shop-leases. Why?"

Corvus stared down at those fourteen letters, *DECIMVS ATILIVS*—feeling a sudden lightning jolt run straight from his scarred right thumb up into the roots of his hair, because he wasn't just looking at Spurius Carvilius's cobbler-cellar anymore; **he was looking at the exact statutory lock-pick that could one day shatter Publius Vedius Pollio's entire six-million-sesterce brick-and-tenement empire if a single witness on Vedius's master-deeds carried the same taint**!

"Because under the Praetor's Edict *De his qui notantur infamia* and the Twelve Tables," Corvus breathed slowly, "any man who has appeared on the public stage for hire, *qui artis ludicrae pronuntiandive causa in scaenam prodierit*—is permanently **infamis and intestabilis**! He can buy bread in the market, certainly, he **cannot stand as one of the five statutory Roman citizen witnesses to a formal conveyance *per aes et libram***! Put four honest citizens and one *infamis* stage-player round the bronze scales, and the entire *mancipatio* is dead wood from the hour the bronze struck the balance!"

* * *

At the fifth hour inside the **Basilica Julia**, heat rolled beneath the marble arcades thick enough to wilt starch out of chalked wool.

For the first morning of his life Corvus sat not behind the third clerks' bench with twenty pounds of wood on his collarbone, on the low pine *subsellium* directly behind **Senator Priscus** and **Aulus Volusenus Niger**, wearing his own snow-white citizen *toga virilis* draped in crisp, severe Republican folds Phileros had pinned at dawn.

Out before the upright iron-shod spear of the Second *Hasta*, twenty-year-old Volusenus was already drowning in four feet of still water.

Priscus had handed his nephew an open-and-shut morning victory—two sworn guild-wardens testifying to Geta's scarlet-booted exit through the false plaster wall, destroying Carvilius's two-year undisturbed possession plea in ten breaths, and all Volusenus had needed to do was sit down and collect the interdict. Instead, greedy to show off Asianic periods before three

senatorial cousins watching from the colonnade, Volusenus had launched into a half-clepsydra peroration attacking Carvilius's *mancipatio* title itself —walking headfirst into **Gaius Sulpicius Rufus**'s waiting net.

Sulpicius Rufus didn't even stand up completely; leaning one elegant hip against the defense rail, Vedius's sleek Bithynian advocate interrupted gently:

"Before my eloquent young patrician friend bursts a vein over plaster-dust, worthy judges, perhaps he will answer one elementary question out of Sabinus. Even assuming a bailiff cut a temporary service-hatch last week, my client holds a sealed *mancipatio* conveyance witnessed by five enrolled citizens of the Suburana and Palatina tribes from three harvests back, expressly reserving *servitus oneris ferendi*, the servitude of wall-and-vault support! Does young Aulus Volusenus contend before forty-five Centumviral judges that an urban wine-seller loses Quiritary ownership won *per aes et libram* because his servant hung garlic over a door?"

Up in the gallery twenty hired *laudiceni* tittered on cue.

Volusenus opened his mouth, blinked sweat out of his eyes, and looked frantically down at his prepared rhetoric-notes—where nothing whatever stood written about *servitus oneris ferendi* against prior *mancipatio*, because Volusenus hadn't bothered checking the five witness names Corvus handed Phileros an hour before court!

"The, the servitude falls by *non usus* when maliciously concealed behind stucco, judges," Volusenus blustered, getting the law flat backward—urban praedial servitudes required *usucapio libertatis* across two full years, and Sulpicius Rufus smiled like a cat watching a plump thrush hop between its paws!

"Concealed for a week extinguishes a two-year urban servitude?" Sulpicius murmured to the grinning bench. "Perhaps in nursery rhetoric-schools on the Quirinal, "

On the front bench **Senator Quintus Servilius Priscus** stopped chewing his fennel seed.

He did not rescue his stammering sister's son himself; instead Priscus leaned three inches sideways toward seventeen-year-old Corvus—who had already passed the *toga virilis* threshold into full legal *pubertas*, legally competent to speak on the facts when designated by principal and *patronus*, and spoke eight quiet words out of the side of his iron mouth:

"Stand up and kill the deed, Lucius Cassius."

Volusenus heard; his oiled head jerked round in disbelief as the seventeen-year-old surveyor's orphan rose smoothly off the back pine bench in plain, unperfumed white wool and stepped to the oak *cancelli* rail beside him.

Across forty feet of marble **forty-five Centumviral judges**, three rows of spectators, and sleek **Gaius Sulpicius Rufus** stared at the tall, broad-shouldered boy with the pale stylus-scar at the left corner of his mouth. Up in the gallery Sulpicius's fat Greek claque-leader frowned, unsure whether to signal jeers at the boy's youth.

Inside Corvus's ribs, the cold iron bolt slid home. Not one drop of sweat moistened his palms; he heard Cato's dry chisel-strokes in Fronto's conservatory and saw Gaius Mallius's nailed wrists jerking in Esquiline sleet.

"With the President's leave, on a single point of fact touching the wax tablet Counsel just waved at the spear," Corvus said.

He did not shout, chant, or saw the air with ringed fingers like Volusenus; drilled by Gnipho's freedman and sharpened by Fronto, his deep chest-voice cut clean underneath the drone of the three neighboring courts so every judge on the wooden tiers heard every consonant without straining.

"Let him speak," the presiding *decemvir* nodded, curious after May's Salarian surprise.

Corvus picked up the certified municipal stage-payment extract Phileros had pulled from the *aediles plebis*' games-register an hour ago and held it flat—arm still, scarred right thumb steady on the edge.

"Learned Sulpicius asks whether garlic hung over a hidden door voids a *mancipatio* witnessed by five Roman citizens," Corvus said cleanly. "Nobody claims garlic voids bronze and scales. The Twelve Tables and the Praetor's Perpetual Edict void it. Fourth down the spine of Spurius Carvilius's alleged conveyance stands the seal and signature of **Decimus Atilius, son of Marcus, Suburana tribe**. Here is the certified games-account of the Plebeian Aediles from the third consulship of Hadrian showing four hundred sesterces paid out of public funds to that same **Decimus Atilius, *archimimus***, for dancing the adulterer in *Laureolus* for hire upon the public stage, confirmed half an hour ago by Atilius himself over a jug of wine on the Vicus Sandaliarius, where he offered to dance the hornpipe again for two denarii!"

A sharp ripple—authentic laughter this time, no paid clappers needed, ran straight across all forty-five Centumviral benches!

Corvus did not smile into the laugh; he drove the iron chisel home while the stone cracked.

"Under Title Two of Julian's Edict, any man who treads the public boards for silver bears lifelong *infamia* under the Law of the Twelve Tables, an *infamis* stage-player is *intestabilis*—incompetent either to summon witnesses or to stand beside the bronze balance himself. Take one rotten timber out of five, judges, and Spurius Carvilius has no *mancipatio*, no *servitus*, and no title save nine stolen inches of wet stucco and two scarlet boots! My client Sextus Pompeius prays immediate restitution of his vault and summary ejection of every unlawful occupant holding under Carvilius's void paper."

Sulpicius Rufus didn't even open his mouth to reply; watching his own instructing clerk go green behind him told the whole court the hit was mortal. Within four hundred breaths thirty-nine *A* tablets rattled out of the urn, granting Pompeius immediate *interdictum* possession, triple damages for cellar-spoliation, and court-viatores marched straight out toward the Vicus Sandaliarius with iron crowbars before sunset!

Outside beneath the blazing colonnade, joyful equestrian **Sextus Pompeius**, having just recovered sixty thousand sesterces of urban frontage plus twelve thousand in damages—pressed a heavy sewn chamois bag straight into Corvus's hands with Senator Priscus's approving nod: **five thousand sesterces** (50 gold aurei!), legal *honorarium* below the ten-thousand-sesterce *Lex Cincia* ceiling, earned in a hundred clean breaths of speech before his eighteenth birthday!

Beside the third marble column **Volusenus Niger** didn't curse Corvus today; pale beneath his tan, ignored completely by Pompeius and his own uncle alike, Volusenus walked down the Basilica steps alone without looking back, which Phileros, tucking away his bone scrapers at Corvus's elbow, watched with narrow eyes.

"A man who barks at you is safe, Sabine," Phileros murmured dryly. "Watch your ribs when a patrician goes quiet."

* * *

At dusk Corvus walked west toward the **Pons Aemilius** feeling ten feet tall inside his crisp white *toga virilis*, fifty gold *aurei* weighing deliciously solid inside his leather belt-wallet—adding to the nineteen hundred sesterces already saved from his Caelian pay to put him past **seven thousand sesterces** personal capital at seventeen!, and carrying a snow-cooled jar of amber Chian wine plus honeyed figs to celebrate with Lucida down by the river breeze.

Halfway down the travertine river-steps beside the bridge-head, where evening market-crowds thinned above the swirling brown Tiber, a knot of poorer neighborhood folk had gathered round a piled heap of pathetic household sticks dumped on the cobbles: a cracked three-legged pine cobbler's bench, a bundle of iron shoe-lasts, a straw mattress dark with cellar-damp, and two clay cooking-pots.

Sitting on the damp mattress weeping silently into her knotted grey hair was a crippled sixty-year-old woman with twisted arthritic knees, while her white-bearded husband—wearing a leather shoemaker's apron and the faded wool cap of a freeborn plebeian citizen, argued brokenly with a bored municipal *viator* holding a sealed court eviction-rod.

Kneeling right down in the bridge-dust beside the old woman—her baker's hair-kerchief still tied over her dark braids, an empty wholesale bread-pannier resting at her hip, was **Lucida**, tearing a clean linen strip off her own apron-hem to bind a deep bleeding scrape on the old woman's elbow while Sura tucked four unsold two-pound Sicilian loaves quietly beside their cooking-pots!

"Vespera?" Corvus called warmly, stepping down the travertine flags carefully so his chalked white *toga* hem wouldn't drag in the mule-dung, holding up the Chian wine-jar with a grin. "Look what Pompeius put in my hand after the Second *Hasta*—fifty gold pieces down! Wait, what happened here?"

The municipal *viator* glanced round, recognized Senator Priscus's young *cognitor* from the Vicus Sandaliarius seizure an hour ago, and saluted cheerfully with his ash rod!

"Cleared all four ground-floor bays of Spurius Carvilius's Sandaliarius block clean onto the street before sunset just as your writ ordered, Master Cassius! Plucked Carvilius's wine-bailiff out by the ears—and pitched these

sub-tenants' cobbler-benches out too when they couldn't show Pompeius's seal!"

The white-bearded old cobbler looked up at seventeen-year-old Corvus standing gleaming white above him in fresh fuller's chalk, holding expensive Chian wine.

"I paid Spurius Carvilius **two hundred forty sesterces**, six months' honest shop-rent in advance on the Kalends of May out of thirty years' shoe-mending, young sir!" old **Gaius Trebatius** choked out, holding up a worthless wax receipt stamped with Carvilius's voided seal. "I never touched nobody's cellar wall! My wife can't climb third-floor stairs on those knees —and your bailiffs split her arm throwing our bed-frame over the threshold and told me to go sue Carvilius in the gutter!"

Corvus's grin faded half an inch; still, the clean, incontrovertible geometry of Roman civil law clicked automatically into place inside his head.

"Carvilius held *ab initio* under a void *mancipatio*, citizen," Corvus explained, not unkindly, in the exact measured tone Julian's *Digest* used for third-party sub-lessees. "A man who owns no title cannot grant valid *locatio conductio* against the true Quiritary owner. Bring your wax receipt round to Senator Priscus's back vestibule on Tuesday morning and I'll have a junior clerk draft you a personal *actio conducti* claim against Carvilius gratis."

Old Trebatius stared at him as if Corvus had spoken Persian. "Sue Hermippus's straw-man on Tuesday while my wife sleeps on river-stones tonight with not two asses left for porridge?"

Down in the dust **Lucida** finished knotting the clean linen strip round the old woman's bleeding elbow.

Slowly she stood up, brushing grey bridge-grit off her bare knees, and looked straight at Corvus.

She did not shout; she did not make a scene in front of the court *viator*. Instead her dark amber eyes traveled slowly down from Corvus's flushed, triumphant face across the snowy, unspotted chalked folds of his brand-new adult citizen *toga*, down to the heavy bulge of fifty gold *aurei* at his waist, and back up to his scarred mouth.

When she spoke, she didn't use Greek or their private childhood name; she spoke crisp, flat Subura Latin.

"Reach into that heavy new belt-pouch of yours and give Gaius Trebatius six gold pieces to rent a dry ground-floor arch across the Velabrum

tonight, Lucius Cassius," Lucida said quietly. "Before you tell me how brilliantly you spoke."

Corvus stiffened inside his white wool, pride stung in front of the watching court-bailiff even as shame pricked hot behind his ribs. Without a word—once the *viator* turned up the steps, Corvus unfastened his chamois bag, counted **three gold *aurei*** (300 HS—sixty sesterces more than the old cobbler's lost rent!) straight into astonished old Trebatius's leather apron, and turned to walk Lucida and Sura across the bridge in fading orange twilight.

Halfway over the stone arch above the brown water, Corvus held out the snow-cooled jar of Chian wine between them as a peace-offering.

"Three hundred sesterces put Trebatius in a better shop than he lost, Vespera, and we still cleared four thousand seven hundred," Corvus said low, trying to recapture the fierce dawn joy of the Sandaliarius alley twelve hours ago. "Plus I proved in open court that one *infamis* witness kills a *mancipatio* chain stone-dead, the exact blade that's going to cut Vedius Pollio's throat open one day!"

Lucida took a small sip from the Chian jar when he uncorked it, wiped her mouth with the back of her flour-scarred wrist, and handed the wine back to him without smiling.

"How much did the fuller charge to chalk that new toga so white, Corvus?" she asked softly, looking down over the travertine parapet at two boys fishing driftwood out of the eddy below.

"Four sesterces," Corvus answered, puzzled. "Why?"

"Because three years ago when Hermippus's bailiffs threw your father's tools onto the Crustumerium road under a strict legal bond," Lucida said —her voice gentle as twilight water, cutting deeper than an iron chisel, "nobody gave you and me three gold pieces on a bridge, and you swore to me in the rain you were learning their law to break their sticks, not to speak Julian's Latin over an old woman's mattress."

She walked ahead up the Fish-Market steps beside silent Sura to check the evening yeast-sponges, leaving Corvus standing still for ten breaths on the bridge with forty-seven gold *aurei* in his belt, cold Chian wine in his hand, and a tiny, invisible hair-crack running right across the happiest day of his seventeen years.

Chapter XII

Saffron and Sweat

Ides of October, AD 158 · Lucida

Under the sixty-foot concrete vaults of the **Baths of Trajan**, three hundred naked women sounded louder than four legions crossing a bridge.

Up through pierced bronze floor-grates billowed thick white steam off subterranean wood-furnaces, mixing with the sharp, expensive reek of Cilician saffron oil, crushed myrtle, wet human hair, and sour wine-sweat scraped off three hundred pairs of thighs by curved bronze *strigiles* and flicked *splat* into the marble perimeter gutters. Every sound multiplied tenfold off the green Karystian marble dadoes and dripping glass mosaic domes overhead: shrill shrieks from the armpit-pluckers' benches where Syrian girls snapped bronze tweezers (*volsellae*) mercilessly along oiled skin; the rhythmic *slap-slap-slap* of flat greased palms kneading fat senators' wives on heated marble slabs; the splash of bodies rolling out of the scalding semicircular *alveus* tub; and the singsong cries of pastry-girls wading bare-legged through the mist selling honeyed sausages and snow-chilled *mulsum* off tin trays.

Eighteen-year-old Lucida—she had passed her eighteenth birthday seventeen days earlier without cake or holiday, marking it only by watching Sura chalk **DIES CCXIII** (Day 213 of 1,095) above Oven One at dawn, knelt in a damp, clinging knee-length linen *subligaculum* inside **Ceionia Fabia**'s curtained corner apse, warming a rock-crystal flask of first-grade Corycian saffron unguent between her palms.

Across the mosaic floor, stretched naked on a slab of veined Phrygian *pavonazzetto* marble with wet red-gold hair coiled high on her crown by two bone pins, twenty-nine-year-old Ceionia Fabia closed her eyes as Dorcas scraped lathering fuller's-earth soda (*nitrum*) off her long, freckled back.

Even stripped bare in pitiless October afternoon glare streaming through forty-foot south-facing glazed panes, an Emperor's adopted daughter carried power in the set of her hip-bones. Three equestrian matrons from the Carinae hovered outside her half-drawn linen curtain pretending to admire the mosaic Nereids while straining both ears for one scrap of Palatine gossip: whether pregnant **Faustina** was carrying another boy at Lorium, whether old **Antoninus Pius**'s winter cough had returned early, whether handsome **Lucius Commodus** would really marry a provincial cousin or stay free for bigger alliances.

"Not so hard over the shoulder-blade, Dorcas; you aren't curry-combing *Volucer*," Fabia murmured lazily, holding out one wet white arm without opening her eyes so Lucida could work warm golden saffron oil—worth forty sesterces the ounce, compounded by Lucida herself from pure Cilician stigmas steeped in sweet Hispanian virgin pressing, down from wrist to collarbone. "Tell me who just waded into the middle basin making noises like a hippopotamus in reeds."

Lucida glanced sideways past the curtain-hem without breaking the long, firm upward stroke of her oiled thumbs along Fabia's forearm.

"Domitia Paulina's cousin **Vibia**, Domina," Lucida murmured smoothly, "accompanied by Senator Aufidius's young wife—wearing three pounds of emerald pearls into steam hot enough to rot silk thread, so everyone sees Aufidius didn't lose his shirt in June's Sandaliarius boundary suit."

Fabia gave a wicked little purr deep in her throat. "Aufidius couldn't win a boundary suit against a dead badger; everyone on the Caelian knows old **Quintus Servilius Priscus** used some terrifying sixteen-year-old Sabine wolf-cub out of Fronto's kennel to tear Vedius Pollio's straw-man apart in six breaths! My brother Lucius heard Fronto bragging about the boy's Cato vowels all last Thursday."

Lucida's oiled thumbs did not falter by the breadth of a hair across Fabia's wet shoulder, though hearing Corvus called *old Priscus's Sabine wolf-cub* inside Ceionia Fabia's curtain sent a tiny, sharp prickle straight down her spine.

Then Lucida's amber eyes—trained by two years in Rome never to watch the front stage when hands moved behind the curtain, caught a flicker

of dark brown wool reflected in the wet polished marble pilaster behind Dorcas's back.

Next door in the warm changing-hall (*apodyterium*), where wooden clothes-cubbies rose four tiers high guarded by salaried bath-attendants (*capsariae*) paid to keep thieves away from senators' wives' gold brooches and silk *stolae*, Fabia's hired Cappadocian locker-woman **Phryne** was not sitting on her guard-stool.

Instead Phryne had slipped one skinny arm elbow-deep inside Cubby Four—**Ceionia Fabia's private cedar cubby**, fished a tiny, thumb-long folded ivory *pugillares* love-note out of the inner girdle-pocket of Fabia's purple-bordered *stola*, tucked it inside her own dirty armpit-rag, and ducked swiftly through the narrow brick service-door leading behind the roaring bronze *testudo* water-boilers!

If Phryne had stolen Fabia's emerald bracelet, she would have bolted toward the street steps. Nobody stole a two-inch folded ivory note without touching twenty gold *aurei* of jewelry right beside it unless **somebody outside was paying silver for Ceionia Fabia's handwriting**!

And Lucida knew whose handwriting sat on that tiny ivory diptych, because Dorcas had grumbled about it in the litter coming up the Oppian Hill: **Gaius Petronius Severus**, handsome twenty-four-year-old military tribune of the Praetorian Guard—a dangerous, indiscreet correspondent for a woman married to Plautius Quintillus while Palatine moralists watched every whisper round Lucius Commodus's sister!

"Wait, the saffron crystal needs thirty breaths deeper in the hot wall-niche to thin the myrrh, Domina," Lucida lied smoothly, wiping excess oil off her palms onto a linen towel without startling either Fabia or rheumatism-stiff Dorcas. "Don't let the cold draught touch your back while I warm it."

She slipped barefoot behind the marble partition—not toward the crowded main *apodyterium*, straight through the low iron-sheeted stokers' hatch into the suffocating brick maintenance passage curving behind the bronze bath-cauldrons!

Back here the glamorous marble *Thermae* vanished instantly into soot, dripping lime, and roaring hundred-and-thirty-degree furnace-draft. Naked slave stokers black with char-ash shoveled split oak into sunken fire-mouths below; directly ahead, thirty paces down the narrow vaulted corridor where

delivery-boys brought bath-wood in from the Viminal steps, stood a barred iron postern, and through those iron bars **Phryne** was already thrusting Fabia's tiny ivory diptych toward a pale, clean-shaved Greek clerk waiting in the alley shadow with four gold *aurei* gleaming in his palm!

Lucida knew that clean-shaved chin and the **three bone wax-scrapers swinging on a brass ring** at his hip before she got within twenty feet of the bars.

Phileros. Chief *librarius* and archive-master to **Senator Quintus Servilius Priscus**—the man who paid Corvus forty-eight sesterces every week!

Thank every god on Olympus and Carmel, smoke from Number Three furnace was blowing thick grey across the iron grating so Phileros stood squinting sideways into the wind and hadn't yet closed his fingers over the ivory!

Shout, and Phileros saw Lucida's face clearly—connecting Priscus's Caelian house to Barba's Fish-Market loft before sunset! Let Phryne pass the note through the bars, and Priscus's Stoic faction locked Ceionia Fabia's indiscretion with a Praetorian tribune right beside Vedius's red water-flask inside Priscus's cedar blackmail chest, destroying Lucida's Caelian patroness and her three-hundred-sesterce monthly Green-stable contract at one blow!

Lucida snatched a wooden bucket of cold furnace-quench water standing beside Boiler Two, kept her head bent low behind her streaming loose damp hair so only a faceless bath-servant's wet shoulder showed through the smoke, lunged the last twelve barefoot strides silently over slick soot, and **slammed her hip into Phryne's ribs** hard enough to knock the Cappadocian locker-thief flat against the brick wall—just as Lucida kicked the iron smoke-damper lever loose with her bare heel!

With a deafening iron *CLANG*, three hundred cubic feet of choking white wood-smoke and live steam belched straight out through the iron grating into the alley, sending Phileros leaping six paces backward coughing into his cloak without ever glimpsing who bumped the lever!

Inside the blinding white steam-cloud on the wet bricks, Phryne opened her mouth to screech; Lucida clamped one oil-slick hand hard over the locker-woman's teeth, pinned Phryne's throat down with one bare knee, ripped the tiny two-inch ivory diptych out of Phryne's fist, and pressed

both open black-waxed inner leaves **flat against the scalding bare copper steam-pipe** feeding the *caldarium* tub two inches above their heads!

Hssssss.

Within four heartbeats two hundred degrees of Trajanic boiler-copper melted Petronius Severus's compromising cursive script and broken Praetorian signet into two mirror-smooth, completely blank pools of warm black beeswax!

Outside in the windy lane footsteps retreated rapidly down the cobbles —Phileros refusing to linger near a bathhouse boiler-accident where *vigiles* ran up within moments.

Lucida lifted her hand half an inch off Phryne's mouth, keeping her forearm wedged across the terrified slave-woman's windpipe in the clearing steam.

"Open your teeth above a whisper," Lucida breathed in Subura Greek right against Phryne's ear, "and Lady Ceionia Fabia tells the bath-procurator you stole her emerald pin from Cubby Four, which puts iron branding-letters across your forehead before moonrise. Walk out the wood-gate right now without your shoes, keep running till you hit Puteoli, and tell nobody whether steam or ghosts took your four gold pieces. Nod once if you want both eyes."

Phryne nodded frantically, scrambled up on hands and knees when Lucida stepped back, and bolted barefoot down the stokers' ash-ramp without looking behind her.

Lucida shut the iron smoke-damper, rinsed soot off her hands and knee in the quench-bucket, tucked the blank, warm ivory diptych safely inside her damp linen waist-band, and walked calmly back through the marble arch into Fabia's curtained apse carrying the warmed rock-crystal flask of saffron oil—less than ninety breaths after she had stepped out.

Fabia was just sitting up wrapped in soft white Milesian toweling while Dorcas slipped crimson kidskin bath-sandals onto her feet.

Lucida waited until Dorcas knelt to tie the left ankle-strap, leaned down as if anointing Fabia's collarbones with warm saffron, and slid the tiny ivory diptych silently onto Fabia's lap beneath the towel-fold, open half an inch so Fabia saw the freshly melted, completely blank wax leaves.

Fabia's green-brown eyes snapped down to the ivory, widened once as she recognized her missing Praetorian note, and shot straight up into eighteen-year-old Lucida's calm amber gaze.

"Locker-woman Phryne tried passing it through the boiler-grate to a shaved Greek carrying three bone wax-scrapers on a brass ring, Domina," Lucida murmured so low not even Dorcas at Fabia's ankles heard. "The boiler-pipe melted the wax before his fingers touched it, and Phryne just left Rome barefoot."

Three bone wax-scrapers on a brass ring. Every political house on the Caelian knew **Phileros**'s trademark belt-ring.

White fury turned Fabia's freckled skin the color of skimmed milk round her nostrils; then, slowly, her fingers closed tight over the blank ivory leaves until her knuckles shone bone-pale, and when she looked back at Lucida, calculation had already replaced shock—she was no longer looking at a convenient eighteen-year-old salve-peddler, rather at an operator worth bringing inside the double doors.

"Quintus Servilius Priscus's Greek bloodhound sniffing inside my bath-cubby," Fabia whispered through motionless lips. She reached into her jewel-casket beside Dorcas's elbow, drew out **five heavy gold *aurei*** (500 HS!), and pressed them straight into Lucida's saffron-oiled palm. "Starting on the Kalends of November, Lucida, you don't wait in the scullery yard or use old Berenice's name at my gate. You bring my cosmetics straight up the private library stair twice a week yourself, and whenever you hear Priscus's clerks whispering down near the Forum Piscarium, you tell me whose name they write."

"You honor my small workshop, Domina," Lucida said smoothly, bowing her damp dark head over the five gold pieces while ice water trickled silently down the inside of her ribs.

* * *

Today was the **Ides of October**—two full solar circuits since two starved, mud-caked fifteen-year-olds had slipped past the Flaminian customs-post behind a flock of bleeding red-ruddled sheep while crowds down on the Campus Martius fought over the bloody tail of the October Horse.

Across the city once again this afternoon the Subura and Sacra Via ward-gangs had brawled in the dust for Mars's horse-head (this autumn the Sacred Way boys had beaten the Subura back past the Regia, leaving half the fuller's apprentices nursing black eyes and split shins at every wine-counter Lucida passed walking down off the Oppian spur).

Back at the Fish-Market *pistrinum*, autumn dusk smelled gloriously of toasted sesame, dry oak embers, and honest prosperity.

Down in the basalt courtyard, swept twice a day with wet pine-boughs now so stale bran never bred beetles—four sleek Reatine hill-mules munched clean bruised barley in whitewashed stalls between shifts; stacked eight feet high under dry tarred sailcloth sat two hundred *modii* of prime amber Sicilian and Sardinian grain paid cash on the nail; and on the black slate beside Oven One fourteen-year-old **Sura** had just chalked in proud, square white letters:

ANNVS I · DIES CCXXVIII — MODII CXIV

Two hundred twenty-eight unbroken days at better than a hundred *modii* —already past a fifth of Trajan's three-year road, with two thousand one hundred sesterces of the burial-guild bread-advance worked cleanly off on schedule and **four thousand two hundred sesterces** net profit banked safely in Lucida's locked strong-chest!

Even paying Scaeva's hated Kalends collector his silent eighty sesterces out at the corner fish-stall five days ago had felt less like bleeding to death than tossing a meat-scrap to a yard-dog whose chain she was filing halfway through every dawn.

Old **Berenice** had limped down from the Argiletum at sunset carrying a peck of sweet Sabine chestnuts tied in a red kerchief to roast on Barba's oven-lip, her swollen ankles much easier since Lucida began buying forty percent of her cosmetic roots at steady silver—and sat gossiping in rapid Syrian Aramaic with wheezing Barba over warm spiced wine while Lucida washed bath-saffron and street-dust off her arms at the stone trough.

"Watch your shutters round the Kalends, little hawk," Berenice muttered out of the good side of her mouth as Lucida dried her elbows. "Hermippus raised rents ten percent down our whole Argiletum block Tuesday because some Caelian senator's clerks have been poking sticks into his master's boundary-stones and water-pipes all summer! Myrtale saw that pale Greek **Phileros**, Senator Priscus's ink-rat—walking past the Oppian

baths three times this week with your tall Sabine boy carrying wax-bundles two paces behind him!"

Lucida hung the linen towel very neatly on its iron peg without turning round for two breaths.

With your tall Sabine boy carrying wax-bundles two paces behind him.

Corvus hadn't been outside the women's bath-postern this afternoon, Thursday afternoon he sat at Fronto's Esquiline declamation bench until dusk—yet **he worked six days a week at the elbow of the exact Greek spy whose fingers Lucida had just scalded off Ceionia Fabia's throat with live boiler-steam**!

When Corvus climbed the outside brick stair at the second watch, carrying a fat earthen jug of stolen ten-year-old Caecuban wine Phileros had gifted him from a grateful Tusculan client's cellar, his white citizen *toga* folded carefully over his arm, dark hair wind-tousled above shoulders that now filled the loft doorframe from jamb to jamb—every shadow of June's cobbler-eviction vanished for three precious hours.

Up in their warm terracotta-floored loft above the sleeping ovens, with Sura curled fast asleep behind the sailcloth partition hugging a stuffed rag-horse Barba had whittled her, they kicked off their boots, sat cross-legged across a low iron brazier-pan roasting split chestnuts on an iron baker's peel, and drank dark, resinous Caecuban wine out of two horn mugs.

"Remember two years ago tonight?" Corvus asked softly, peeling char-skin off a steaming chestnut with ink-stained thumbs and dropping the sweet yellow kernel straight into Lucida's open palm before peeling one for himself. Wine and hearth-glow had warmed his grey-green eyes dark as olive-leaves; next month he turned eighteen, the milestone where Priscus promised to advance him from junior factual *cognitor* to lead complex civil suits in his own voice under the Praetor's Edict, with **nine thousand four hundred sesterces** already saved in his Caelian strongbox toward the distant four-hundred-thousand mountain. "Eleven copper asses between us, rain coming through Berenice's tiles, and Sticho's seven-day piss-vats waiting at dawn."

"And you split your lip on Volusenus's stylus four weeks later because you couldn't keep your Sabine mouth shut," Lucida teased low, touching one chestnut-warm fingertip briefly—before she could stop herself, to the tiny white crescent scar at the left corner of his mouth.

Corvus didn't jerk back as he had up by the Janiculum water-wheels last summer. Instead his hand came up halfway, fingers brushing the warm curve of her wrist, eyes holding hers across two feet of red coal-light with an intensity that turned the air inside the low brick loft thick and breathless as unrisen dough.

"Wait till Day One Thousand Ninety-Six, Vespera," Corvus said huskily —still never letting on that he knew about her eighty-sesterce monthly chain to Vedius, believing he was guarding her pride while counting every day until he had the silver and legal teeth to smash Vedius whole. "Two years and four months left on those stones downstairs. The morning the *Annona* prefect stamps your citizen *ius Quiritium* tablet, we buy forty *iugera* of dry Sabine hill-pasture above Crustumerium just so nobody ever threatens us with ground-rent again, and build a stone house where every pipe and brick-stamp carries our own two names."

"Sabine hill-pasture bores me to death after three days; I want two Ostian grain-warehouses and a four-mule litter with green curtains so Ceionia Fabia's cousins have to step out of my mud," Lucida said lightly, clinking her horn mug against his to break the dangerous pull tightening between their mouths before eighteen-year-old blood swept two years of careful boundaries over the cliff.

By the third watch the heavy Caecuban wine and fourteen hours of standing in the Basilica Julia dragged Corvus's eyelids down despite himself. Stretched sideways on his folded grey wool cloak across the warm floor-tiles beside the brazier while listening to Lucida recount how old Barba chased a thieving gull out of the flour-bin with a broom, Corvus answered slower and slower until his deep breathing lengthened into deep, unguarded boy's sleep—his dark temple resting two inches from Lucida's bare left ankle, his scarred right hand lying relaxed palm-up across the warm terracotta between them.

Wide awake in the red twilight rising through the oven-vent, eighteen-year-old Lucida did not move her ankle away.

For a long time she sat completely still listening to the faint nighttime sigh of shifting embers down in Barba's brick domes and the steady rise and fall of Corvus's chest.

Inside her belt-pouch lay **five gold *aurei*** paid three hours ago by **Ceionia Fabia**, sister to **Lucius Ceionius Commodus**, ally to Praeto-

rian tribunes and green chariot-factions—for scalding **Senator Quintus Servilius Priscus**'s chief spy off her private life.

And two inches from Lucida's bare foot slept **Quintus Servilius Priscus's sharpest young blade**, dreaming of Sabine hill-pasture and Cato's clean ledger while serving the exact austere Stoic faction around **Marcus Aurelius Caesar** and **Junius Rusticus** that meant to break Fabia's brother across their knee the day old Emperor Antoninus stopped breathing at Lorium.

Very gently, careful not to wake him, Lucida reached down in the red dark and laid her warm thumb-pad flat against the raised white crescent brick-stamp scar across Corvus's sleeping right knuckle, matching skin to old Subortanae clay.

Hold on for eight hundred and sixty-seven more mornings, she begged the silent brick rafters overhead, feeling a sudden cold premonition tighten round her heart despite the ninety-degree warmth rising through the floor. *Let me finish my three years on the stones before the old Emperor dies and their two houses tear Rome in half—or neither of us will recognize the hand holding the knife.*

PART THREE

The Narrow Stripe and the Stola

March, AD 159 – December, AD 159

Chapter XIII

The Hexagonal Basin

Seventh Day Before the Ides of March, AD 159 · Corvus

Seen from the upper brick gallery of Trajan's grain-storehouse, the sea did not end at the shore; a dead emperor had cut six straight stone sides around two thousand feet of captive green water and locked the Mediterranean inside a ledger.

Eighteen-year-old Corvus braced both forearms on the salt-crusted travertine parapet, dark woollen riding-cloak snapping round his calves in the sharp March sea-wind, counting the hulls moored stern-first along Side Four of the **Portus Traiani**.

Four days ago on the *Navigium Isidis*, priests in shaved skulls and white linen had launched their gilded cedar model barque into the surf outside the Ostian lighthouse to declare winter's closed sea open again. Already forty deep-bellied freighters that had gambled an early February crossing from Alexandria, Leptis Magna, and Lilybaeum crowded the six-sided basin hull to hull, painted wooden eyes staring salt-streaked off curved swan-sterns while two-man human treadwheels creaked inside towering timber dock-cranes, swinging fat net-slings of wheat sacks out of dark hatches onto numbered limestone quays.

Every pier-stone carried its carved Roman numeral; every mooring-ring had its sworn harbor clerk; every gangplank swarmed with half-naked dock-porters (*saccarii*) trotting bent double under hundred-pound Egyptian linen sacks, dropping one brass tally-token into an overseer's wooden box at the foot of the plank before vanishing into shadowed, six-foot-thick brick warehouse vaults that stretched half a mile toward the Tiber canal.

Beside Corvus on the gallery, thirty-two-year-old **Tullia Crispina** pulled her sea-green woollen *palla* tighter under her chin, six blown-glass Campanian bracelets clinking pale green at her narrow wrists like harbor ice.

"My late husband Gnaeus used to stand on this exact stone and weep sentimental Campanian tears over the majesty of Caesar's grain-fleet," Crispina said in her low, smoky Puteoli contralto, dark painted eyes fixed coldly on a beamy three-masted freighter—the *Isis Pharia* out of Alexandria, berthed directly below Pier Fourteen. "Then Gnaeus died of a surfeit of Baian oysters last May leaving me four hundred thousand sesterces out on twelve-percent maritime bottomry notes, and I discovered half these sunburned skippers are worse thieves than Cilician pirates. Look down on the *Pharia*'s foredeck, Lucius Cassius. Why are those four *mensores* standing round the bronze drum instead of pouring?"

Corvus narrowed his grey-green eyes against the bright salt glare bouncing off the water.

Down on the *Isis Pharia*'s broad pine deck, thirty feet below, the ship's Greek master **Sarapion**—whose cargo of forty thousand *modii* of prime Fajyum hard wheat carried a hundred-and-twenty-thousand-sesterce bottomry loan (*pecunia traiecticia*) from Tullia Crispina's strongbox, was arguing heatedly with **Gaius Hostilius**, chief sworn grain-measurer of the Ostian *corpus mensorum*, while four muscular measurer's assistants leaned on their curved iron striking-rods (*rutelli*) chewing roasted chickpeas.

Senator Priscus had sent Corvus down to Portus at dawn because Priscus never dirtied his own senatorial shoes in commercial bottomry disputes—senators were forbidden by the old *Lex Claudia* to own large sea-ships openly, yet Crispina's father had backed Priscus's Hispanian legateship twenty years ago, and eighteen-year-old Corvus had won four straight commercial arbitrations since his birthday in November without dropping a single figure.

"They aren't waiting for porters," Corvus said, watching the precise angle at which Hostilius's assistant held an empty linen sack three feet *above* the iron-bound rim of the certified municipal *modius* tub before letting a test-stream of golden Egyptian wheat cascade down into the cylinder. "Watch the boy's elbows, Domina. If you pour dry wheat gently from rim-level, kernels lie loose with air between them and forty thousand honest *modii* fill forty thousand tubs. Drop wheat fast from chest-height onto a

tilted side-board and tap the iron hoop once with your knee before drawing the iron *rutellus* across the top, and the grain packs eight percent denser inside the drum—turning Sarapion's forty thousand *modii* into thirty-six thousand eight hundred on the dock tally!"

Crispina turned her head sharply to look up two inches into Corvus's wind-burned face. Around her eyes tiny fan-lines crinkled through sheer, delighted appreciation; she smelled not of heavy Caelian white-lead or suffocating myrrh, of clean lemon-verbena water, cedar wool, and cold sea-spray.

"Three thousand two hundred *modii* 'shortage' at delivery," Crispina calculated instantly, bracelets chiming as she tapped two ringed fingers against the parapet, "which triggers the default forfeiture clause in Sarapion's charter-party, bankrupts my borrower before he can pay off my twelve-percent sea-note, and lets whoever bribed Gaius Hostilius buy up the distressed cargo at half-price on the Ostian steps tomorrow noon!"

"And look who is standing inside the arched doorway of Vault Nine watching Hostilius's knee tap the drum," Corvus added quietly.

Down in the brick shadow behind the weighing-beam stood a dapper Smyrniot factor wearing a green-bordered business *paenula* and carrying a silver-mounted calamarium at his belt: **Philargyrus**, harbor agent for **Publius Vedius Pollio**.

Nothing in Portus happened twice by accident.

"Stay on the dry stones if you wish, Domina, or walk two paces behind me," Corvus said, handing his heavy travel cloak to Crispina's litter-guard so he stood plain and broad-shouldered in his crisp white citizen *toga* girt up tightly *cinctu Gabino* round his waist to leave both arms free for climbing ship-planks. "And bring your notary with fresh wax."

Down the steep travertine stair Corvus went in long, unhurried five-foot surveyor's strides, Crispina following briskly in cork-soled Puteoli half-boots without needing any slave's elbow, her notary trotting behind.

Out across the springing twenty-foot fir gangplank of the *Isis Pharia* Corvus walked, sea-water slapping hollow green against pitched cypress planking underneath his calfskin soles, stepping straight onto the wheat-strewn pine foredeck where Greek skipper Sarapion was tearing his grey curls in despair before bulky **Gaius Hostilius**.

Hostilius, fifty, bull-bellied, wearing the bronze medallion of the *mensores frumentarii* guild over a grease-shining leather jerkin—scowled round as Corvus's shadow fell squarely across the brass-rimmed wooden *modius* measure.

"Clear the plank, city boy!" Hostilius barked, waving his smooth iron *rutellus* rod like a truncheon. "Official harbor measurement under port rules, no advocates on deck till the tally-board's chalked!"

"Read Paragraph Four of Hadrian's Port Regulation nailed behind your own weigh-house door, Gaius Hostilius," Corvus replied pleasantly, planting both feet wide against the slight harbor swell without giving half an inch. "A maritime bottomry creditor holding registered *hypotheca* over hull and lading inspects every tenth *modius* on deck in person or by *procurator*. Allow me to introduce **Tullia Crispina**, creditor for a hundred and twenty thousand sesterces on this hold—and myself, **Lucius Cassius Corvus**, holding Senator Quintus Servilius Priscus's warrant."

Over in the shadow of Vault Nine on the quay, Vedius's agent Philargyrus straightened abruptly out of his slouch.

Hostilius's bluster dropped half a note at Senator Priscus's name, though brazen dock-habit held his chin up. "Inspect till your eyes bleed, young master! Certified municipal *modius* stamped by the *Praefectus Annonae* in January, thirty-two *sextarii* dead true! Not my fault if this Alexandrian thief loaded wet Fajyum sweepings that shrank four thousand measures on the voyage!"

"Shrank four thousand measures in dry wind without a drop of bilge-rot?" Corvus asked mildly. He squatted on his heels beside the heavy oak-and-bronze *modius* cylinder—ignoring the angry assistant Measurer hovering at his shoulder, and ran his scarred right thumb round the inner bottom chine where wooden staves met the circular oak floor-board.

No false wooden bottom; Hostilius wasn't stupid enough to carry a rigged tub when port centurions checked depths once a week with brass rods.

Except Corvus's thumb didn't just check depth; **his surveyor's nose smelled rancid mutton-fat mixed with fine marble-dust**, and his scarred knuckle felt a smooth, bevelled ring of hardened tallow-and-chalk cement: inside *this* tub the inner chime wasn't greased, **the underside of**

the iron tripod cross-stay had a fresh wooden wedge knocked loose half an inch!

Corvus looked higher—at the **heavy curved iron *rutellus* striking-rod** in Hostilius's own fist, and then at the *second* wooden *modius* tub sitting "empty" behind the assistant's calves waiting to swap in rotation!

Without asking leave, Corvus reached past the assistant's shin, tipped the second oak *modius* cylinder sideways onto its bronze hoop in the bright March sun, and rapped the center of its circular oak bottom hard from *underneath* with his brass folding rule.

Clack.

Underneath the impact, a thin eighth-inch crust of yellow beeswax dusted over with glued wheat-bran **popped clean off the oak floor-board**, Wait: removing inner wax *increased* volume! Hostilius had **concaved the inner oak floor-board three-eighths of an inch on a lathe** after the *Annona* inspector stamped the outer bronze rim in January, hiding the pale fresh-turned oak fibers under a wash of bran-water so every single "standard" *modius* scooped three extra handfuls of Sarapion's Egyptian wheat above legal measure—stealing eight percent across forty thousand tubs while keeping a clean unshaved spare tub beside his left boot in case a port centurion asked to gauge!

Corvus picked up the curved iron *rutellus* rod off the deck-bench and laid its straight back edge flat across the inner floor of Tub Two. Daylight shone a clear quarter-finger wide beneath the iron straight-edge across the scooped wooden belly!

On the quay crisp footsteps halted; Crispina leaned over the low bulwark rail looking down at the daylight gap under the iron bar, and laughed aloud, a low, musical sound cold enough to freeze harbor mullet.

"Well, Gaius Hostilius," Corvus said, rising smoothly to his full six feet while Sarapion's six Egyptian sailors closed silently round the gangway behind the sweating measurers with belaying-pins in their fists. "Carving out the belly of a stamped public *modius* after official sealing falls under the *senatus consultum* applying the *Lex Cornelia de Falsis* to fraudulent public weights and measures. Deportation and total confiscation if you own four hundred thousand sesterces; the Ostian quarry-chains for ten years if you don't. Would you like me to call the Port Centurion off Pier Twelve to gauge Tub Two right now—or would you rather smash Tub Two over the

rail yourself as 'cracked in handling,' re-measure Sarapion's cargo from Sack One using the Port Centurion's own bronze standard drum, and tell my notary which Smyrniot factor in Vault Nine paid you ten gold pieces this morning?"

Sweat ran gray down Hostilius's bull-neck into his leather collar. Glancing wildly toward Vault Nine on the quay, he saw **only an empty brick arch**: Vedius Pollio's agent Philargyrus had already melted quietly back into the warehouse crowd the instant Corvus laid the iron straight-edge across the scooped wood!

Abandoned on the plank with six furious Alexandrian sailors behind him and Senator Priscus's name in front of him, Hostilius folded like wet cardboard.

"Ten *aurei* cash at the bathhouse last night from Philargyrus, Vedius's factor," Hostilius croaked, wiping his mouth on his forearm while his knees went slack. "Swore nobody behind Tullia Crispina's widow-veil knew grain-gauges from hair-combs! Don't call the centurion, young sir, I've got three daughters in Ostia—we'll re-tally from Sack One with the harbor bronze standard before dusk!"

Up on the sunny gangplank Tullia Crispina watched Corvus dictate six crisp lines of sworn *testatio* preserving Philargyrus's name on wax before letting terrified Hostilius smash the shaved tub into kindling. When Corvus stepped back onto the limestone quay beside her, brushing dry Fajyum wheat-chaff off his white *toga*, Crispina did not praise him like a clever schoolboy the way Fronto or Priscus did; she looked straight at his mouth and scarred right thumb with level, adult calculation.

"You just saved my chest forty-two thousand sesterces before lunch, Lucius Cassius," Crispina said quietly. "Come into my counting-room before the tavern flies wake up; I have twelve more charters inside my cedar box that smell of this same Smyrniot rat."

* * *

All afternoon inside her private second-floor brick loggia above the *Horrea*, where green sea-light flickered across black-and-white mosaic dolphins on the floor, eighteen-year-old Corvus and Tullia Crispina tore **Publius**

Vedius Pollio's coastal shipping net apart sheet by sheet over salted red mullet, olives, and dry Surrentine wine.

Unlike Caelian senatorial ladies who left numbers to sticky-fingered Greek stewards, Crispina had grown up on her father's Puteoli timber-wharves; she read compound sea-interest, Rhodian jettison averages, and warehouse lien priorities as fast as Corvus himself.

And by the tenth hour, laying twelve bottomry notes side by side across her inlaid *mensa*, Corvus saw the whole architecture of what Vedius Pollio was building down at the river-mouth:

"He isn't chasing state *annona* African wheat," Corvus said, tracing four Sicilian and Sardinian hulls with the butt of his stylus. "Nobody touches state quota grain without bringing the *Praefectus Annonae*'s soldiers down on his head. Vedius is buying up bottomry paper and bribing measurers exclusively on **medium private coastal hulls carrying free-market Sicilian and Sardinian hard wheat**, the exact independent grain supply medium Subura *pistrina* rely on whenever state allocations run twenty *modii* short of their daily hundred!"

Corvus kept his face calm over the wax, though inside his chest every nerve pulled taut. *Subura pistrina running a hundred modii a day.* Day Three Hundred Seventy-Three on Sura's slate back behind the Fish-Market today—two full years still ahead before Lucida stood safe inside Roman citizenship! Squeeze private Sicilian wheat at Ostia next autumn, and twenty independent freedmen and Junian Latin bakers in Rome would miss a single day's hundred-modius quota, forfeit their statutory runs, and drop straight into Hermippus's foreclosing lap!

"Sharp eyes," Crispina murmured, leaning across the corner of the citrus-wood table so her green glass bracelets clicked lightly against Corvus's ink-stained wrist. "Vedius offered my steward eight hundred thousand sesterces flat last month to buy out my entire maritime loan-book at twenty percent discount, claiming a widow couldn't police twenty skippers from Puteoli to Alexandria. Until the fourth hour this morning, I half intended to take his silver and buy quiet Sabine sheep-walks."

"Don't sell him a single plank," Corvus said immediately, grey-green eyes hard as river-flint. "Enforce every charter at Ostia, Puteoli, and Centumcellae with sworn private *mensores* watching the drums, and your four

hundred thousand principal clears ninety thousand net before November —while starving Vedius's warehouse corners."

Crispina propped her chin on one ringed hand, dark painted lashes half-lowered as she studied the lean line of his eighteen-year-old jaw, the broad mason-and-surveyor shoulders under his loosened afternoon tunic, and the white stylus-scar at the corner of his mouth.

"Quintus Servilius Priscus pays you what, eighty sesterces a week now, plus whatever *Lex Cincia* crumbs grateful old knights drop in your lap?" Crispina asked softly.

"One hundred sesterces a week since January, plus pleading gifts," Corvus answered evenly—he had **fourteen thousand two hundred sesterces** stacked inside his Caelian box now, proud silver to a Subura clerk, less than four percent of the four-hundred-thousand-sesterce equestrian mountain he had sworn outside the Esquiline Gate to climb before twenty-one.

"Beggar's porridge for a man who spots a three-eighths-inch lathe-scoop in ten breaths," Crispina said. "My coastal villa at **Laurentum** sits six miles south down the pine-road. Ride down in my carriage before dusk so we can draft preventive *interdicta* and factor-warrants on all eleven remaining hulls tonight before Philargyrus sends fast horses to Puteoli at dawn. Sign on as my retained maritime *cognitor* and audit-partner across the summer sailing season, with Senator Priscus's blessing, naturally, I'll send him two barrels of Baian oysters on Monday—and you take **twenty-five percent of every contested recovery and penalty we collect between March and October**."

Corvus's pulse gave one heavy, slow hammer-stroke against his ribs.

Twenty-five percent on contested penalties across four hundred thousand sesterces of maritime paper, **twenty-five to forty thousand sesterces in a single sailing season**, vaulting him past fifty thousand before his nineteenth birthday while jamming an iron bar straight between Vedius Pollio's spokes at Ostia so clean Sicilian wheat kept flowing up the Tiber to Barba's and Lucida's ovens!

"My horse is saddled downstairs, Domina," Corvus said.

* * *

Six miles south of the Tiber mouth along the paved *Via Severiana* shore-track, where dark umbrella-pines leaned landward away from booming white March surf and rich senators kept winter-spring sea-retreats out of Rome's river-fog, **Tullia Crispina**'s Laurentine villa sat built straight out onto black volcanic rock ledges so high tide threw salt mist right against the warm glazed gallery windows.

Until the fifth hour of the night there was nothing between them save relentless, exhilarating work: three tall bronze oil-lamps burning clear olive oil without tallow-stink, Crispina's silent Greek secretary engrossing duplicate charter-notices in neat Chancery script while Corvus paced five-foot surveyor's lengths across warm hypocaust mosaic dictating ironclad shipping clauses out of Labeo and Julian, pausing only to eat roasted Laurentine wild boar tenderloin and salty Lucrine mussels off silver plates without ever laying down his stylus.

At midnight Crispina dismissed the Greek secretary to bed with a flick of two fingers, bolted the cedar folding-doors against the colonnade draught herself, and poured two goblets of dark, unwatered Falernian *vino vecchio* while Corvus pressed his bronze crow-and-plumbline signet—carved for six denarii last winter, into the hot red wax of their partnership *chirographum*: **twenty-five thousand sesterces minimum guaranteed audit-share** against the summer fleet, lying crisp and sealed beside the middle lamp.

Outside the tall mica panes, Tyrrhenian rollers crashed white and rhythmic against the stone sea-wall; inside, resinous pine-cones popped orange sparks inside the bronze brazier.

Crispina set the brimming silver goblet in Corvus's hand, then did not return to her chair across the citrus-wood table. Slowly she lifted both arms behind her dark coiled hair, pulled out two carved tortoiseshell pins so heavy black Campanian waves tumbled past her bare collarbones smelling of lemon-verbena and warm skin, and slid all six green glass bracelets off her wrists *clink-clink-clink* onto the polished table right beside his twenty-five-thousand-sesterce tablet.

"Eighteen in November, Phileros told my steward," Crispina murmured, standing six inches in front of him in a single unpinned sea-green Coan silk house-tunic thin enough that the red brazier-light behind her traced both dark nipples and the soft shadow between her thighs clean through the weave. "And working sixteen hours a day between dusty basil-

icas and some Subura baker's garret. Tell me, Lucius Cassius: do Cato's speeches keep you warm at night, or do you ever take off your armor?"

Corvus did not pretend country stupidity, and his hand holding the silver goblet did not shake—though every drop of eighteen-year-old blood in his body went hot and heavy into his groin at once.

For two and a half years inside Rome, while fullers' apprentices and junior clerks spent two copper *asses* every market-day grunting five breaths inside airless Subura *lupanar* cribs smelling of sour cabbage and twenty prior men's sweat—Corvus had touched no woman on earth, partly from iron miserliness over every copper coin, mostly because every time desire woke ragged in the dark above Barba's ovens, the face behind his shut eyelids had dark braids dusted with white *siligo* flour and a tiny brown olive-pip mark beneath her left collarbone, separated from his hand by two yards of warm terracotta tile and three unspoken mountains of fear.

Here stood no miserable two-as crib-slave, and no childhood best friend whom one clumsy touch might shatter forever: here stood a thirty-two-year-old equestrian widow worth nearly two million sesterces, smelling of lemon-leaves and salt spray, looking up at his mouth with frank, amused, utterly unsentimental adult appetite.

"Armor comes off when the door's bolted, Domina," Corvus said, voice rough in his throat, setting the untouched silver goblet down beside her green bracelets.

Crispina smiled, reached up with both smooth, ringless hands to catch the neck-hem of his white woollen tunic, and pulled his mouth down onto hers.

She tasted of dark Falernian wine, salt mussels, and smooth, practiced certainty, parting his lips immediately with her tongue, nipping lightly right over the pale white stylus-scar at the left corner of his mouth to feel whether it was tender, then murmuring *"Take the wool off before you tear my silk, Sabine"* as she stepped backward onto the wide, fleece-draped tortoiseshell reading-couch beside the brazier and drew her sea-green Coan shift straight off over her head in one fluid shimmer.

Corvus dragged his tunic off over his shoulders and dropped it on the mosaic. Thirty months of hauling brick-hods, swimming freezing aqueduct tanks, and walking twelve Roman miles of steep basalt hills every day had carved his six-foot frame lean and flat-muscled from rib-cage to hip, only

the faint pale cupping-circles under his left shoulder-blade and the jagged red-turned-white trench scar down his right shin marking where Rome had tried to kill him at fifteen.

Crispina's dark eyes ran straight down his bare chest to his hard, springing cock, her breath catching once with genuine Campanian pleasure as she lay back against stacked crimson cushions and parted sleek, depilated thighs oiled faintly with sweet almond.

"Jupiter be thanked—not one ounce of soft Quirinal pudding on your ribs," she whispered, reaching down to close warm, knowing fingers around the base of his shaft, guiding him between her thighs without coyness or delay. "Come here, little crow, don't rush the harbor-mouth just because the sea's open."

When he pushed inside her slick, gripping heat for the first time in his life, a low raw groan tore involuntarily out of Corvus's chest against her throat; his scarred right hand locked into the thick black hair behind her ear while his left braced hard into the fleece mattress beside her hip. Crispina wrapped both strong, smooth calves high around the small of his back, tilting her pelvis expertly to take his full length deep while raking short manicured nails down his sweat-damp shoulder-blades, whispering filthy, laughing Campanian encouragements in Greek and Latin against his jaw whenever eighteen-year-old urgency drove him too hard and fast, slowing his hips with a bite to his earlobe until both of them were slick with sweat in the red brazier-glare.

Halfway through, she rolled him smoothly onto his back across the wide fleece—straddling his hips upright in the flickering bronze lamp-light, fuller thirty-two-year-old breasts swaying oiled and flushed above him while Corvus gripped both curves of her waist in wide, calloused hands, watching through half-blind heat how she took her own sharp, shuddering climax first with head thrown back and teeth gleaming white in the dark before leaning low over his chest, hair curtaining both their faces, driving down hard and fast onto him until his spine arched clean off the fleece and his seed spent hot and convulsive deep inside her while outside the mica panes a ninth wave boomed white thunder against the rocks.

Long afterward, when the bronze lamps had burned low to blue-gold beads on floating wicks and the brazier coals had sunk under grey ash, Crispina slept soundly turned on her side with one warm thigh flung lazily

across Corvus's hip, comfortable, satisfied, owning every stone of her villa, her ships, and her morning.

Wide awake in the salt dark, eighteen-year-old Corvus lay flat on his back listening to the receding surf hiss down black Laurentine gravel.

On the citrus-wood table four feet away gleamed the six green glass bracelets beside the red-waxed contract worth **twenty-five thousand sesterces**—more silver won between dawn and midnight today than his dead father Gaius Cassius Corvus had earned trudging muddy Sabine ditches with a *groma* across forty honest years of life.

Corvus lifted his right hand in the dimness, smelled lemon-verbena and another woman's musk drying on his scarred thumb-knuckle where dry flour and river-water had been, and stared straight up at the coffered cedar ceiling without blinking until pale grey sea-light crept through the shutters, telling himself fiercely that twenty-five thousand sesterces brought the gold ring six months closer, and refusing to ask why his chest felt hollow as a scooped wooden *modius*.

Chapter XIV

The Green Stables

Thirteenth Day Before the Kalends of May, Ludi Cereales, AD 159 · Lucida

Before the sun cleared the Baths of Agrippa on the last morning of the **Games of Ceres**, the brick courtyard of the **Stable of the Greens** (*Trigarium Factio Prasina*) smelled of rubbed garlic, boiled Cyprian laurel-fat, nervous stallion dung, and forty thousand gold pieces riding on sixteen hooves wrapped in woven broom-straw *soleae* for the morning walk down to the sand!

Eighteen-year-old Lucida stood beside her two hired mule-carts just inside the bronze-studded stable arch on the western edge of the Campus Martius, checking lead tally-seals off her wax board while white-tunicked African grooms rolled forty-pound stoneware jars of tendon-embrocation and steaming cedar tubs of bruised barley-and-fenugreek mash down the straw-strewn aisle.

Four hundred fifteen unbroken mornings now sat chalked on Sura's black slate back behind the Fish-Market (**ANNVS II · DIES L**—fifty days deep into her second statutory year, every single dawn above a hundred and ten *modii*!), and the burial-guild bread-advance was nearly two-thirds cleared. Better still, nineteen months of supplying **Ceionia Fabia**'s race-stable chests had put nine thousand sesterces of clean reserve silver into Lucida's private strong-chest hidden beneath Oven Two's dry ash-floor, wearing finest-spun unbleached linen and a neat dark-green woollen *palla* today that marked her as a prosperous house-purveyor rather than a dock-runner.

All down the vaulted hundred-foot stable gallery, preparation for the afternoon's twenty-four chariot heats hummed at fever pitch.

Inside open-fronted box-stalls lined with planed oak so frightened thoroughbreds couldn't splinter their hocks kicking stone, forty prized Spanish, Cappadocian, and North African Cyrenaican stallions tossed braided manes threaded with green silk ribbons and green glass evil-eye beads while veterinary slaves sponged down quivering shin-bones with warm vinegar. Out on the sanded harness-floor four star *agitatores*, scarred, bow-legged men worth more silver than ten senators' villas, led by twenty-two-year-old Lusitanian **Diocles Minor**—stood with both arms raised parallel to the ground while trainers hauled wet rawhide rib-thongs (*fasciae*) round and round their chests from armpit to hip, lacing their torsos into rigid leather barrels so a snapped axle wouldn't stove their ribs in on impact. Into each man's waist-belt went the curved, razor-edged steel hook-knife (*falx*) with which a charioteer who wrapped his driving-reins round his own body, as every Roman driver did to steer by trunk-weight—had three heartbeats to slash himself loose if his team went down before four galloping horses dragged his skull to jelly along the barrier wall.

Down at Stall One, where two Praetorian guardsmen in white parade tunics leaned on unstrung javelins to keep stable-boys back, laughter rang warm and careless over the whickering of horses.

Twenty-eight-year-old **Lucius Ceionius Commodus** stood bareheaded in an emerald-green morning tunic embroidered at the wrists with gold palm-branches, holding flat on his open ringed palm a square of warm Attic honey-and-sesame cake while **Volucer**, the famous seven-year-old bay African *funalis* (left-hand trace-horse, the brains and pivot of the entire four-horse team, who swung tightest round the bronze turning-posts!)—velveted the cake delicately off the imperial prince's fingers without grazing skin.

"Look at the eye on him this morning, Publius!" Lucius exulted, wiping sticky honey and horse-saliva cheerfully onto his own fifty-aureus green tunic while patting the bay stallion's arched, shining crest. "Not a drop of night-sweat on the flank, and his frogs hard as boxwood since my sister's woman switched him off your factor's greasy pitch onto pure Cyprian laurel! How much have the Blues laid against him in the seventh *missus*?"

Standing on the far side of *Volucer*'s oak stall-door, immaculate in white holiday wool, shaved skull gleaming like oiled ivory, plump depilated hands

folded placidly over a carved citron-wood betting-tablet—**Publius Vedius Pollio** smiled with effortless, musical charm.

"Two hundred thousand sesterces even money across three Carinae tables, my Lord Lucius, and I covered eighty thousand of it in your name before dawn so the odds wouldn't shorten," Vedius purred, and then, glancing down the sunlit aisle past Lucius's shoulder toward the two mule-carts unloading green-sealed stoneware jars by the gate, **Vedius Pollio's moist brown eyes met eighteen-year-old Lucida's straight on across thirty feet of straw**.

For two heartbeats neither Vedius's smile nor Lucida's hand holding her wax delivery-board moved a fraction of an inch.

Behind Vedius's velvet pupils Lucida watched the entire equation lock together inside that terrible accounting-machine of a skull: *Ceionia Fabia's mysterious stable-purveyor... green-pitched forty-pound stoneware jars... the silent eighty-sesterce Kalends tribute-payer who blocked Scaeva at the Fish-Market bakehouse with Fabia's lead seal!*

And right here, twenty paces from **Lucius Ceionius Commodus** feeding honey-cakes to *Volucer*, Vedius Pollio could not lift a finger, could not shout *"My Junian Latin chattel!"*, could not set Scaeva on her without admitting openly to young Lucius that Vedius had been overcharging the prince's beloved horses for years and picked a fight with Ceionia Fabia's own personal supplier on race morning!

Instead, as Lucius turned to inspect *Volucer*'s braided tail-ribbons with the Lusitanian driver, Vedius strolled six leisurely paces down the aisle to admire a white Cyrenaican trace-colt—bringing himself within four feet of the cedar bran-tubs where Lucida stood signing the head-groom's receipt.

Smell of crushed bitter almonds and snow-water drifted across the horse-straw between them.

"Pure Cyprian laurel-fat and bruised Reatine barley," Vedius murmured softly, pitching his musical voice as though praising the colt's pasterns so the groom three yards away heard nothing strange. "Remarkable how industrious one fifteen-year-old orphan grows by eighteen when Rome feeds her well. Four hundred fifteen mornings on those noisy Fish-Market stones now, isn't it, Lucida? Six hundred eighty mornings still to grind before Trajan's little fairy-tale turns pumpkin-rind into gold."

Lucida dipped the head-groom's reed pen calmly, signed *L · T* beneath the jar count, and looked straight at the smooth white fold beneath Vedius's ear without dropping her chin.

"Volucer's off-fore tendon hasn't swelled a hair since September, Dominus," Lucida replied in velvet Caelian Latin, quiet and clear as glass. "Lord Lucius told Lady Fabia at supper last night that whoever kept his bay sound through April deserved Caesar's own grain-warrant. Shall I tell Lord Lucius you were asking after the recipe?"

A tiny, genuine flash of connoisseur's delight flickered deep inside Vedius's dark eyes—a butcher admiring how cleanly his own calf stepped around the pole-axe.

"Keep your jars clean, little Tyrian," Vedius murmured, turning smoothly back toward Lucius's laugh at Stall One, "and sit high out of the sun at the Circus this afternoon. Crowds on Ceres's day trample careless folk underfoot in a blink."

Crowds on Ceres's day trample careless folk underfoot in a blink.

Lucida's fingers tightened slightly around her wax tablet as her empty mule-carts rolled back out into the roaring holiday street. Vedius Pollio never wasted breath on weather forecasts; somewhere inside that giant wooden-and-marble bowl between the Palatine and Aventine this afternoon, a trap already had its iron teeth greased.

* * *

One hundred and fifty thousand citizens wearing compulsory snow-white holiday togas in honor of Mother Ceres turned the three soaring tiers of the **Circus Maximus** into a mile-long canyon of blinding white chalk under an April sky blue as painted Egyptian glass.

Up on the high wooden sun-benches (*maeniana*) above the western curve of the **meta secunda**, where honest guild-masters and prosperous shop-folk sat on rented rush cushions eating salted lupins and fried pork-rinds while passing wine-skins down the row—Lucida sat wedged between wheezing old **Habinnas Barba** (wearing a ridiculous green woollen scarf tied round his bald crown, hoarse already from bellowing *"Prasina! Prasina!"* through four preliminary heats) and fifteen-year-old **Sura**, whose

grey eyes darted constantly along the vaulted stair-vomitoria below just as Lucida had quietly warned her before noon.

Two hundred feet straight down across shimmering waves of heat and roasted-nut smoke lay the vast yellow ribbon of arena sand divided lengthwise by the marble barrier (*spina*), where seven colossal gilded wooden eggs and seven spouting bronze dolphins stood poised on high frames to count off the seven killer laps of each *missus*, flanking the towering red granite obelisk Augustus had hauled across the sea from Heliopolis to cast noon's shadow down the center of the world.

Directly opposite across the track, beneath crimson silk sun-awnings below the empty Palatine box, seventy-two-year-old **Emperor Antoninus Pius** had stayed quietly out at Lorium pruning vines rather than endure six hours of roaring dust, leaving his two adopted sons to preside side by side—Lucida could pick out tiny dots of purple and white along the senatorial marble podium: **Lucius Commodus** leaning half over the balustrade waving a green silk napkin with both hands; dark-bearded **Marcus Caesar** sitting dutifully beside him reading state dispatches on his knee right through the preliminary crashes!; and thirty seats left along the white-togated senatorial front row, stern grey-bearded **Senator Priscus**, behind whose bench Corvus had told her yesterday morning he wouldn't even be sitting today, because Corvus was spending Ceres's holiday auditing late Ostian grain-tallies and meeting a witness at the tenth hour!

Wait.

Meeting an Ostian barge-witness at the tenth hour near the Circus arcades, Corvus had mentioned offhandedly last night while washing ink off his wrists in Barba's courtyard—because holiday crowds covered a frightened clerk slipping away from Emporium watchers better than an empty street!

Lucida leaned forward over her knees, shading her amber eyes with one stain-faded hand to scan the arched travertine exits along the lower Blue-and-Green betting-galleries directly below the *meta secunda* at **Gate Twelve**.

Down on the yellow sand below, attendants in Ceres's white linen had just finished the ancient rural rite of releasing red hill-foxes across the infield to burn winter mildew out of Italy's standing wheat; four trumpeters stepped to the chalk starting-line (*alba linea*); up in the presiding lodge

Lucius Commodus stood up radiant in gold-trimmed purple and dropped the weighted white linen **mappa** straight toward the dust!

Twelve iron gate-latches clanged back as one; forty-eight stallions exploded out of the twelve curved starting-stalls (*carceres*) in a rolling yellow hurricane of flying sand, cracking rawhide whips, and screaming axles while **one hundred and fifty thousand human throats** detonated in a single animal roar loud enough to rattle roof-tiles half a mile off on the Aventine!

Down the straight first quarter-mile thundered three teams each of **Greens, Blues, Reds, and Whites**, iron tire-rims rasping sparks hub-to-hub as Lusitanian **Diocles Minor** held **Volucer** tucked cunningly half a length behind the leading Blue *quadriga* to let Blue eat the choking dust-wind through Laps One, Two, Three, and Four. One by one four gilded bronze dolphins tipped nose-down into their marble water-basins along the *spina*.

Up beside Lucida, old Barba was standing on his pine bench pounding both flour-scarred fists on his own chest and screaming Cappadocian war-oaths until his solitary eye bulged purple; Lucida wasn't watching *Volucer* anymore.

Her eyes were locked two hundred feet below on **Vomitorium Twelve**, where a thin, nervous forty-year-old harbor clerk in a brown Ostian *paenula* clutching a sealed leather tally-pouch against his belly had just stepped into the shadowed mouth of the stairwell—looking tensely uphill toward the Forum Boarium for Senator Priscus's runner, while **six burly men in Blue and Green scarves** drifted casually into the exact same stairwell arch from opposite sides, with **one-eared Gaius Ummidius Scaeva** leaning calmly against a pastry-pillar outside the outer arcade watching the bronze dolphins tip!

Crowds on Ceres's day trample careless folk underfoot in a blink.

Oh, gods—that's Priscus's Ostian grain-witness down in Gate Twelve, and Corvus or Phileros is walking straight toward that arch right now!

"Sura—stay with Barba, don't move off this plank!" Lucida shouted straight into Sura's ear, shoving past twenty cursing spectators along the packed wooden row and plunging down the steep travertine interior steps three at a time while out on the track the fifth bronze dolphin tipped and catastrophe struck the sand!

Rounding the razor-tight three-post turn of the **meta secunda** forty yards off at full forty-mile-an-hour gallop, the leading **Blue** trace-horse slipped half a foot in churned sand; **Diocles Minor** whipped bay **Volucer** instantaneously through a four-foot suicide gap along the inner marble curb while behind them **Red One** slammed square into the slewing Blue axle-hub!

Ashwood chariot-boxes detonated like dry kindling hit by ballista-bolts.

Two stallions somersaulted neck-over-crupper in a spray of crimson foam and snapped bronze; Red's driver failed by half a heartbeat to draw his belt-*falx* before three terrified runaway horses dragged him upside down across fifty yards of hard sand, painting a yard-wide dark smear beside the marble wall while *Volucer* and the Greens tore clear into Lap Six and **fifty thousand Blue and Green bettors along the western tiers surged screaming off their benches toward the lower rails and betting-stairs at once**!

Inside the narrow, vaulted stone funnel of **Vomitorium Twelve**, daylight vanished beneath a stampeding human avalanche of drunken men in white wool roaring *"Foul turn! Blue cut! Pay the Green board!"*

Twenty steps above the bottom landing, pinned tight against the sweating travertine wall by surging shoulders, Lucida saw every merciless beat play out ten yards below her in four heartbeats of dim arch-light:

Two of Scaeva's fake "Blue" partisans flashed hidden iron knuckles, not knives, no blades that an urban cohort surgeon could call murder!—driving one short, crushing blow straight into the solar plexus of the brown-cloaked Ostian clerk while a "Green" partisan hooked the clerk's ankle backwards on the slick steps and yelled *"Blue thief stole my purse!"*

Down went the Ostian witness flat on his spine across the bottom three stone treads, and **four hundred panicking, cheering, twelve-stone racegoers** surged straight down the dark stairwell over his chest, throat, and skull like cattle stampeding through a chute!

Bones cracked dull and wet beneath hobnailed boots; someone snatched the crushed leather tally-pouch clean off the dying man's belt in the press; and by the time Lucida fought her elbow clear to the bottom arch-mouth gasping for air while the seventh-lap trumpet blared **Green victory** across the sky, **Scaeva** and his six scarfed thugs were already strolling calmly away past the cattle-market sausage-stalls without looking back, leaving *vig-*

iles stretchermen cursing over another "holiday crowd-crush victim" whose ribs had been trodden flat!

And twenty paces across the dusty arcade square—running up breathless from the Velabrum side too late because crowd-barriers had blocked the lower street, came **Phileros**, stopping dead beside a portico column as the *vigiles* pulled a coarse sack over the dead Ostian clerk's mangled face!

Lucida shrank flat behind a garlanded Ceres fruit-booth before Phileros's pale eyes swept the arch. Corvus wasn't with Phileros—thank heaven Corvus hadn't walked into those boots himself!, yet watching Phileros turn chalk-grey and stride rapidly northwest toward the **Campus Martius** told Lucida immediately where Corvus was waiting for the afternoon's word.

* * *

Out beyond the stifling dust and drunken victory-bonfires of the Circus valley, the **Porticus Pompei**—four vast parallel avenues of shady plane-trees, splashing marble fountains, and bronze statues of conquered nations behind Pompey's stone theater, lay breezy and green in slanting golden April twilight.

Lucida walked swiftly down the central gravel walk beneath rustling young plane-leaves, heart still knocking hard against her ribs from the wet crunch of ribs inside Vomitorium Twelve, scanning the marble exedra benches for Corvus's tall dark head so she could warn him privately before tonight that **Scaeva**—not accidental Circus drunks, had trampled Priscus's Ostian witness and stolen the leather tally-pouch.

Near the tall marble statue of **Syria** holding a carved bronze palm-branch beside the middle fountain-basin, two figures came strolling slowly toward her out of the western colonnade shadow, deep in low, intimate conversation.

Eighteen-year-old **Corvus** walked on the outside, six feet tall, wearing not his stout Subura-mended working wool, a supple, exquisitely fulled tunic of creamy Tarentine summer fleece under a light toga whose folds smelled from ten paces off of cedar-wood rather than fuller's sulfur.

And walking directly at his left side—so close her sea-green silk *palla* brushed his hip at every stride, her ringed white fingers resting possessively

inside the crook of Corvus's right forearm while six pale green Campanian glass bracelets chimed lightly against his scarred right wrist, walked **Tullia Crispina**.

Lucida stopped dead beside the splashing marble rim of the fountain before her brain even gave her feet the order.

She knew who Tullia Crispina was; every merchant round the Emporium and Porticus Minucia knew the rich thirty-two-year-old Puteoli shipping widow worth nearly two million sesterces who rode behind sleek Apulian mules and broke crooked skippers over her knee.

More than that: eighteen-year-old Lucida had spent three winters compounding perfumes and watching Caelian women walk out of inner bedrooms into mirror-light. One single glance took in the faint, lazy flush along Crispina's bare throat above her sea-green silk, the unmistakable proprietary ease with which Crispina's thumb stroked the inner tendon of Corvus's bare forearm as she laughed up at something he said, and—drifting straight across six feet of April fountain-air, **the crisp scent of Campanian lemon-verbena water**, the exact faint ghost-smell Lucida had noticed twice on Corvus's hair-roots up in Barba's loft over the past five weeks without knowing its name!

Corvus looked up—and saw Lucida standing ten feet in front of them beside the marble statue of Syria.

For one naked fraction of a heartbeat, every drop of color left Corvus's sun-browned Sabine cheeks; his right arm twitched involuntarily inside Crispina's clasp before eighteen months of courtroom iron froze it still so he wouldn't insult a two-million-sesterce client on a public walk.

Crispina felt that tiny muscle-check under her fingers immediately. Her dark painted eyes slid slowly over eighteen-year-old Lucida from braided blue-black hair and dark green wool *palla* down to the faint purple-brown dye-shadow that never completely faded around Lucida's cuticles, summing up *pretty Subura baker-or-perfume girl from the boy's old neighborhood* in half a breath, and keeping all five ringed fingers resting lightly, unmistakably, right on Corvus's skin.

Run away or drop her eyes like a shamed servant, and Lucida would have hated herself until the day they put her ash-urn in Salvius's wall.

Instead Lucida's spine went straight as Ceionia Fabia's six-inch gold hairpin. Every trace of breathless alarm over Vomitorium Twelve vanished behind placid, crystalline Caelian velvet.

"Good evening, Lucius Cassius," Lucida said smoothly in crisp Forum Latin, inclining her braided head the exact quarter-inch an independent *exercitor* of a registered hundred-modius *pistrinum* gave an advocate on a public walk.

"Lucida," Corvus said—his voice half a tone lower and rougher than usual, grey-green eyes searching hers fiercely across the ten feet of raked gravel to read why she was in Campus Martius alone at dusk. "May I present my client **Domina Tullia Crispina**, Lucida, co-master of the Piscarium *pistrinum* and purveyor to the Caelian houses."

"Ah—the hundred-modius Sicilian bread-ovens near the Fish-Market!" Crispina said pleasantly, giving Lucida the warm, deadly-gracious smile equestrian ladies bestowed upon clean tradeswomen whose bills got paid by stewards. "Lucius Cassius was telling me down at **Laurentum** last month how hard independent city bakers fight to find clean hard wheat when Ostian factors skim the tubs. Perhaps once our summer Alexandria charters clear Portus, my steward can spare your ovens two hundred *modii* at fair wharf-rate."

Down at Laurentum last month.

Not an afternoon meeting in an Ostian warehouse office, *down at her seaside villa at Laurentum*, dropped casually like a poisoned honey-almond straight onto Lucida's tongue so the younger girl knew precisely whose bed-linen smelled of lemon-verbena!

Inside Lucida's chest something hot and jagged twisted hard enough to taste like copper at the back of her throat—remembering Corvus's scarred thumb trembling wet against her collarbone above the Janiculum water-wheels, remembering his sleeping cheek two inches from her bare ankle by the October chestnut-coals while both of them held back out of terror of ruining everything they had built, and not a flicker of pain reached her mouth.

"Domina Crispina is generous," Lucida replied, smiling straight back into the older woman's painted Campanian eyes with luminous, lethal courtesy, "though my *pistrinum* buys directly off Agrigentine hulls cash

down without forty-day bottomry paper; we find clean Sicilian grain keeps much sweeter when too many brokers' hands haven't warmed the sack first."

Crispina's dark eyebrows arched a hair's breadth at the sting hidden inside the silk; Corvus's jaw tightened white along the bone.

"I stopped only in passing from the Circus, Lucius Cassius," Lucida added evenly, looking straight into Corvus's eyes now so he caught the iron warning underneath the polite words, "to mention that the crowd-crush down in **Vomitorium Twelve** after *Volucer*'s win trampled an Ostian harbor-clerk in a brown *paenula* dead on the bottom steps—right beside six noisy partisans whose chief had only one ear. Your colleague Phileros saw the stretchers leave; if you had an evening meeting down near the cattle-market, save your clean Tarentine wool the walk."

Corvus's eyes locked hard onto hers, taking the whole warning in one flash (*Vedius killed Fulvius; don't walk into the trap; and yes, she saw the wool*).

"Thank you," Corvus said quietly. "Will you—will Barba have the courtyard shutter unbarred at the second watch tonight?"

Are you coming home to the loft tonight, or going back to lemon-verbena? hung unspoken behind his teeth, and *Are you locking me out?* hung behind hers.

"Barba unbars the courtyard only for the midnight grain-carts after the first watch on feast-nights," Lucida said calmly, turning back down the shady avenue of plane-trees before Crispina could speak again. "Good fortune with your Alexandria hulls, Domina. Good evening, Lucius Cassius."

She walked all the way out through Pompey's marble arch onto the noisy, torch-lit April cobbles without once quickening her pace or looking back, holding her head steady while Green chariot-fans danced drunkenly round bonfires singing *Volucer*'s name, until she turned into a dark, empty fuller's passage behind the Temple of Bellona, pressed both fists flat against rough tufa stone out of every human eye, and breathed through clenched teeth until the shaking in her ribs turned cold and hard as volcanic mill-lava.

Chapter XV

Lex Aquilia

Seventeenth Day Before the Kalends of August, AD 159 · Corvus

Under the blazing July sun outside Vespasian's Temple of Peace, seventy-year-old **Quintus Lollius Urbicus**, Prefect of the City, sat bolt upright in his curule chair wearing heavy winter-weight wool without once wiping the sweat trickling out of his iron-grey Numidian beard onto his purple border.

Men who had marched behind Urbicus twenty winters ago beyond Hadrian's Wall into the black peat-bogs of Caledonia swore the old general had left all human feeling froze solid somewhere north of the Clyde and brought back only a measuring-rod and an executioner's axe. Three cases ahead of Corvus on the morning docket, Urbicus had dispatched a crooked cattle-drover to the Sardinian mines in forty breaths, dismissed an equestrian's boundary-whine in twenty, and ordered forty lashes on the spot for a night-watchman who fell asleep over a charcoal-brazier.

Now two sweaty Syrian porters set down a woven rope-stretcher directly on the scorching travertine pavement in front of the Prefect's stone dais.

Lying flat on a folded horse-blanket across the ropes was **Thais**, a twenty-four-year-old skilled silk-and-linen damask weaver from Antioch—bought out of savings two years ago and married *contubernio* (though not yet formally manumitted before the Praetor because her husband lacked the five-percent *vicesima libertatis* tax!) by **Marcus Licinius Syriacus**, a weeping, round-shouldered freedman cap-maker kneeling beside her stretcher clutching Corvus's toga-hem.

Eleven nights ago, up on the fifth floor of a rotten timber-framed Subura *insula* owned through two straw-leases by **Gaius Munatius's brother-in-law**, worm-eaten fir ceiling-joists overloaded with wet am-

phora-clay stored illegally upstairs had snapped at midnight without warning, dropping twelve hundred pounds of rubble straight across Thais's sleeping loom-bench and shattering both sides of her pelvic ring.

Asclepiades of Pergamum had kept her breathing; she would never stand upright, never work a foot-treadle loom, and never carry a living child past the fourth month again.

Across the pavement stood the landlord's sneering defense pleader **Vibius Crispus**, waving a two-hundred-sesterce bag of copper and small silver lazily toward the stretcher.

"My client denies all structural *culpa*, Illustrious Prefect," Vibius drawled, fanning his neck with a folded papyrus leaf. "Old Subura fir dries brittle in July heat; Jupiter sends timber-splits just as he sends thunderbolts! Even if Chapter Three of the *Lex Aquilia* applied, look at the woman—both hands whole, eyesight clear, quite capable of spinning coarse wool with a hand-spindle from a stool! Two hundred sesterces generously covers thirty days' lost spinning while her bruises fade."

Down on the rope-stretcher, Thais bit hard on a knotted strip of rag so she wouldn't cry out before the terrible old Prefect as street-flies buzzed round the blood-spotted bandages strapping her crushed hips; beside her, Syriacus looked up in blind terror at eighteen-year-old Corvus, who had taken the desperate cap-maker's brief for **no silver fee at all**, purely because watching broken Subura folk thrown onto cobbles had eaten at his ribs ever since old cobbler Trebatius wept by the bridge last summer.

Except standing here in ninety-eight-degree glare before **Lollius Urbicus**, Corvus faced the cruellest trap in the entire Roman civil law.

Had Syriacus managed to free his beloved Thais before the ceiling fell, Syriacus would have recovered **almost nothing** today—only Asclepiades's twenty-eight-sesterce doctor's bill and bare lost wages, because as **Gaius** wrote in cold black ink, *cicatricium aut deformitatis nulla fit aestimatio, quia liberum corpus nullam recipit aestimationem*: **no money valuation is ever put upon scars or crippling deformity of a free human body, because a free body has no market price**.

Only because Thais was still technically her husband's **slave chattel** on paper could Corvus win the four thousand sesterces Syriacus needed to keep both of them out of the gutter—and only if Corvus stood six feet above that weeping twenty-four-year-old woman in open public square and priced her

broken womb and crushed bones **strictly like a cracked wine-jar or a hamstrung pack-mule**!

Cry pity before Lollius Urbicus, and the old Caledonian iron-post cut your clepsydra off in ten words. Speak butcher's arithmetic, and they ate this winter.

Corvus stepped half a pace ahead of Syriacus, adjusted no fold of his crisp white toga, and looked straight up into Lollius Urbicus's unblinking yellow-grey eyes.

"Counsel offers two hundred sesterces for bruises, Prefect," Corvus said, his deep Fronto-honed voice dry as baked brick, devoid of a single tremor of sentiment. "Chapter Three of the *Lex Aquilia* prices neither bruises nor tears; under Sabinus and Julian it awards the owner the **highest market value the damaged chattel held within the thirty days preceding the wrongful *ruptio***, less residual scrap value on the block today."

Down on the stretcher Thais flinched slightly at hearing herself called *damaged chattel* and *scrap value*, turning her pale, sweating face away toward the rope; Syriacus squeezed his eyes shut. Corvus did not look down at either of them; he kept the iron shutter locked behind his ribs and laid three certified wax tablets one by one along the edge of the Prefect's clerk-table.

"First, on *culpa*: here is the sworn deposition of two fourth-floor tenants who warned the landlord's *insularius* nine days before the collapse that wet clay-tubs upstairs were bowing the fifth-floor fir joists two full inches out of level and dropping worm-frass into their soup. Storing heavy industrial wet clay on worm-eaten residential pine after warning isn't Jupiter's thunderbolt; Julian's *Digest* Book Nine calls overloading rotten beams classic actionable *imperitia et negligentia*."

Urbicus didn't nod, yet his heavy chin stayed still, meaning *Go on to quantum; liability is proved.*

"Second, on market depreciation within thirty days," Corvus continued without drawing breath, holding up the second tablet. "Thirty days ago at the Saepta Julia dealers' pens, healthy Syrian four-heddle damask weavers aged twenty to twenty-five fetched **four thousand eight hundred sesterces** certified average—supported here by Syriacus's own workshop ledger showing Thais wove fourteen yards of patterned Coan-style table-linen a month clearing seventy sesterces net above thread. Today, with both iliac

crests fractured inward, verified here under the seal of **Asclepiades of Pergamum**—she cannot work foot-treadles, cannot stand at an upright warp-beam, and carries permanent pelvic narrowing fatal to parturition, destroying all *partus ancillae* breeding value that normally accounts for twenty percent of a twenty-four-year-old female slave's Saepta price."

Vibius Crispus opened his mouth to sneer; Corvus's voice cut flat across his teeth like a mason's trowel:

"A crippled hand-spinner who must be lifted onto a night-stool by a second person fetches **at most four hundred sesterces** at the damaged-goods block behind Castor, less two hundred eighty sesterces already spent on surgical splints and squill-wine to keep the owner's capital asset from dying altogether! Four thousand eight hundred less four hundred, plus two hundred eighty salvage expense: **four thousand six hundred eighty sesterces** pure statutory *damnum iniuria datum*, Illustrious Prefect—and since the defendant denied liability *infitiando* despite prior joist-warnings, the *Lex Aquilia* **doubles the condemnation against a liar to nine thousand three hundred sixty sesterces** unless paid down before sunset!"

Silence dropped like lead over the hot travertine paving-stones. Vibius Crispus's fan stopped moving mid-air as the *duplum* penalty for false denial slammed shut over his client's fingers!

Up on the curule dais, old **Lollius Urbicus** stared down for four slow heartbeats at eighteen-year-old Corvus, measuring the boy's unblinking grey-green eyes, the absence of wasted adjectives, the surgical mastery of *infitiatio* doubling—and lifted one gnarled brown forefinger toward his *assessor*.

"Liability proved on overloaded beams," Urbicus rasped in dry camp Latin. "Enter single *damnum* at **four thousand four hundred sesterces** if paid in silver into the plaintiff's hand before the tenth hour today; **eight thousand eight hundred** *in duplum* with bodily seizure of the landlord's rents tomorrow dawn if unpaid. Next scroll!"

Behind Corvus, freedman Syriacus collapsed onto both knees kissing the dusty hem of Corvus's toga and sobbing thanks in Aramaic, four thousand four hundred sesterces was enough not only to rent a sunny ground-floor garden room where Thais could sit propped on cushions in clean air, enough to pay her five-percent manumission tax so she died a free Roman wife!

Yet as the porters lifted the stretcher carefully off the stones, twenty-four-year-old **Thais** looked up once past her sobbing husband straight into eighteen-year-old Corvus's face.

She bowed her dark head in silent gratitude for their saved lives—and at the exact same time shrank half an inch back into her blanket away from his eyes, the way a lamb shrank from a clean-handed butcher who had weighed its kidneys down to the ounce without blinking once.

Corvus watched her stretcher sway out through the colonnade arch into the glare, refusing Syriacus's tearful offer of twenty denarii out of the judgment, and stood still for ten breaths in the shade of a porphyry column wiping dry dust, there was no sweat—off his scarred right thumb.

That is how you win inside their marble, he told himself coldly. *Cry over her broken womb and Vibius walks away paying two hundred coppers; price her womb like cracked Syrian pottery and she sleeps in a garden tonight.*

Still, all the way up the Carinae steps toward his lonely bachelor third-floor study, rented in May two weeks after that freezing dusk encounter in Pompey's Portico, because sleeping two yards from Lucida in Barba's ninety-degree summer loft while Tullia Crispina's green bracelets and Ceionia Fabia's unspoken shadow hung between them had become physical torture neither eighteen-year-old body could endure without catching fire or drawing knives—Corvus couldn't quite wash the sound of his own voice pricing *partus ancillae* out of his ears.

* * *

At the eleventh hour, carrying a woven rush basket of yellow Sabine freestone peaches bought off a Crustumerium countryman's mule at the Colline market, Corvus turned down the noisy, brine-sharp alley behind the **Forum Piscarium**.

He still kept half the loft rent paid three months ahead in Habinnas Barba's ledger, ignoring Lucida's curt insistence in May that she needed none of his silver—and still stopped by the bakehouse courtyard every ten or twelve days before sunset to check Sura's arithmetic slate and make sure Hermippus's thugs weren't sniffing round the walls.

Inside the smoky stone arch, heat from two banked twelve-foot brick domes rolled out to meet him mixed with the rich, nutty fragrance of four

hundred fresh loaves cooling on willow racks. Up beside Oven One, fifteen-year-old **Sura**, grown tall and willow-straight now, her scarred left forearm bare in July heat without shame inside her own courtyard—spotted Corvus first, beamed with pure, unforced loyalty that hadn't learned adult politics yet, and tapped her chalk proudly against today's square white numerals:

ANNVS II · DIES CXXXVIII — MODII CXVI

Five hundred and three unbroken days altogether—nearly halfway across the thousand-and-ninety-five-day canyon!

"Good girl, Sura," Corvus said warmly, tossing the biggest Sabine peach straight into her floury hands before pausing short beside the inner grain-room door.

Out through the brick storeroom doorway stepped two women talking low in rapid Greek: crooked old one-eyed **Berenice** leaning on a cornel-wood stick, and beside her a trim, sour-faced fifty-year-old freedwoman wearing an expensive, unmistakable dark-green Caelian house-stola and carrying an embroidered linen tally-bag stamped on the bronze clasp with **a prancing horse above *DOMVS CEIONIA***!

Corvus knew that mole on the left nostril from Phileros's Caelian household intelligence sheets within half a breath: **Dorcas**, chief confidential tire-woman to **Ceionia Fabia**, sister of Lucius Ceionius Commodus!

Right behind Dorcas in the doorway stood eighteen-year-old **Lucida**.

She wore a sleeveless summer baker's shift of fine unbleached Egyptian linen belted snug round her narrow waist with twisted green cord, dark braids pinned high off a damp, glowing olive neck, bare arms dusted faint gold-white to the elbows from checking flour-bolters. At eighteen she had grown into something that stopped grain-porters mid-stride on the street without her ever lifting an eyelash: full breasts shifting unconstrained save for a light inner linen band as she turned, long thighs outlined clean against thin linen by the red oven-draft behind her, amber eyes sharp and sleepless as a peregrine's.

Seeing Corvus standing six feet away looking straight at **Dorcas's *Domus Ceionia* clasp**, Dorcas snapped her tally-bag shut without a word, pulled her hood forward, and brushed briskly past Corvus out into the Fish-Market crowd with Berenice hobbling behind her.

Alone between the stacked Sicilian wheat-sacks and the silent afternoon lava-mills, Barba and the day-kneaders were napping in the shady stable-arch

across the yard—Lucida did not flinch, explain, or step back. She folded both flour-dusted forearms lightly below her breasts and met Corvus's grey-green eyes head-on.

"Did Tullia Crispina run short of Puteoli biscuits, Lucius Cassius, or did you take a wrong turn coming down from the Carinae?" Lucida asked smoothly.

The sting landed clean; Corvus set the basket of Sabine peaches down on the clean oak weighing-table without taking the bait.

"Crustumerium peaches off a farmer's cart from my father's road," Corvus said evenly. "And a warning from Lollius Urbicus's tribunal at noon. Two rotten sixth-floor ceilings fell in the lower Subura last week, I just argued the *Lex Aquilia* damage suit on one of them—and Urbicus's clerks are preparing street-by-street building and *horrea* inspections before the August Dog-Days. Keep your upper grain-loft load spread evenly over the stone piers rather than the middle pine beams, or municipal surveyors will slap a temporary *opus novum* suspension on your courtyard, and one suspended day kills five hundred mornings on that slate."

For two breaths the hard Caelian armor softened half a millimeter around Lucida's mouth; whatever walls had gone up between them since spring, she knew a life-or-death operational warning when he brought one.

"Barba braced the middle pine beams with two nine-inch oak posts in June," she answered more quietly, picking up one fuzzy yellow Sabine peach to smell the sun-warmed skin—remembering stealing green peaches together out of Fidenae orchards at thirteen until their stomachs cramped, before setting it carefully back in the basket. "Why was Senator Priscus's clerk watching Dorcas's clasp as if she carried plague?"

Corvus stepped two paces closer into the warm flour-scented shadow so not even napping Barba across the yard could hear.

"Because Dorcas carries **Ceionia Fabia's** purse, Vespera," Corvus said low, dropping his voice to their childhood name for the first time since April, "and Ceionia Fabia spends twelve hours a day building a Praetorian and chariot-faction party around her brother Lucius while **Publius Vedius Pollio** pours silver into Lucius's stables! Half the lawsuits Priscus puts in my hands this year are aimed straight at tearing up the floorboards under Vedius and Fabia's crowd—if you're taking Caelian silver out of Fabia's

bedroom, you're standing right on the fault-line when those two stones grind together!"

Lucida's amber eyes flashed bright molten gold in the gloom.

"Oh, *I'm* standing on a fault-line taking silver from Ceionia Fabia's bedroom?" she whispered fiercely, stepping one barefoot pace *forward* instead of back until barely ten inches of ninety-degree air separated her linen-clad chest from his white wool toga, smelling cleanly of warm Sicilian wheat, sweat, and bitter-almond soap. "When Scaeva walked into this courtyard with two cudgel-men on Day One of my three-year count to unhook my mules while you were asleep upstairs, Lucius Cassius, Senator Priscus's pure Stoic name wasn't here to stop him—**Ceionia Fabia's lead horse-seal stopped him cold on that stone threshold**! You take twenty-five-thousand-sesterce shipping shares and seaside suppers at Laurentum from Priscus's rich equestrian widows to climb toward your gold ring; don't walk into *my* mill in chalked wool and lecture me on whose silver keeps my throat uncut!"

Blood hammered hot into Corvus's temples, part fury, part a sudden physical ache so violent looking down six inches at her flushed throat and the dark olive-pip mark rising and falling just above her damp linen edge that both his fists clenched white inside his toga-folds to keep from catching her waist and crushing her mouth against the wheat-sacks right there.

Tell her you know about Vedius's eighty sesterces every Kalends, a voice inside his ribs shouted. *Tell her you've banked fifty-eight thousand sesterces already solely to buy an iron hammer heavy enough to smash her patron!*

And right behind it spoke crisp, poisonous eighteen-year-old pride: *Tell her while she has Fabia's gold in her pocket and just threw Crispina's Laurentum bed in your teeth, and she'll laugh in your face and call you Priscus's errand-boy!*

"Keep your beams braced for August, Lucida," Corvus said, his voice flat and cold again, stepping back out of reach of the heat radiating off her bare arms. "I didn't come to count your Caelian jars."

He turned and walked out through the Fish-Market arch into the red evening sun without looking back—missing how Lucida stood motionless beside the basket of Sabine peaches for twenty breaths after his shadow vanished, pressing two floury knuckles silently against her dry lower lip.

* * *

Four hours after sunset, up inside **Senator Quintus Servilius Priscus**'s shady, peperino-walled Caelian library where smoky wax consular masks stared through bronze lamp-glow, eighteen-year-old Corvus sat across a scarred oak campaign-table from **Priscus**, **Quintus Junius Rusticus**, and **Phileros**.

Both double cedar doors were bolted from the inside; not a single household slave had been left in the adjoining peristyle.

"Old Antoninus stumbled twice getting out of his bath at Lorium four mornings ago," Junius Rusticus said quietly without preamble, ink-stained thumb resting motionless on his knee. "Marcus Caesar had to catch his elbow before the chamberlains saw. Seventy-three in September; his mind is clear as spring water, yet his legs swell below the knee whenever damp wind blows off the Tyrrhenian marshes. Two years left, perhaps eighteen months, if winter treats him kindly."

Corvus sat utterly still, stylus poised over blank wax. Never before tonight had Priscus or Rusticus spoken the unspeakable sentence—**the death of Antoninus Pius**, aloud in front of an eighteen-year-old equestrian candidate.

"When that night comes," Senator Priscus picked up, cracking a dry fennel seed between his back teeth, "every greedy equestrian syndicate, racing-faction boss, and Syrian luxury-contractor who has lent gold to young **Lucius Commodus**—with **Publius Vedius Pollio** foremost among the pack, expects Lucius to demand equal tribunician and proconsular *imperium* alongside Marcus, throwing twenty years of clean Stoic administration open to the wolves! Marcus himself is too generous toward his adoptive brother to strike first; therefore Marcus's friends clean the stables *before* the old Emperor stops breathing."

Priscus pushed two heavy, red-sealed municipal survey-rolls across the oak table until they bumped against Corvus's scarred right thumb.

"Prefect Lollius Urbicus watched you argue that *Lex Aquilia* joist-collapse at noon today, Lucius Cassius," Priscus said, grey eyes glinting cold approval. "Starting on the Kalends of August, Urbicus empowers a special three-man technical sub-commission under my supervision to enforce two sleeping statutes without mercy across Regions IV, VI, and VIII: first,

Emperor Trajan's sixty-foot maximum height cap on street-front *insulae*—giving us legal crowbars to condemn and raze the top two timber storeys off twelve overpriced Subura tenements Vedius Pollio milks through straw landlords! Second, an unannounced forensic audit of **every private hundred-modius *pistrinum* registered since last year** suspected of fronting undeclared syndicate capital or drawing *annona* privileges on padded donkey-counts!"

Priscus tapped the lower red seal with one bony finger.

"Do this cleanly through autumn and winter without letting a single target buy warning, boy, clearing sixty thousand more out of Crispina's autumn Alexandria fleet and forty thousand in fiscal forfeitures on Vedius's condemned leases—and by next year at nineteen you will hold half the four-hundred-thousand-sesterce census needed for Marcus Caesar himself to sponsor your equestrian gold ring when his day dawns. Open Region VIII and check the flagged bakehouses."

Inside the bolted library, bronze lamp-flames burned straight and motionless.

Corvus broke the red wax seal on the Region VIII *pistrina* schedule with steady fingers, unrolled the crisp white papyrus across his knees, and ran his grey-green eyes down Column One, Column Two, Column Three, all genuine front-companies controlled by Hermippus and Numerius Vettius —and stopped at Line Twelve of Column Four:

REGIO VIII · FORUM PISCARIUM · PISTRINVM BARBAE ET LVCIDAE LAT · IVN · — DENUNTIATIO ANONYMA DE PECVNIA EXTERNA ET MODIIS SIMVLATIS.

Anonymous denunciation alleging concealed outside syndicate backing and padded daily modius tallies.

Corvus didn't need two guesses to know which Smyrniot steward had slipped that "anonymous" denunciation into the Urban Prefect's box the week Vedius Pollio spotted Lucida inside the Green stables: **Hermippus** was using Senator Priscus's own anti-corruption broom to sweep Lucida's three-year citizenship count into the gutter at Day Five Hundred!

Across the oak table **Junius Rusticus** was watching Corvus's eyelashes with quiet, terrifying acuity.

"Do you know any of the Region VIII mill-lessees on Column Four, Lucius Cassius?" Rusticus asked softly.

Betray a flicker of recognition right now, and Priscus reassigned Region VIII to another clerk who would march ten *vigiles* into Habinnas Barba's courtyard at midnight on the Kalends of August, halt the four lava mills for three days while auditing her Caelian and burial-guild books, and **destroy Lucida's thousand-and-ninety-five-day citizenship run forever**!

Keep Region VIII inside *his own* hands, and Corvus controlled the inspection calendar, controlled the weighing-drums, and could steer the iron wrecking-hook straight into Vedius's straw-mills next door while shielding Barba's threshold, without stubborn, furious Lucida ever knowing whose hand turned the bolt!

Corvus looked smoothly up from Line Twelve into Junius Rusticus's searching dark eyes, not a pulse-beat showing in his throat.

"Numerius Vettius's three sweepings-mills sit on Column Two, Senator —the same Vettius who borrows from Hermippus," Corvus answered cleanly, rolling the papyrus shut and sliding it into his own leather dispatch-case. "Give me two sworn measurers who don't drink Hermippus's wine, and we'll weigh every suspect hopper in Region VIII before September ends."

Chapter XVI

Weevils in the Hold

Fourteenth Day Before the Kalends of October, AD 159 · Lucida

When Lucida slit the belly-stitch of the ninth Sicilian sack with her bronze sampling-horn at the second watch of the night, the wheat inside moved by itself.

Under the red glare of Oven One's cresset, thousands of tiny snouted black *curculio* beetles boiled out through the parted hemp threads over her wrist, carrying the unmistakable sour, mushroomy stench of bilge-rotted grain that had lain three weeks wet under a leaky hatch at Messana and been topped off two palms deep at the mouth with clean dry kernels to cheat dockside buyers.

Habinnas Barba plunged both flour-scarred hands into Sack Ten, Sack Eleven, Sack Twelve—ripping twine open down the entire afternoon wagon-load delivered off **Gaius Baebius**'s river-lighter, and let out a strangled Cappadocian curse that ended in gray phlegm spat onto the basalt flags.

"Every single sack!" Barba wheezed, holding two handfuls of hollow, black-crawling husks toward the lamp. "Forty-eight *modii* of sprouted slime! Dump that filth between our Orvieto stones tonight and it gums every furrow solid with wet paste before the fourth watch—and our clean dry bin holds **sixty-two *modii***, thirty-eight short of Trajan's hundred!"

Beside the wall-slate fifteen-year-old **Sura** froze with chalk poised in her hand beneath yesterday's proud **DIES DLXV** (Day 565). Five hundred sixty-five unbroken days and nights, more than half of Lucida's thousand-and-ninety-five-day climb out of Junian Latin servitude—and if those four volcanic mills failed to grind and bake thirty-eight clean *modii* more before the midnight-to-midnight *annona* tally closed, **every single one of those**

five hundred sixty-five days dropped dead into the Tiber, resetting her statutory count to Day One!

Lucida didn't scream at absent Baebius and didn't waste five breaths kicking spoiled sacks. Standing in her dark brown working tunic with grain-weevils crawling over her bare knuckles, she brushed the beetles cleanly into the ash-pit so none escaped into her clean dry bin, and read **Publius Vedius Pollio**'s handwriting straight through the rotten hemp.

Ever since April in the Green stables, when Vedius realized whose Caelian salve-jars had cost him Lucius Commodus's grooms, and especially since August, when **Corvus**'s building-commissioners started tearing the top two storeys off Vedius's straw-owned Subura tenements!—Hermippus had stopped playing gentlemanly games. Vedius didn't dare smash Ceionia Fabia's purveyor openly with clubs; instead he had paid Baebius thirty gold pieces down at Ostia to slip forty-eight *modii* of weevil-slime onto Lucida's twilight cart after the wholesale Porticus Minucia brokers bolted their shutters for the night!

"Keep all four mules harnessed on the clean sixty-two *modii* right now so the stones never stop turning," Lucida ordered Barba, already unbuckling her flour-apron and unlocking her hidden floor-box behind Oven Two to count **sixteen gold *aurei*** (1,600 HS, quadruple market price for fifty *modii*!) into a soft leather waist-belt. "Heat both domes white with dry oak. I'll have fifty clean *modii* rolling through that arch before the fourth watch horn blows."

"From where at midnight, girl?" Barba rasped, catching at her cloak-hem in genuine dread. "Every private broker from the Tiber to the Viminal locked iron grilles at dusk! Only the imperial **Horrea Galbana** down under Monte Testaccio keeps night-clerks awake for dawn barge-unloading—and Hermippus's cousin drinks dice-wine with half the bailiffs in Court Three!"

"Half isn't all," Lucida said, buckling her short five-inch bone-handled warehouse cord-knife inside her right boot-top and throwing a dark hooded woollen *paenula* over her braided hair. "Send two of the Marsian kneaders down behind me with our flatbed two-mule dray to wait outside the eastern *Galbana* postern, and don't take your eyes off those hoppers till you hear my whistle."

* * *

Built round three colossal colonnaded travertine courtyards covering twenty acres between the Aventine slope and Potsherd Hill, the **Horrea Galbana** at midnight felt less like a market than a fortified legionary fortress of bread.

Six-foot-thick ashlar walls without ground-floor windows shut out thieves and fire alike; narrow arched entry-gates bristled with triple Laconian iron locks guarded by sleepy imperial *vilici* with mastiffs on chain-leads; and inside Courtyard Two, a hundred and forty numbered brick storage-vaults (*cellae*) stretched away under dim hanging oil-lanterns, breathing out a dry, intoxicating, temple-deep warmth of **two million *modii* of sun-baked Egyptian, African, and Sicilian wheat** resting behind mortised Lebanese cedar planks.

Lucida knew every night-watch face in Courtyard Two from three winters of buying Emporium oil fifty yards west. Avoiding Gate One where Hermippus's drinking-crony Rufus sat snoring beside a mastiff, she slipped four silver denarii cleanly into the palm of an old Cilician night-porter at the eastern postern, left her two Marsian kneaders holding the mule-dray in the dark lane outside, and walked straight down the echoing travertine arcade to **Vault Twenty-Four**—the non-quota commercial surplus bin where merchant-shippers stored excess Sicilian flint-wheat (*triticum durum*) above state *annona* levy.

Inside the high brick doorway, beside an iron brazier kept carefully screened in brass wire-mesh ten feet clear of the dry grain-dust, sat **Decimus Valerius**.

Twenty-six years old, discharged two springs back after six years pulling marine oars and boarding-hooks in the Misene fleet, Decimus had broad, sun-darkened Campanian shoulders bursting the seams of a sleeveless scarlet tunic, cropped black curls oiled with cheap spikenard, a heavy silver ring stamped with Ceres's wheat-ear on his thumb, and the lazy, insolent dark eyes of a petty gatekeeper who grew rich charging rich men's factors midnight grease-money.

He looked up from trimming his fingernails with a bronze pocket-blade as eighteen-year-old Lucida stepped into the lantern-circle and pushed her dark wool hood back off her braided hair.

"Shut till the first horn, sweetheart," Decimus drawled automatically, boots propped comfortably on an empty olive-firkin, then lowered both

boots flat onto the stone as he recognized her face from the Emporium quays. A slow, appreciative grin showed white teeth under dark moustache-stubble. "Wait—Habinnas Barba's pretty Tyrian partner from the Fish-Market ovens! Out walking the docks alone at midnight without your mute shadow?"

"Baebius dumped forty-eight *modii* of wet Messana weevil-sweepings at my gate at dusk," Lucida said without preface, stepping right up to his counting-desk and laying **eight gold *aurei*** (800 HS, sixteen sesterces the *modius* for fifty *modii* of four-sesterce wheat!) in a neat gleaming yellow line across his scarred pine board. "Vault Twenty-Four holds eleven hundred *modii* of dry Agrigentine surplus consigned to Numerius Flaccus, which you have authority to release against cash deposit plus shrinkage-margin. Measure fifty clean *modii* onto my mule-dray outside the east postern before the third watch ends: Flaccus gets his two hundred fifty sesterces book-price in the morning, and **five hundred fifty sesterces stays in your belt** for losing half an hour's sleep."

Decimus looked down at the eight gold pieces shining under the hanging lamp—more silver than the *Horrea* paid a deputy *vilicus* across four months, and whistled softly through his teeth.

Then he leaned back against the thick Lebanese cedar planks holding back forty wagon-loads of warm Sicilian wheat, scratching his bare collarbone with the flat of his bronze nail-knife, and didn't touch the gold.

"Five hundred fifty sesterces is sweet honey," Decimus said, dark eyes dropping unhurriedly from Lucida's wind-flushed cheeks down the open throat of her brown woollen *paenula* to the curve of her waist and hips underneath. "Trouble is, **Hermippus**'s market-clerk came round all three courtyards at sunset buying wine and whispering that anybody who let a single sack of private Sicilian grain roll toward the Fish-Market before morning would have Publius Vedius Pollio's harbour-factors blacklisting his cousins from Ostia to Puteoli. Eight gold pieces buys a man's blind eye on ordinary nights, Tyrian; risking Hermippus's teeth takes friendlier persuasion."

He stood up off the stool—two inches shorter than Corvus, thicker through the neck and forearms, smelling strongly of Campanian red wine, dry wheat-chaff, and hot male skin, stepping round the counting-table until barely two feet separated his scarlet chest from hers.

"Two winters I've watched you walk down Bollard Twelve with your chin in the air as if dock-men were mud under your calfskin soles," Decimus murmured, reaching out one broad, calloused thumb to brush the loose dark curl beside her ear—not grabbing, waiting with cocky, unmistakable hunger to see whether desperation made the proud eighteen-year-old Fish-Market *exercitor* beg, cry, or run. "Leave six of those yellow coins on the pine for Flaccus and my gate-boys, leave the knife in your right boot on that stool, and give me half an hour behind the cedar partition where it's warm, and my porters load **sixty** *modii* of cleanest Agrigentine amber onto your dray before the watch-horn blows."

Inside Vault Twenty-Four the hanging oil-flame hissed softly; behind six-inch cedar retaining-planks, mountains of dry sun-heated Sicilian grain ticked faint and warm in the quiet.

Lucida stood motionless with Decimus's thumb half an inch from her jaw, doing the coldest, cleanest ledger-reckoning of her eighteen years.

Walk out that brick arch with her pride untouched and eight gold pieces in her purse: at dawn Sura's chalk stayed blank beneath **DIES DLXV**, five hundred sixty-five mornings died, Trajan's three-year citizenship road collapsed to rubble, and **Publius Vedius Pollio** owned her labor, her ovens, and her corpse forever.

More than that—deeper down beneath numbers, down where five months of silent fury and starved eighteen-year-old blood had burned ever since she watched **Tullia Crispina**'s ringed white hand stroke Corvus's bare forearm under Pompey's plane-trees while Corvus climbed toward his gold ring, something dark, fierce, and wholly unsentimental uncoiled behind Lucida's breastbone.

Men in Rome—senators, shipping widows, equestrians, dock-bailiffs, treated a woman's body as either a locked strongbox whose single scratch ruined the owner, or a helpless rag thrown down in mud. **Lucida Tyria's daughter belonged to neither camp.** Corvus had not lost one ounce of his mind or iron taking twenty-five thousand sesterces out of Tullia Crispina's seaside bed at Laurentum; why the Hades should an eighteen-year-old woman let some cocky Misene marine think taking half an hour of warm skin put a collar round *her* neck, when sixty *modii* of prime wheat bought **five hundred sixty-six unbroken mornings toward Roman liberty**—and her own eighteen-year-old body was tired to death of sleeping

cold on virtuous flour-sacks waiting for a boy who smelled of lemon-verbena?

Lucida did not tremble, did not drop her eyes, and did not touch the knife in her boot.

Instead she reached up with steady, stain-faded fingers, caught Decimus's wrist before his thumb touched her cheek, and looked straight into his surprised dark eyes from six inches away.

"Three rules, marine," Lucida said, her voice low, smoky, steady as weighed bronze. "First: you write and stamp the sixty-*modius* gate-release tablet with Numerius Flaccus's bin-seal *right now* while all eight gold pieces sit on this table, and hand the waxed wood into *my* hand before a hook unpins my cloak. Second: my boot-knife stays in my boot, your hands stay off my throat and hair, and you spill your seed on the cedar planks, never inside me—give me a bastard belly in Year Two and I'll pay Berenice's alley-boys four gold pieces to feed your balls to the Emporium eels. Third: sixty *modii* sit loaded on my mule-dray within twenty breaths after I buckle my belt. Agree, or keep your four-sesterce wages and watch me buy Gate One."

Decimus stared at her parted dark lips and blazing amber eyes, and whatever petty bully's triumph he had expected vanished instantly into hard, stunned physical arousal at dealing with a predator instead of a rabbit.

"Gods in Baiae," Decimus breathed, half-laughing under his breath as his hand went straight for the iron bin-seal and wax diptych on his desk. "Done—watch me write it!"

Within forty heartbeats the official two-leaved **Horrea Galbana** release-warrant for **sixty *modii* of Lot Nine Agrigentine hard wheat, paid in full**, sat stamped in warm red wax and tucked securely inside Lucida's leather money-belt beside two recovered gold *aurei* (she swept two of the eight back into her own purse the instant he said *six*!).

Lucida walked past him behind the tall cedar grain-partition where clean, folded linen grain-tarpaulins lay stacked waist-high against warm Lebanese timber, dropped the heavy iron privacy-latch across the inner wicket *herself*, unpinned her woollen *paenula* onto a clean sack, and unbuckled her belt, leaving her linen shift on, hiked loose above her bare olive thighs and hips while pulling ONLY the left shoulder-cord down far enough that Decimus's mouth found warm bare breast and the dark olive-

pip mark under her collarbone as she pushed his scarlet tunic off his heavy muscled shoulders.

There were no gentle whispers and no romantic lies behind the cedar grain-wall. Decimus was twenty-six, clean-skinned, hard-muscled from fleet oars, smelling of salt sweat and crushed wheat rather than Caelian perfume; when he gripped both bare curves of her thighs to lift her hips back onto the waist-high stack of folded linen tarpaulins and knelt first for twenty fierce, greedy breaths with his hot mouth and rough tongue buried straight between her parted legs until her thighs clamped tight round his cropped black curls and a sharp, silent shudder arched her spine against the warm cedar wood, eighteen-year-old Lucida bit down hard on the knuckle of her own forefinger so not one sound escaped into Courtyard Two—eyes wide open on the rough brick vault overhead, letting pure animal heat wash five months of knotted tension clean out of her belly!

"Look at me, Tyrian," Decimus panted hoarsely, rising between her knees with his thick, heavy shaft slick against her hip, hands braced on the stacked linen on either side of her ribs as she guided him inside herself with her own steady hand, setting the angle and depth herself, wrapping both strong ankles tight above his muscled buttocks to control every hard, driving thrust against the creaking cedar grain-wall! Every slam of timber behind her shoulder-blades sent a tiny golden shower of dry Sicilian wheat-kernels trickling over the top plank down around their sweating shoulders; she dragged blunt fingernails hard across his broad sunburned back, refused his mouth when he tried to kiss her lips—pressing her hot cheek instead against his pounding neck-vein, driving her hips back into his hard rhythm until a fierce, hot spasm clenched straight up from the core of her groin through her ribs, and two breaths before Decimus groaned deep in his chest to spend, she unlocked her heels and shoved firmly against his lower ribs so he pulled out gasping to spill hot white across the dusty cedar floor-planks and empty hemp sacks just as agreed.

Ten breaths later—while Decimus still leaned with one hand braced on the timber catching his wind and staring at her in dazed admiration, Lucida was already wiping her inner thighs dry with clean linen tow, tying her shoulder-cord snug, buckling her leather money-belt with the waxed sixty-*modius* release warrant over her smoothed brown tunic, and shaking three golden Sicilian wheat-kernels out of her braids.

"Call the four night-porters in off the steps, Valerius," Lucida said evenly, voice steady and brisk as if they had just finished weighing salt-fish. "Sixty *modii* out of Bin Nine, bottom-probed by my own horn before they tie the necks."

Decimus dragged his scarlet tunic back over his damp head, shook himself with a crooked, rueful grin, and reached for his brass whistle. "Come back anytime Baebius wets your wheat, Fish-Market—next month I won't even charge Flaccus's six yellow chicks."

"Next month," Lucida replied, unlatching the cedar wicket and stepping out into the crisp September night air without looking back at the rumpled tarpaulin, "I won't be buying out of anybody else's bin."

* * *

At half an hour before dawn, with all sixty *modii* of flint-hard golden Agrigentine grain roaring clean through four freshly dressed Orvieto lava mills behind the Fish-Market and **ANNVS II · DIES DLXVI — MODII CXIV** chalked safe and white on Sura's slate!, Lucida stood naked behind the bolted stable-screen pouring bucket after bucket of cold well-water blended with sharp fuller's vinegar over her head, breasts, belly, and thighs.

She scrubbed with coarse pumice-meal until not one trace of cheap spikenard or another man's sweat clung to her skin, braided her wet blue-black hair tight in the red dawn light, and dressed in fresh-ironed white wool.

Looking down at her own steady hands lacing her boots, she waited to feel some crack of girlhood grief or dirtiness. Nothing came—only a strange, hard, weightless relief, as if a last childhood tether tying her body to an imaginary Sabine cottage with Corvus had finally been cut cleanly with her own knife, leaving both arms free to fight on equal ground.

By noon, carrying a heavy canvas bag containing **twelve thousand sesterces** out of her accumulated Caelian cosmetic and Green-stable reserves, she climbed the noisy Argiletum stairs first to check old **Berenice**'s drying-racks before meeting her guild straw-buyer.

Inside the dim herb-scented shop, sixty-three-year-old Berenice was pounding dried Pontic wormwood in a brass mortar while cursing the dust raining down through her ceiling joists from hammering two streets east.

"Hear those iron crowbars up on the Clivus Suburanus, little hawk?" Berenice spat into the hearth-ash, pointing her pestle toward the window. "Urban Prefect's building-commissioners again! Tore the sixth and seventh timber floors clean off Numerius Vettius's cousin's tenement at dawn because the eaves stood sixty-eight Roman feet above the curb instead of Trajan's sixty, threw thirty weavers' mattresses into the gutter and slapped forty thousand sesterces demolition liens across the ground-title! You know whose name every landlord from the Firewall to the Carinae is spitting into red wine this week when they curse the wrecking-hooks?"

Lucida kept her fingers still sorting dried rose-hips on the marble tombstone slab. "Senator Priscus's?"

"Priscus sits clean in the Senate eating fennel!" Berenice cackled grimly. "Out on the cobbles with brass surveyor's rods and ten *vigiles* hook-men behind him walks **your eighteen-year-old Sabine crow—Lucius Cassius Corvus**! Tall as a spear, cold as January sleet, measuring poor folks' roof-tiles to the quarter-inch for his Caelian masters! Keep your Fish-Market grain-loft low, girl, or your childhood sweetheart will take a crowbar to your shingles before winter, unless you go round to his Carinae bachelor door at dusk and beg him prettily to skip your street!"

Lucida dusted dried rose-chaff briskly off her palms and tied her canvas money-bag shut with two sharp jerks.

"The day I beg Lucius Cassius Corvus to skip my street," Lucida said quietly, "you can pour your green savin bottle into my own porridge, Beroe."

Half an hour later she stood two hundred yards uphill on the wide, roaring **Clivus Suburanus** itself, beside seventy-year-old **Marcus Ulpius Felix**—a deaf, granite-honest retired citizen baker from Salvius's burial guild who hated Hermippus like poison and had agreed for two hundred sesterces fee to hold legal Quiritary straw-title (*fiducia cum amico*) with secret simultaneous counter-bond in Lucida's strongbox until Day 1,095 made her a full Roman citizen!

Directly in front of them, wedged between a thriving coppersmith's forge and an oil-press, yawned a forty-by-ninety-foot fire-gutted commercial lot whose upper timber floors had burned down three winters back, leaving **indestructible three-foot-thick Republican peperino stone ground-piers** and, twenty feet underneath the char-ash, **two bone-dry vaulted**

tufa cellars capable of storing two thousand *modii* of Sicilian hard wheat behind Lucida's own Laconian iron locks where neither Vedius Pollio's bribed skippers nor midnight *Horrea* gatekeepers could ever choke her hoppers again!

Better still: once cleared and roofed in fireproof brick arches under Trajan's precise fifty-eight-foot legal limit—two clear Roman feet below Corvus's sixty-foot wrecking-rod!, the street-front arches would rent to four honest Subura shops clearing thirty percent a year!

Across a portable folding table set on the curb, the bankrupt owner's auction-banker (*coactor argentarius*) tapped his wax hammer over the boundary-plan while sixty yards further up the steep basalt street—surrounded by four helmeted *vigiles* surveyors holding painted ten-foot measuring-poles against a tall fuller's cornice!, a tall, dark-haired eighteen-year-old in a crisp white citizen toga stood squinting upward along a brass plumb-bob.

Corvus did not look downhill through the market-wagons and never saw the dark-veiled young woman standing beside old Ulpius Felix at the auction table.

Lucida watched Corvus's distant white shoulder in the bright September sun for three slow heartbeats, touched the waxed sixty-*modius Horrea* tablet still tucked inside her belt as proof of what last night had cost, and leaned close to deaf old Felix's ear.

"Put down the twelve thousand cash silver right now, Uncle Felix," Lucida said clearly, "and tell the *coactor* our masons start laying dry brick over those wheat-vaults on Monday morning."

Chapter XVII

Dry Pipes

Ninth Day Before the Kalends of November, AD 159 · Corvus

Three strokes of a six-pound iron sledge drove the tapered lead plug cold into the bronze collar, and half a street in Trans-Tiberim went quiet as a cut throat.

Down inside the brick inspection pit at the foot of the Janiculum steps, two public water-slaves (*aquarii*) wiped grey solder-paste round the crushed pipe-stub while **Gaius Caecilius**—a fat, saffron-perfumed wool-dyer whose front gate bore Mercury's painted purse and whose back ledger belonged ninety percent to **Publius Vedius Pollio**, stood wringing both dyed-yellow hands on the cobbles at Corvus's elbow.

"Twelve thousand sesterces of dipped Canusian fleece sitting in hot alum mordant right this instant, Master Cassius!" Caecilius wailed over the sudden dying gurgle of his brick yard-flume. "Leave those vats without cold rinse-water past the sixth hour and the alum burns every thread brittle as dry hay! Take thirty gold pieces deposit while my advocate petitions the *curator* on Monday—forty!"

Corvus, nineteen next month, standing broad-shouldered in an unspotted dark-grey autumn wool *paenula* over his white citizen toga, his surveyor's brass folding-rule tucked cleanly beside his belt-wallet—did not even look down at Caecilius's trembling yellow fingers.

Over the past seven months since Laurentum, thirty-one contested shipping audits at Portus and fourteen Subura building-and-water seizures had hardened Corvus's courtroom manner into something older advocates watched from across the Basilica with wary respect: never loud, never theatrical, moving through opposing paper like an iron saw through green pine. Inside Senator Priscus's strong-room and Tullia Crispina's Puteoli

bank-chest now sat **ninety-two thousand sesterces** in Corvus's own clear name, nearly a quarter of the four-hundred-thousand-sesterce equestrian threshold already conquered before nineteen!

"Your advocate won't find any *curator* on Monday willing to unseal an unlicensed twelve-digit branch soldered straight into a municipal *castellum* apron without imperial grant, Gaius Caecilius," Corvus said evenly, holding a waxed two-leaved deposition flat on his left forearm while dipping an iron stylus—not ink, hard iron into black beeswax, with his scarred right hand. "Under the *Lex Quinctia*, piercing the public main carries a hundred-thousand-sesterce fine and summary seizure of your drying-frames. However, Urban Prefect Lollius Urbicus cares much less about one Trans-Tiberim wool-washer than about the undisclosed syndicate principal who financed your illegal lead-work and holds beneficial mortgage over the three over-height Subura tenements at the bottom of the Vicus Patricius."

Corvus turned the wax board toward Caecilius's sweating nose.

"Sign six lines right here naming **Hermippus, steward to Publius Vedius Pollio**, as lender-in-possession on those three Vicus Patricius blocks and producing his private rent-quittances before noon," Corvus said quietly, "and my water-clerk issues you a temporary seven-day emergency cartage-permit to draw rinse-water in barrels from the public *lacus* basin forty paces uphill so your twelve thousand sesterces of Canusian fleece comes out of the alum whole. Refuse, and the masons rip up forty yards of your courtyard pavement before lunch."

Caecilius stared down into the pit where the plumber's iron crowbar already rested under his second flagstone, swallowed hard, and snatched the stylus out of Corvus's fingers.

Within eighty breaths Corvus held Hermippus's own secret rent-schedule for three prime Vicus Patricius *insulae* locked safe inside his leather satchel—another mortar-brick pried cleanly out of Vedius Pollio's lower foundation wall!

Only as Corvus walked back down the steep, stepped brick alley toward the **Pons Aemilius** behind the clanking municipal tool-cart did he notice three barefoot Syrian washerwomen standing bewildered round a small, sunken neighborhood overflow-trough (*lacus inferior*) tucked behind a potter's arch two hundred paces downhill from Caecilius's compound.

Instead of the brisk two-inch spout of clean overflow water that usually spilled down from the upper *castellum* weir to feed poor lane-trades along the river-flat, the worn stone lion's mouth above the trough dribbled thin brown rust-drops and sucked empty air.

"Stopped dead in the middle of rinsing forty yards of Caelian table-linen!" the oldest Syrian woman cried in rapid Antioch Aramaic to a young mule-boy holding two empty bleaching-tubs. "Run across the Fish-Market bridge right now and tell **Lucida Tyria's daughter** somebody plugged the upper pipe behind the wool-yard, or her flax bleaches yellow before sunset!"

Corvus checked half a stride on the basalt cobbles.

Tell Lucida Tyria's daughter.

He turned back two steps toward the dry stone lion-spout, running the subterranean hydraulic map through his head in three heartbeats, and swore silently under his breath.

Caecilius's unlicensed twelve-digit branch hadn't tapped the main primary chamber directly; Caecilius's crooked plumber had tapped the **secondary overflow culvert** feeding this lower poor-folk's trough, and when the *aquarii* hammered their broad lead shut-off plate across the cracked junction collar two hundred breaths ago to seal the leak fast without draining the main tank, **they had choked off the legitimate four-digit neighborhood overflow pipe running underneath it at the same stroke**!

"Master Commissioner?" the municipal foreman asked, halting his mule-cart as Corvus frowned back uphill. "Should we go back and chisel a bypass groove round that lower collar? Takes half a day's fresh *opus signinum* mortar to set dry, and you wanted us up on the Viminal before the sixth hour."

Unplugging that junction collar today before Caecilius's wax deposition was formally registered at the Urban Prefecture risked giving Caecilius's lawyer an excuse to claim the water-slaves botched an authorized neighborhood culvert rather than an illegal private tap! Tomorrow morning, once Urbicus's clerk entered Hermippus's rent-roll irrevocably on record, Corvus could send two plumbers back at his own personal expense to re-bore the poor women's four-digit spout wider and cleaner than ever—costing the Syrian linen-bleachers at most one afternoon's mule-haul down to the Tiber bank.

"Leave the lead plate solid until the Prefecture stamps the seizure-roll at noon," Corvus told the foreman briskly, pulling two silver denarii out of his own pouch and tossing them to the startled Syrian mule-boy by the dry trough without giving his name. "Hire a river-donkey to carry water-jars up from the embankment until tomorrow afternoon, boy; the municipal masons re-open the lower lion-spout tomorrow before dusk."

Clean, practical, fair by any sensible administrator's measure, except as Corvus crossed the sunny bridge toward the Forum, he knew down in his ribs how *two silver denarii tossed by an unnamed commissioner who just dried up her washers' trough* would sound by the time that mule-boy reached the Fish-Market ovens.

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Up in Senator Priscus's inner Caelian *tablinum* at the eighth hour, **Phileros** laid Caecilius's wet-sealed Vicus Patricius confession alongside four earlier Subura tenement schedules and rubbed his dry white hands together with the nearest thing to joy his bloodless Greek face ever displayed.

"Three blocks on the Vicus Patricius, two on the Sandaliarius, four behind the Argiletum," Phileros murmured, ticking squares off a large linen street-plan of Regions IV and VIII pinned across the oak table. "Every single one owned beneficially by Publius Vedius Pollio through front-freedmen, every single one carrying illegal seventh-floor timber garrets or unpermitted workshop furnaces! Once Lollius Urbicus signs the consolidated forfeiture decree—Wait until winter, Senator Priscus says, let Vedius borrow deeper on Ostian winter grain-futures first so the margin call breaks both knees at once!, half Vedius's Subura rent-roll falls onto the auction-spear in a single week."

Corvus leaned over the linen map, checking sightlines and fire-breaks down the familiar tangled alleys with a surveyor's automatic eye—and paused at a fresh red cinnabar square inked neatly on the **Clivus Suburanus** sixty yards below the Sandaliarius corner.

"Who filed the new masonry rebuilding notice on Lot Fourteen there?" Corvus asked, tapping the red square with his scarred right thumb. "That lot burned down to the Republican peperino piers before we came to Rome; it stood empty weeds in July."

Phileros glanced down at the municipal *aedes novae* building-register open beside his elbow.

"Bought cash down on the fourteenth day before the Kalends of October for twelve thousand sesterces, without a single sesterce of mortgage recorded, by one **Marcus Ulpius Felix**, aged seventy, freedman baker of the Palatina tribe," Phileros read out, lifting one pale eyebrow fractionally toward Corvus. "Member of the *Collegium Aesculapii et Hygiae*, the exact burial club that registered a bread-supply lien on Habinnas Barba's Fish-Market *pistrinum* eighteen months ago. And look at the architectural plan filed with the aediles: two deep vaulted tufa wheat-cellars holding two thousand *modii* below street-level, ground-floor commercial brick arches, three fireproof brick residential storeys above, **total cornice height fifty-seven Roman feet nine inches**—two feet three inches clear beneath your sixty-foot wrecking-bar!"

Corvus stood completely still above the map, staring down at that neat red square.

Old deaf Marcus Ulpius Felix didn't own twelve thousand spare sesterces; Felix lived on salted turnips and three hive-bees out past the Appian Gate.

Lucida had bought forty feet of prime Clivus Suburanus frontage for twelve thousand cash silver behind a citizen straw-man, designed the cornice two feet under Corvus's own statutory blade so he couldn't touch a single brick of her roof, and excavated two-thousand-*modius* grain-vaults right under **Gaius Ummidius Scaeva**'s nose in the dead center of Vedius Pollio's tenement territory!

Fierce, involuntary admiration hit Corvus first, nobody else on earth at eighteen could have turned Spanish oil-dregs and Caelian horse-liniment into four thundering mills and a forty-foot Subura brick-lot while bleeding eighty sesterces a month to a shark!—and hot on admiration's heels came sharp alarm, plus a darker, rougher question tightening his jaw:

Twelve thousand sesterces cash in September, while still paying off Salvius's burial guild and feeding four mills? Even Caelian face-paint and Green-stable hoof-jars didn't coin twelve thousand loose silver pieces overnight—**how deeply had Ceionia Fabia bought into Lucida's pocket since summer?**

And worse: Lot Fourteen on the Clivus Suburanus shared its eastern rear party-alley directly with one of the three rotten seven-storey timber death-traps Caecilius had just confessed belonged to **Vedius Pollio**! If Vedius discovered his own Junian Latin tributary was building fireproof wheat-vaults behind a straw freedman sixty paces from Scaeva's rent-office, or if a dry wind carried one spark off Vedius's worm-eaten pine balconies onto unfinished scaffolding—

At the tenth hour, instead of riding out toward the Esquiline gardens or meeting Tullia Crispina's factor at the Forum baths, Corvus left his white toga folded on his Carinae stool, pulled on stout hobnailed boots under his dark grey working tunic and cloak, and walked fast down into the smoky roar of the **Clivus Suburanus**.

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By the eleventh hour of a gusty late-October afternoon, the bricklayers and mortar-hod boys on Lot Fourteen had knocked off at sunset whistle, leaving behind the clean, sharp smell of wet pozzolana lime, sawn Sabine fir scaffolding-poles, and fresh red *bipedales* bricks rising four unfinished storeys above the noisy Subura cobbles.

Down at street-level a stout timber hoarding barred the front arches behind a padlocked wicket; Corvus didn't bother knocking at the padlock. Having grown up round clay-clamps and scaffolding since he could walk, he stepped into the narrow three-foot drip-alley alongside the coppersmith's wall, caught the projecting heel of the first lashed ashwood builder's ladder two feet above his head, hauled himself effortlessly onto the first plank catwalk, and climbed three successive swaying pine ladders past freshly mortared window-arches up onto the **top fourth-storey working deck, fifty-six vertical feet above the basalt street**.

Up here the smelly, frying-pan clatter of the Subura dropped away beneath his boots into a vast sea of blackened clay pantiles, smoking fuller's vents, and red sunset blazing straight across from the distant Janiculum ridge where Trajan's water-wheels turned.

Corvus crouched swiftly beside the eastern corner pier with his folding brass rule, testing the mortar mix with his thumbnail—clean sharp red pit-pozzolana two-to-one with slaked white lime, honest *opus testaceum*

twenty-four inches thick, built to stand three hundred years!, while checking how perilously close **Vedius Pollio**'s leaning, seven-storey timber-and-wattle tenement loomed across the narrow five-foot rear alley: rotten pine balconies sagging greased wool-rags almost within jumping reach!

Below his boots on Ladder Three, dry ashwood rungs creaked fast and light—not a heavy mason's tread, someone climbing barefoot-nimble in soft leather boots without touching the side-ropes for balance.

Up through the square scaffold-well rose a dark braided crown, olive shoulders under a slate-blue woollen *tunica* belted tight for climbing, and blazing dark amber eyes.

Lucida swung cleanly onto the three-plank pine catwalk twelve feet away, stopped dead as she recognized Corvus standing tall against the blood-red western sky beside her corner brick pier, and let go of the ladder-pole with both hands.

October gusts whipped loose black tendrils across her high cheekbones; fifty-six feet straight down past the unrailed outer edge of the three twelve-inch pine planks, iron-tired butcher's carts rumbled like toys over lethal basalt stones.

"Did you climb up here with a crowbar in your cloak to measure whether Marcus Ulpius Felix laid one brick past sixty feet, Commissioner," Lucida asked, her voice pitched low and flat across the wind, trembling with three months of banked fire, "or did you come to toss me two silver denarii the way you tossed them at my crippled Syrian linen-bleachers in Trans-Tiberim this noon after you plugged their water?"

Corvus straightened slowly beside the brick pier, folding his brass rule shut with a sharp *snick*.

"Caecilius tapped the municipal culvert illegally for Hermippus; shutting that collar broke Vedius's hold on three tenements down this very street, and municipal plumbers re-bore your bleachers' four-digit lion-spout clean tomorrow morning at my own cost," Corvus answered steadily across the swaying planks. "Which you would know if you had asked me instead of listening to street-gossip—just as I wouldn't have had to read on Phileros's Caelian map at noon that you sank twelve thousand sesterces behind old Ulpius Felix five feet away from Vedius Pollio's rottenest fire-trap in Rome!"

"Why on earth would I ask **Senator Priscus's** building-commissioner permission before laying my own brick?" Lucida shot back, taking two

fierce strides along the creaking pine planks toward him, ignoring the fifty-six-foot drop three inches left of her boot-heel as completely as she had ignored Number Three kiln's parapet at fifteen. "So you could run back up the Clivus Scauri, or down to **Laurentum**—and mark my straw-buyer's name in red cinnabar right below my Fish-Market ovens on your secret Region VIII audit-scroll?"

Corvus froze half a breath.

Right below my Fish-Market ovens on your secret Region VIII audit-scroll.

Only Priscus, Rusticus, Phileros, Lollius Urbicus's chief clerk, and Corvus knew which bakehouses stood flagged on that confidential July scroll, unless **Ceionia Fabia's** Palatine or Prefecture ears had bought a leak and fed it straight to Lucida to poison her against him!

"You think *I* put your Fish-Market ovens on Urbicus's audit-scroll?" Corvus demanded, his calm courtroom iron cracking open for the first time all year as he took two heavy strides forward along the groaning planks until six feet separated them in the howling red wind. "**Hermippus** slipped an anonymous denunciation into the Prefecture box in July to halt your thousand-and-ninety-five-day count! I lied straight into Junius Rusticus's eyes to keep Region VIII inside my own satchel so **no inspector in Rome has set one boot across Habinnas Barba's threshold for four straight months** while I tore Numerius Vettius's mills apart instead!"

For one stunned beat Lucida's parted lips went motionless—nobody had told her *why* the dreaded August *annona* audit had mysteriously skipped her courtyard while hitting three streets round her!, and instead of gratitude, **hotter, wilder terror and fury** blazed up in her amber eyes because being shielded in secret like a helpless child felt ten times more dangerous to her hard-won autonomy than open war!

"Nobody asked you to lie to Junius Rusticus for me, Lucius Cassius!" she cried back into the wind, both fists clenched tight at her sides. "Keep my name inside your satchel today, and tomorrow when **Senator Priscus** orders you to choose between his Stoic war on **Ceionia Fabia** and a Junian baker-girl down by the Fish-Market, whose wax tablet gets burned? Where do you think I got twelve thousand sesterces to dig my own wheat-vaults here—begging? **Hermippus dumped forty-eight *modii* of live black weevils into my bins at midnight in September** while your fine

maritime blockades squeezed Ostia, and I bought my own sixty *modii* out of the *Horrea Galbana* before dawn **without needing your Caelian ring or your widow's ships**!"

Bought my own sixty modii out of the Horrea Galbana at midnight.

Corvus knew the *Horrea Galbana* night-wardens, knew **Decimus Valerius** in Courtyard Two, knew what midnight favors took when Hermippus blacklisted silver—and watching the defiant, unflinching lift of eighteen-year-old Lucida's chin in the red sunset glare, Corvus read the exact truth written iron-plain in her eyes before his mind even formed words.

Jealousy, black, murderous, primitive, hotter than pitch-fire, stripping three years of Cato and Julian off his bones in half a heartbeat—roared straight behind Corvus's vision.

"Who held the bin-key in Courtyard Two at midnight, Lucida?" Corvus whispered, stepping right into the last four feet between them so the pine scaffold-plank dipped beneath their combined weight. "Valerius with the silver wheat-ear on his thumb? Did six gold pieces open the lock, or did you, "

"Say one more word about whose hand touched me while **Tullia Crispina's** green glass bracelets rattle against your wrist in Pompey's garden," Lucida hissed back, eyes bright gold with rage and unshed salt, taking half a furious step sideways to brush past him toward the ladder-well—

And her right calfskin heel came down square on a wet, slick gob of unhardened white slaked-lime mortar spilled three inches from the **unrailed outer edge of the pine plank fifty-six feet above the basalt cobbles**!

Her boot shot clean out from under her into empty air; gravel and wet lime rained fifty feet straight down onto a passing mule-awning below as her hip pitched outward over the abyss!

Corvus didn't think; before her cry even hit her teeth he lunged sideways across the groaning pine board, hooked his left elbow iron-tight around the rough upright fir scaffold-post until bark tore skin through his sleeve, and **locked his scarred right hand and forearm straight round Lucida's narrow waist and twisting wrist** over fifty-six feet of open Subura sky, yanking all eight and a half stone of her body crashing backward out of empty air, slamming both of them hard back against the solid, rough red masonry of her newly laid corner brick pier!

For ten wild, ragged heartbeats neither of them could draw speech.

Pinned tight from breastbone to thigh between Corvus's six-foot frame and the fresh-mortared bricks—his heart hammering like a trapped stallion's ribs straight through two thin layers of wool into her crushed breasts, his right hand still locked bruising-hard into the bare flesh of her hip under her hitched cloak while her fingers dug white-knuckled into the back of his neck where she had grabbed to keep from falling, they gasped raw October wind into each other's mouths from two inches away.

Wet white lime-dust off the fresh mortar had smeared pale across Corvus's jaw and across the corner of Lucida's parted lower lip.

Corvus looked down at the white lime on her mouth, smelled cedar-oil, warm baker's skin, and terror mixing between their bodies, felt both her thighs pressed solid and trembling against his own—and dropped his forehead half an inch until the white scar on his lip brushed the lime on hers without quite closing the kiss.

"Vespera," he breathed raggedly against her mouth, voice shaking like a fifteen-year-old boy's in river-fog, all ninety-two thousand sesterces and two rival Caelian palaces forgotten for three agonizing breaths on a windy plank. "Drop Fabia's jars, let me pay off Vedius's eighty sesterces tomorrow morning, *yes, I heard Vedius boast of your twenty denarii outside Fronto's gate a year ago!*—let me buy you clean out before, "

Against his ribs, Lucida went rigid as cold iron from heel to crown.

He had known about her eighty-sesterce monthly chain for an entire year—watching her bleed twenty silver denarii every single Kalends in silence while piling ninety thousand sesterces inside his own Caelian chest and sleeping at Tullia Crispina's seaside villa!

Humiliation hotter than scalding bath-steam burned every soft nerve out of her throat. She planted both palms flat against Corvus's chest and shoved back with every ounce of baker's wrist-strength she owned—breaking his hold now that both her boots stood safe on solid pine beside the ladder-well, wiping the white lime-smudge roughly off her own mouth with the back of her forearm until her lip glowed dark red.

"Touch Hermippus with one silver coin behind my back," Lucida said, each word quiet, clear, and final over the moan of wind through the scaffolding—"and Vedius Pollio revokes my commuted *operae* agreement the same hour, calls me in for household service to spite Senator Priscus, and breaks six hundred days of my mill-count before noon! Stay off my walls,

Lucius Cassius. Keep your ninety thousand sesterces, keep your widow, and keep your hands on your own side of the street."

She swung onto the top ashwood rung without touching his arm and went down all four ladders into the darkening Subura smoke without once looking up.

Fifty-six feet above the street, nineteen-almost-nineteen Corvus stood alone beside the fresh red brick pier until purple night swallowed the Janiculum hills, staring down at five faint white lime-marks where her fingers had gripped his dark cloak over his heart, tasting bitter white lime dry on his own scarred lip.

Chapter XVIII

The Hairpin

Seventeenth Day Before the Kalends of January, AD 159 · Lucida

"Pull the third braid half a finger tighter above the left temple, Tyrian, so my cousin **Faustina** sees I haven't grown one grey thread since autumn while she waddles round the Palatine nine months swollen like a sow before market-day."

Nineteen-year-old Lucida stood behind the carved tortoiseshell chair in **Ceionia Fabia**'s heated Caelian dressing-chamber, combing warm quince-seed mucilage smoothly through three feet of pale red-gold patrician hair before coiling the plaits into the high, scalloped crown court ladies copied off Faustina's own bronze coin-dies—while making tiny, invisible improvements at the temples so Fabia's neck looked two inches longer than the Empress-to-be's.

Outside the double-glazed *lapis specularis* windows, a raw mid-December tramontana wind rattled dry laurel hedges under iron-grey clouds heavy with snow off the Sabine peaks; tomorrow night the **Saturnalia** candles would burn again, three full winters since fifteen-year-old Lucida had stood barefoot-damp on these exact mosaic hippopotami with Fabia's gold emerald needle denting her throat over twelve silver denarii!

Tonight Lucida wore a soft plum-brown woollen *tunica* woven in Tarsus, a delicate gold chain tucked beneath her collar, and clean kidskin half-boots paid out of a workshop and bakehouse fortune already worth **twenty-eight thousand sesterces** net above her nearly retired burial-guild advance—with **six hundred fifty-five unbroken mornings** (ANNVS II · DIES CCXC) standing solid on Sura's Fish-Market slate and her new two-thousand-*modius* stone grain-vaults on the Clivus Suburanus already roofed safe under fireproof brick arches!

Only old **Dorcas** sat muttering rheumatism-prayers over jewel-clasps in the far corner; over the past fourteen months since Trajan's Baths, Fabia had learned that nineteen-year-old Lucida neither flattered, gossiped, nor flinched, and talked in front of her mirror as candidly as generals talked over camp-maps.

"Look at the double-dyed Sidonian purple on this *stola*, Lucida," Fabia said, lifting a heavy, dark blood-violet silk hem toward the tall silvered bronze mirror while Lucida stitched the coiled red-gold crown fast with fine bone needle and red wool thread, Roman hairdressers sewed court coiffures rather than trusting loose pins alone—before sliding the famous six-inch green emerald *acus* diagonally through the top knot as an ornament and a dagger. "Sixteen hundred sesterces the pound my husband Quintillus paid for it, and tonight across the citrus table **Annia Galeria Faustina** will touch her own fat pearl belly three times an hour to remind every senator in the triclinium that *her* womb drops Caesars like figs, even if half the poor little mites die in their cradles before cutting teeth—whereas *my* betrothal ring went back into Hadrian's box when I was fifteen so Mark could marry his uncle's daughter instead!"

Lucida kept her fingers deft and feather-light round the emerald pinhead, watching Fabia's pale green-brown eyes narrow inside the bronze reflection.

Everyone in Rome knew the whispered history: twenty-one years ago dying Emperor Hadrian had compelled Antoninus Pius to adopt seventeen-year-old **Marcus Annius Verus** alongside seven-year-old **Lucius Ceionius Commodus**, Fabia's little flesh-and-blood brother—binding Marcus by solemn betrothal to **Ceionia Fabia** herself so old Aelius Caesar's blood would sit beside Marcus on the Palatine! The week Hadrian's ashes went into his riverside mausoleum, mild-mannered Antoninus broke Marcus's betrothal to Fabia and married Marcus to Antoninus's own daughter **Faustina** instead, leaving proud, brilliant Fabia sidelined into marriage with Plautius Quintillus while watching clumsy-hipped, fertile Faustina wear Augusta's diadem!

"Empresses who carry ten children in twelve winters lean heavily on physicians and Stoic tutors, Domina," Lucida murmured quietly, touching a trace of crushed Syrian alkanet in sweet almond oil to Fabia's thin lips

with an ivory spatula. "Whereas a brother who enters purple in full health remembers which sister kept his friends fed while others lectured him."

Fabia's eyes met Lucida's in the polished bronze—sharp, cold, and hungry.

"You see farther through brick walls than half my husband's cousins in the Curia, girl," Fabia whispered, leaning two inches back against Lucida's hands so even deafening-ear Dorcas across the chamber heard nothing. "Do you know why Marcus summoned Quintillus and Lucius to dine quietly up on the Palatine tonight instead of waiting out at Lorium for Saturnalia? Because seventy-three-year-old **Antoninus** couldn't sit a horse from his vineyard back to the portico on Tuesday without two chamberlains lifting his knees! He makes his valet lace thin splints of dried linden-wood inside his linen undershirt every morning before audience so the foreign embassies think old Father Pius still stands straight as a spear, and **Quintus Lollius Urbicus**, Marcus's pet iron dog at the Urban Prefecture, has dropsy swelling both thighs thick as wine-jars; Asclepiades's rival told my steward Urbicus won't live to see next autumn's vintage!"

Inside Lucida's chest, her calm pulse beat one swift, silent stroke faster.

Lollius Urbicus dying before next autumn; Antoninus Pius laced upright in wooden splints at seventy-three.

If Urbicus died first and Antoninus followed within the year—right around the final months of Lucida's **thousand-and-ninety-five-day** mill run!, every court warrant, every Subura building-commission, and every patronal shield in Rome would fly into the air like chaff in a threshing-wind!

"Quintus Servilius Priscus and sour-faced Junius Rusticus think we're blind," Fabia breathed, emerald earrings flashing green fire as she stood up in full Sidonian purple *stola* so Lucida could drape the gold-hemmed *palla* across her left shoulder. "Priscus has spent all autumn using that ruthless young Sabine hound of his—the tall nineteen-year-old who broke Spurius Carvilius and shut Vedius's Trans-Tiberim dye-pipes, to strip every equestrian moneylender friendly to my brother Lucius bare before the old man dies! Let them try. The Praetorian cohorts remember whose father wore purple first, and **Cornelius Repentinus** down at the Guard Prefecture doesn't read Epictetus in bed!"

Fabia turned round, caught Lucida's chin lightly between two unwarmed, ring-heavy fingers, without the needle-point this December, with

genuine conspirator's intimacy—and dropped a thumb-sized rock-crystal scent-flagon mounted in solid gold leaf straight into Lucida's palm.

"Four hundred forty mornings left on those dusty Fish-Market millstones of yours before Trajan's statute makes you a citizen, isn't it, Lucida?" Fabia murmured. "Keep your ears open down around the Forum Piscarium and the Carinae this winter. Bring me one clear scrap of paper showing how Priscus and Rusticus plan to tie my brother Lucius's hands in the Senate when Lorium sends black riders, and the morning Lucius puts on Caesar Augustus's ring, **you won't need donkey-flour to break Publius Vedius Pollio's collar; my brother will sign your *restitutio natalium* in imperial purple ink before noon**, making you freeborn in law as if your mother had never seen a slave-ship!"

Restitutio natalium—imperial grant of simulated free birth, higher even than Trajan's freedwoman citizenship, wiping every trace of servile origin and Vedius Pollio's *ius patronatus* off the face of the earth in three strokes of Caesar's pen, **if she handed them Senator Priscus's throat—and Corvus's ruined career alongside it**!

"May the Emperor live long in health, Domina," Lucida answered in flawless, unblinking Caelian formula, bowing low over the gold-mounted rock-crystal bottle, "and may Lord Lucius's friends never lack clean oil when lamps burn late."

* * *

Stepping out through the Caelian service-postern into the first watch of the night felt like walking straight from a perfumed furnace into iron water.

While Lucida had been coiling Fabia's hair indoors, the low grey clouds off the Sabine mountains had broken into something Rome saw barely once every three or four winters: dry, silent **December snow**, sifting fine white powder down through the dark arches of Claudius's aqueduct and dusting the black basalt cobbles of the Clivus Scauri until passing mule-hooves sounded muffled as ghosts.

Wrapping her thick brown woollen outer cloak tight over Fabia's Tarsian tunic—the gold-mounted crystal bottle riding heavy as a lead plumb-weight inside her pocket, Lucida walked swiftly down the steep stepped cut between high peperino garden walls, escorted twenty paces behind by one

of her burly Marsian bakery-porters carrying a shuttered horn lantern and an oak cudgel.

Halfway down the Clivus Scauri, her path took her directly past the austere grey peperino flank of **Senator Quintus Servilius Priscus**'s mansion.

Up behind a narrow second-floor library window—the exact room where Phileros kept his cedar chests, yellow bronze lamp-light glowed warm behind mica panes against the falling snow. Moving across that lighted rectangle for two heartbeats passed a tall, broad-shouldered silhouette with black hair bent low over an unrolled scroll beside a stooped older consular figure.

Lucida did not slow a single stride on the snowy steps; within five heartbeats the high garden corner cut off the window, and she descended into the smoky, noisy glow of the Subura trough where fried-pork sellers were already hanging pine garlands for tomorrow's Saturnalia and street-urchins screamed catching melting white flakes on their tongues.

Yet when she turned through the Fish-Market arch and gave three short raps on Barba's iron-bound oak postern, the warm courtyard inside held no holiday cheer.

Sixteen-year-old **Sura** unbolted the wicket immediately, pulling Lucida and the Marsian porter inside before shooting the heavy iron bar home with both scarred hands and holding her small black slate straight up under the doorway lantern!

Across the wax-wiped slate Sura had drawn a razor-accurate plan of Lucida's newly roofed **Clivus Suburanus** grain-vaults (*Lot Fourteen*) and the leaning, worm-eaten seven-storey timber fuller's *insula* looming five feet behind its eastern rear wall—with a jagged chalk earless stick-figure drawn right across the timber building's doorway and three words underneath:

ONE-EAR BOUGHT BACK WALL TODAY · WATCHERS AT FISH-STALL

Lucida's stomach dropped cold.

"Scaeva?" Lucida asked low, pulling off her snow-dusted hood. "How do you know Scaeva took over the rear tenement instead of just collecting Hermippus's rent?"

Sura flipped the slate over, writing fast in fierce, slanted chalk strokes:

SAW HIM THROW OLD INSULARIVS OUT AT DUSK · PUT FOUR NEW CAPPADOCIANS ON TOP FLOOR WITH OIL-DRUMS · POINTED AT FELIX'S NEW BRICK ROOF

Behind them near the glowing mouth of Oven One, sixty-four-year-old **Habinnas Barba** came shuffling out of the flour-bin arch wrapped in two sheepskin vests despite the eighty-degree oven-draft, and doubled halfway over against the oak weighing-table as a long, tearing winter cough racked his barrel chest!

Lucida crossed the stone floor in three strides, steadying the old Cappadocian's flour-white elbow before his forehead struck the scale-beam. When Barba pulled his rag away from his mouth and tried clumsily to tuck it inside his belt before she saw, the unbleached linen showed dull grey-pink speckles in the cresset light—the exact rusty winter warning Corvus had coughed three Saturnalias ago, laid over forty years of volcanic stone-dust and flour-paste!

"Don't fuss round my ribs like a hen, Tyrian; cold air got down the flue when the Marsians brought oak in," Barba wheezed fiercely, waving her hand off with stubborn soldier's pride as he straightened up toward the four Reatine mules already harnessed to begin tonight's **Day Six Hundred Fifty-Six** grind. "Read what the little mute wrote! Why the Hades does Vedius Pollio's one-eared butcher put four Cappadocians and oil-drums up in a condemned timber garret five feet behind old Ulpius Felix's new stone vaults?"

Lucida stared at Sura's chalk map in the red oven-glow, every wheel inside her head turning at ice-water speed.

Why put four thugs and lamp-oil drums inside a rotten seven-storey timber tenement **already flagged for demolition** by Corvus's sixty-foot building-commission?

Either Vedius had sniffed out, or merely suspected—that old Ulpius Felix fronted for Lucida's burial-guild circle and wanted a choke-hold right against her new two-thousand-*modius* wheat reserve… **or Vedius was preparing to burn down his own condemned seven-storey timber shell in dry weather before Urbicus's crowbars razed it**, collecting neighbor-clearance rights while framing surrounding bakeries and brick-plots in the smoke!

Not tonight in wet December snow; nobody burned green Subura timber in winter damp when roofs dripped slush. Vedius planted pieces six months ahead, for July or August when Dog-Star wind turned Rome into a tinder-box!

"Move only *half* our Sicilian reserve—four hundred *modii*, never the whole thousand, into the Clivus Suburanus tufa vaults this winter," Lucida instructed Barba and Sura quietly, wiping Sura's slate clean with her sleeve so no hired kneader saw Scaeva's name, "and brick up the two small rear ventilation-slits facing that timber alley three courses thick with iron shutters tomorrow morning! Now get upstairs beside the warm smoke-flue until the third watch, Barba; I'll weigh the first forty *modii* myself while Asclepiades's boy brings you hot hyssop-oxymel."

Barba grumbled fiercely in Cappadocian Greek, yet his knees were shaking enough under his sheepskins that he let Sura steer him up the warm loft steps toward hot barley-water while the four Marsian kneaders worked their paddles at the far end of the vaulted bake-hall.

* * *

At midnight—after the Marsians had racked the first two hundred risen loaves under damp cloths and gone into the warm inner kneading-room to eat their Saturnalia-eve garlic pork round a dice-board, snow began falling thicker through the square twenty-foot skylight opening in the center of the courtyard roof, hissing faintly in tiny white stars whenever stray flakes drifted near the warm stones round Oven Two's ash-pit.

Lucida sat alone on an upturned olive-wood mortar beside the banked red brick mouth of Oven Two, knees drawn up inside her cloak, tallying year-end silver columns on wax while listening to the deep, hypnotic *grrrm-grrrm-grrrm* of her four lava mills turning steadily in the rear shed.

Six weeks had passed since Corvus caught her waist over fifty-six feet of empty air on the Clivus Suburanus scaffolding and she told him to stay on his own side of the street. Six weeks without a single basket of peaches, without a note, without glimpsing his tall dark head once across the Forum —while up on the Caelian Hill tonight **Ceionia Fabia** had practically offered her imperial freeborn status on a silver platter in exchange for driving a knife straight into Senator Priscus's back!

Outside on the silent, snow-muffled alley stones behind the bolted oak postern, knuckles rapped low against iron-studded wood:

Tap-tap. Pause. *Tap.*

Lucida's stylus froze half an inch above the wax.

Nobody inside the walls of Rome knew that signal except two people; they had tapped *two-and-one* on hollow willow trunks along the Crustumerium ditch at ten years old whenever Corvus's drunken father came home swinging his leather belt or her mother's cough brought blood.

Slowly Lucida set down her wax tablet, walked across the flour-dusted basalt flags past the thin veil of falling white snow in the middle of the yard, and slid back the narrow bronze spy-plate at eye-level in the oak gate.

Two inches outside the iron grille stood nineteen-year-old **Corvus**.

He wore neither citizen toga nor Caelian commissioner's badge, only a dark, snow-powdered coarse woollen cloak pinned with plain iron at his throat, bare-headed so fine white December flakes tangled unmelted in his thick black hair and clung to his straight dark eyebrows. No litter, no slave, no lantern; his breath misted white in the freezing alley dark, and cradled in both bare, ink-and-brick-scarred hands he held a square unbleached linen napkin steaming faintly with heat.

For three heartbeats Lucida could have slid the bronze spy-plate shut and walked back to her ledger. Every smart, armored adult instinct she had forged over thirty-eight months in Rome told her to leave the iron bar down.

Her left hand reached down and lifted the heavy iron drop-bar silently out of its stone socket instead.

Corvus stepped inside out of the snow-wind, waiting until she dropped the bar back into place before speaking—taking in the four steady lava mills rumbling safe in the rear shed, the fresh **MODII CXV** chalked ready on Sura's morning board, and nineteen-year-old Lucida standing three feet away in her plum-brown Tarsian wool with red oven-light gilding her dark braids.

"Saturnalia tomorrow," Corvus said quietly, no clever Fronto periods, plain flat Sabine speech rough with cold. "Old Diodorus from Crustumerium brought dried autumn figs down on a firewood mule at dusk and baked six in fennel-dough with honey. Smelled like your mother's pan the winter we were twelve. Thought if I left them outside the gate, the Fish-Market dogs would get them before dawn."

He held out the knotted warm linen napkin without stepping past the snow-line unless invited.

Sweet, unmistakable smell of split purple Sabine figs blistered in wild honey and crushed fennel-seed drifted out through the warm linen—sweeping away Trajan's Baths, Laurentum surf, Horrea cedar-planks, and Caelian purple in one devastating rush straight back to two skinny children licking burned fig-syrup off cold thumbs behind a clay-clamp in Sabinum.

"Bring them over by Oven Two before you drip slush into my clean salt-bins," Lucida said, turning quickly toward the glowing brick arch so the red cresset-light wouldn't catch the sudden hot sting behind her eyelids.

They sat three feet apart on two upturned wooden flour-measures beside the warm brick cheek of the sleeping twelve-foot oven, watching white snow-crystals drift lazily down out of the black Roman sky into the center of the stone yard and vanish on warm basalt ten feet from their boots.

Corvus untied the linen corners between them: six fat dark Sabine figs split open in blistered fennel-crust, still piping hot from having ridden inside his wool cloak against his chest all the way down from the Carinae.

Neither of them spoke a single patron's name, not Priscus, not Fabia, not Crispina, not Vedius, not Felix, not Urbicus. By unspoken nineteen-year-old pact, every stone beyond this courtyard wall ceased to exist until the six figs were gone.

"Burned the bottom of the third one just like your mother always did when the brushwood popped," Lucida remarked gravely after her first bite, holding up the blackened crust-bottom between stained thumb and forefinger.

A real laugh—low, startled, rust-creaking from months of disuse, broke out of Corvus's chest, lighting his deep-set grey-green eyes warm in the coal-glow as he bit cleanly through a scorching fig and winced as hot honey scalded his tongue.

"You ate four out of six that December when my father broke his ankle in the boundary-ditch and swore a crow flew through the window and stole the fourth," Corvus accused, licking sticky dark fig-honey off the crescent brick-stamp scar across his right thumb-knuckle.

"Three and a half," Lucida corrected virtuously, hugging both wool-clad knees inside her cloak while warmth spread from the sweet hot fruit and the glowing brick dome right out into her fingertips. "The crow plainly

took the half with the ants on it. How many clients' slaves are going to dump cheap clay *sigillaria* dolls on your Carinae doorstep at dawn tomorrow now that you're a terrifying Forum advocate?"

"Fourteen already tonight—all ugly little terracotta Herculeses with cross-eyes," Corvus admitted wryly, tossing a bit of dry fennel-stalk onto the glowing red ash-bed where it flared bright gold and vanished. "Saved the ugliest cross-eyed one in my pocket for Sura's shelf." He drew a tiny, lopsided three-inch painted clay gladiator out of his cloak-fold and stood it solemnly on the stone lip beside Oven Two, where it squinted fiercely across the yard like a drunken thumbsucker.

Lucida laughed aloud, soft, unguarded, clear in the snowy dark—leaning sideways to straighten the little clay gladiator's crooked shield so it wouldn't topple into the embers.

Turning her head back from the brick lip, she found Corvus no longer looking at the clay figurine.

He was sitting eighteen inches away on his upturned tub, melted snow glistening like tiny glass beads in his black hair, looking straight at her laughing mouth and throat in the red ember-light with an expression so stripped of courtroom iron, raw, starving, nineteen years old and lonely to the bone atop ninety-two thousand sesterces—that the laugh died clean out of Lucida's chest.

Slowly Corvus lifted his right hand, still warm and faintly sticky at the thumb with Sabine fig-honey—and brushed one single cold white snowflake that had blown sideways under the eaves off the dark braid resting over her left collarbone, right above the hidden olive-pip birthmark.

His scarred knuckles grazed the warm wool over her skin and stayed there, trembling once, just as they had trembled by the Janiculum tailrace at sixteen, except neither of them was sixteen now; both of them knew in their flesh what mouths and thighs did behind bolted doors when lamps burned low, and both of them knew that if Corvus leaned three inches closer across that upturned flour-tub tonight and put his scarred mouth on hers, neither Caelian palace nor twenty-eight thousand sesterces nor ninety-two thousand sesterces would keep their clothes on past three breaths!

Lucida's lips parted silently; her breath came warm and white against the back of his wrist; inside her pocket **Ceionia Fabia**'s solid-gold rock-crystal

flagon pressed cold as an icicle against her hip—reminding her what Fabia had asked her to steal from this boy's house two hours ago!

Kiss him tonight while carrying Fabia's gold poison in her pocket and hiding Scaeva's four oil-drums behind Lot Fourteen, and she turned herself into a traitor worse than locker-woman Phryne!

Very gently, before her own traitorous hands could catch his cloak-collar and drag him down onto the warm flour-sacks behind the oven, Lucida lifted two fingers, wrapped them briefly around Corvus's scarred right wrist, pressed his palm once warm and hard against her own cheek for the space of two silent heartbeats, and set his hand back down on his own knee.

"The Marsians come out of the kneading-room at the third watch horn, Corvus," she whispered, voice aching rough in the quiet, "and snow's thickening on the Carinae steps."

Corvus sat motionless for three breaths, reading everything he couldn't reach in her dark amber eyes without anger tonight—only a deep, quiet, winter grief, then nodded once, stood up to his full six feet in the red glow, and pulled his damp woollen cloak-folds together.

"Tell Barba to drink hot squill-vinegar for that rattle I heard through the floor-vents," Corvus said softly at the postern before lifting the bar, "and keep an eye on the timber garrets behind Ulpius Felix's rear alley when dry weather comes. *Io Saturnalia*, Vespera."

"*Io Saturnalia*, Sabine," Lucida whispered back.

When the heavy oak door clicked shut and she dropped the iron bar back into its socket, she stood alone watching tiny white snowflakes drift into the warm stone circle where his boots had melted two dark wet prints—leaving the cross-eyed little clay gladiator standing guard beside Oven Two while four hundred thirty-nine mornings remained between them and the storm.

PART FOUR

Dog-Star Over Subura

March, AD 160 – October, AD 160

Chapter XIX

Letters to Syria

Sixteenth Day Before the Kalends of April, Liberalia, AD 160 · Corvus

Chian mastic wax did not smell like honest Italian beeswax when held near a bronze lamp-flame; it melted pale pistachio-green and gave off a sharp, medicinal breath of crushed terebinth pine that clung to a man's cuticles long after he washed.

Inside **Senator Quintus Servilius Priscus**'s inner Caelian *tablinum* at the second watch of the night, nineteen-year-old Corvus held a pierced brass cipher-plate steady over a sheet of thin Egyptian *Augusta* papyrus while **Phileros** squinted through watering, bloodshot eyes two inches from the bronze lamp-spout, reading out numbered Greek letter-pairs from Priscus's private wax draft.

"Row Four, Column Seven: *omicron, kappa, tau, omega*," Phileros murmured hoarsely, rubbing his inflamed left eyelid with a knuckle. Forty years of shaving midnight tablets had finally begun clouding the Greek archive-master's sight since winter, which was why tonight, for the first time in three and a half years, Senator Priscus had ordered Corvus behind the bolted double cedar doors after every household slave had been locked into the lower ergastulum.

At the head of the scarred oak table sat sixty-three-year-old Priscus himself, wrapped in an unbleached woollen night-mantle against the March damp, chewing dry fennel seeds one after another while three sealed dispatches from Antioch lay open beside his elbow.

Corvus dipped his split reed cleanly into gall-and-lampblack ink and wrote the shifted Greek characters through the thirty-six rectangular slots of the brass grille without asking what the words meant—until his own

brain, fluent in every twist of Chancery Greek since seventeen, decoded the sentence underneath his moving nib whether he wished to read it or not:

To Gaius Terentius Scaurianus, Senior Tribune of the Third Gallica at Raphaneae, and Friends of the Old House beside the Orontes: Greeting. The aged vine at Lorium sheds bark daily and will scarce endure a second frost. On the night when two seals arrive from Rome—one bearing purple for both brothers out of fear of the Camp, one bearing the green terebinth ring —administer the military sacramentum of the three Syrian legions solely in the single name of Marcus Aurelius Antoninus Augustus. Grant neither corn-warrant, legionary eagle, nordonative promise to any messenger arriving in the name of Lucius Ceionius, lest Eastern armies divide what Hadrian left crooked.

Corvus's reed nib did not pause, blot, or scratch loud across the papyrus fiber; only the muscle along his jaw tightened half a millimeter in the bronze lamp-glow.

Two years ago on the Caelian he had copied boundary-suits; last summer he had torn illegal seventh-floor garrets off Subura tenements; tonight he was writing **high treason**, or supreme statecraft, depending entirely upon which Emperor wore purple forty-eight hours after old Antoninus Pius stopped breathing!

Down on the marble Palatine fifty yards west of the Forum, **Marcus Caesar** himself almost certainly knew nothing of this letter; Marcus was too scrupulous, too genuinely fond of his careless younger brother Lucius to conspire behind closed shutters against him. Instead **Priscus** and **Junius Rusticus**'s hard-eyed senatorial faction—watching **Vologases IV of Parthia** already massing heavy armored cataphracts along the Armenian border while **Cornelius Repentinus** (who owed his Praetorian Prefecture to Antoninus's concubine Lysistrata and drank wine with Lucius's sporting friends!) commanded twelve cohorts of Praetorian swords inside Rome, were building an iron wall across the Eastern legions ahead of time so that even if the Praetorian Guard forced Marcus to share titles at home, **not one single Syrian legion** would obey Lucius Commodus's seal!

"Last line," Phileros whispered, sliding the wax draft an inch closer to the flame. "*Burn the outer cover; keep the inner leaf against comparison of rings. Vale.*"

Corvus lifted the pierced brass grille off the papyrus, blew lightly across the wet Greek letters rather than dusting sand that might smudge the fine strokes, and transcribed a **duplicate check-copy** onto a razor-thin leaf of shaved lime-wood bark (*philyra*)—standard Roman intelligence practice when sending couriers across the sea to Seleucia Pieria, so that when an answer returned six months later, its numeric key could be verified word for word against the sender's retained copy.

Priscus reached out with blue-veined fingers, took the bronze signet carved with a tiny fruiting terebinth tree off a chain beneath his tunic, not his public Servilius family ring, a private factional seal—held a stick of pale green Chian mastic wax into the lamp-flame until sweet pine-resin smoked, and pressed the terebinth deep into the green pool sealing the Antioch papyrus.

Then Priscus did not lock the thin lime-bark duplicate inside his own iron-bound cedar *armarium* behind the consular masks.

Instead he folded the bark leaf inside a flat oilskin wallet sealed at one corner with a second drop of pale green mastic, and pushed it straight across the oak table into Corvus's scarred right hand.

"Lock that inside your private strongbox at the Temple of Castor tomorrow morning alongside your own deposit-tablets, Lucius Cassius," Priscus said quietly.

Corvus looked up from the green-sealed oilskin into his patron's slate-grey eyes. Even Phileros blinked once in the dimness; Phileros's own box had held every secret of the Servilius house for thirty years.

"If Lollius Urbicus dies of this dropsy before midsummer," Priscus explained without emotion, as though discussing storage of winter turnips, "Cornelius Repentinus and **Ceionia Fabia**'s Caelian friends will spend three months hunting excuses to put urban search-warrants through my *tablinum* and Rusticus's Tusculan library while old Antoninus naps at Lorium. Nobody searches the Castor strongbox of a nineteen-year-old equestrian pleader from Sabinum whose name sits on maritime bottomry suits. Keep that bark leaf dry until the night Lorium sends black riders; bring it back to my hand unbroken when Marcus enters the Curia, and I will add **fifty thousand sesterces** out of my Tusculan timber-sales toward your equestrian census the morning you put on the narrow stripe."

Fifty thousand sesterces, on top of the **one hundred sixty-two thousand sesterces** Corvus already held clear at Castor after winter settlements! Two hundred twelve thousand in sight before twenty, past the halfway mark to the immortal four-hundred-thousand-sesterce line where no magistrate's iron spike could ever touch his wrists!

And inside the same oilskin wallet rode enough green-waxed Greek explosive to send Quintus Servilius Priscus—and nineteen-year-old Lucius Cassius Corvus beside him, straight down the Gemonian Steps with iron hooks in their throats if Lucius Ceionius Commodus ever read five words of it.

"It won't see daylight until you ask for it, Senator," Corvus said evenly, sliding the thin oilskin packet inside the secret inner leather lining of his dispatch-satchel.

* * *

From the Caelian ridge Corvus walked north across the dark saddle of the Subura—kept clear of cutthroats for him now by his own height, heavy oak walking-staff, and the fact that half the *vigiles* patrols between the Carinae and Viminal saluted Urban Commissioner Cassius on sight, climbing the steep paved ramp up onto the **Quirinal Hill** where **Tullia Crispina** kept her town *domus* through the spring court-term.

It was past the third watch horn; frost-rimed March stars glittered sharp above the marble roof of Quirinus's temple, and Corvus's mind was still humming cold and tight from the Antioch cipher-sheet riding against his ribs. Crispina's steward had sent a runner at dusk asking him to stop by however late to witness the renewed spring Alexandria bottomry powers before her Puteoli factor rode south at cockcrow.

Inside Crispina's warm, myrrh-scented atrium, the sleepy night-porter knew Corvus so well after twelve months that he merely nodded toward the lighted rear *cenatio* without rising off his stool to announce him.

Walking noiselessly in damp leather soles down the carpeted mosaic corridor toward the half-drawn crimson silk *velum* closing off the small winter dining-room, Corvus heard two lazy male voices laughing over dice-cups inside—Crispina's spendthrift equestrian cousins **Sextus Tullius** and **Numerius Balbus**, up from Baiae for next week's Quinquatria gladiator

shows, and halted half a pace outside the curtain fold to wait until servants cleared their cups rather than walking in uninvited with street-mud on his cloak.

"Sixty-four thousand clear profit off three Alexandria hulls since September, Crispina!" Numerius Balbus was crowing thickly over the clink of silver ladles. "Everybody at the Baiae baths swears that fierce young Sabine *cognitor* you dug out of Priscus's kennel has teeth like a moray eel! Tell the truth among cousins now—he's nineteen, broad in the loins as a Samnite murmillo, already past a hundred and fifty thousand sesterces on his own slate, and living in your pocket four nights a month. Don't tell us you mean to top up his four hundred thousand next year and marry a country surveyor's boy!"

Outside in the dark mosaic passage, Corvus stood completely motionless, right hand resting still on the leather strap of his satchel.

Inside the warm crimson curtain **Tullia Crispina** laughed, that low, smoky, musical Campanian laugh Corvus knew against his own throat in the dark at Laurentum—followed by the soft chime of her six green blown-glass bracelets as she set down her wine-cup.

"Marry a Crustumina ditch-surveyor's orphan whose fingernails still smell faintly of Subura brick-lime when it rains?" Crispina purred in amused, affectionate derision, as a woman praised a favorite mastiff to dinner-guests. "Have another cup of Falernian before your wits curdle, Numerius! One doesn't put a marriage-contract around a hungry plebeian hound, marriage gives a man half the keys to the Puteoli warehouses and airs at my father's table! No: you toss a clever nineteen-year-old boy twenty-five-percent bones off the disputed charters so he tears your enemies' factors to bloody ribbons, let him warm the couch when winter wind blows cold off the sea, and persuade him next month to lock his hundred and sixty thousand sesterces inside Senator Priscus's ten-year Tusculan land-syndicate where he can't draw it out without our signatures! That way even when he buys his pretty little gold ring at twenty-two, he stays neatly on the leash carrying *our* scroll-boxes!"

Both Baian cousins roared delighted approval; ivory dice rattled across citrus-wood; chairs scraped back as slaves brought torches to light the two drunken equestrians out through the side garden postern toward their litters.

Corvus did not step back down the hall, did not clench his jaw, and did not let a single breath quicken inside his chest.

Standing in the shadow behind a marble bust of Crispina's Puteoli grandfather while the garden postern clanged shut behind her cousins, nineteen-year-old Corvus felt no heartbreak at all—because heartbreak belonged to boys who had brought their hearts into the room, and Corvus had left his heart down beside a snowy Fish-Market oven eating burned Sabine figs three months ago.

What filled Corvus's veins instead was pure, glacial, razor-edged clarity.

Lock his hundred and sixty thousand inside Priscus's ten-year land-syndicate so even with a gold ring he stays neatly on the leash.

All of them, austere Stoic **Quintus Servilius Priscus** handing him treasonous Syrian green-wax letters worth fifty thousand sesterces, sleek Campanian **Tullia Crispina** opening her thighs and counting-house at twenty-five percent, kindly moralizing **Junius Rusticus** looking sorrowfully at his sandals—every single man and woman above the four-hundred-thousand-sesterce wall saw nineteen-year-old **Lucius Cassius Corvus** as a useful iron tool to pry open dirty locks while keeping their own ringed hands clean!

Very well. Tools made of Noric iron had no obligation to warn soft thumbs before cutting backward.

Corvus walked calmly forward, parted the crimson silk *velum* with two steady fingers, and stepped into the warm lamp-lit *cenatio*.

* * *

Tullia Crispina reclined alone on the wide purple-draped dining *lectus* in a loose saffron-yellow evening tunic pinned at one bare white shoulder with cameo gold, picking candied Damascus plums out of a silver shell. Seeing Corvus step out of the passage tall and dry-eyed, she smiled warmly, without the faintest suspicion that he had arrived ninety breaths before her cousins' torches cleared the garden, and patted the cushioned place beside her hip.

"There comes my tireless night-owl!" Crispina murmured, holding out the waxed spring Alexandria power-of-attorney roll from the side-table. "You missed my tedious cousin Numerius by three breaths—Jupiter be praised, two hours of Baian horse-gossip gave me a temple-ache. Sign the

four Ostian charter-warrants while the wax is soft, darling, and then come drink half a cup of warm spiced Setine; Senator Priscus's steward sent word today about a marvellous ten-year Tusculan land-trust where you and I can pool two hundred thousand sesterces at eight percent starting in April!"

Corvus walked unhurriedly to the citrus-wood table, set his leather dispatch-satchel, with Priscus's green-sealed Syrian bark-leaf locked safely inside—down beside the bronze lamp-stand, read every single Latin word of the four spring Alexandria maritime warrants twice to make sure no hidden tie-in clauses sat buried in the boilerplate, signed *L · CASSIVS · C · F · CRVST · CORVVS* in crisp black ink, and stamped his bronze crow-and-plumbline ring.

"My hundred and sixty-two thousand stays in coined silver and short thirty-day Ostian grain-bills inside Castor's vault through next spring, Domina," Corvus said pleasantly, wiping his nib clean on a linen rag without looking up. "Ten-year Tusculan dirt moves too slowly when port defaults pay quadruple."

Crispina's dark painted brows drew together half a millimeter, unused to having soft pillow-baits declined quite so briskly—then smoothed out as she slid barefoot off the couch, green glass bracelets chiming along her wrists, and came up behind his shoulder, sliding both lemon-verbena-scented palms flat down the front of his coarse woollen tunic from chest to groin.

"Always counting thirty-day hulls, little crow," she whispered against the side of his neck, kissing the hard tendon below his ear while her fingers unfastened his leather belt-buckle with practiced ease. "Put the pen down before you turn into Phileros at twenty. Leave your cloak, stay till cockcrow."

Corvus turned smoothly inside the circle of her arms and looked down four inches into her dark, self-satisfied Campanian eyes.

Twelve months ago on the stormy Laurentine shore he had entered her couch half-grateful, half-dazzled that an equestrian woman worth two million sesterces wanted his eighteen-year-old country hands on her skin.

Tonight he caught the single cameo gold pin at her right shoulder between his scarred thumb and forefinger, snapped the clasp open so the saffron silk dropped straight to her ankles around her bare feet, and backed

her two steps flat against the high cushioned head-rest of the purple dining-couch without kissing her lips once.

Crispina gasped—part surprise at the sudden silent force in his wrists, part sharp dark excitement, as Corvus shoved his own tunic up off his shoulders, kicked the fallen silk clear, and bent her forward over the piled embroidered cushions right beside the silver plum-dishes instead of lying beneath her as she liked to direct!

"Lucius—" she started breathlessly, twisting her dark head halfway back over her bare white shoulder with an uncertain laugh as his wide, calloused left palm planted flat between her shoulder-blades holding her chest down into the purple silk while his right hand parted her oiled thighs from behind,

And broke off into a sharp, ragged cry into the bolster as he drove straight inside her to the hilt in one hard, unsparing stroke!

No boyish haste tonight, and not one grain of tenderness: nineteen-year-old Corvus held both white curves of her equestrian hips locked inside bricklayer's hands that didn't bruise and couldn't be shaken loose, setting a relentless, deep, measured pace that made the bronze lamps tremble in their chains and the six green glass bracelets slide clashing up and down Crispina's outstretched wrists as she clutched the carved tortoiseshell couch-head! Every patronizing word he had just heard through crimson silk—*subura brick-lime, hungry plebeian hound, scraps under the couch*, burned cold and silent behind his unblinking grey-green eyes without ever once making him lose control or raise his voice; he reached round under her belly with his scarred right thumb, working her slick swollen flesh with surgical, pitiless precision while driving deep from behind until Crispina lost every ounce of smooth Campanian poise—sobbing broken Puteoli Greek filth into the crushed purple cushions, nails tearing threads out of her own expensive cushion as two violent, convulsive shudders wrenched through her thighs before Corvus buried himself one final crushing stroke deep, jaw locked silent without a groan, spending hot inside her while staring straight over her bent bare spine at his own leather satchel by the lamp.

When he stepped back off the couch ten breaths later and pulled his rough grey woollen tunic cleanly back down over his shoulders, Crispina lay sprawled sideways across the rumpled purple silk catching her breath, cheeks flushed dark crimson, heavy hair tangled wild across her damp

mouth, looking up at him through half-dazed dark lashes with the first trace of genuine wariness she had ever shown him.

"Where are you going at the fourth watch?" she asked huskily, pushing wet hair off her forehead with a trembling braceleted wrist as Corvus buckled his belt and slung his satchel across his chest. "The rain's starting outside."

Corvus reached into his belt-pouch, drew out the heavy bronze Laconian latch-key to her Quirinal garden postern that she had given him last autumn so he could come and go without waking porters, and set it down with a quiet metallic *chink* squarely in the middle of her silver plum-tray.

"My Ostian factor-clerks open the Porticus Minucia rolls at first dawn, Domina," Corvus said, his voice courteous, calm, and thirty miles away. "Have your steward send April's twenty-five-percent settlement tally round to my Carinae office by notary; my docket is full until summer."

Crispina stared from the bronze garden-key gleaming among the sticky plum-stones up into his flat grey-green eyes—understanding in one silent flash, as a sharp Puteoli merchant's daughter always understood a closed ledger, that whatever nineteen-year-old boy had walked down to Laurentum last spring would never cross her bedroom threshold again.

"Be careful how high you fly on wax wings, Lucius Cassius," Crispina said coldly, pulling a purple coverlet up across her bare breasts. "Rome melts clever boys faster than sea-sun."

"Not wax, Domina," Corvus said from the doorway, bowing two exact inches before letting the crimson curtain fall between them. "Brick."

Out in the freezing fourth-watch drizzle before dawn, Corvus did not turn up toward his Carinae room. He walked all the way down the slick basalt steps of the Quirinal until he stood alone beneath the towering grey *pietra gabina* vault of the **Arch of the Firewall** separating Augustus's gleaming marble Forum from the sleeping black canyon of the Subura, the exact stone arch where he and fifteen-year-old Lucida had ducked behind the severed head of the October Horse three and a half years ago.

Half a mile south through the thin cold rain, white wood-smoke was already rising steady and fragrant from **Habinnas Barba**'s and **Lucida**'s two brick oven-flues—Day Seven Hundred Forty-Seven of her thousand and ninety-five, grinding clean wheat in the dark without asking any senator, widow, or emperor for breath.

Touching the pale green Chian mastic seal hidden inside his satchel with fingers that smelled faintly of terebinth resin and rain, nineteen-year-old Corvus turned away from Crispina's hill toward the Forum vaults, counting the two hundred thirty-eight thousand sesterces still standing between his hands and the day he broke every chain in Rome.

Chapter XX

The Vinegar-Men

Thirteenth Day Before the Kalends of July, AD 160 · Lucida

Every barracks of the **Vigiles** in Rome smelled from fifty paces down the street like a pickled-cabbage cellar that had married an ironworks.

Standing inside the arched travertine courtyard of the **Fourth Cohort's Subura Excubitorium** in blazing mid-June glare, nineteen-year-old Lucida watched twelve bare-chested freedmen fire-troopers (*siphonarii* and *centonarii*) haul thick, coarse patchwork woollen blankets out of stone vats of sour Campanian vinegar (*acetum*) with wooden tongs, hanging them dripping brown across pine racks before tonight's first patrol.

Plain aqueduct water boiled into useless steam when thrown onto burning olive-oil cellars or pitch-tarred Subura roof-shingles; heavy woollen *centones* soaked sodden in sour vinegar smothered flaming grease dead on contact without exploding sparks up the stairwells. Beside the vinegar-vats stood two wheeled bronze **Ctesibian double-piston force-pumps** (*siphones*), their greased leather valves hissing *chuff-chuff* as four pump-men tested the swiveling brass gooseneck nozzle by shooting a solid thumb-thick jet of water thirty feet up onto a brick practice-tower; and racked along the shady east wall like siege-weapons for a barbarian town rested forty **twenty-foot ashwood demolition-poles** shod in terrible curved iron hooks (*hami*) and wall-sickles (*falces*).

Centurion **Gaius Arrius Aper**—forty-six, missing two fingers off his left hand from a fallen burning beam in Hadrian's last year, himself a former Junian Latin who had won his Roman citizenship the hard male way by six years of hauling water-buckets before rising twenty ranks to carry the centurion's vine-rod, counted Lucida's **twenty bright silver denarii** into his bronze helmet-liner with brisk, unsentimental respect.

"Eighty sesterces buys clean axle-grease on Carts Three and Four all through July and August, Mistress Lucida," Arrius Aper grunted, tucking the silver into his belt-purse and walking her three paces into the shade beside the racked iron wall-hooks. "I checked your old baker Ulpius Felix's new four-storey brick warehouse on the Clivus Suburanus myself on Tuesday night. Twenty-four-inch *opus testaceum* piers, vaulted tufa cellars, iron shutters on the rear alley slits: honest masonry. If every greedy landlord in Region IV built like that instead of stacking seven storeys of dry pine matchwood on mud-brick stilts, my boys would sleep six hours a night."

"It isn't my own brick arches catching fire first that keeps me awake, Centurion," Lucida said quietly, touching one finger to the cold, sharpened iron point of a twenty-foot *falx* demolition-hook. "Five feet across our eastern rear drip-alley stands a leaning seven-storey timber fuller's block whose top garrets have four Cappadocian caretakers storing unsealed lamp-oil jars right against rotten lath. Suppose a wind blows west off the Esquiline one dry night in August and that seven-storey pine torch goes up?"

Arrius Aper stopped smiling. He glanced once across the sunny yard to make sure his junior *optio*—a slick Greek-speaking clerk near the water-trough, was out of earshot, then looked squarely back at nineteen-year-old Lucida.

"You grew up thin enough to know how Rome burns, girl, so I won't feed you nursery porridge," the scarred fire-centurion said low. "When a seven-storey timber *insula* catches in August wind, four bronze *siphones* and all the sour vinegar in Campania won't save one stick of it; flames jump ten-foot streets faster than a horse runs. What the Cohort *does* inside three hundred breaths of arriving is **pull down everything standing twenty paces downwind with these iron hooks and ballista-chains** to starve the fire before it eats Augustus's marble!"

Cold certainty slid down Lucida's spine. "And who chooses *which* neighbor's wall gets pulled flat into rubble first when smoke blinds the lane?"

"On my watch, wind and stone decide," Aper answered grimly. "On the third watch of alternate nights when *Optio* **Gaius Nymphidius** commands the forward hook-party—and Nymphidius drinks free Chian wine twice a week with **Hermippus's** rent-collectors down by the Sandaliarius, I've seen hook-crews spend half an hour 'clearing' a stout two-storey brick shop

whose owner refused to sell his lease, while letting a crooked syndicate's empty timber shell burn clean to the ground so the landlord clears forty tenants overnight without paying one brass *as* in eviction lawsuits! Keep twenty barrels of sour vinegar and four iron crowbars inside your own Fish-Market and Clivus Suburanus cellars from the Kalends of July onward, girl —and if bells ring after midnight on an odd-numbered watch, send a fast runner straight to *my* quarters behind the Viminal gate before Nymphidius gets hooks into your mortar."

"Send your runner a fat roasted kid every Kalends through October, Centurion, and count another twenty denarii if my brick stands whole at November rains," Lucida said cleanly.

Walking down off the Viminal slope toward the Fish-Market, where Sura's morning slate today read **ANNVS III · DIES CXI** (Day 841 of 1,095, **only two hundred fifty-four mornings left** until full Quiritary Roman citizenship shattered Publius Vedius Pollio's leash forever!)—Lucida turned Centurion Aper's warning over and over in her head.

Scaeva's oil-jars in the condemned seventh-floor garret behind Lot Fourteen; Nymphidius drinking Hermippus's wine; and August's Dog-Star wind six weeks away.

Before dusk, however, a perfumed Quirinal footman in purple-trimmed livery arrived at Berenice's old Argiletum counter bearing a polite wax tablet stamped with a red carnelian four-horse chariot, inviting *"Lucida, purveyor of Syrian and Corycian unguents to the Caelian houses,"* at twelve silver denarii show-fee to bring her finest alabaster sample-casket up to the *Domus Volusenia* on the Quirinal Hill at the second hour of the night, ostensibly to display summer scents before **Aulus Volusenus Niger**'s visiting Campanian aunts!

Lucida held that red carnelian *quadriga* wax impression up to the afternoon light for three slow breaths.

She had never seen **Aulus Volusenus Niger**'s face close up; yet she remembered November three and a half years ago like hot iron—fifteen-year-old Corvus climbing Berenice's dark stair spitting blood through a split left lip after Senator Priscus's arrogant patrician nephew drove an ivory stylus into his mouth at Festus's rhetoric school, and Dorcas mentioning only last month on the Caelian that young Volusenus had lost eighty

thousand sesterces on Blue chariots this spring and been seen creeping out of **Hermippus's** private moneylending office at dusk!

Walk past a patrician's sealed twelve-denarius summons without checking what game Hermippus's newest debtor was playing? Never. Only a fool walked blind, and only a coward stayed home; instead Lucida left her rarest vials locked at the bakehouse, packed six legitimate commercial sample-pots inside an iron-cornered cedar casket, dressed not in humble shop-brown, in **rich, unadorned deep-saffron Coan linen beneath an immaculate ivory woollen *palla*** that made her look more like a Syrian tetrarch's daughter than any fuller's girl, and took two six-foot Marsian kneaders armed with legal oak carrying-poles right up to Volusenus's Quirinal torch-gate.

* * *

There was not one Campanian aunt or respectable Roman matron inside the **Domus Volusenia** tonight.

Even before Volusenus's smirk-faced Greek *atriensis* led Lucida down the colonnade (ordering her two burly Marsian porters to wait by the outer vestibule fountain, where Lucida quietly signaled them to keep one heavy boot wedged inside the inner door-bolt!), the roar of drunken male laughter, shrill Phrygian double-flutes, and rattling ivory dice rolling out of the garden *triclinium* told the whole story.

Inside a high, frescoed summer banquet-room lit by forty smoking bronze candelabrum-branches, nine couches arranged in three hollow sides around flooded mosaic fish-patterns held twenty-odd flushed young senatorial sons and equestrian advocates reclining on rose-strewn silk with myrtle wreaths askew over sweating brows. Half-naked Gaditane castanet-girls in transparent yellow gauze sat perched along the lower couch-hems pouring unwatered Setine wine into shallow glass bowls.

Up on the host's *lectus imus* lounged twenty-two-year-old **Aulus Volusenus Niger**, plumper in the jowls than at seventeen, cinnamon beard-oil shining wet under his wreath, twisting his red carnelian chariot-ring incessantly around a puffy finger.

And three couches left along the *lectus medius*, reclining upright on one lean elbow in a crisp white dinner-*synthesis* among three junior Forum

pleaders, an untouched cup of watered wine held loosely in his scarred right hand, visibly hating every drunken giggle in the room and present solely because Senator Priscus had ordered him not to snub his nephew's reconciliation supper!—sat nineteen-year-old **Lucius Cassius Corvus**.

Corvus had not known she was coming.

The instant Volusenus's steward pulled back the embroidered curtain and nineteen-year-old **Lucida** stepped onto the threshold in deep saffron linen and ivory wool carrying her cedar sample-casket, **Corvus's entire six-foot body locked rigid as carved basalt** on the middle couch.

Up on the host's cushions Volusenus Niger clapped both ringed hands loud enough to silence the Phrygian flute-player, rising half onto his knees with a wet, triumphant grin aimed straight across the mosaic at Corvus!

"Friends! Fellow ornaments of the Centumviral Spear!" Volusenus bellowed thickly across the room, sweeping his wine-cup toward Lucida in the doorway. "My learned colleague **Lucius Cassius** sits over there drinking plain cistern-water tonight as if Cato died this morning, forgetting where he learned such charming street-Latin! Since I hate seeing a rising man grow homesick for Subura mud, my steward tracked down his very own childhood alley-mate from the fuller's piss-vats, **Lucida of the Fish-Market**, come all the way uphill with twelve denarii worth of grease-pots! Step into the middle, sweetheart, take that heavy wool off your shoulders, and rub some Syrian spikenard onto our ankles while you tell the couches what old ditch-friends charge after midnight!"

Drunken laughter started along two of the upper couches—and died halfway in five throats as four perceptive junior advocates glanced sideways at **Corvus**.

Corvus had not stood up yet, and had not uttered a syllable.

Resting against the white linen table-napkin on his couch-edge, Corvus's scarred right hand had closed slowly, convulsively tighter around the thin blown-glass Sidonian drinking-cup he held until, with a tiny, razor-sharp *crick* audible three couches off—**the delicate glass bowl collapsed inward into twenty jagged splinters inside his bare fist**.

Dark red wine and bright arterial crimson ran together between Corvus's knuckles onto the white napkin; Corvus didn't even blink at his cut palm, already shifting his right heel onto the mosaic floor to rise and tear Aulus Volusenus Niger's windpipe out across his own ancestors' table,

which under Roman law meant *vis atrox* against a senator's nephew inside his own *domus*, instant ruin before tomorrow noon!

Lucida beat Corvus by half a breath.

Before Corvus's sandal took weight, nineteen-year-old Lucida stepped calmly forward onto the central mosaic fish-medallion—never touching the clasp of her ivory *palla*, standing tall and utterly unhurried beneath forty bronze flames, and looked straight past Volusenus's flushed face first **for one single fraction of a second into Corvus's blazing grey-green eyes**, giving him the tiniest, fiercest downward flick of two eyelashes:

Sit still. Watch me gut this pig without staining your toga.

Corvus caught the signal; with superhuman effort his boot paused flat on the stone, his bleeding right hand wrapping silently inside his white linen table-napkin out of sight while his jaw stayed locked white as bone.

Lucida turned her calm, luminous amber gaze onto **Aulus Volusenus Niger** on the host's couch and smiled—the exact thin-lipped, bone-chilling Caelian smile she had watched **Ceionia Fabia** turn on trembling chamberlains.

"My steepest apologies to your couch, Aulus Volusenus," Lucida said, her clear, unhurried contralto carrying into every corner of the hushed *triclinium* in Palatine Latin cleaner than half the drunken knights in the room spoke. "Your steward's tablet named your worthy Campanian aunts; had he mentioned you needed cheap ankle-grease for Gaditane tavern-dancers, I would have sent old Sticho's fuller-boy instead of bringing **the exact Corycian saffron and white-almond caskets Lady Ceionia Fabia and Praetor Aufidius's wife ordered mixed for next week's Palatine supper**."

Along the upper couch, young **Aufidius Minor**—cousin to Praetor Aufidius, sat straight up out of his slouch, blinking hard at the striking saffron-robed young woman as Ceionia Fabia's name hit the mosaic!

Volusenus's wet grin slipped half an inch sideways. "Ceionia Fabia's back-stairs peddler still kneels when—"

"Oh, I never kneel outside temples, worthy host," Lucida interrupted smoothly, setting her cedar casket down on a marble tripod with a crisp snap and opening the lid just long enough for twenty pairs of rich male eyes to glimpse six rock-crystal flasks stoppered in gold leaf, "especially on floors whose mosaic mortar looks damp with heavy mortgages! Though since

you kindly mentioned the Argiletum and Sandaliarius alleys, **Hermippus**, chief steward to Publius Vedius Pollio—asked across our grain-street only yesterday whether any Quirinal gentlemen knew when a certain **eighty-thousand-sesterce Blue chariot note stamped with a red carnelian *quadriga*** would pay its June interest before going up on the Basilica steps! Shall I tell Hermippus's clerk tomorrow morning that your silver went into Setine wine tonight, or would Praetor Aufidius's cousin like to smell real Cilician crocus before I take Lady Fabia's casket home?"

Total, suffocating silence dropped over all nine couches.

Not a single guest in that room had known until five heartbeats ago that Senator Priscus's own patrician heir **Aulus Volusenus Niger** was eighty thousand sesterces deep in secret gambling paper to his uncle's mortal enemy **Vedius Pollio**!

Volusenus went the exact greenish-white color of rancid mutton-tallow beneath his cinnamon beard-oil, his left hand jerking instinctively inside his dinner-robe to hide the red carnelian *quadriga* ring on his finger, confirming every syllable to twenty pairs of razor-sharp Roman gossip-ears at once!

Down on Couch One, delighted **Aufidius Minor** burst into a loud, malicious bark of patrician laughter, tossing four gold *aurei* (400 HS!) ringing onto Lucida's cedar tripod!

"Send two flasks of that Corycian saffron round to my mother's house on the Carinae tomorrow noon, Mistress Lucida—and charge my cousin Aulus twelve denarii extra for teaching his table manners!" Aufidius crowed, while a second young quaestor beside him tossed **two more gold *aurei*** onto the tray for his bride's dressing-table!

Lucida swept all six gold pieces, plus Volusenus's advance twelve silver denarii already in her steward's receipt—smoothly into her belt-purse, closed the cedar casket with two unhurried brass latches, inclined her head graciously to Aufidius and the silent couches without glancing once more at paralyzed, humiliated Volusenus, and walked unhurriedly out through the embroidered curtain.

* * *

Out in the dark, laurel-scented Quirinal peristyle on her way toward the street-vestibule where her two Marsian porters waited with oak poles ready,

swift footsteps crossed the travertine flags behind her before she reached the colonnade turn.

"Vespera, wait."

Nineteen-year-old Corvus stepped between two moonlit fluted columns ahead of her, his white dinner-*synthesis* gleaming pale in the June dark, his right hand wrapped tight inside a blood-soaked white table-napkin through which fresh dark crimson was already seeping across his knuckles.

Lucida stopped dead, eyes dropping instantly from his pale, furious face straight down to that blood-soaked linen around his scarred right hand!

Without thinking—all evening sophistication vanishing in one heartbeat of visceral childhood reflex, she set her cedar casket down on the column-stylobate, caught his left wrist to pull his wrapped right hand into the patch of moonlight, and unwrapped the bloody napkin with quick, practiced fingers.

Three sharp quarter-inch cuts crossed the heel of his palm and the meat below his scarred thumb; one tiny triangular sliver of clear Sidonian glass still stood wedged bright in the skin above his lifeline.

"Idiot Sabine," Lucida breathed fiercely under her breath, gripping his thick wrist steady against her hip while pinching the glass sliver cleanly out between two fingernails before pressing a clean folded linen square from her own sample-casket hard over the bleeding cuts and binding it tight round his hand. "Breaking twenty-denarius Sidonian glass in your bare fist because a fat debtor with cinnamon grease in his curls barked my name! Three heartbeats slower and you would have jumped across that fish-mosaic at his throat and handed your own career to Lollius Urbicus's lictors on a dish!"

Corvus didn't flinch once as her thumb pressed hard into the bleeding cuts; staring down at the dark crown of her braided head bent close over his hand in the warm June night-scent of bruised laurel and saffron linen, his left hand came up half an inch toward her bare neck—then dropped back to his side, clenched tight.

"How did you know Volusenus owed Hermippus eighty thousand on a red carnelian note?" Corvus asked very quietly over her bent head.

Lucida finished tucking the linen knot snug under his scarred right thumb and lifted her eyes two inches from his chest straight up into his face.

"The same way you know whose straw-men own the Sandaliarius," she answered evenly. "By counting every coin moving down my street

before somebody uses it to burn my roof. Listen to me, Corvus, forget your cousin's bruised vanity for ten breaths and hear something real: this afternoon Centurion Arrius Aper at the Fourth Cohort of *Vigiles* warned me that Hermippus has bribed *Optio* Nymphidius on the odd-night demolition hook-crews, and Scaeva still has four men keeping oil-jars in that condemned seven-storey timber garret directly behind Ulpius Felix's new brick grain-vaults! Why hasn't your building-commission torn down those upper two timber storeys yet?"

Corvus's jaw set hard in the moonlight. "Because two days ago **Lollius Urbicus** collapsed on his tribunal with black dropsy in both lungs—he hasn't signed a single demolition warrant since the Ides, and until Antoninus names an acting Prefect or Urbicus wakes up, every contested sixty-foot raze order on Vedius Pollio's Subura blocks stands frozen in Chancery!"

Both nineteen-year-olds stared at each other in the warm, dry June night air, already eighty degrees at midnight, not a drop of rain since the Kalends of May, forty thousand wagon-loads of dry Subura pine baking brittle overhead while Lollius Urbicus lay dying and Scaeva's oil-jars sat untouched behind her wall!

"Two hundred fifty-four mornings left on my Fish-Market stones," Lucida whispered. "Keep your Carinae shutters barred when Dog-Star wind blows next month, Sabine."

"Move Sura and your night-ledgers out of that Clivus Suburanus vault-house back to solid stone until Urbicus recovers—or let me put four Caelian watchmen in your alley tomorrow," Corvus urged low, catching her elbow with his unbandaged left hand as she picked up her cedar casket.

Lucida looked down at his fingers on her saffron sleeve, then up at the fresh red blood soaking dark through her own white linen bandage round his right palm, proof that even across three couches and two rival worlds he would still shatter glass in his bare flesh at an insult to her name, even while carrying secrets inside his Caelian box that could bury everything she knew.

"My Marsians carry stout oak, Lucius Cassius, and nobody guards my alleys for me," she said softly, slipping her elbow free without anger—almost gently, before stepping out toward the torch-gate. "Put turpentine-salve on that palm before morning so your stylus-hand doesn't stiffen. You're going to need it."

Chapter XXI

Red Wind in August

Nineteenth Day Before the Kalends of September, AD 160 · Corvus

Forty-one days without rain had baked the clay roof-tiles of Rome hot enough by noon to blister a pigeon's claws, and at the third watch of an August night when the hot southern *Auster* blew dry dust all the way from Libya, the brass fire-bells along the Carinae began clanging all at once.

Corvus did not wake to the bells; he was already sitting shirtless at his open third-floor Carinae window in the stifling dark, squinting by a single tallow dip over municipal archive sheets while warm wind rattled dry papyrus corners like locust wings.

First came a low, greasy orange smear blooming behind the black pantile ridge of the lower **Clivus Suburanus** three hundred yards north.

Forty breaths later—too fast, ten times too fast for an accidental overturned kitchen-brazier or cobbler's lamp!, a solid **seventy-foot column of roaring white-and-scarlet oil-flame** tore clean through the seventh-floor roof-shingles of the condemned timber fuller's *insula* directly behind **Marcus Ulpius Felix**'s—behind **Lucida**'s, new four-storey brick grain-vaults!

Superheated Spanish lamp-oil drums bursting high under dry pine rafters sent blazing golden gouts arching thirty feet sideways across the narrow drip-alley on the back of the howling southern wind; instantly the terrifying nocturnal chorus of a Subura conflagration split the dark from hill to hill: brass *vigiles* bugles (*buccinae*) blaring alarm from the Viminal barracks, dogs howling frantic in locked yards, mothers screaming children's names down pitch-black wooden staircases already filling with suffocating pine-smoke, and the sharp *crack-crack-BOOM* of sun-dried terracotta roof-pantiles exploding off burning oak purlins like legionary sling-stones!

Corvus dragged on rough grey woollen tunic and thick hobnailed boots in ten heartbeats, snatched two items off his oak table—his stamped bronze **Urban Prefecture Building-Commission tessera** (still valid under the temporary seal of the urban *vicarius* three weeks after old Lollius Urbicus died of dropsy in July!) and a three-foot solid Noric iron pry-bar, soaked his coarse winter woollen cloak dripping wet inside his room's clay water-amphora, tied a wet linen rag tight across his nose and scarred mouth, and bolted down the dark Carinae steps four treads at a leap.

Halfway down the stepped cut into the Subura canyon, the street ceased to be a road and became a panicking cattle-chute.

Hundreds of half-naked shoemakers, weavers, prostitutes, and smoky-faced children poured uphill screaming against Corvus's chest, dragging straw mattresses, birdcages, brass kettles, and crippled grandparents out of the roaring orange furnace below while sparks big as winter chestnuts whirled overhead on the hot Libyan wind, setting canvas shop-awnings ablaze sixty yards downwind! Runaway butcher's mules with singed manes bolted blind over dropped bundles; Corvus flattened his wet-cloaked shoulder against stone shop-piers, hooking bruised children up onto high baker's counters out of the trampling hooves as he fought his way yard by yard upstream into heat fierce enough to crisp his eyelashes.

Fifty paces below the Sandaliarius corner, the seven-storey timber fuller's block behind **Lot Fourteen** was already a single skeletal cage of white-hot vertical pine beams collapsing inward floor by roaring floor!

Up on one unburned fifth-floor balcony overhang—cut off from the blazing central pine stair, a fuller's journeyman tossed two bundled feather-mattresses down onto the basalt cobbles, dropped his screaming six-year-old boy into twenty outstretched neighbors' arms, and jumped blind through orange smoke himself, breaking his collarbone with an audible crack ten feet from Corvus's boots.

And directly across the narrow five-foot rear drip-alley stood **Lot Fourteen**—Lucida's fifty-eight-foot fireproof red brick *insula*!

Her twenty-four-inch *opus testaceum* brick walls and iron-shuttered rear vents were **holding clean against the blast**, not one inner timber joist had caught yet!—except out in the front smoke of the Clivus Suburanus, blocking the street with forty freedmen troopers swinging twenty-foot iron-

shod demolition hooks (*falces*) and a heavy wheeled battering-beam, stood **Optio Gaius Nymphidius** of the Fourth Cohort of *Vigiles*!

"Hook the third-storey brick window-piers on Felix's block, heave together on the horn!" Nymphidius was bellowing at the top of his greased lungs, pointing his vine-switch *away* from the collapsed arson-pile straight at **Lucida's intact red brick facade**! "Pull that whole brick front flat across the street for a firebreak before flames jump the coppersmith's roof!"

"Centurion Aper's pump-wagons aren't even on the street yet!" an honest grey-haired *siphonarius* protested, squinting up through blowing sparks at Lot Fourteen's untouched tile cornice. "Optio, those twenty-four-inch brick piers are blocking the east draft—pull Felix's wall down and the wind blows straight into the coppersmith's charcoal-sheds!"

"Shut your teeth and set four iron claws into that middle brick arch, soldier, before I put you on bread-and-water!" Nymphidius roared, doing **Hermippus**'s exact paid butcher-work in broad torchlight: pulling Lucida's twelve-thousand-sesterce brick building down into rubble under untouchable emergency fire-law while burying her underground wheat-vaults beneath collapsed masonry!

Corvus burst through the cordon of spear-butts, tore the wet rag down off his chin, and thrust his stamped bronze Prefecture *tessera* two inches in front of Nymphidius's smoke-streaked nose while jamming his three-foot iron pry-bar horizontally beneath the nearest hook-pole!

"Drop that iron hook off Sound Masonry, *Optio*, by order of the Urban Prefecture Building Commission!" Corvus shouted over the roar of collapsing pine rafters fifty feet behind the block. "Twenty-four-inch *opus testaceum* standing *upwind* of the coppersmith's court *is* your firebreak—pull that pier down and I charge you personally before Tribune Sempronius at dawn with corrupt destruction under the *Lex Iulia de Vi*! Look under the ground-arch, there are living folk inside those vaults!"

Nymphidius recoiled half a pace at seeing a six-foot Roman citizen commissioner brandishing the dead Prefect's bronze seal—yet already six iron claws had bitten deep into the unhardened autumn mortar of Lot Fourteen's upper fourth-storey brick parapet while twelve troopers down the smoky line heaved blind on hemp drag-ropes without hearing Nymphidius's whistle!

High overhead, mortar groaned like splitting ice; red *bipedales* bricks began peeling outward sixty feet above the street!

And down inside the open vaulted ground-arch of Lot Fourteen, lit bright crimson through billowing black smoke—nineteen-year-old **Lucida**, sixteen-year-old **Sura**, and two soot-blackened Marsian kneaders soaked head-to-foot in dripping brown vinegar were hauling heavy sixty-pound sacks of Sicilian reserve wheat frantically up the narrow stone cellar steps before buckling hot iron shutters trapped them below!

Corvus didn't waste another breath on Nymphidius; vaulting the slackened drag-rope, he plunged straight under the trembling ground-floor brick arch into blinding grey lime-dust!

"Out of the arch, Nymphidius's hooks already cracked the fourth-storey parapet!" Corvus roared down the smoky tufa stair-mouth as two loose bricks crashed splintering onto the basalt flags three feet behind his heels.

Up out of the smoking cellar stair stumbled Lucida—hair plastered wet with sour brown vinegar to her soot-streaked cheeks, her linen tunic torn open at one singed shoulder, carrying one end of a heavy wooden grain-stretcher while burly Marsian **Marcus** carried the front! Right behind them scrambled Sura, dragging eighteen-year-old junior baker's boy **Titus**, who had gone back down for the bronze tally-chest and twisted his ankle on the bottom step!

Overhead a sickening, thunderous *CRACK* split the air from wall to wall: twelve *vigiles* troopers hauling blindly down in the smoke had just torn the entire unfinished eastern fourth-storey brick gable loose off its timber centering, dropping **ten cartloads of solid brickwork and flaming pine scaffold-planks** straight down through the third- and second-floor wells toward the ground-floor vault-arch!

"Back, under the Republican peperino pier!" Corvus yelled, dropping his wet wool cloak and driving his three-foot Noric iron bar angled like a siege-prop under the buckling oak lintel-beam of the cellar-head while grabbing Lucida's vinegar-soaked belt with his left fist to haul both her and Sura flat beneath the indestructible three-foot-thick Republican stone arch-pier!

Down came the sky.

Deafening white lime-dust, shattered red bricks, and blazing pine beams hammered the courtyard floor two feet in front of their faces in a five-

heartbeat avalanche that knocked every breath out of their lungs and turned midnight pitch-black; a massive twelve-inch fir beam bounced end-over-end off the fallen masonry pile and **slammed sideways across young Marsian Titus's outstretched left shin** a fraction of a heartbeat before Marcus could yank the boy clear!

Titus's shriek cut thin and terrible through the choking brick-dust.

For three heartbeats chunks of broken tile pattered down onto Corvus's braced back—he had thrown his own body curved like a masonry arch straight over crouched Lucida and Sura against the peperino pier, taking a glancing fist-sized lump of hard mortar square across his left shoulder-blade that numbed his arm to the elbow!

In the pitch-black lime-cloud underneath his ribs, Lucida coughed sour vinegar-air once against his throat, hands flying wildly up his chest until her wet fingers found his face whole and uncrushed.

"Corvus, your back!" she gasped raw into his ear, before Titus screamed again in the rubble six feet away and both of them scrambled out simultaneously into the clearing red glare.

Centurion **Gaius Arrius Aper** had just arrived at a dead run from the Viminal with his second detachment and two bronze water-*siphones*, knocking Nymphidius's hook-gang violently off the drag-ropes with the flat of his vine-staff and turning twin hissing white jets of water straight onto the collapsed fuller's embers!

On the rubble-choked threshold, Corvus heaved the fallen twelve-inch fir beam off young Titus's leg with bleeding, blistered hands while Lucida dropped to both knees beside the boy, slitting his blood-soaked trouser-linen away with her boot-knife: both tibia and fibula jutted white-splintered through torn skin four inches above the ankle—a compound crush-fracture that meant either immediate Pergamene bone-setting or gangrene within four days, and meant Titus would never stand twelve hours at a kneading-trough again!

Lucida whipped off her own vinegar-wet leather belt, twisted a tight tourniquet four inches above the boy's knee with an oak stick to check the pumping dark blood, and barked at tall Marsian Marcus:

"Lift him steady on that shutter-board, straight down the back steps to **Asclepiades of Pergamum** behind Peace's Temple, tell him I pay fifty silver denarii down if he saves the foot! Sura, run to the Fish-Market right now

—tell Barba to allow no panic and keep all four mills turning **Day Eight Hundred Ninety-Seven** past a hundred and ten *modii* even if half the Subura burns to cinders!"

She started up off her bruised knees to follow the stretcher, and froze as four armored soldiers of the **Urban Cohorts** marched through the hissing steam behind tall, hawk-nosed **Tribune Lucius Sempronius** of the *Vigiles*, while crooked *Optio* **Nymphidius** stepped eagerly forward holding up **two half-burned, oil-soaked pine torch-staves** pulled out of the rear drip-alley rubble!

Burned deep into the uncharred wooden butt of both pine staves in two-inch iron branding-letters—visible ten feet off by lantern-light, shone:

PIST · PISC · BARBAE

Fish-Market Bakery of Barba.

Beside the coppersmith's wall thirty paces off through thinning smoke, Corvus glimpsed **one-eared Gaius Ummidius Scaeva** standing calmly among gawking neighbors with his arms folded across his brown cloak, watching Tribune Sempronius's face—and watching **Lucida**!

Cold horror turned Corvus's stomach to stone.

Scaeva hadn't merely burned down Vedius's condemned seven-storey timber shell to clear forty unprofitable tenants and smash Lot Fourteen's roof; **Scaeva had planted oil-torches branded with Barba's stolen bread-crate iron** in the rear alley so Tribune Sempronius would impound *both* Lot Fourteen AND the Fish-Market *pistrinum* before sunrise under a capital *incendium* investigation!

Shut Barba's Fish-Market ovens for **one single twenty-four-hour inquest** on Day Eight Hundred Ninety-Seven, and **nearly two and a half years of Lucida's three-year citizenship road died before noon**, and worse, a Junian Latin suspected of urban *incendium* went straight into chains at the Castra Urbana!

"Go with Titus's stretcher to Asclepiades right now before the boy bleeds out on the cobbles!" Corvus hissed urgent and low against Lucida's soot-blackened ear before Tribune Sempronius spotted her torn linen shift behind the water-pump. "Don't let Sempronius take your name in this alley while Nymphidius holds those planted brands—go through the coppersmith's yard, let *me* break Nymphidius's inquest on the stones!"

"Corvus, don't touch Felix's, " Lucida began fiercely, catching at his torn sleeve as Titus groaned weakly on the shutter-board behind her and blood seeped past the tourniquet stick—leaving her three heartbeats to choose between a boy bleeding to death in front of her knees and a magistrate thirty feet away!

"Save the boy's leg, I won't let them touch the Fish-Market ovens, I swear by my father's bones!" Corvus said, shoving her gently behind the steaming bronze *sipho* wagon so she vanished after Titus's stretcher down the side-cut two heartbeats before Tribune Sempronius strode into the arch!

* * *

By first grey smear of August dawn, seven burned-out Subura shop-fronts smoked dull white under hissing vinegar-blankets, six charred human corpses lay laid out under coarse matting by the fountain-curb, and **Tribune Lucius Sempronius**—furious, sleepless, facing Palatine wrath over losing half a block three hundred yards from Augustus's Forum, sat straddling a commandeered butcher's stool in the middle of ankle-deep wet ash with his clerks writing summary arrest warrants on his knee.

"Two resined pine fire-brands stamped *PIST · PISC · BARBAE* pulled straight out of the ignition-alley between Lot Fourteen and the burned seven-storey block!" Nymphidius recited virtuously, standing at stiff military attention beside the soot-stained brands. "Old baker Marcus Ulpius Felix registered Lot Fourteen to dry baking-wood and roast grain; clearly his careless night-boys from Barba's Fish-Market ovens stored hot charcoal or oil-brands in the passage, touched off the fuller's lath, and burned sixty citizens out of bed! Give me ten cohort soldiers, Tribune, and I'll padlock Barba's Fish-Market mills and haul Barba and Felix in irons before the first hour!"

Padlock Barba's Fish-Market mills before the first hour—with only thirty *modii* left to finish Day Eight Hundred Ninety-Seven!

Smoke-blackened from hair to boots, left shoulder throbbing purple where the fallen mortar lump had struck him, dried Sidonian glass scars pale across his blistered right palm, nineteen-year-old **Corvus** stepped straight up to Tribune Sempronius's stool beside **Centurion Arrius Aper**.

"Sign a padlock order on the Fish-Market *pistrinum* off those two clean pine butts, Tribune," Corvus said, his voice cold, flat, carrying twenty paces through the dripping quiet so every watching shopkeeper and Centurion Aper heard every syllable, "and by the third hour Senator Quintus Servilius Priscus lays sworn evidence before Marcus Caesar showing your *Optio* Nymphidius just tried to cover **seventh-floor commercial arson** with planted crate-wood!"

Sempronius's hawk-head snapped up. "Who are you—Urban Sub-Commissioner Cassius? Explain yourself in sixty breaths before I clear this street!"

Corvus picked up one of Nymphidius's two stamped pine brands by its unburned square handle and held it next to a fallen, half-calcined red brick from Lot Fourteen's rear wall.

"Three facts of stone and wind, Tribune, ask your own veteran Centurion Aper if one inch lies!" Corvus snapped cleanly. "First: tonight's *Auster* wind blew hard **from south-east to north-west** all night long. Look at the soot-shadow baked onto Lot Fourteen's surviving twenty-four-inch brick wall: clean red clay below twenty feet, blistered white oil-glaze **forty-five feet up at fifth- and sixth-storey level**, proving intense downward-and-westward flame blew *out of the upper fuller's garrets onto Felix's roof*, never up from ground-level! Second: smell the char on Nymphidius's pine handle —soaked in cheap rancid Spanish lamp-dregs, yet no ash baked into the branded letters because whoever tossed it into wet alley rubble *after* Aper's water-pumps cooled the stones forgot five hundred degrees of falling pine rafters would have burned a thin crate-stick to grey powder in forty breaths! Third, and decisive against Nymphidius's lie that Lot Fourteen held baking-furnaces or roasting-flues—**here is the certified Aediles' architectural building-file for Lot Fourteen**!"

Corvus reached into his scorched leather satchel, where he carried duplicate Region IV building-sheets—and slapped the official stamped plan across Sempronius's knees.

"No ovens, no flues, no fire-pits permitted or built inside Lot Fourteen, solely cold subterranean tufa grain-storage vaults!" Corvus drove home triumphantly.

And right there, in the grey light of dawn, **Tribune Sempronius's sharp equestrian finger slid two lines further down the Aediles' at-**

tached tax-and-surety schedule—the fine-print financial rider Phileros's clerk had stapled to the back of Region IV's suspect-building dossier last month!

Sempronius frowned, squinting hard at the bottom wax seal.

"Wait a moment, Commissioner Cassius," Sempronius said slowly, hawk-eyes narrowing. "If cold grain-vaults exonerate the Fish-Market ovens from fire-negligence, and they do, Nymphidius, stand back under arrest in quarters until Centurion Aper inspects that seventh-floor oil-sump!—what is **seventy-year-old pauper Marcus Ulpius Felix**, assessed at four thousand sesterces total property in the Appian census, doing filing a twelve-thousand-sesterce cash purchase and an eighteen-thousand-sesterce masonry contract backed by commercial receipts from **Lucida, Junian Latin co-exercitor of the Fish-Market bakery**?"

Ice shot straight through Corvus's veins.

No—Phileros's clerk had cross-indexed Felix's Appian pauper census sheet right onto the back of the building-plan!

"Under Trajan's municipal rebuilding rescript and the *Lex Iunia* restrictions on disguised *fiducia* trusts," Tribune Sempronius said crisply to his clerk, delighted as any bureaucrat at finding a clean fiscal forfeiture to show the Palatine so his morning report didn't come back empty-handed!—"a pauper citizen holding urban land-title purely as unrecorded *interposita persona* to evade municipal surety deposits forfeits the rebuilding ground-lease to summary public re-auction within seventy-two hours! Enter **Fish-Market *Pistrinum*: cleared of all *incendium* suspicion, mills to remain open uninterrupted**. Enter **Clivus Suburanus Lot Fourteen: ground-surface rebuilding lease sequestered for municipal re-auction Thursday at the sixth hour**!"

Corvus opened his mouth to block the sequestration on equitable *impensae utiles* grounds, and stopped as silence parted the smoke-blackened crowd at the foot of the street.

Walking slowly up the ash-choked cobbles from the direction of Peace's surgery came nineteen-year-old **Lucida**.

Young Titus's blood had dried dark rust across both her bare forearms and torn linen skirt; her dark braids hung half-unpinned and grey with cold fuller's ash; behind her walked mute **Sura**, eyes huge and hollow

after checking that Barba's four Fish-Market mills were still turning safe at **MODII CXII** on **Day Eight Hundred Ninety-Seven**.

Lucida stopped ten paces away beside a municipal clerk hammering the painted wooden **LOCATIO PVBLICA — EX AUCTORITATE PRAEFECTVRAE** sequestration placard straight into the scorched oak hoarding of **her twelve-thousand-sesterce brick building**, reading in three silent heartbeats both halves of what had just happened:

Her Fish-Market *pistrinum* and her precious citizenship count stood **untouched and safe**... because nineteen-year-old **Lucius Cassius Corvus**, standing five yards away beside the Vigiles Tribune with *her* Aediles' building-file open on the magistrate's knee, had just handed over the exact paper that stripped old Ulpius Felix's straw-mask off in public, **throwing thirty thousand sesterces of her blood, brick, and buried tufa vaults onto Thursday's rubble-auction block—where every vulture in Rome, starting with Publius Vedius Pollio and Senator Priscus's own land-buyers, would smell bare meat**!

Corvus took two steps through the wet grey ash toward her, blistered hands open at his sides.

"Vespera, Nymphidius had planted Barba's branded pine torches in the alley to padlock your Fish-Market mills before the first hour," Corvus said low, urgent, begging her with his eyes to hear the whole equation before judgment. "Showing Sempronius the cold-vault plan was the only way on earth to stop ten soldiers shutting your stones down on Day Eight Hundred Ninety-Seven! By Thursday noon I can put an equestrian bidder into that auction to buy your lease back—"

"Put one of your equestrian bidders into my auction?"

Lucida spoke barely above a whisper, her voice raw and scraped thin with pitch-smoke, blood dried brown from young Titus's crushed leg flaking off her knuckles as she looked from the Prefecture placard nailed into her bricks straight into Corvus's soot-streaked face.

"Titus lost three inches of shin-bone on Asclepiades's table twenty breaths ago while you were handing my straw-man's census sheet to a *vigiles* tribune without asking me," Lucida said, every word dropping dead and flat into the wet August ash between their boots. "And now you offer to buy *my* walls back inside *your* equestrian friend's pocket so I rent my own stones off your leash?"

"Lucida, without that plan they were marching to padlock Barba's ovens!"

"I had Centurion Aper on the street and four witnesses from the coppersmith's forge who watched Scaeva's Cappadocians carry oil-drums upstairs in December!" she answered, dark amber eyes dry, unblinking, colder than winter river-ice inside ninety-degree smoke. "Don't bring an equestrian bidder near my bricks on Thursday, Lucius Cassius. If your Caelian friends bid one brass *as* on Lot Fourteen, you'll learn how steep Subura rubble costs."

She turned away without wiping the ash off her cheek, put one blood-stained arm round trembling Sura's shoulders, and walked straight down into the rising sun Smoke—leaving Corvus standing ankle-deep in black vinegar-slush beside the saved vault-arch while municipal hammers nailed his rescue across her door.

Chapter XXII

Sleeping Almond

Sixteenth Day Before the Kalends of September, AD 160 · Lucida

Three days after the fire, wet grey ash still lay crusted two inches thick in the basalt wheel-ruts of the **Clivus Suburanus**, smelling sourly under the blazing sixth-hour sun of boiled Campanian vinegar, charred fuller's wool, and roasted rats.

Nineteen-year-old Lucida stood in the narrow strip of blue shade beneath the coppersmith's stone awning across the street from **Lot Fourteen**, wearing an immaculate mourning-dark brown linen *tunica* without ornament—her singed left eyebrow penciled smooth with burnt antimony, blistered palms salved in beeswax and wrapped in narrow white linen strips, watching the municipal *praeco* plant the iron-shod auction spear upright in a bucket of sand before **her own blackened red brick arches**.

At dawn this morning back behind the Fish-Market, sixteen-year-old **Sura** had chalked **ANNVS III · DIES CLXX** across the smoky slate—**Day Nine Hundred overall**, leaving **one hundred ninety-five mornings** between Lucida's throat and Quiritary Roman citizenship, while over behind Vespasian's Temple of Peace, eighteen-year-old Marsian kneader **Titus** lay groaning through fever inside Asclepiades's surgery with iron splints pinning his shattered shin together, paid fifty silver denarii down out of Lucida's purse plus four sesterces a day life-pension sworn before Barba so the crippled boy never begged bread.

Out round the municipal auctioneer's folding table in the glare gathered the carrion-birds who always smelled fresh urban ash before the bricks grew cold.

Closest to the spear stood **Gaius Varius**, a sleek, perfumed freedman land-jobber who bought burned Subura frontages at three pennies on the

silver piece for **Hermippus** and **Publius Vedius Pollio**, fanning flies off his chin with a green ivory tablet.

Six paces left of Varius stood amiable, red-cheeked equestrian **Sextus Pompeius** from Tibur—the exact rose-growing client for whom sixteen-year-old Corvus had won his first five-thousand-sesterce courtroom speech two summers ago! Pompeius kept glancing uneasily thirty yards uphill into the shadowed colonnade of a wine-warehouse, where a tall, dark-haired nineteen-year-old in a white citizen toga stood motionless behind a travertine pillar with his bandaged right hand tucked inside his *sinus* fold.

Corvus.

Even after she had told him in the wet ash at sunrise not to bring one equestrian bidder near her bricks, Corvus had drawn thirty-five thousand sesterces out of his own Castor strongbox and sent amiable Sextus Pompeius down into the heat to outbid Hermippus's shark and buy Lot Fourteen's sequestered rebuilding lease back for her, believing, with that maddening, unbreakable Sabine arrogance of his, that rescuing a woman against her orders made the chain sweet!

Let Sextus Pompeius win that spear today with Corvus's silver, and **every single brick above her two-thousand-*modius* grain-vaults stood registered in the name of Senator Priscus's client**—attachable tomorrow noon if Priscus ever turned on Ceionia Fabia's purveyor! Let Gaius Varius win it, and **Vedius Pollio** walled her wheat-bins shut before sunset!

Lucida glanced once sideways down her own shady awning. Standing calmly beside old **President Gaius Salvius** of the burial guild (silver skull-plate glinting beneath his straw sun-hat) waited sour-faced fifty-year-old **Dorcas**, wearing **Ceionia Fabia's** dark-green Caelian stewardess *stola* and carrying a sealed bronze warranty-box at her belt.

Out in the sun the municipal *praeco* wiped sweat off his bald pate and bawled the terms across the noisy street:

"By summary decree of Tribune Lucius Sempronius under the Trajanic Rebuilding Edict! Perpetual municipal surface-and-vault *locatio* of **Lot Fourteen on the Clivus Suburanus**, forty feet street-front by ninety deep, forfeited for unrecorded straw-surety! Two subterranean tufa vaults intact; three lower *opus testaceum* brick storeys standing; eastern fourth-storey

gable collapsed by hook-clearance! Upset reserve **six thousand sesterces**, who lifts a finger for good Subura stone?"

"Ten thousand!" Hermippus's front-man **Gaius Varius** called lazily, barely lifting one ringed forefinger off his fan.

"Fourteen thousand!" **Sextus Pompeius** barked at once, glancing uphill toward Corvus's pillar for approval.

"Eighteen thousand," Varius purred without looking round.

"Twenty-four thousand!" Pompeius countered stoutly, ready to climb straight to Corvus's thirty-five-thousand ceiling while half the street craned necks at two rich buyers fighting over half-wrecked brick!

Up behind the warehouse pillar thirty yards away, Corvus stood watching Varius prepare to bid twenty-eight—calculating coldly that Hermippus wouldn't authorize past thirty thousand on a fire-damaged lot once Nymphidius sat under arrest.

Lucida nodded half an inch to grey-haired **President Gaius Salvius**.

Old Salvius stepped heavily out of the coppersmith's shade right up to the auctioneer's clerk-table, planted his scarred legionary armorer's knuckles flat across the municipal scroll, and dropped a **heavy triple-sealed bronze-witnessed *tabula*** *clank* beside the sand-bucket!

"Before these two fine gentlemen bid thirty thousand sesterces on hot air, Master Herald," Salvius boomed in rough camp Latin loud enough to stop passing mule-carts, "read out the statutory **prior *pignus tacitum* builder's and materialman's hypothec** registered at the Urban Praetor's table yesterday noon under Emperor Marcus, under **Divus Hadrianus's and Caesar Antoninus's Senate Decree on Rebuilt Ruins**!"

Both Gaius Varius and Sextus Pompeius froze with fingers half-raised in the glare; thirty yards uphill in the colonnade shadow, **Corvus stepped abruptly six inches clear of his travertine pillar**, grey-green eyes narrowing sharp as hawks' down the street!

The municipal clerk broke the seal on Salvius's tablet, squinted rapidly down the notarized masonry accounts, and whistled under his breath before handing it up to the sweating herald.

"Notice to all bidders!" the herald read aloud, squinting against the white sun. "Duly recorded under the *Senatus Consultum* granting privileged statutory first-lien (*privilegium exigendi* and *tacita hypotheca*) to any guild or lender advancing stone, lime, brick, and masons' wages for the

erection or repair of an urban edifice! Sworn unpaid masonry, pozzolana, and timber-shoring balance owed upon Lot Fourteen to the master-masons of the **Collegium Aesculapii et Hygiae**: **twenty-two thousand four hundred sesterces**, bearing statutory twelve-percent reconstruction interest—payable **in hard coined silver across this barrel-head by any winning outside purchaser *before* the Prefecture delivers keys**, over and above the hammer-price!"

Dead silence hit the sunny street, followed by three neighbor coppersmiths grinning into their beards!

Lucida hadn't forged a single copper *as* of false debt: over the past ten months she had deliberately routed all **twenty-two thousand four hundred sesterces** of Lot Fourteen's brick, lime, and mason contracts through a formal interest-bearing construction advance on Salvius's guild books (collateralized privately by her own cash sitting safe in a separate guild chest!) **precisely so that if anyone ever stripped old Ulpius Felix's straw title away, twenty-two thousand four hundred sesterces of ironclad first-priority builder's lien sat bolted straight onto the bricks**!

Pay twenty-four thousand hammer-price *plus* twenty-two thousand four hundred cash lien on top—**forty-six thousand four hundred sesterces** for a fire-cracked Subura lot worth thirty thousand whole!

Hermippus's front-man **Gaius Varius** snapped his ivory fan shut with an ugly curse, glaring straight across the gutter at nineteen-year-old Lucida in the coppersmith's shade as he realized who had salted the well. "I withdraw my eighteen thousand on undisclosed encumbrance!"

Beside the sand-bucket poor **Sextus Pompeius** wiped streaming sweat off his red cheeks, looking helplessly uphill toward Corvus, thirty-five thousand total in his wallet couldn't touch forty-six thousand four hundred! —and shook his head apologetically: "On newly noticed twenty-two-thousand statutory *pignus*, Master Herald, my twenty-four thousand stands withdrawn under *error in substantia*!"

"Both prior bids voided on newly read lien, re-opening Lot Fourteen *cum onere pignoris* (subject to the twenty-two-thousand-four-hundred guild masonry hypothec) at the upset reserve of **six thousand sesterces**!" the herald shouted, lifting his wax-headed hammer in ninety-five-degree heat with noon soup calling his belly. "Unless the lien-creditor waives

immediate cash call, any bidder brings twenty-eight thousand four hundred down on the nail!"

Out of the coppersmith's shade stepped **Dorcas** in her crisp dark-green *stola*, holding up a written waiver from Salvius's burial guild **deferring cash call for five years solely in favor of Dorcas, Roman citizen freedwoman of Ceionia Fabia**, while laying **sixty gold *aurei*** (6,000 HS exact upset reserve!) ringing flat onto the pine board!

"Six thousand sesterces in the name of **Claudia Dorcas, citizen**, with the guild's five-year rollover attached," Dorcas announced in clipped Caelian Latin—holding secret simultaneous five-year irrevocable operating sub-lease (*locatio perpetua*) to **Lucida** already signed in her purse!

Rap! Down came the herald's hammer on the sand-bucket rim before Gaius Varius could even spit into the ash.

Lot Fourteen, all forty street-front feet, three standing brick storeys, and both bone-dry underground tufa vaults still holding four hundred *modii* of untouched Sicilian wheat!—was **hers again for six thousand sesterces song-money**, bought clean out of municipal forfeiture without one coin of Corvus's thirty-five thousand touching her mortar!

Across thirty yards of shimmering August heat and white ash-dust, nineteen-year-old **Lucida** turned her head and looked straight up the street into **Corvus**'s eyes where he stood alone beside the warehouse pillar.

Behind him confused Sextus Pompeius was already trotting uphill carrying Corvus's unspent thirty-five-thousand-sesterce bag back in both hands. Corvus didn't look at Pompeius; his pale, soot-shadowed face stared straight down the Clivus at **Dorcas's dark-green Caelian *stola*** standing beside Lucida at the auction table, watching Lucida drive herself three inches deeper into **Ceionia Fabia**'s pocket purely rather than take one clean silver denarius from his hand.

Neither of them nodded; neither raised a hand. Lucida turned smoothly into the scorched brick archway of Lot Fourteen beside Salvius's masons to order fresh roof-shoring before the September rains, shutting the street behind her back.

* * *

She did not celebrate that night.

At the first watch an unpleasant, expected consequence of Gaius Varius's humiliation arrived at the Fish-Market bakehouse gate: a perfumed Cappadocian runner carrying **Hermippus**'s lead patronal seal, summoning Junian Latin **Lucida** under quarterly *obsequium* obligation to attend **Publius Vedius Pollio** in person at the fourth hour of the night up at his breezy **Oppian Hill summer gardens**—ostensibly to deliver and apply snow-chilled bitter-almond and white-poppy lotion (*diacodion*) to blisters Vedius had taken sunning himself six hours on **Lucius Ceionius Commodus**'s pleasure-barge off Ostia!

Old **Habinnas Barba**, propped upright on two flour-sacks beside Oven One chewing hyssop-root while his single eye blazed fury over grey sunken cheeks—caught Lucida's cloak with chalky, trembling fingers.

"Don't climb that fat viper's hill past midnight, little Tyrian!" Barba rasped hoarsely. "After Varius ate dirt at noon and Nymphidius went into irons? Send Sura's cousin or pay eighty sesterces fine, he means to lock you inside his cellar!"

"Miss a direct *obsequium* summons without bodily sickness, Barba, and tomorrow morning Hermippus files a summary *accusatio ingrati liberti*—ungrateful freedwoman's daughter, before the Urban *Vicarius*, who isn't stern old Lollius Urbicus anymore; it's **Publius Cornelius**, who eats Vedius's turbot twice a week!" Lucida answered calmly, strapping **no steel blade** inside her boot tonight because Scaeva's gate-porters searched ankles to the skin, instead coiling her thick blue-black braids high on her crown and sliding **one heavy, six-inch solid-gold needle-pointed hairpin**—Fabia's Saturnalia gift, sharp enough to pierce bull-hide, clean through the center knot where every respectable woman wore hair-ornaments untouched by male gate-guards!

"Keep two Marsians sitting awake at the bottom of the Oppian steps with horn lanterns until the fourth watch," Lucida told Barba, pressing his dry hot wrist reassuringly once before pulling up her hood. "Vedius Pollio doesn't murder geese in his own summer bedchamber while Ceionia Fabia expects her hair pinned on Friday; he wants to see my hands shake. Keep the hoppers full on **Day Nine Hundred One**."

Up on the high southern terrace of the **Horti Vedii**, ninety-degree Dog-Star suffocation gave way to soft night breezes whispering through imported Syrian pomegranates and trickling snow-chilled fountains—fed

now through legal twenty-digit *calices*, though still lush while Subura families two hundred yards downhill slept six abreast on burned pavement!

At the garden gate **one-eared Gaius Ummidius Scaeva** patted her cloak-hips, wrists, and boot-tops himself with rough, practiced contempt, ignoring the single gold hairpin gleaming openly in her coiled black braids —and jerked his scarred chin toward an open-sided white marble summer sleeping-pavilion (*cubiculum aestivum*) glowing softly behind translucent Egyptian linen mosquito-curtains at the crest of the lawn, while Scaeva himself resumed pacing his twenty-yard sentry beat down along the lower cypress walk among deafening August cicadas.

Inside the linen curtains, four silver lamps burned scented rose-oil low around a wide tortoiseshell couch spread with unwarmed, snow-ironed Pelusian flax sheets.

Stretched flat on his belly across the white linen wearing only a loose purple silk loin-cloth lay fifty-one-year-old **Publius Vedius Pollio**, his shaved ivory skull resting sideways on folded plump forearms, his broad, hairless back and shoulders burned bright lobster-scarlet from Ostian sea-glare. On the low citrus-wood table beside his nose stood a half-empty crystal flagon of heavy thirty-year Setine wine mixed cloudy white with **Theban poppy-head syrup** (*meconium*) prescribed by his physician to dull sun-scald so he could sleep, next to an onyx dish holding his emerald signet ring and **a tiny bronze strongbox tag stamped *AEDE · CASTORIS · ARCA · XLII***!

Temple of Castor, Vault Forty-Two.

"Come out of the doorway so the gnats don't follow you under the net, little builder," Vedius murmured without lifting his head, his light flute-player's voice slightly thickened at the edges by Setine wine and poppy-milk, though his dark velvet eyes watching her approach across the marble were wide awake and bright with malice. "Uncork your snow-pail and put plenty of white poppy-milk over the shoulder-blades; Lord Lucius insisted on racing twenty-oared galleys round the lighthouse without awnings till the seventh hour, and skins bred for shade blister cruelly."

Lucida knelt noiselessly on a rush mat beside the low couch, opened her double-walled cork snow-pail, scooped two smooth fingers of ice-cold whipped bitter-almond cream and poppy-mucilage onto her palms, and laid both chill hands lightly across the burning scarlet skin below Vedius's neck.

Vedius gave a long, theatrical shiver of pleasure, *"Ahhhh, snow off Soracte!"*—letting his eyelids droop halfway down as Lucida worked steady, soothing circular strokes across his sun-cooked shoulders without pressing hard enough to break a single blister.

"Gaius Varius came home weeping into his beard at the eighth hour," Vedius remarked conversationally into the folded crook of his own elbow while her cold fingers moved across his shoulder-blades. "Twenty-two thousand four hundred sesterces of burial-guild mason's lien tucked inside Claudia Dorcas's green skirt! Very neat, Lucida, truly admirable Puteoli footwork! Even Senator Priscus's sour young Sabine crow stood up by the wine-pillars looking as though somebody had stolen his turnip."

Lucida kept her fingers moving smooth and rhythmic as oiled clockwork—smooth and rhythmic as *well-greased mill-gears*, saying nothing.

Vedius turned his shaved ivory cheek an inch further on his forearm so one moist brown eye looked straight up into her face from twelve inches away.

"You really believe," Vedius murmured softly—almost tenderly, the exact tone in which he had mourned his twelve-thousand-sesterce green parakeet three springs ago, "that one hundred and ninety-four mornings from tonight you are going to walk into the Prefecture of the *Annona* with flour on your eyelashes, collect Emperor Trajan's citizenship bronze, and keep both Fish-Market mills and Lot Fourteen out of my strongroom?"

"I count only today's flour and today's salve, Dominus," Lucida answered quietly, scooping fresh snow-almond onto his lower ribs.

Vedius chuckled—a soft, sleepy, wet purr deep in his fat throat as the heavy poppy-laced Setine wine began pulling his eyelids lower and lower under the rhythmic chill of her hands.

"Count away, little mouse," Vedius slurred gently. "Your Caelian lady Fabia protects nobody until old Antoninus dies… and the week Antoninus dies, **Cornelius Repentinus** holds ten thousand Praetorian swords for my table while old one-eyed **Berenice** down on the Argiletum answers a sealed capital *delatio* already sitting ready in **Castor Vault Forty-Two**… naming which pretty Syrian girl carried green hellebore-and-savin bottles up the Caelian steps four Saturnalias ago! Under Sulla's poison law… Junian Latins don't collect baker's citizenship… they go underground, and every brick Ulpius Felix or Dorcas holds for you… comes… home…"

His voice trailed off into a thick, bubbling sigh.

Within sixty slow counts of the deafening cicadas pulsing in the dark cypress trees outside, the heavy Theban poppy-draft inside his Setine wine dragged Publius Vedius Pollio three fathoms under: jaw dropping slack against the white Pelusian sheet, plump depilated fingers uncurling limp over the couch-edge, loud, rhythmic, dead-drunk snores rasping in and out of his open throat!

Inside the glowing linen mosquito-net, nineteen-year-old Lucida stopped her almond-slicked fingers dead against the back of his neck.

A sealed capital delatio already sitting in Castor Vault Forty-Two naming which Syrian girl carried green hellebore-and-savin bottles up the Caelian steps four Saturnalias ago.

Somehow, through frightened Myrtale years ago, or a bribed scullery-maid—Hermippus had pieced together December 156's green abortive phials, prepared a capital *Lex Cornelia de Sicariis et Veneficis* poison denunciation against old Berenice and Lucida, and locked it inside **Vault Forty-Two at the Temple of Castor** timed to unseal the week Antoninus Pius died!

Outside down on the lower terrace, Scaeva's hobnails crunched gravel twenty-five yards away, four full hundred-breath circuits before he walked back near this lawn, every small indoor sound drowned completely beneath ten thousand August cicadas sawing in the pomegranates.

No slave in the pavilion. No witness under heaven.

Slowly, wiping bitter-almond cream silently off her right thumb and forefinger onto her brown linen knee, nineteen-year-old Lucida reached up with clean dry fingers into the center coil of her dark braids and slid out **six solid inches of razor-pointed Caelian gold**.

She held the needle poised vertical in the warm rose-lamp glow, **one finger-breadth above the soft, pale, hairless hollow at the base of Publius Vedius Pollio's shaved skull**, directly between the first cervical vertebra and the occipital bone where butcher-boys at the Forum Boarium pithed unruly calves with a two-inch awl—instant severance of the breath-cord, not three drops of red blood on the sheet if you wiped the pin-prick with cold alum-paste, indistinguishable at sunrise to any sleepy physician from drunken summer apoplexy after six hours of Ostian sunstroke and heavy poppy-wine!

One downward push of eight stone behind her baker's wrist, and Mousa's river-mud, Sura's sulfur-mill terror, sixty-eight Kalends of eighty-sesterce blood-money, young Titus's shattered shin-bone, and Vault Forty-Two's poison snare vanished together into darkness!

Lucida's amber eyes narrowed to slits; her shoulder locked directly above the needle-butt to drive home—

And **stopped dead half an inch above the sweating ivory skin**.

Not out of pity, she would have pithed Publius Vedius Pollio with calmer bowels than she gutted a Fish-Market eel—and not out of fear of Scaeva on the gravel.

Her hand stopped because **three years of reading Gaius's *Institutes* and watching Corvus map Roman property chains slammed an iron ledger-sheet shut across her brain two heartbeats before steel, before gold—touched flesh**:

Suppose Publius Vedius Pollio lies dead of "apoplexy" on this sheet at dawn on Day Nine Hundred One—one hundred ninety-four days BEFORE Lucida holds Roman citizenship!

Does a Junian Latin go free because her patron dies in his sleep?

Never under Roman law! Under the *Lex Iunia Norbana*, *ius patronatus* and the reversionary slave-claim over a living Junian Latin passed automatically at the instant of death to the dead patron's **heir or receivership creditor**! Vedius Pollio had neither wife nor child; every banker in the Forum knew his sole intestate agnate heir—his drunken cousin **Marcus Vedius** at Baiae—sat pledged four hundred thousand sesterces deep on defaulted Tusculan mortgages held directly by **Senator Quintus Servilius Priscus**!

Kill Vedius Pollio tonight with one hundred ninety-four days still unground on her Fish-Market stones, and before September's Kalends **Senator Quintus Servilius Priscus foreclosed Marcus Vedius's inheritance, putting Lucida's own Junian Latin leash, her Fish-Market ovens, and Castor Vault Forty-Two straight inside Corvus's ruthless Caelian patron's iron cupboard**, where Priscus wouldn't wait lazily for old Antoninus to die before crushing Ceionia Fabia's Caelian confidante!

Whereas while greedy, lazy **Vedius Pollio** breathed—believing he still had till Antoninus's death to spring Vault Forty-Two, Lucida knew **the exact vault number (ARCA XLII) at the Temple of Castor**, had **one**

hundred ninety-four mornings to finish her thousand-and-ninety-five-day statutory shield OR pull Vault Forty-Two's teeth first, and kept her own throat out of Senator Priscus's Stoic jaws!

For three slow snores from the fat pink man beneath her knee, nineteen-year-old Lucida held the needle motionless half an inch above death —proving to her own bones who owned the room, then smoothly lifted the six-inch gold *acus* away and slid it silently back through the center coil of her dark braids.

Before rising off the rush mat, she took one lump of stiff white beeswax out of her cosmetic salve-kit, pressed it hard for two heartbeats over **both sides of the tiny bronze AEDE · CASTORIS · ARCA · XLII strong-box tally-key** and Vedius's emerald scarab ring lying beside his empty poppy-cup—lifting crisp, razor-sharp negative impressions into her salve-tin without moving either piece a tenth of an inch on the onyx dish, pulled the linen sheet neatly up over Vedius's greased shoulders like a dutiful handmaid, and stepped silently out through the mosquito-curtains.

Down by the cypress turn Scaeva glared sideways as she walked down the moonlit path swinging her empty cork snow-pail.

"Asleep already?" Scaeva grunted suspiciously.

"Dead to the world under cold almond and poppy, bailiff," Lucida said softly without breaking stride toward the iron gate. "Don't rattle your hobnails on the marble till noon, or he'll dock your tallow."

Chapter XXIII

Under the Vault

Tenth Day Before the Kalends of October, AD 160 · Corvus

Forty-eight days of brassy sky broke in three heartbeats over the Viminal crest with a clap of autumn thunder loud enough to crack dry roof-tiles from the Baths of Trajan to the river.

Before street-peddlers on the **Clivus Suburanus** could snatch fried-fish pans inside doorways, hail big as broad-beans hammered white across scorching basalt, turning instantly into a solid grey curtain of warm September rain that swept two months of horse-dung, fuller's chalk, and black August fire-ash roaring ankle-deep—then shin-deep, down the steep mountain funnel of the Subura toward the Forum valley.

Down at the bottom of the Sandaliarius turn, where blackened char-timber from August's collapsed seven-storey tenement had washed sideways across the municipal iron sewer-grate, brown flood-water backed up three feet high within two hundred breaths, swirling dead rats, cabbage-crates, and floating wooden sandals straight back across the sidewalks!

Nineteen-year-old Corvus came striding fast down the flooded wall-curb out of the Argiletum—soaked straight through his dark grey woollen *paenula* and tunic to the skin, black hair plastered flat across his brow, holding his waxed leather dispatch-satchel high under his left armpit to keep Senator Priscus's autumn fiscal sheets dry, when through the blinding silver sheet of rain he saw the open ground-floor archway of **Lot Fourteen**.

New red brick shoring already crowned the repaired third storey above; down at street-level, where brown ash-laden flood-water was surging within two inches of topping the low travertine cellar-sill and pouring straight down into the subterranean tufa grain-vaults below, **nobody stood except nineteen-year-old Lucida**.

Her Marsian porters were nowhere in sight—doubtless dispatched half an hour earlier before the sky burst to clear the lower Fish-Market drains! Standing knee-deep in churning brown rainwater at the top of the steep vaulted cellar stair, soaked dark blue linen clinging tight as paint to every line of her back and thighs, Lucida was straining with both braced shoulders to lift the second of two heavy four-inch-thick tarred oak flood-boards (*tabulae cataractae*) into the vertical stone mortise-grooves cut into either door-jamb, while a three-foot wall of backed-up street-water jammed the right plank sideways an inch above its bottom seat!

Once water topped that lower board and cascaded down the narrow stone steps into two-thousand-*modius* tufa vaults holding **four hundred *modii* of dry winter Sicilian reserve wheat**, four hundred *modii* swelled into sour rotten mash overnight—breaking her winter margin with one hundred fifty-nine mornings left on her count!

Corvus did not call her name, thirty-six days had passed since the August rubble-auction without one word spoken between them—and did not ask whether she wanted his hands on her plank.

He vaulted the floating cabbage-crates into thigh-deep rushing water right beside her hip, wedged the chiselled iron toe of his surveyor's walking-staff beneath the jammed right end of the two-hundred-pound oak flood-board to clear a wedged lump of fire-brick out of the stone groove, and leaned all twelve and a half stone of his soaked frame downward onto the top oak edge beside her bare straining forearms!

Lucida's head whipped round half an inch through streaming black hair as his shoulder met hers in the pouring grey roar; she didn't tell him to let go, she threw her entire hip and back down on the left end in wordless, instantaneous childhood rhythm with his heave on the right:

"One—two—drop!"

THUD.

Tarred four-inch oak slammed dead flush into the pitched travertine sill-slot, cutting off the foaming brown street-surge two inches below the top rim!

"Upper hatch—the gutter-spout's overflowing off the coppersmith's eaves!" Lucida gasped through stinging rain, ducking backward down the first three dry stone cellar steps as four gallons of roof-cascade burst straight off a broken lead gargoyle overhead toward the open sloped trap-doors!

Corvus stepped down onto the stone stair right behind her heels, caught both heavy iron pull-rings of the twin pitched-pine cellar storm-doors overhead, hauled them slamming shut against the inclined stone curb, plunging both of them out of deafening grey rain-glare into dark, dry subterranean brick-and-tufa silence—and shot the heavy interior iron crossbar *clang* across both hooks!

Above their heads a river of September storm-water roared harmlessly over pitched two-inch pine and tarred oak seams without letting through more than a thin trickle down the outer limestone channel.

Down below their wet boots stretched the vaulted subterranean belly of **Lot Fourteen**: forty feet long by twenty-eight wide, carved out of dry grey Republican tufa rock and vaulted overhead in clean new red *bipedales* brick arches, warm from the earth's steady eighty-degree summer hold, smelling deeply and cleanly of dry golden Sicilian wheat stacked eight sacks high on cedar pallets, fresh lime-mortar, and pitched pine.

Hanging from an iron hook driven into the central brick pier burned **one single terracotta olive-oil lamp**, throwing long amber shadows and flickering gold edges across forty yards of silent stone.

Lucida stood four steps down on the dry tufa floor wringing brown rainwater out of her heavy unpinned braids with both hands, chest rising and falling fast beneath soaked dark-blue linen that clung translucent from collarbone to bruised knee.

Two steps above her by the bolted hatch stood Corvus, water dripping steadily off his jaw, eyelashes, and dark grey wool hem onto the clean dry stone, unbuckling his soaked outer *paenula* and setting his leather dispatch-satchel carefully up onto a dry projecting brick shelf shoulder-high beside the central pier so damp wouldn't soak through the seams.

Now that the flood-board sat tight in its groove and not a handful of wheat had wetted, silence rushed in between them ten times louder than the thunder rumbling muffled through six feet of rock overhead.

Lucida let go of her wet hair, wiped rain off her cheekbones with the back of one bandaged palm—the pale pink burn-scars from August's fire-night still fresh across her knuckles, and looked coldly up at him in the amber lamp-glow.

"The storm-sluice down at the Forum opens in half an hour once the *vigiles* lift the grate," she said flatly, taking a step backward toward her

stacked grain-pallets to put twelve feet of dry stone between them. "Wait on the top step till the curb drains if you want, Lucius Cassius, then unbolt the hatch and go back to your Caelian dry clothes. Nobody owes silver for pushing an oak board."

Corvus stood motionless by the central brick pier, water trickling cold down the hollow of his throat inside his clinging tunic, staring across twelve feet of warm golden shadow at her pink fire-scarred knuckles—and at **Claudia Dorcas's green Caelian warehouse-seal** hanging brazenly on bronze wire from the first grain-pallet beside Lucida's hip!

Thirty-six days of watching her walk past him in the Forum as if he were dead stone after he broke Nymphidius's arson frame to save her Fish-Market stones, thirty-six nights of lying wide awake in his Carinae room watching young Marsian Titus hobble on one crutch past Peace's portico while knowing **Ceionia Fabia**'s stewardess held the surface-lease over this very vault!—snapped the iron band round Corvus's ribs clean in two.

"Claudia Dorcas's lead horse-seal hanging right on your winter wheat," Corvus said, his deep voice quiet and shaking slightly at the bottom edge in the low brick vault. "Six thousand sesterces out of **Ceionia Fabia's** purse at the August spear, purely so you could spit in Sextus Pompeius's face rather than let thirty-five thousand clean sesterces out of my own Castor box put that roof back in your hands without strings!"

Lucida laughed once—short, jagged, wholly without mirth in the warm underground air.

"Without strings?" she repeated, taking two barefoot-silent strides forward in wet leather soles until only six feet separated them beside the lamp-lit brick pier. "Thirty-five thousand sesterces from **Quintus Servilius Priscus's** right-hand *cognitor*, the exact man who tossed my dead straw-buyer's pauper census sheet onto Tribune Sempronius's knee at sunrise without asking my leave, cost me six thousand sesterces and half an upper storey, and wanted his own Tibur equestrian holding the key over my head so whenever Priscus whistled against Fabia, you could lock my grain indoors 'for my own safety'!"

"Without that plan on Sempronius's knee at dawn," Corvus roared back—all three years of Fronto's quiet courtroom restraint shattering off the low brick vault so the hanging lamp-flame jumped, "ten soldiers of the Urban Cohorts were marching down the Fish-Market steps at the first hour

with iron padlocks to **shut Barba's four mills cold on Day Eight Hundred Ninety-Seven**! One unground morning, Lucida—**eight hundred ninety-six days wiped dead to nothing**, and you dragged in chains to the Castra Urbana on planted arson-wood while you knelt stitching Titus's leg! Would you rather sit in irons tonight owning unsequestered rubble?"

"I would rather burn in my own ovens holding my own iron bar than live one hour inside a cage you built behind my back!" Lucida shouted straight up into his face, stepping across the last four feet until her wet chin tilted two inches below his scarred mouth, dark amber eyes blazing bright gold in the single flame. "Three years you've treated me like a lame sheep you have to herd into your clean Sabine pen while you climb toward your precious gold ring! Hiding six denarii in your waistband at fifteen while you coughed blood; hiding for twelve whole months that you knew **Vedius Pollio** bled eighty sesterces off my wrists every Kalends while you fucked **Tullia Crispina** on silk sheets at Laurentum and left me paying blood-silver out of olive-dregs!"

"You threw my hand off on the scaffold when I offered to pay Vedius out, and walked down to the *Horrea Galbana* at midnight to pay **Decimus Valerius** on cedar planks behind Bin Twenty-Four instead!" Corvus snarled, raw murderous pain ripping clean out of his throat before his brain could stop his tongue.

Lucida didn't flinch, apologize, or drop her eyes by a hair; she shoved both wet, fire-scarred palms **hard straight into the center of Corvus's soaked chest**, driving him half a step back against the central red brick pier!

"At least Decimus Valerius named his filthy price straight to my face across a counting-board instead of bringing me roasted figs in the snow with another woman's lemon-verbena still washed into his hair!" she hissed.

Corvus's hands shot out and locked around both her wet wrists before she could shove a second time, spinning her round in one fierce, unbroken half-turn until **her own soaked back slammed flat against the warm, rough red *bipedales* bricks of the central pier**—trapping her between his six-foot frame and her own masonry just as fifty-six feet of Subura air had pinned them in October, except down here there was neither wind, street, nor audience under earth or sky!

"Try pulling your wrists free and telling me to my face you wanted Valerius's hands on you!" Corvus breathed raggedly against her parted lips,

chest heaving hard against her breasts through two layers of drenched, clinging wool and linen, grey-green eyes black-pupiled and blind with four years of starvation.

Lucida didn't pull her wrists down; she arched her neck up off the rough red brick, bared small white teeth, and **bit straight down onto Corvus's scarred lower lip**, hard enough that the old white stylus-scar split warm and salt, bright red blood blooming instantly across both their wet mouths —before opening her lips beneath his with a low, fierce animal sound deep in her throat!

Everything broke at once.

Corvus groaned deep inside his ribs against her bleeding kiss, letting go of one wrist to tangle his fingers rough into her heavy, rain-soaked braids while his scarred right hand dropped straight down her wet ribcage to drag the clinging dark-blue linen hem up over her bare, rain-chilled olive thigh and hip!

Lucida tore at the wet woollen neck-seam of his grey tunic with both hands until strong Caelian stitching ripped three inches down his collarbone, dragging his mouth harder down onto hers, tasting his blood, rainwater, and salt together, tongue meeting tongue in raw, bruising, breathless fury that had five years of river-mud, winter pleurisy, flour-dust, terror, and intolerable loneliness packed behind every gasp!

"Damn your gold ring—damn your Caelian house," she panted torn and ragged against his jaw as Corvus dragged his ripped wet tunic clean off over his head, dropping it onto the dry tufa stone, and buried his bleeding mouth down the side of her wet throat straight onto the tiny dark olive-pip birthmark below her left collarbone, sucking hard enough to leave dark purple-red proof on her skin while both hands slipped under her soaked shift, snapping the thin knotted inner linen *strophium* breast-band clean in two with one jerk of bricklayer's wrists and dragging her wet blue linen straight off over her raised arms!

Nineteen years old, stripped naked to the warm amber lamp-glow from unpinned wet black hair falling past full, rain-pebbled breasts down to narrow waist, dark triangle of curls, and strong walker's thighs braced wide against warm red kiln-brick, Lucida didn't cover an inch of herself—she caught Corvus's bare scarred shoulders in both hands, dragged him skin-to-skin flat against her breasts so both pounding hearts slammed unobstructed

together, and reached straight down between their bellies to wrench his wet leather belt-buckle and loin-cloth undone, wrapping warm, stain-faded fingers hard around his rigid, aching length!

Corvus hissed through clenched teeth against her ear, forehead dropping hard against the rough brick beside her temple as her thumb slid slick over the head; then he hooked both forearms beneath her bare knees, lifted her clean off her wet leather boots so her calves locked fierce as iron bands round his bare waist and her naked spine pressed into rough warm pozzolana brick, and dropped his mouth onto her bare right breast, teeth grazing nipple until Lucida's head slammed back against the masonry with a choked, shameless Syrian curse, nails raking four white tracks down his scarred shoulder-blades where fallen August fire-mortar had bruised him purple!

"No widows, no gatekeepers—look at me, Sabine, look right in my eyes when you, " Lucida gasped hoarsely, reaching down with one hand to guide him straight to her slick, burning entrance while throwing her left arm blindly sideways onto the shoulder-high brick ledge beside the pier to brace herself against the first hard upward drive of his hips—

And her fingers slammed square across **Corvus's unbuckled leather dispatch-satchel** on the brick shelf, knocking it sideways off the narrow mortar-lip!

Heavy waxed tablets and folded oilskin hit the dry tufa stone beside Corvus's bare heels with a loud *clatter*, popping the damp leather inner flap wide open two feet from the hanging lamp!

Neither of them would have stopped for ordinary court-scrolls if the whole Senate had fallen off the shelf; except **face-up right in the bright yellow puddle of lamp-light** slid two objects side by side:

First, a folded, red-rubricated Urban Prefecture receivership draft headed in **Corvus's own unmistakable upright Sabine hand**:

BONA VEDII POLLIONIS — SEQUESTRATIO IN FIDEM L · CASSII CORVI : ITEM IVS PATRONATVS ET REVERSIO PISTRINI PISCARIENSIS (LVCIDAE LAT · IVN ·)...

(*Sequestration into the receivership custody of Lucius Cassius Corvus: Item, the patronal right and reversion of the Fish-Market Bakery of Lucida, Junian Latin!*)

And resting two inches beside it, escaped from the split inner seam—gleamed **a flat oilskin packet sealed with pale pistachio-green Chian mastic wax stamped with Senator Priscus's secret terebinth tree**!

At the exact same instant, as Corvus glanced instinctively down at the clatter and back up at Lucida's freezing shoulder, his bare forearm brushed her discarded blue tunic hanging off the pallet-hook beside his knee, knocking **Ceionia Fabia's solid-gold Palatine rock-crystal scent-bottle** (engraved round the gold collar *C · FABIA · AELII · CAES · F*) rolling bright and chiming across the stones right against Priscus's green-sealed Syrian packet!

One heartbeat ago Corvus's hips had been braced between her parted thighs, notched hot and slick against the very threshold of entering her, both bodies trembling on the edge of the cliff.

Now **Lucida stared straight down over his bare shoulder at her own name and Fish-Market bakery written in Corvus's handwriting under *SEQUESTRATIO IN FIDEM L · CASSII CORVI*—**while **Corvus stared straight down at Ceionia Fabia's royal *AELII CAESARIS FILIA* gold bottle** rolling against his treasonous Syrian dispatch!

Lucida went colder than January river-ice against his chest.

Every drop of blood drained from her face; she unlocked both ankles from around his waist and **shoved with arms, knees, and shoulders all at once** like a wildcat tearing out of a wire snare, dropping bare-footed onto the stone floor and snatching her wet blue linen tunic flat across her breasts and thighs while backing six paces away toward the wheat-sacks!

"Wait, Vespera, read the whole clause, don't read four words upside down!" Corvus rasped, standing naked from the waist up, chest heaving raw in the amber glare, blood from her bite smeared dark crimson across his scarred mouth and chin as he bent fast to sweep the green-sealed Syrian packet back out of sight into his satchel while holding out the Prefecture sheet! "That isn't a seizure *against* you! When I spring the Subortanae brick-fraud and Caelian water-theft to bankrupt Vedius Pollio this winter, **every asset in Vedius's estate—including his patronal reversion over you!, gets frozen by fiscal receivership**! I wrote my own name in as temporary court *sequester* specifically so **neither Priscus nor the State Treasury can touch your ovens while you finish your last hundred and fifty mornings**!"

"So **you** hold my Junian slave-reversion inside **your** receivership box instead of Vedius Pollio!" Lucida whispered—shaking from bare heels to wet braids now, not with cold, with revulsion and terror so absolute her voice sounded like breaking glass in the vault. "First Sextus Pompeius tries to buy my Lot Fourteen ground-lease behind my back; and when that fails, **Lucius Cassius Corvus writes a court decree transferring Publius Vedius Pollio's dead-patron leash over my corpse straight into his own pocket**, just in case I don't behave nicely toward Senator Priscus's faction when old Antoninus dies!"

"I am trying to keep Priscus and Vedius *both* off your throat while **Ceionia Fabia's royal gold** rolls out of your pocket onto my boots!" Corvus shouted back, hauling his torn grey woollen tunic roughly down over his wet shoulders with shaking hands, pointing down at the gold-collared rock-crystal bottle gleaming on the stone. "*Aelii Caesaris Filia!* How much Palatine gold has Lucius Commodus's sister poured into your strongbox since last winter to buy ears inside Priscus's house? Was *that* how you paid twelve thousand cash for this lot, and why you let me climb down here tonight—hoping green wax might fall out of my bag?"

Silence hit the subterranean vault like an axe driven into bone.

Even as the monstrous accusation left Corvus's bleeding mouth, half his mind knew she hadn't knocked his satchel down on purpose, yet four years of poisonous suspicion, wounded pride, and finding Fabia's gold rolling two inches from a cipher that could hang him drove the blade past pulling back!

Lucida stopped trembling altogether.

Slowly she pulled her damp, torn dark-blue tunic down over her head, knotted her belt around her waist without hurrying, bent down to pick up Ceionia Fabia's gold-mounted crystal bottle off the tufa floor, and looked across ten feet of amber shadow straight into Corvus's eyes.

On her bare wet throat just above her torn collar-hem, the dark red bruise his mouth had sucked over her olive-pip birthmark burned vivid against olive skin; on his lower lip, a single bright bead of her bite swelled dark red and dropped onto his grey wool chest.

"Your father Gaius Cassius drank sour Sabine wine until he misread blue clay-marl out of sheer sloppy pride and pulled twenty cartloads of wet mud down onto his own neck, leaving two children starving in the rain,"

Lucida said—speaking softly, clearly, using the one sacred grave neither of them had ever profaned since they were thirteen years old. "You don't drink wine, Lucius Cassius; you drink Senator Priscus's ink. And when your Caelian pit collapses on you, don't tap twice-and-once on my gate."

Corvus's face went white as cut travertine around his bleeding mouth.

"At least Gaius Cassius died a freeborn Roman citizen under open sky with his own name on his tomb," Corvus answered, voice dead flat, matching grave for grave across ten feet of stone as something four years old died screaming between their ribs, "instead of begging freedom off drunken guests over pickled thrushes at Puteoli and leaving his child kissing patrician hairpins in Caelian bedrooms."

Lucida did not blink, weep, or strike him.

She walked barefoot past his shoulder without grazing a thread of his wool, climbed the six dry stone steps to the cellar-head where outside thunder had rolled away east toward Tibur leaving slow rain dripping off eaves, shot back the interior iron crossbar with one wrench of both scarred hands, threw open the pitched pine storm-hatch into cold grey evening air, and stepped out into the empty street without looking back into the dark.

Chapter XXIV

The Old Man's Vintage

Fourteenth Day Before the Kalends of November, AD 160 · Lucida

Twelve miles west of Rome along the paved **Via Aurelia**, where low rolling Etruscan clay-hills smelled of wild fennel, bruised pine-needles, and distant Tyrrhenian salt, the master of sixty million human beings sat under a plain whitewashed timber grape-arbor splitting half-asses on a wax slate while wasps crawled undisturbed over his knuckles.

Lucida stood quietly in the dappled October leaf-shadow behind **Ceionia Fabia**'s camp-chair—four days past her own twentieth birthday now, wearing modest dove-grey Tarsian wool pinned high enough round her throat to hide the last faint shadow above her collarbone, **Day Nine Hundred Sixty-One** chalked safe back at the Fish-Market before dawn, staring through hanging purple clusters of late *amineum* wine-grapes at **Emperor Antoninus Pius**.

After four years inside Rome's crushing marble theaters, hundred-foot brick tenements, and gilded Caelian halls, imperial **Lorium** looked almost shockingly small: no soaring Hadrianic domes, no Egyptian obelisks, only the sunny, rambling country farmhouse where Antoninus had grown up as a boy seventy years ago and where he still preferred to live ten months out of twelve like a thrifty Sabine squire checking his own bailiff's turnip-weights.

Thirty paces across the stone-flagged press-yard, two giant twenty-foot oak lever-beams (*prela*) groaned rhythmically down upon stacked rush baskets of crushed grapes while eight bare-legged country slaves—and right in the middle of the splashing stone treading-vat beside them, **twenty-nine-year-old Lucius Ceionius Commodus** with his purple-bordered tunic hiked shamelessly into his belt, crimson must-juice staining both muscular

thighs to the knee as he laughed and sang vintage catches!, trod red foam pouring sweet and heady down stone channels into sunken terracotta *dolia*.

Under the vine-arbor sat seventy-four-year-old **Antoninus** himself.

Tall, long-faced, silver-bearded like benign Father Numa on bronze medallions, he wore a plain undyed woollen tunic woven by women of his own household; before sitting down for afternoon petitions he had eaten two dry crusts of spelt-bread without wine—every palace servant knew the old man's habit, so hunger wouldn't weaken his patience or make his belly rumble impolitely in front of nervous provincial envoys.

Yet standing twelve feet behind Fabia's shoulder with a dyer's-and-healer's trained eye, twenty-year-old Lucida saw everything the bronze coin-makers left out.

Underneath that humble white wool tunic, whenever Antoninus leaned half an inch forward to take a scroll, **stiff flat strips of dried linden-wood** laced tight inside a linen bodice creaked faintly against his ribs —propping up a seventy-four-year-old thoracic spine curved so sharply by age that without wooden stays his chin would have rested on his breastbone! Around his ankles, loose soft felt house-boots hid swollen, doughy white flesh pitting deep above the leather laces; his breath carried across twelve feet of sweet grape-must the dry, unmistakable camphor-and-horehound odor of old men whose lungs filled slowly after midnight; and his pale blue eyes, gentle and shrewd as ever while questioning an Ostian salt-contractor over three missing amphorae, watered constantly at the outer corners.

At Antoninus's right elbow stood thirty-nine-year-old **Marcus Aurelius Caesar**, thinner and darker-ringed round the eyes than ever, dutifully blotting every rescript his adoptive father signed without once glancing out toward the sunny treading-vat where carefree Lucius splashed must; three paces left on a cushioned bench sat Marcus's wife **Annia Galeria Faustina**, fanning sleepy yellow-jacket wasps away from her plump eighteen-month-old toddler **Fadilla** while watching **Ceionia Fabia** across the arbor with flat, unblinking maternal hostility.

"Four years ago tonight," Fabia murmured so softly over her left shoulder that only Lucida holding her parasol-case heard above the creak of the oak wine-beam, "he walked three miles round those upper olive-terraces without a stick. Today two freedmen lifted him onto that cushion before the Baetican envoys came through the gate, and **Galeria Lysistrata**, his dead

wife's Greek freedwoman who warms his feet and sells Praetorian centurionates behind Marcus's back—had the Pergamene doctor burn mugwort over his kidneys at dawn."

Out in the sunny yard Lucius Commodus vaulted laughing over the low stone lip of the treading-vat, rinsed crimson grape-skins off his calves with a bucket of cold well-water, and came striding barefoot up to the arbor carrying a foaming two-handled earthenware bowl of fresh, unfermented first-press *mustum* to offer the old Emperor for the traditional autumn blessing to Liber Pater.

"First blood off the south slope, Father!" Lucius called warmly, dropping effortlessly to one stained knee before Antoninus's chair without a trace of court stiffness. "Sweeter than Chian honey, pour three drops on the hearth-stone so frost spares the late olives!"

Old Antoninus smiled—real, paternal fondness warming his lined grey cheeks as he looked down at bright-curled Lucius, so different from overburdened Marcus, and set both veined hands on the carved oak chair-arms to stand upright for Liber's libation, waving away Marcus's instinctively outstretched hand with mild pride:

"An old farmer still pours his own vintage, Mark."

Antoninus pushed up onto both felt-booted feet, took the heavy clay bowl of purple must into his hands—

And **his swollen left knee folded inward like wet chalk**.

Before Lucius or Marcus could catch both elbows, seventy-four-year-old Caesar pitched sideways against the arbor-post; the linden-wood stays beneath his tunic cracked audibly against oak; the earthenware bowl shattered across the flagstones, splashing dark crimson grape-must like fresh arterial blood straight across **Marcus's white toga-hem and Lucius's bare insteps**, while a thin string of yellowish bile ran down Antoninus's silver beard as a sudden grey-lipped dizziness seized his heart!

Every voice in the press-yard died stone-dead. Even the slaves up on the twenty-foot oak press-beam froze hanging on their ropes.

For eight terrible heartbeats **sixty million people's peace hung crooked against a wooden post** while two Praetorian tribunes stepped instinctively six inches closer to opposite princes, and then old Antoninus drew one long, wheezing breath through clenched yellow teeth, wiped his

beard dry himself with a corner of his plain wool sleeve, and forced a dry, steady countryman's quip past grey lips:

"Slippery wasps under a clumsy heel, boys. Pour Liber another cup off the beam; clearly the god wanted double measure."

Everyone laughed on cue—too loud, too brittle, as Marcus and tall chamberlains eased the trembling seventy-four-year-old Emperor gently back onto his cushioned carrying-chair and bore him indoors behind drawn linen curtains "to change his splashed boots."

Across the puddle of smashed clay and dark red grape-must soaking into hot dust between them, **Marcus Aurelius Caesar** and **Lucius Ceionius Commodus** stood facing each other for three silent breaths—crimson vintage staining both men's hems alike, before Marcus turned briskly indoors after the physicians without looking back, and Ceionia Fabia rose smoothly from her camp-chair, her green emerald hairpin flashing cold fire in the afternoon sun.

"Bring my wool wrap round the olive-walk, Lucida," Fabia murmured quietly. "The shade just turned very cold."

* * *

Behind the low stuccoed bath-wing of the Lorium villa, where gnarl-trunked century-old olive trees sloped down toward a muddy country lane crowded with couriers' tethered horses, twenty-year-old Lucida walked three paces behind Fabia and Dorcas—her eyes missing nothing in the lengthening golden shadows.

Coming fast up the gravel horse-path straight from a foam-lathered post-mule just ridden hard out from Rome walked **Quintus Junius Rusticus** in his coarse, clasp-free dark Stoic cloak, carrying a sealed leather dispatch-tube tucked beneath his ink-blackened thumb.

Blocking the narrow brick arch into the Emperor's private courtyard stood **Sextus Cornelius Repentinus**, newly elevated three months ago beside Furius Victorinus to command the **Praetorian Guard**, a thick-necked, pock-marked equestrian soldier of fortune with heavy gold rings biting into hairy fingers and the cold eyes of a camp Quartermaster who knew every senator in Rome whispered behind his back that old Antoninus's Greek concubine **Lysistrata** had put the Praetorian sword in his hand!

Fabia halted behind a clipped boxwood angle ten paces up the terrace, motioning Dorcas and Lucida still with two fingers downward.

"The Emperor is resting after the sun, Senator Rusticus," Prefect Repentinus said at the arch—courteous on the surface, planting two hundred pounds of Praetorian iron squarely in the Stoic's path. "If you bring urban dispatches from the Senate, my *cornicularius* will carry them in to Caesar Marcus."

Rusticus looked down first, true to lifelong habit—at Repentinus's gilded military boots, and never offered his hand.

"Letters from **Antioch** concerning King Vologases's horsemen on the Euphrates go into Marcus Caesar's own palm, Prefect, never through camp-clerks," Junius Rusticus replied in his quiet, dry parchment voice. "Keep your cohorts polished for parade; foreign frontiers belong to consuls."

Repentinus's pock-marked cheeks darkened dull brick-red as Rusticus brushed past his elbow through the arch without bowing, leaving the Praetorian Prefect staring after the Stoic's coarse cloak for three ugly breaths before Repentinus turned on his heel, glanced straight up the boxwood terrace toward **Ceionia Fabia**, and touched two ringed fingers significantly to his sword-belt in silent understanding!

Behind Fabia's shoulder, twenty-year-old Lucida stood motionless as carved olive-wood while two halves of a deadly puzzle clicked shut inside her head with an audible iron snap:

Letters from Antioch concerning King Vologases's horsemen on the Euphrates…

And three weeks ago down inside the flooded brick vault beneath Lot Fourteen, sliding out of **nineteen-year-old Corvus's** split leather satchel right beside her own name on a receivership sheet, **a flat oilskin packet sealed in pale pistachio-green Chian mastic wax**—the exact Levant resin Syrian couriers used from Antioch and Seleucia, stamped with Senator Priscus's private terebinth tree!

Corvus wasn't merely hunting crooked brick-stamps and aqueduct pipes for Quintus Servilius Priscus anymore. **Corvus was holding Priscus's and Rusticus's secret Syrian succession dispatches inside his own bag!**

* * *

Heavy autumn rain swept in off the Tyrrhenian Sea after dark, drumming loud on the low red pantiles of the **Mansio ad Duodecimum**, the private brick posting-house half a mile up the Via Aurelia where Ceionia Fabia's party lodged overnight because Faustina had pointedly packed every spare Palatine guest-chamber inside the Lorium villa with her own Annii cousins.

At the third watch of the night, after Dorcas had retired behind the inner partition and Marsian guards stood soaked under the stable eaves below, thirty-one-year-old **Ceionia Fabia** sat barefoot in a dark woollen night-robe beside a roaring olive-root hearth, turning her six-inch green emerald hairpin slowly end over end between both hands while rain streamed black down the shutter-cracks.

Across the small table twenty-year-old Lucida finished packing unused saffron and camphor salve-pots into oiled felt, waiting—knowing before Fabia opened her mouth that the bill for two years of Caelian protection had just come due.

"You saw his knees buckle over the grape-bowl," Fabia said quietly into the snapping olive-sparks.

"Linden-wood stays don't hold water out of lungs when January fog comes up the Tiber, Domina," Lucida answered without pretense.

Fabia stopped spinning the gold needle and laid it flat across the scarred pine table, pointing directly between them.

"Four months, five at the outside, if Lysistrata's Greek doctors bleed him carefully," Fabia said, low rapid patrician vowels stripped of every court curl. "When old Antoninus stops breathing at Lorium, Marcus holds the tribunician power already—nobody disputes Marcus's purple. What hangs on a razor's edge for **twelve hours** between Lorium's midnight courier and the morning Senate meeting is whether Marcus names my brother **Lucius** full co-equal **Imperator et Augustus** beside him, with half the armies, half the treasury, and the Eastern command against Parthia—or whether **Quintus Servilius Priscus** and **Junius Rusticus** stampede the Senate before dawn into voting Marcus sole Augustus and packing Lucius off to some toothless priesthood where Priscus's hounds can strip every friend of our house, including **Vedius Pollio**, **Cornelius Repentinus**, and everyone holding Dorcas's Caelian leases—down to bare bone!"

Lucida folded her oiled felt cloth neatly square, stain-faded thumbs calm on the table-edge. "Marcus Caesar loves his brother, Domina; anyone watching them over the spilled must today saw that."

"Marcus loves *duty* better than blood, and if Rusticus and Priscus hand him a *fait accompli* from the frontier legions swearing they will recognize Marcus alone, Marcus will sigh over Epictetus and cage Lucius 'for the peace of the Republic'!" Fabia snapped softly, leaning forward until emerald fire danced in her eyes across two feet of hearth-glow. "Repentinus's post-riders caught wind in September that Priscus and two ex-consuls have already slipped **ciphered Greek instructions to Antioch** behind Marcus's back, ordering senior tribunes of the Syrian legions to refuse my brother's name on the *sacramentum* oath! Priscus keeps *no* copy inside his Caelian *tablinum*, Repentinus's locksmith checked his cedar chest while Priscus dined out last Tuesday and found only brick-stamps and a dusty bottle of red ditch-water!"

Lucida's pulse did not jump by a quarter-beat; inside her head she saw the dusty Sidonian glass flask of red Sinope ruddle-water from Chapter Five sitting harmlessly in Priscus's chest while **the real Syrian lime-bark duplicate rode inside nineteen-year-old Lucius Cassius Corvus's satchel or Castor strongbox**!

"Why tell a Fish-Market baker high Senate secrets at midnight, Domina?" Lucida asked evenly.

Fabia smiled—cold, intimate, sister-to-sister across a gulf of ten million sesterces.

"Because **one hundred sixty-eight grinding mornings** still stand between your throat and Trajan's three-year citizenship roll, Lucida, putting your Day One Thousand Ninety-Six in **early April**, once Vestalia and guild audit holidays are reckoned!" Fabia murmured with surgical accuracy. "And because two weeks ago **Publius Vedius Pollio** dined with my brother Lucius and boasted over his third cup of Setine that long before March arrives, he holds a **sealed capital *veneficium* denunciation inside Vault Forty-Two at Castor** ready to pull old Berenice and *you* down into the executioner's pit the instant Repentinus takes emergency interregnum powers—wiping out three years of flour in an afternoon so Lot Fourteen and your Fish-Market mills fall straight into Vedius's lap!"

There sat every blade in the dark, counted down to the single day: **tenth of April, AD 161** for Day 1,095; Antoninus dying before spring; Vedius's Castor Vault Forty-Two; and Corvus's receivership net waiting on the other side!

"Whereas," Fabia whispered, sliding two smooth, unringed fingers across the pine to touch the back of Lucida's scarred hand, "you grew up in the same Sabine ditch as **Lucius Cassius Corvus**, Priscus's brilliant nineteen-year-old vault-keeper, whom half the Quirinal saw break glass in his bare fist for your name at Volusenus's supper in June! Bring me **one authenticated leaf or green terebinth wax-key of Priscus's Syrian treason** before the old Emperor dies: my brother Lucius rides straight into the **Castra Praetoria** with Repentinus, forces full co-equal **Augustus** purple on the Senate at sword-point, **burns Vedius Pollio's Castor Vault Forty-Two unopened**, signs your full Roman citizenship and freeborn *restitutio natalium* in wet imperial purple before sunrise, and hands you Ostian state grain-warehouses big enough to buy and sell ten men like Vedius!"

Outside in the dark courtyard a post-horse whinnied shrill against the pouring October rain; inside on the hearth an olive-root collapsed in a shower of bright gold sparks.

Twenty-year-old Lucida looked down at Fabia's six-inch green emerald needle gleaming on the pine planks between them—thinking of Corvus standing half-naked in the brick vault three weeks ago with blood from her own teeth running down his chin, saying *at least Gaius Cassius died a freeborn citizen under open sky instead of leaving his child kissing patrician hairpins in Caelian bedrooms*.

Hand Priscus's green-waxed Syrian letter to Ceionia Fabia tonight, and when Lucius Commodus and Praetorian Prefect Repentinus crushed Senator Priscus for treason, **nineteen-year-old Lucius Cassius Corvus, whose hand wrote the Greek cipher and whose box held the bark—would not go into polite island exile; still shy of the four-hundred-thousand-sesterce equestrian ring, Corvus would hang nailed by both wrists outside the Esquiline Gate in winter sleet**!

Even after everything they had torn out of each other's skin in the vault, even knowing he had written her bakery into his own receivership roll—the thought of iron spikes driven through Corvus's scarred right thumb turned Lucida's belly cold with fierce, instantaneous refusal.

No. She would break **Castor Vault Forty-Two** with her own wits first, keep all four Orvieto lava mills thundering day and night through winter frost across her last **one hundred sixty-eight grinding mornings**, and reach April a free Roman citizen **without selling Corvus's neck to Praetorian swords—so long as Corvus kept his hands off her ovens**!

"Priscus's young *cognitor* and I haven't spoken a civil word since August's rubble-spear, Domina," Lucida lied smoothly, lifting steady amber eyes into Fabia's gaze without giving either yes or refusal, keeping Fabia's protection warm through winter while guarding her own counsel. "Still, clerks drop wax shavings when winter fevers hurry them. If green mastic falls across my broom before spring, Domina will not hear of it second."

Fabia picked up her gold hairpin, slid it into her night-braid with a satisfied purr, and blew out the nearer lamp.

All night long while rain lashed the Aurelian road twelve miles from Rome, twenty-year-old Lucida lay wide awake behind her curtain counting backward from a hundred and sixty-eight, praying to no god on earth save iron mill-axles and dry Sicilian wheat that old Emperor Antoninus's wooden stays held his chest upright until April.

PART FIVE

Aequanimitas

December, AD 160 – March, AD 161

Chapter XXV

Saturn's Scales

Third Day Before the Ides of December, AD 160 · Corvus

Inside the subterranean travertine vaults beneath the **Temple of Saturn**, where Rome had locked its bullion, bronze laws, and fiscal contracts since the Kings were driven out, winter air never warmed past the temperature of river-bottom stone.

Twenty-year-old Corvus stood beside a lead-sheathed stone counting-pier thirty feet below the Forum pavement, warming stiff fingers briefly above a caged brass oil-lantern—open braziers were forbidden on pain of death inside the **Aerarium Saturni**, while two grey-haired public treasury slaves hauled Chest Nineteen of the *Praedia et Figlinae* contractor-rolls out of a recessed peperino niche.

Up above in the yellow December river-fog wrapping the eight colossal granite columns of Saturn's porch, Rome smelled of waiting.

Old Urban Prefect **Lollius Urbicus** lay five months ash inside his tomb; old Praetorian Prefect **Tattius Maximus** had died in autumn, leaving the Guard divided between upright **Furius Victorinus** and Lysistrata's greedy creature **Sextus Cornelius Repentinus** out at Lorium seventy-four-year-old **Antoninus Pius** had canceled two straight December salutations on account of winter catarrh; and every money-changer along the Janus Medius charged half a percent higher interest on ninety-day silver because nobody knew whose face would sit stamped on April's coins.

Beside Corvus, sixty-year-old **Phileros** wiped watering eyes with a linen rag, holding a magnifying globe of clear water-filled rock crystal two inches from the unrolled parchment schedule of **Publius Vedius Pollio**'s *Figlinae Subortanae* imperial brick-supply contract from AD 155–156, the exact

years **Domitia Lucilla**, mother of Marcus Caesar, lay dying while Vedius's factors stripped her clay-beds bare!

"My left eye sees nothing save grey cobwebs in lamp-light now, Sabine," Phileros murmured without self-pity, sliding the crystal globe across the stone pier into Corvus's scarred right hand. "Read the fiscal voucher totals certified by Procurator **Rufus** for Kilns One through Four in the consulship of Severus and Sabinianus, and compare them against the five pine tallies you carried out of the mud at fifteen."

Corvus didn't even need the crystal globe; at twenty his grey-green surveyor's eyes read faded four-year-old iron-gall ink in cellar gloom as sharply as noon chisel-cuts.

Out of his inner leather pouch Corvus drew two things he had carried since October 156: the heavy four-pound circular bronze **signaculum** die (*EX · PR · DOM · LVCILLAE · OP · DOL · L · NAEVI · RVFI*) and the five split pine kiln-tallies stolen off Rufus's counting-table while Mousa bled in the fog.

Line by line across cold stone, four and a half years of buried math locked shut with the clean, terrible ring of an iron portcullis dropping home.

"In AD 155 and 156," Corvus read aloud quietly, scarred thumb tracking the Treasury parchment column, "Publius Vedius Pollio's supply-company drew **seven hundred twenty thousand sesterces** out of the *fiscus* and the *opera publica* chest for delivering two hundred forty thousand first-grade two-foot *bipedales* bricks stamped from Kilns One through Four of *Figlinae Subortanae* for the repair of Trajan's Market vaults and the Ostian granaries. Look at the physical kiln-firing tallies Rufus notched for his own clay-gangs on those exact dates: Kilns One through Four fired **sixty thousand bricks total** across both seasons! One hundred eighty thousand *bipedales*—three-quarters of the entire imperial draw, **five hundred forty thousand sesterces of pure phantom clay**, never entered an oven! Rufus stamped sample top-courses with this bronze die using Domitia Lucilla's exempted tax-mark while shipping cheap unfired sun-dried rubble-fill behind the facing walls!"

Phileros smiled, thin, pale, corpse-cold in the yellow lantern-light.

"Under the *Lex Iulia de Residuis* and Hadrian's fiscal constitutions," Phileros whispered, "defrauding the public *opera* on falsified imperial estate

stamps carries **quadruple restitution**—two million one hundred sixty thousand sesterces instant Treasury lien against every coin, warehouse, and tenement Publius Vedius Pollio owns! And under the statutory *praemium* schedule for private citizen *delatores* who prove hidden public embezzlement without state help, the prosecuting citizen recovers **one full fifth of collected principal, four hundred thirty-two thousand sesterces** paid straight across Saturn's bronze balance!"

Corvus's breath misted white and motionless above the parchment.

Four hundred thirty-two thousand sesterces in a single statutory stroke, vaulting over the **four-hundred-thousand-sesterce equestrian census** in one morning even without touching the **one hundred ninety-four thousand sesterces** already sitting clean inside his Castor box! Six hundred thousand sesterces total—the narrow purple stripe, the gold equestrian ring on his scarred hand, untouchable citizen immunity from the Esquiline cross forever!

"Wait," Corvus said, refusing to let gold dazzle one corner of his surveyor's eye as he unrolled **Sheet Seven** attached to Vedius's Treasury surety-file. "Hermippus isn't stupid. Two years ago, right after I broke Spurius Carvilius's Sandaliarius deed, Hermippus transferred legal Quiritary title over Vedius's Subura commercial leases, Ostian grain-sheds, and Aulus Lucidius's Puteoli patronal reversions into a separate **protective *fiducia cum amico* shield-trust** conveyed *per aes et libram* to Vedius's straw knight **Gaius Munatius**, specifically so that if a fiscal fine ever hit Vedius's brick-company, Vedius's Subura empire sat walled off behind Munatius's bronze-and-scales deed!"

Corvus pulled Sheet Seven, the certified archive copy of that protective *mancipatio* deed—under the brass lantern and ran his scarred thumb straight down the five statutory Roman citizen witnesses listed along the spine:

1. *P. Cornelius Scipio Salvidienus · 2. L. Vibius Rufus · 3. M. Pompeius Silo · 4. C. Terentius Varro · 5.* ***SEX · VIBIVS · M · F · FAL · BALBVS***.

Corvus stopped dead on Witness Five.

Sextus Vibius Balbus, son of Marcus, of the Falerna tribe, a Campanian municipal knight from Capua!

"Phileros," Corvus said very softly, pulse slowing into that dead, lethal courtroom stillness that always preceded blood, "hand me the Praetorian

Prefect's provincial *infamia* index roll from Chest Four, Campania, consulship of Bradua and Varus, four months *before* Vedius executed this shield-trust!"

Even half-blind Phileros sucked breath sharp through his teeth as Corvus dragged down the Campanian roll, flipped three stiff vellum sheets, and stabbed one ink-stained fingernail squarely onto Entry Nine under **CAPVA**:

SEXTVS VIBIVS M · F · FAL · BALBVS — CALVMNIAE DAMNATVS IN IVDICIO PVBLICO ANTE III ID · MAI · BRADVA ET VARO COSS.

Condemned for malicious false accusation in a public criminal trial on the thirteenth of May, four months before standing as fifth citizen witness beside Publius Vedius Pollio's bronze scales!

Under the Praetor's Perpetual Edict and the Law of the Twelve Tables, a man condemned of *calumnia* bore lifelong **infamia** and became **intestabilis**, just as dead in law beside the *mancipatio* balance as stage-player Decimus Atilius had been in Chapter Eleven's Sandaliarius rehearsal!

Vedius Pollio's entire two-million-sesterce protective shield-trust was **rotten wood from the hour the bronze struck the scale**—meaning the instant Corvus proved *both* the Subortanae brick-fraud AND the Caelian fifty-digit lead *fistulae* water-theft (still sitting corked red inside Priscus's cedar cupboard!), **every single asset Vedius thought sheltered, every Ostian lease, every Subura mill-lien, AND Vedius's patronal reversion and Castor Vault Forty-Two!**, collapsed straight into fiscal receivership!

"One problem left before we spring the trap," Phileros cautioned low, closing Chest Nineteen silently before the treasury slave returned. "Gaius Munatius's trust-deed omits Hermippus's private side-ledger proving Vedius kept beneficial enjoyment after the sham sale. To obtain an *instantaneous* emergency interdict and receivership transfer *per aes et libram* on court-day without giving Hermippus forty-eight hours to burn Castor Vault Forty-Two or spirit gold out of Rome, we need **one living patrician or equestrian insider whose own debt-papers carry Hermippus's cross-seal linking Munatius's trust directly back to Vedius's personal chest**—plus five unimpeachable Roman citizen witnesses standing shoulder-to-shoulder at the Praetor's spear!"

Phileros looked meaningfully across the cold lantern-flame at Corvus.

"And tonight at midnight," Phileros added dryly, "Hermippus forecloses **one hundred ten thousand sesterces** of compounded Blue-chariot dice notes against Senator Priscus's own nephew **Aulus Volusenus Niger**, whom Senator Priscus washed his hands of yesterday morning, swearing he would let the boy be posted *decoctor* on the Forum column rather than pay one copper to horse-thieves!"

Corvus slowly rolled the bronze *signaculum* die back into oiled leather.

Hermippus's cross-seal linking Munatius's trust, sitting right on Aulus Volusenus Niger's defaulted gambling notes!

* * *

At the fourth hour of a freezing December night, thick white river-fog had climbed all the way up onto the **Quirinal Hill**, muffling street-lamps to drowned yellow blurs and glazing frost across the silent bronze doors of the **Domus Volusenia**.

Nobody answered Corvus's knock at the main street-portal; every doorkeeper, Gaditane flute-girl, and silver candelabrum from June's drunken symposium had already been sold off to Saepta brokers over the past month to stave off minor creditors. Walking round to the narrow side service-alley, twenty-year-old Corvus pushed against the unbolted oak garden door, felt it swing inward on dry hinges with a mournful creak, and stepped alone into the dark, unheated marble *atrium*.

Moonlight filtering pale and ghostly through fog above the open ceiling *compluvium* showed stripped ancestor-cupboards, dark rectangular dust-scars on plastered walls where painted panels had been pried down for silver, and—dry leaves blown ankle-deep round the dry central rainwater *impluvium* basin.

Sitting slumped on the cold marble rim of that dry basin in a rumpled, wine-stained wide-striped senatorial tunic, barefoot in freezing forty-degree air, unshaved for four days, without a live coal burning anywhere in the cavernous house, sat twenty-three-year-old **Aulus Volusenus Niger**.

Between both puffy, trembling hands Volusenus held a broad-bladed twelve-inch Noric steel **boar-hunting spearhead-knife** (*culter venatorius*), its razor point resting pressed sideways deep into the crease of his own bare right groin directly over the pulsing femoral artery, where Roman

patricians who lacked Cato's nerve to rip open their own bowels opened a two-inch slit that bled a man white to sleep inside three hundred breaths before tomorrow noon's *infamia* placard nailed his father's name to the bankruptcy column.

Hearing Corvus's calm hobnailed step cross the threshold mosaic, Volusenus jerked violently, nicking a quarter-inch bright red bead out of his inner thigh before squinting wild-eyed and tear-streaked through the fog-gloom.

"Hermippus's dogs come early?" Volusenus choked out with a ragged, hysterical laugh that broke in the middle. "Tell your filthy Smyrniot master he's six hours shy of the Kalends, and by dawn all he auctions off this basin is cold meat! Wait." Volusenus blinked hard as Corvus stepped out of pillar-shadow into the grey *compluvium* light. "**Cassius?** Did my uncle send his pet Sabine crow uphill to watch a Volusenus open his leg properly so Priscus can boast of Republican severity in the Curia?"

Twenty-year-old Corvus stood six feet away across dry blown plane-leaves, hands tucked warm inside his dark grey cloak, looking down at the boy who had split his fifteen-year-old lip open with an ivory stylus in Festus's rhetoric gallery while sixteen rich youths laughed, the boy who six months ago in the adjoining *triclinium* had tried to make nineteen-year-old Lucida kneel with ankle-oil before drunken advocates.

One quiet turn on his heel out that garden door, and inside two hundred breaths Aulus Volusenus Niger bled out into the dry rainwater basin, leaving **no rival left inside Priscus's house**.

Instead Corvus stepped smoothly forward, faster than drunken, shivering Volusenus could push steel, and **kicked the flat wood handle of the boar-knife clean out of Volusenus's numb fingers**, sending Noric steel skittering and clanging twenty feet across empty black-and-white mosaic into the corner!

Volusenus doubled over gasping, clutching his nicked thigh with both hands before collapsing into raw, ugly, snot-and-salt weeping against his bare knees, all twenty-three years of oiled Quirinal swagger gone to empty wet rags.

"Get your tunic down over your leg before you freeze your balls off on cold Luna marble, Aulus," Corvus said flatly, without a shred of either theatrical pity or gloating in his deep Sabine voice as he squatted two

paces off on his heels and drew **three heavy, red-sealed wax *chirographa* tablets** out of his leather satchel. "And read the seals on these before you waste good steel."

Volusenus wiped his wet nose roughly on his purple *latus clavus* stripe, squinting down at the three tablets Corvus tossed onto the dry basin-rim beside him.

"My eighty-thousand-sesterce Circus note from March, rolled into **one hundred twelve thousand** payable to Gaius Munatius's trust at dawn!" Volusenus whispered, staring in stunned disbelief from Hermippus's emerald scarab seal up into Corvus's calm grey-green eyes. "Where in Hades did you get Hermippus's active collection-tablets two hours past midnight?!"

"Bought the paper *half an hour* ago through an Ostian shipping factor out of Munatius's greedy junior partner's hand for **forty-two thousand sesterces cash silver** out of my own Castor strongbox," Corvus said calmly, pulling a flint-striker, iron tinder-horn, and bundle of dry pine-shavings out of his pocket to light a small yellow flame right inside the cold bronze brazier-pan standing beside the basin. "Because a careless patrician who never read Julian's title on *usurae* didn't notice that Hermippus rolled thirty-two thousand sesterces of unpaid monthly interest directly into new interest-bearing principal: **illegal compound *anatocismus***, utterly void under every Senate decree since Lucullus, which meant Munatius's factor jumped at forty-two thousand hard silver tonight rather than risk having me plead statutory usury-voidance in court tomorrow."

Volusenus stared mesmerized at the small yellow pine-flame licking up inside the cold brazier, scarcely daring to breathe. "Forty-two thousand of *your* silver... so now *you* own my bankruptcy writ at dawn instead of Vedius Pollio?"

Corvus picked up the two compounding penalty-tablets, seventy thousand sesterces of crushing, career-killing *infamia* paper, and **held their waxed corners straight into the yellow pine-flame**!

Black beeswax hissed, bubbled, and dripped blazing into the cold ash; dry pine wood caught orange along the margins as seventy thousand sesterces of patrician ruin curled into black smoke between Corvus's scarred right thumb and forefinger, leaving **only the clean base forty-two-thousand-sesterce receipt bearing Hermippus's cross-seal to Munatius's trust** intact in Corvus's left hand.

Volusenus's mouth fell open in the orange fire-glow; tears cut clean tracks through the four-day stubble on his cheeks. "Why?" he whispered hoarsely. "I split your mouth open when you didn't even own shoes. I dragged your girl in front of Aufidius's couches in June."

"Touch her name a second time while we both breathe, Aulus, and I'll pick that boar-knife out of the corner and open your groin myself," Corvus said quietly, conversationally, watching the last wax seal turn to grey cinder in the pan. "You owe me forty-two thousand sesterces at honest four percent payable across five years out of your Sabine olive-rents, keeping your senatorial stripe whole and your name off tomorrow's *decoctor* column. In return, I want **two things** signed right now before this pine-shaving goes out."

"Name them!" Volusenus breathed, grabbing eagerly for Corvus's stylus with shaking ringed hands.

"First: your sworn affidavit authenticating Hermippus's own cross-endorsement on this base bond directing payment into **Gaius Munatius's *fiducia* chest for the personal account of Publius Vedius Pollio**, the missing link proving Munatius's trust is a sham front for Vedius's embezzled Treasury silver. Second: on the day old Antoninus dies, or the day Senator Priscus gives me the word, whichever strikes first, **Aulus Volusenus Niger stands beside the Praetor's bronze scales in clean white patrician wool as my fifth Roman citizen witness** when I break Publius Vedius Pollio's entire world in half. Break oath or whisper one word to Hermippus, and this forty-two-thousand base note goes onto the column at noon."

Volusenus did not hesitate half a breath; dropping onto both knees beside the small dying flame in his stripped ancestral hall, Senator Priscus's proud nephew wrote six clean lines of authentication across fresh wax, pressed his red carnelian *quadriga* ring deep into the seal-groove, and caught Corvus's scarred right wrist roughly with both cold hands before Corvus could rise.

"When you strike that fat oyster's shell open, Lucius Cassius," Volusenus whispered fiercely, patrician humiliation burned clean over into lethal convert's zeal against the usurer who had nearly driven steel into his groin, "call me at midnight or noon. I'll hold the bronze scale steady with my own teeth!"

* * *

Six evenings later on the first night of the **Saturnalia**, when the ancient woollen fetters were unbound from the feet of ivory Saturn down in the Forum and half a million Romans poured roaring through the streets in synthesis dining-robes shouting *"Io Saturnalia!"* while household slaves wore conical white felt **pilleus** liberty-caps for five brief carnival days of dice and unpunished insolence, twenty-year-old Corvus sat over roasted thrushes and warm Sabine wine inside **Tullia Crispina's** glazed Carinae winter-triclinium.

Four months after August's great Subura fire, municipal reconstruction orders for seasoned Apennine fir roof-beams and Campanian lime had tripled freight rates along the Tiber wharves; across the inlaid citrus-wood table Crispina's freedman steward counted Corvus's quarter-share dividend from their joint Ostian timber-barges: **thirty-six thousand sesterces** in clean Antonine silver denarii, lifting Corvus's personal liquid reserve back to **one hundred eighty-eight thousand sesterces** even after advancing Volusenus's rescue silver.

"Put two hundred and twelve thousand more beside it before summer, Lucius Cassius," thirty-one-year-old Crispina murmured, leaning one bare ivory-bracelet wrist on her crimson dining-cushion while outside her garden wall drunken Subura fullers beat brass pans and sang ribald verses about Caesar's doctors, "and you won't need Quintus Servilius Priscus's patronage to ask the Censor's clerk for the horse-and-ring. Or", her level dark eyes rested calm and unblushing on his scarred mouth across the lamp-cluster, "marry a Carinae equestrian widow whose timber-wharves already clear four hundred thousand on the Censor's books, and skip waiting for old emperors to cough."

It was the cleanest, safest staircase left in Rome: instant equestrian sufficiency, warm linen, intelligent alliance, no blood in flooded brick cellars, no teeth-marks left burning across his lower lip.

Outside in the frosty lane beyond Crispina's bronze garden-grille, three tipsy Cappadocian litter-slaves stumbled past carrying pine torches, knocking white felt carnival *pillei* askew over scarred ears and roaring laughter that would turn back into iron whip-scars on the morning of the twenty-fourth when the felt caps came off.

Half a mile down the dark hill behind the Forum Piscarium, Corvus knew, nobody was wearing carnival felt tonight; four black volcanic Orvieto

millstones were turning blind and relentless through Saturnalia night just as they turned every other night of the year, white flour powdering dark braids and burned olive forearms while sixty-five-year-old Habinnas Barba coughed rusty paste into his rag so a real bronze plaque—not five days of drunken wool, would stand nailed above the Porticus Minucia in April.

"A man who marries his four hundred thousand across a supper-table never owns his own boots when storm-wind hits the porch, Tullia," Corvus said evenly, signing the timber-quittance with a steady hand and rising into the cold Saturnalia torch-glare. "Keep the barges loaded with seasoned fir; by March I bring my own four hundred thousand to the scales."

Chapter XXVI

Forty Days to April

Seventh Day Before the Kalends of March, Terminalia, AD 161 · Lucida

White hoarfrost lay thick as spilled salt along the basalt threshold of the Fish-Market bakehouse on the morning of the **Terminalia**, and inside the roaring stone courtyard sixty-five-year-old **Habinnas Barba** could no longer lift a sixty-pound Sicilian wheat-sack above his hip without bracing one knee against the hopper-post.

Twenty-year-old Lucida stepped silently across the flour-dusted flags in the red fourth-watch cresset glare, hooked her own strong forearms beneath the bottom corners of the sack before Barba's proud old spine could buckle, and swung all sixty pounds smoothly up over the iron lip of Number Three *catillus* as if they had rehearsed lifting together.

"Bag's stitched crooked at the ear," Barba wheezed through his teeth, refusing to look at her hands as he leaned both knotted palms against the warm volcanic bell until the blue-grey pinch around his nostrils eased. "Agrigentine weavers use rotten hemp since autumn. Don't stand behind my elbow, girl; go check Sura's steelyard."

When he coughed into his folded woollen neck-rag three breaths later, the sound down inside his barrel chest was no longer dry dry-pea rattle; it bubbled thick and wet like porridge boiling low in an iron pot, and the rag he shoved hastily inside his sheepskin vest showed bright rusty streaks even in dim tallow-light.

Asclepiades of Pergamum had told Lucida the plain truth behind closed shutters ten days ago after listening with his ear pressed flat against Barba's flour-scarred back: forty-five winters of volcanic stone-grit and fine wheat-paste had turned half the old Cappadocian soldier's lower lungs to hard grey scar-stone; take him out to sunny Tibur hills away from mill-dust

tomorrow morning and he might breathe two gentle summers yet—leave him standing every midnight inside flour-fog beside four thunderous lava mills, and March cold could drown him in a night.

And three nights ago when Lucida had ordered a sunny room rented for him above an olive-yard on the Aventine with a gentle Syrian boy to boil his goat's-milk, old Barba had picked up his eight-foot iron ember-peel and threatened to smash his own registration plaque off the *Annona* wall if she tried putting him to pasture **forty-five mornings short of the finish-post**!

Up beside Oven One, seventeen-year-old **Sura**, tall, calm-eyed, managing four Marsian kneaders and twelve dawn guild-runners now solely with three sharp taps of an oak tally-stick and lightning chalk, stepped down off her wooden stool and underlined this morning's square white letters twice:

ANNVS III · DIES CCCXX — MODII CXVIII

One thousand and fifty unbroken days and nights.

Lucida stood beside the glowing twelve-foot brick dome doing the subtraction she could have recited backward under torture: **forty-five mornings left** between today's *Terminalia* sacrifice to Jupiter of the Boundary-Stones and the tenth morning of April, when **Day One Thousand Ninety-Five** closed on the Urban Prefect's roll and Junian Latin *Lucida* walked up the marble steps of the Porticus Minucia to receive the bronze citizen certificate that smashed **Publius Vedius Pollio**'s *ius patronatus* to powder forever!

"Look at those numbers, little Tyrian," Barba rasped beside her, solitary black eye shining fierce and fever-bright under chalk-white brows as he rapped one scarred knuckle against Sura's *CCCXX*. "Forty-five sunrises! Shorter than a recruits' march from Caesarea to the Euphrates! Let my chest rattle till Ceres's April horns blow; on the morning of the forty-sixth day I drink three cups of unwatered Chian on the Prefect's steps, watch you spit across Hermippus's boots as a full Roman citizen of the Palatina tribe, and sleep till July!"

Lucida reached out—ignoring his grumpy flinch, and tucked the warm woollen scarf tighter across his heaving throat with fingers faintly stained from yesterday's Caelian alkanet batch.

"Drink the hot squill-and-hyssop mug Sura set on the ash-ledge right now, old mule, or you don't get a drop of Chian in April," Lucida told him

fiercely, swallowing down the sharp ache in her own throat before turning toward the street-arch as red sunrise touched the Forum gables.

* * *

At the seventh hour, wrapped in a sober charcoal-grey woollen *palla* against the biting February river-wind while street-altars on every corner smoked with sacrificial honey-cakes and garlands hung on ancient neighborhood boundary-posts for the *Terminalia*, twenty-year-old Lucida walked slowly along the south flank of the **Temple of Castor** in the Forum Romanum.

High above her head rose the three soaring white Corinthian marble columns supporting the twins' entablature; directly alongside her hip, built straight into the twenty-foot-high concrete-and-travertine podium beneath the temple floor, stood a row of narrow, iron-grated bronze doors (*loculi aerarii*) guarded day and night by armed public watchmen, the safest private safe-deposit vaults in the Roman Empire, where senators, widows, and syndicates stored gold bullion, wills, and sealed criminal denunciations.

Inside her pocket rode the hardened white beeswax impression she had lifted off sleeping **Publius Vedius Pollio**'s bedside dish six months ago: **AEDE · CASTORIS · ARCA · XLII**.

Even sixty gold *aurei* wouldn't bribe a daytime Castor vault-warden to open Door Forty-Two without both Vedius's emerald scarab AND the registered depositor present in flesh; Lucida was walking the narrow travertine lane between Castor's podium and the round smoke-plumed roof of **Vesta's Temple** simply to see which clerk held the fourth-watch night roster —when out from the shadowed colonnade of the **Lacus Juturnae** spring stepped an old, stoop-shouldered Greek freedman wrapped to his ears in a faded dark cloak, tapping the wet travertine curb cautiously ahead of his sandals with a peeled hazel wand.

Three worn bone wax-scrapers hung silent at his belt-ring, though his left eye stared completely milky-blind into the February mist and his right squinted half-shut behind red rims.

Phileros.

Since that violent September cloudburst inside Lot Fourteen's brick vault five months ago, Lucida had neither spoken one word to **Lucius Cassius Corvus** nor crossed within fifty paces of Senator Priscus's Caelian

household. Seeing Priscus's thirty-year shadow standing ten feet away beside Juturna's cold marble basin made every nerve along Lucida's wrists go taut at once.

She started to step smoothly past without greeting; Phileros tilted his shaved grey chin two inches toward the faint rustle of her Tarsian woollen hem and spoke low in Syrian-inflected Greek:

"Don't hurry past the water, daughter of Lucida Tyria. A blind clerk sells cleaner merchandise than sighted ones, because he can't identify his buyer's face tomorrow before a praetor."

Lucida stopped three paces from the marble spring-curb, checking both ends of the misty travertine colonnade: only two Vestal temple-sweepers forty yards off and idle pigeons ruffling feathers against frost.

"Senator Priscus's archive-master has the wrong woman if he's peddling boundary-scrolls," Lucida said coldly.

Phileros gave a dry, soundless chuckle that showed pale gums. "Four and a half years ago in November I bought your Sabine boy's first brick-stamp whisper in the Clivus Scauri vestibule for four sesterces a day. Next month, once Quintus Servilius Priscus puts the narrow purple stripe on twenty-year-old **Lucius Cassius Corvus**, Priscus sends half-blind old Phileros out to count olives on a damp Tusculan hillside at twelve sesterces a month until dropsy finishes me. Before I go count olives, I intend to sew **fifty gold *aurei*** inside my saddle-pad, and nobody in Rome today needs fifty gold pieces' worth of Castor air half as badly as a Junian baker-girl with forty-five mornings left on her slate."

Lucida's fingers slid inside her cloak-fold without making a sound. "Fifty gold pieces buys facts with dates and seals attached, Greek—never smoke. Give me one corner free so I know your basket isn't empty."

Phileros turned his milky eye toward the iron-barred bronze doors set into Castor's concrete podium twenty paces west.

"Door Forty-Two," Phileros murmured softly, and Lucida's heart gave one cold, silent thud against her ribs. "Two days ago at dusk, **Hermippus** met **Gaius Vibius**, confidential urban clerk to Praetorian Prefect **Sextus Cornelius Repentinus**, outside Vault Forty-Two to add a fresh co-depositor seal. Inside sits a sworn capital *delatio* under the *Lex Cornelia de Sicariis et Veneficis*, signed by your frightened former garret-girl **Myrtale**, whom Scaeva tracked down in Ostia this winter!—accusing one-eyed **Berenice** of

the Argiletum and **Lucida, Junian Latin**, of compounding and delivering lethal abortive hellebore-and-savin poisons to Caelian houses, causing the death of a slave-maid three winters back."

Every breath of February mist felt like crushed glass entering Lucida's lungs, though her voice stayed level as weighed iron: "The slave-maid behind Ceionia Fabia's screen in December didn't die; Dorcas married her off to a country bailiff at Praeneste!"

"Dead or picking turnips at Praeneste matters **six weeks after arrest**, girl, never on arrest night!" Phileros hissed gently. "Repentinus's clerk endorsed that packet for summary interregnum execution under public-safety powers **the hour couriers ride in from Lorium**, and yesterday afternoon old **Emperor Antoninus** walked ten paces outside his Lorium colonnade in cold sea-wind, took a shaking chill in his chest, and went to bed refusing supper! If Antoninus dies next week instead of April, Scaeva and Repentinus's urban *stationarii* kick in Berenice's door and your Fish-Market bakehouse **within three hours of midnight**, lock your four lava mills behind military seals while dragging you to the Prefecture cells, and **kill forty-five remaining mornings of your three-year citizenship run before sunrise**, even if Ceionia Fabia pulls you out of chains three days later!"

Fifty gold *aurei* was five thousand sesterces—nearly a sixth of Lucida's entire liquid reserve after repairing Lot Fourteen, and worth ten times the price for warning alone.

"My runner brings twenty-five gold pieces to the Juturna steps within the hour, and twenty-five more when you name the second half of your basket," Lucida said crisply, reading from the tilt of the old Greek's mouth that he had kept his sharpest hook for dessert. "Speak it now."

Phileros leaned two inches closer on his peeled hazel stick, milky eye staring blind past her shoulder toward the Curia Julia.

"You think your childhood friend **Lucius Cassius Corvus** will save your ovens if Vedius falls first?" Phileros whispered, not maliciously, with the terrible, clinical indifference of a man who had watched Roman contracts eat human hearts for forty winters. "Listen to the exact wording of the emergency fiscal receivership decree I helped Corvus engross last night for the *Praetor Aerarii*! The morning old Antoninus dies—before Repentinus can unseal Vault Forty-Two, Corvus intends to spring his *Figlinae Subor-*

tanae brick-fraud and Caelian water-theft before five citizen witnesses, voiding Gaius Munatius's shield-trust *per aes et libram* and sweeping **every single mill, warehouse, and patronal claim of Publius Vedius Pollio** into summary state-and-receivership sequestration under Corvus's own seal!"

"Corvus screamed in September that putting his own name on that receivership sheet was meant to shield my ovens," Lucida said low, throat dry as chalk.

"Perhaps his twenty-year-old heart even believes so," Phileros replied softly, tapping his hazel stick once on wet travertine, "because even clever twenty-year-olds forget **Paragraph Nine of the Treasury Receivership Instructions** until the clerks arrive with lead wire! Whenever *any* commercial *pistrinum* carrying a disputed patronal reversion or syndicate lien enters *aerarium* receivership, regardless of who sits named as *sequester*—**sworn Treasury *tabularii* padlock the hoppers and suspend commercial grinding for three mandatory market-days** while weighing grain-stock against state claims! Three unground mornings on Day One Thousand Fifty-Five, daughter of Tyria, kills Trajan's unbroken three-year statute **just as stone-dead as Scaeva's iron crowbars**, leaving your citizenship dead on the floor and your Junian reversion sitting legally inside **Lucius Cassius Corvus's** four-hundred-thousand-sesterce equestrian strongbox!"

For five heartbeats the entire Forum Romanum, white marble temples, wheeling winter gulls, shouting lawyers pouring out of the Basilica Julia across the square—went dead silent inside Lucida's ears.

Three mandatory market-days of Treasury hopper-padlocks the hour Vedius Pollio's estate enters fiscal receivership.

Whether **Vedius Pollio** struck first with Vault Forty-Two's poison warrant, OR **Corvus** struck first with his grand fiscal *per aes et libram* triumph, **either hammer hitting Rome before mid-April snapped her thousand-and-fifty-day mill-run forty mornings short of citizen liberty**!

And once her statutory mill-road broke, with Vedius ruined and Priscus's faction seizing the courts unless **Lucius Ceionius Commodus** took co-equal purple at the **Castra Praetoria**! only **one person on earth** held power to sign an immediate imperial citizenship rescript (*ius*

Quiritium and *restitutio natalium*) over the heads of Treasury clerks and poison-warrants alike:

Emperor Lucius Verus—for the price **Ceionia Fabia** had named in the dark inn at Lorium!

Lucida reached inside her belt-wallet right there behind Juturna's marble screen, counted **twenty-five heavy gold *aurei***, she always walked the Forum carrying emergency gold sewn flat along her ribs since August! silently into Phileros's dry, papery palm, and promised the remaining twenty-five at Berenice's herb-counter before dusk.

"Enjoy your Tusculan olives, Phileros," Lucida whispered, and turned north toward the Argiletum stairs at a swift, silent walk.

* * *

Seventy-eight worn pine steps above the noisy shoemakers' stalls of the Argiletum, sixty-four-year-old **Berenice**'s sixth-floor garret smelled identically of dried rue, white lead, fried onions, and rat-droppings as it had on the rainy October dusk when two barefoot fifteen-year-olds climbed out of the Subura mud.

Only Berenice herself had shrunk smaller under her motheaten wolf-pelt shawl, her single good right eye squinting sharp as a needle through tallow-smoke as twenty-year-old Lucida bolted the fir door behind her and laid **ten gold *aurei*** (1,000 HS travel-silver!) plus an Ostian mule-voucher flat on the old Hebrew tombstone grinding-slab.

"Myrtale sang to Hermippus's clerk in Ostia, Beroe," Lucida said without wasting a breath on cushions. "Vault Forty-Two at Castor holds a capital Sullan *venena* warrant naming both of us over December's green bottles, countersigned by Repentinus's Prefecture clerk to execute the night old Antoninus dies at Lorium—and Antoninus went to bed with chest-fever yesterday afternoon. Leave the white-lead pots on the shelf, take my Marsian cart waiting downstairs before the ninth hour, and go straight down to my cousin's dye-yard at Puteoli until I send Sura's thrush-sign."

Old Berenice stared down at the ten gold pieces gleaming on the carved Hebrew letters of the dead child's stone, chewed her toothless lower lip twice, and then, with the infuriating, fatal stubbornness of old women who have survived sixty-four hard winters on one square yard of floorboards,

pushed five of the gold coins back and hobbled to her top cedar shelf instead!

"Not tonight before the Kalends, little hawk," Berenice rasped, dragging down a heavy leaded iron strong-tin where she kept thirty years of buried Syrian gold earrings and emerald-paste beads hidden behind dried squid-bones. "Gaius the Syrian perfume-factor owes me **sixteen hundred sesterces** payable cash across my counter on the third day of March! Leave Rome tonight, and that oily Sidonian thief swears I died and steals forty winters of my burial-silver! I've got the cobbler's boy down at the street-arch paid two denarii to whistle if soldiers turn off the Forum—give me six days to collect Gaius's silver on the Nones, and my mule trots out the Ostian Gate before moonrise!"

"Beroe, if Lorium sends riders before the Nones, "

"Old emperors with four Greek doctors take ten days dying of winter phlegm; my second husband took five in a cold garret!" Berenice snapped, pressing into Lucida's reluctant palm a **flat, thumb-sized lead horn-box sealed with red pitch**. "Keep your five gold pieces for your Marsians, girl, and carry *this* inside your belt-seam till April: finely ground **unslaked Puteoli quicklime mixed with dried euphorbia-resin dust**. Throw one pinch upward across a hound's or a bailiff's open eyes in a narrow doorway, and water in his eyeballs boils white blind before he draws breath to swing! My mother carried it out of Ascalon when Titus's soldiers marched south."

Lucida closed her fingers tight around the cold lead quicklime-box, looking round the tiny fourteen-by-eleven-foot garret, at the sagging wicker screen behind which fifteen-year-old Corvus had coughed rusty blood while she held his freezing ribs against her bare skin in the dark, swearing neither plank, sickness, nor senator would ever tear them apart.

Through the unglazed dormer crack outside, freezing February twilight was turning the vast sea of Subura pantiles iron-blue toward the Caelian ridge on the south and the towering Castra Praetoria ramparts on the north-east.

Forty-five mornings left on her honest millstones.

And if old Emperor Antoninus Pius failed to hold breath for forty-five mornings—if black riders galloped down the Via Aurelia next week while Vedius's noose and Corvus's Treasury padlocks converged simultaneously on her Fish-Market arch, twenty-year-old Lucida tucked Berenice's blinding

quicklime-box deep inside her belt beside her boot-knife, knowing down in the marrow of her bones that whatever burned in Rome that night, **she would not die a slave**.

Chapter XXVII

The Cracked Tile

Fourth Day Before the Nones of March, AD 161 · Corvus

An Empire that had stood still for twenty-two summers began sliding into the sea over three slices of **Alpine cheese**.

At dusk on the fourth day before the Nones of March, while cold sleet-mixed rain blew sideways off the Tiber across Senator Priscus's Caelian courtyard, a mud-plastered freedman groom from Marcus Caesar's private Lorium household flung himself off a blown bay mule before the postern gate had half-opened, tracking yellow Aurelian road-clay straight across black-and-white geometric mosaic into the bolted *tablinum*.

Twenty-year-old Corvus stood beside the glowing oak brazier warming ink-horns for **Priscus** and **Quintus Junius Rusticus** both consular senators stayed seated like carved peperino tomb-figures while the panting courier knelt and spoke six low sentences in Greek:

"At supper last evening the Emperor called twice for aged Raetian **Alpine cheese** with honeyed mulsum against the Pergamene physician's prayer. Around the third watch he vomited black sour curds till morning; at sunrise violent fever seized both lungs. By noon today he was talking in delirium to dead kings about tribute-defaults and foreign embassies. Caesar Marcus has not left his bedside since the fourth hour and sends word by his own ring: *two nights at most; keep the Curia lists clean*."

Priscus dismissed the soaking courier to the kitchen hearth with two gold pieces and waited until the heavy cedar door-bolt shot home.

Inside the silent study, twenty-two years of Antonine gold turned abruptly to cold iron.

"Alpine cheese at seventy-four," Priscus murmured dryly, cracking a fennel seed between yellow back molars without a trace of grief. "Even gods

die through their teeth. Junius: does **Furius Victorinus** hold the night watch at the Praetorian Camp tomorrow, or **Cornelius Repentinus**?"

"Repentinus takes the Guard watch on the sixth and the Nones," Rusticus answered grimly, ink-stained thumb rubbing the coarse dark fold of his *abolla*. "And Repentinus had four horse-couriers saddled outside **Ceionia Fabia's** Caelian gate an hour before sunset—clearly **Galeria Lysistrata** sent her own bedroom runner ahead of Marcus's man! The hour old Antoninus stops breathing, Fabia and **Vedius Pollio** will push young Lucius straight toward the Praetorian ramparts unless two hammers fall before noon: Marcus holding undivided Eastern military loyalty, and Vedius Pollio stripped bare of coined silver before he can underwrite a single Praetorian donative!"

Priscus turned his sharp slate-grey eyes squarely onto twenty-year-old **Corvus**.

"Before the Castor strongroom grilles shut at the second hour tonight, Lucius Cassius," Priscus ordered quietly, "go fetch **my green-sealed Syrian lime-bark duplicate** out of your private arca and bring it back here before cockcrow so Scaurianus's fast Liburnian galley sails from Brundisium with the matched key the instant Lorium flashes torches. Second: are **Aulus Volusenus** and your other four citizen witnesses ready to stand before Urban Fiscal Praetor **Manius Acilius** at thirty breaths' call?"

"All five sworn and waiting inside the first milestone, Senator," Corvus answered cleanly, and added one detail he had quietly engineered that very afternoon over wine with young **Quaestor Caecilius** at the Treasury: "And Quaestor Caecilius has initialed an administrative rider exempting active *annona* bread-ovens from temporary inventory-padlocks during receivership transfer, provided the operating co-master countersigns my interim custody receipt before the seal-clerks march."

Neither Priscus nor Rusticus cared a straw about minor *annona* bakehouse riders at an hour when thrones shook; Priscus nodded once:

"Good. Bring me the green terebinth packet before the fourth watch, boy—and the afternoon Publius Vedius Pollio's scales tip in the Basilica, **four hundred thirty-two thousand sesterces** fiscal bounty puts the gold ring on your finger before the old Emperor's pyre cools."

* * *

At the second hour of the night Corvus unlocked Box Nineteen inside the concrete podium of **Castor's Temple**, passing thirty paces east of **Vault Forty-Two** without knowing Myrtale's capital poison warrant sat ticking like a coiled adder behind its bronze grille! tucked Priscus's thin oilskin packet sealed in pale green Chian mastic safely inside the inner pocket of his leather dispatch-satchel alongside Quaestor Caecilius's fresh *annona* padlock-waiver, and stepped back out into the cold March rain.

Priscus's Caelian house lay straight south up the Clivus Scauri.

Corvus's boots turned north-west toward the smoky red glow behind the **Forum Piscarium** instead.

Five months and twelve days had passed since **Lucida** walked barefoot out of Lot Fourteen's flooded vault leaving her teeth-blood drying on his mouth and two desecrated graves lying like drawn swords between them. Five months during which twenty-year-old Corvus had buried himself eighteen hours a day inside Treasury parchments, bought Volusenus off a hunting-knife, pushed his liquid Castor chest past a hundred and fifty thousand sesterces even after Volusenus's loan, and crossed the street twice in January fog rather than force his shadow across her path.

Tonight old Antoninus Pius lay dying twelve miles west, **Cornelius Repentinus** commanded twelve cohorts of Praetorian iron on the Nones, **Scaeva's** thugs were prowling every Subura corner, and unless Lucida **countersigned Quaestor Caecilius's interim custody receipt** before Corvus sprang his fiscal receivership over Vedius Pollio's estate, routine Treasury clerks *would* slap three-day inventory padlocks across her hoppers and break her three-year citizenship count **fewer than forty mornings from home**!

Inside the Fish-Market alley, warm nutty steam of baking Sicilian loaves rolled out into the freezing drizzle alongside the deep, rhythmic subterranean *grrrm-grrrm-grrrm* of all four volcanic lava mills turning steady through their **thousand-and-fifty-ninth unbroken night**.

Rather than knocking at the lower courtyard gate where Marsian kneaders worked around sick old Habinnas Barba's brazier—through the crack of the shutter Corvus glimpsed white-haired Barba sitting propped on three grain-sacks wrapped in sheepskins beside Oven One, breathing shallow through parted bluish lips while stubbornly watching the third-watch peel-count! Corvus climbed the familiar outside brick staircase to the upper loft and rapped softly on the shuttered pine door:

Tap-tap. Pause. *Tap.*

For five rain-dripping heartbeats nothing moved inside.

Then the interior iron bolt slid slowly back, and seventeen-year-old **Sura** opened the door six inches, lifting a horn oil-lamp high.

Her right hand wasn't holding the lamp; Sura's right palm was wrapped clumsily in a blood-spotted linen rag where a sharp edge of sheet-copper off Number Two hopper-chute had sliced across her skin an hour ago, and three paces behind her beside the glowing charcoal pan stood twenty-year-old **Lucida** warming pine-resin salve over the coals in a small bronze spoon.

Lucida wore a dark woollen working tunic belted snug at her waist, blue-black braids coiled high and fastened through the center knot with **Ceionia Fabia's six-inch green emerald-headed gold pin**. Five hard winter months had honed subtle hollows beneath her high olive cheekbones, making her dark amber eyes look larger, fiercer, and older than twenty in the yellow tallow glow.

Seeing Corvus standing tall in the doorway, rain streaming off his dark grey cloak, the faint pale line of September's tooth-scar still visible across his scarred lower lip—Sura stepped back automatically with wide, anxious grey eyes to let him out of the rain before glancing in mute appeal toward Lucida for pardon.

Lucida did not order him down the stairs; neither did she set down the hot bronze salve-spoon.

"Why are you climbing Fish-Market stairs at midnight in March rain, Lucius Cassius?" she asked quietly.

"Shut the door against the draft first," Corvus said, stepping just inside onto the warm terracotta tiles where he had slept with his cheek two inches from her ankle at seventeen, unbuckling his soaked outer cloak and setting his **leather dispatch-satchel** down beside the wooden flour-chest near the door-jamb so wet leather wouldn't spot Sura's sleeping-mat. "Let me bind Sura's hand straight while I talk; that rag's tied crooked across the thumb-web and it'll split open first sack she lifts."

Before proud Lucida could object, Corvus knelt on one knee beside seventeen-year-old Sura on the rush mat, who trusted Corvus with childlike certainty despite five months of adult war, took the warm pine-resin spoon gently out of Lucida's fingers without brushing her skin, and began cleaning and strapping Sura's three-inch copper cut with swift, practiced country-

boy care while speaking low and fast so not a syllable carried down through the floor-joints to the Marsians below.

"Listen to every word without interrupting me, Lucida," Corvus said over Sura's bandaged fingers. "Yesterday evening at Lorium **Emperor Antoninus** ate Raetian Alpine cheese, vomited through the third watch, and lies burning in chest-delirium tonight. Marcus Caesar's own courier rode into Priscus's yard at dusk giving the old man **forty-eight hours at most**."

Behind Corvus's bent dark shoulder, twenty-year-old Lucida stood completely still beside the wooden flour-chest—two feet away from Corvus's unlatched wet leather dispatch-satchel resting on the warm tiles!

Forty-eight hours at most. Thirty-seven mornings too early for April tenth; four days too early even for stubborn old Berenice's sixth-of-March departure to Puteoli!

"Why bring Caelian death-watches to a Subura bakehouse?" Lucida asked, keeping her voice level as cold water while her eyes dropped once, silent, razor-swift, to the brass buckle of Corvus's wet satchel beside the chest.

"Because **Cornelius Repentinus** holds the Praetorian watch on the sixth and the Nones, and Scaeva's dogs will own every unguarded alley in Rome during the twelve-hour interregnum before the Senate sits!" Corvus said urgently, knotting Sura's clean linen strip firm around her wrist and turning on one knee to look straight up into Lucida's face, pulling **Quaestor Caecilius's waxed administrative custody-and-waiver sheet** out of his tunic breast! "The morning Lorium sends word, before noon, I go before Fiscal Praetor Acilius with five citizen witnesses and **destroy Publius Vedius Pollio root and branch**—breaking his *Figlinae Subortanae* fraud and voiding Gaius Munatius's trust *per aes et libram* in a single hour! Every lease and patronal claim Vedius holds passes into my receivership custody, and if you **countersign this temporary ten-day administrative custody receipt tonight** placing your Fish-Market operating keys formally under my *sequester* seal through the interregnum, Quaestor Caecilius waives inventory padlocks while you and Sura stay safe behind four armed Caelian watchmen inside my Carinae house until Vedius is in exile!"

Lucida looked down at the waxed official sheet held out in Corvus's scarred right hand, headed **TRADITIO CLAVIVM TEMPORARIA**

IN MANVM L · CASSII CORVI SEQUESTRIS (*Temporary Delivery of Keys into the Hand of Receiver Lucius Cassius Corvus*)!

Everything half-blind **Phileros** had sold her for fifty gold pieces behind Juturna's spring eight days ago screamed loud as brass trumpets inside her skull—twisted fatally darker by five months of distrust:

Sign traditio clavium *handing legal possession of her bakehouse keys over to Receiver Lucius Cassius Corvus tonight, and the instant Corvus ceases to be mere silent landlord and takes formal possession as* ***operating sequester***, ***Lucida ceases in law to be independent*** **exercitor** ***personally running the mill under Trajan's Edict****, killing her forty remaining days on fine-print technicality while locking her inside Senator Priscus's camp right when Repentinus unseals Castor Vault Forty-Two!*

Corvus truly thought, she could see the raw, fierce, desperate sincerity blazing in his grey-green eyes!—that dragging her inside his legal fortress for ten days would save her skin from Scaeva's clubs; **he could not even see that his fortress erased three years of her blood and left her dependent on his citizen mercy for every breath she drew afterward**!

Whereas three inches inside Corvus's damp leather satchel beside the flour-chest, she could smell the unmistakable sharp, medicinal breath of **warmed Chian terebinth mastic** drifting up off the damp leather as heat from Barba's ovens below warmed the floor-tiles! lay **Senator Priscus's Syrian succession letter**, the exact talisman for which **Ceionia Fabia** and soon-to-be co-Emperor **Lucius Verus** would burn Vault Forty-Two unopened and sign **Lucida's unconditional imperial Roman citizenship** in wet purple ink before sunrise!

Destroy Corvus's patron Priscus—knowing Corvus himself would cross **four hundred thirty-two thousand sesterces** into equestrian immunity (honestior, safe from the Esquiline cross!) the moment his Vedius bounty cleared! or watch forty remaining days of her freedom die under twin hammers?

"Sura," Lucida said calmly in Greek without taking her eyes off Corvus, "go down to the cooling-arch with your clean bandage and bring Master Cassius and me two warm mugs of spiced barley-water before he walks back into the sleet, and check that Barba drank his squill-syrup."

Seventeen-year-old Sura nodded obediently, picked up her small shutter-lantern, and slipped quietly out down the outside brick steps, pulling the door-latch to behind her.

"Let me fetch the iron ink-horn and my brass bakery stamp from behind the partition screen so you can show me Caecilius's clause under the lamp, Corvus," Lucida said softly—stepping behind Corvus's back toward the low wooden flour-chest beside the door while indicating the charcoal pan in the front corner. "Hold that wax near the coals; rain's chilled the surface too hard to read."

Unsuspecting, heart lifting with sudden, immense relief at hearing her ask to read the clause instead of shouting him out the door! twenty-year-old Corvus turned toward the glowing charcoal brazier in the front corner, crouching on one knee with his back squarely toward the door-chest to tilt Caecilius's damp wax tablet toward the red coals.

Six feet behind his turned broad shoulders, twenty-year-old Lucida moved without drawing one audible breath, hands swifter and stiller than when she melted Fabia's ivory love-note against Trajan's scalding copper steam-pipe.

One noiseless lift of Corvus's damp satchel flap; fingers dipping straight into the inner leather pocket; drawing out the flat three-by-five-inch oilskin wallet sealed at one corner with **pale pistachio-green Chian mastic stamped with Priscus's terebinth tree**!

Touching the warm tip of her thin bronze salve-spatula—still hot from the brazier coals thirty breaths earlier! for two heartbeats underneath the green mastic edge lifted the resin seal cleanly off the oiled skin without cracking a single branch of the stamped terebinth tree. Out slid **one razor-thin shaved lime-bark leaf (*philyra*) covered in neat shifted Greek columns written in Corvus's own unmistakable upright hand** into its exact place inside the oilskin went an identical-weight blank shaving of thin linden-bark packing from her Caelian salve-box; one firm thumb-press re-tacked the warm green mastic shut; back into the inner satchel pocket slid the oilskin wallet, flap lowered at the exact angle Corvus had left it, all inside **twelve noiseless heartbeats** while rain drummed steady on the roof-pantiles overhead!

Lucida tucked Priscus's treasonous Syrian bark-leaf flat inside her high-laced bodice directly over her pounding ribs, picked up her cold dry ink-

horn from the chest, and walked calmly across the warm tiles to stand beside Corvus at the brazier.

Corvus stood up to his full six feet in the red coal-glow, holding out the waxed custody-receipt and stylus with hope shining naked and unguarded across his lean, rain-wet twenty-year-old face—for ten heartbeats looking wholly like the fifteen-year-old boy who had carried half a roast kid up Vicus Cuprius in his first pair of shoes.

"Sign just below Barba's bakery title on Line Six, Vespera," Corvus said low, "and pack one dry tunic; Sura and the Marsians can sleep in my ground-floor study until, "

"Leave the tablet on my counting-stool till tomorrow's sixth hour so Habinnas Barba, who holds half our registered *societas* seal—puts his thumb beside mine after dawn bake," Lucida interrupted gently, taking the wax tablet out of his hand and laying it unbroken on her stool without signing a stroke tonight. "Sign behind old Barba's back while he's spitting blood downstairs, and he'll pull his name off the *Annona* plaque before noon out of pure Cappadocian pride. Send your Carinae clerk round tomorrow afternoon, if Lorium's torches haven't burned yet."

It sounded completely true to old Barba's fierce character; Corvus hesitated half a breath, looking down into her shadowed amber eyes, then nodded slowly.

"Tomorrow at the sixth hour, not one watch later," Corvus agreed, stooping by the chest to swing his wet cloak and leather satchel—feeling its familiar weight wholly unchanged! back across his broad shoulder before pausing with his hand on the wooden latch.

Outside on the stairs Sura had lingered thoughtfully under the eaves to give them peace.

Looking up six inches at twenty-year-old Corvus in the dim red glow, knowing with terrible, crystal finality that within forty-eight hours his Caelian patron **Quintus Servilius Priscus** would fall ruined before Praetorian swords because of the thin bark leaf burning right now against her own breastbone, while Corvus's own 432,000 HS Vedius bounty would carry Corvus across the equestrian line where no executioner's nail could touch him, **and knowing he would hate the ground under her sandals until the day one of them died once he learned whose hand carried**

Priscus's letter to the Camp—Lucida stepped across the two feet of warm terracotta between them.

She did not reach for his scarred mouth; September's blood had sealed their mouths shut.

Instead she took Corvus's scarred, rain-cold right hand between both her warm, alkanet-shadowed palms, lifted his knuckles slowly in the quiet loft, and **pressed her lips once, long, dry, still, solemn as wine poured down a February tomb-pipe for the beloved dead, straight onto the raised white crescent brick-stamp scar across his right thumb**.

Corvus's breath caught deep in his chest; his fingers tightened once round hers, mistaking a funeral rite for truce.

"Vespera—" he whispered rough in the dark.

"Go up your hill out of the rain, Lucius Cassius," Lucida said softly, releasing his hand and stepping back behind the threshold. "And stand clear of crooked walls when the wind shifts."

She closed the heavy pine door between their faces and slid the iron bolt home with both hands, leaning her forehead flat against cold iron in the dark until his footsteps faded down the wet brick stairs into the night.

Chapter XXVIII

Alpine Cheese

Night of the Day Before the Nones to the Nones of March, AD 161 · Lucida

Out at Lorium twelve miles west through freezing March rain, when the tribune of the Praetorian night-watch stepped beside the narrow camp-bed at the second watch to ask the Emperor for the night's password, seventy-four-year-old **Antoninus** opened fever-bright blue eyes one final time, ordered the golden household statuette of Fortune carried across the passage into **Marcus**'s bedroom, spoke a single Latin word to the soldier —***"Aequanimitas"***, and turned his face quietly toward the wall as if going to sleep.

Nobody down behind the **Forum Piscarium** heard that noble Latin noun.

Down in the smoky mud of Rome two hours past midnight, an Emperor's death arrived first as the frantic bare-heeled slap of a twelve-year-old Argiletum cobbler's apprentice skidding through black slush to hammer both bleeding fists against Habinnas Barba's bolted oak postern!

Inside the blazing courtyard, where all four Orvieto lava mills thundered steady through **Day One Thousand Sixty-One** (**thirty-four mornings left** until mid-April's citizen bronze!) and Lucida stood fully dressed in stout leather boots with Priscus's stolen Syrian bark-leaf stitched inside a flat oiled kidskin pouch directly beneath her breast-band—she shot back the bronze spy-slit herself before the boy's third blow fell.

White-faced, drenched to the bone, trembling too violently to speak straight Latin, the cobbler's boy pressed his mouth right against the iron grille:

"Old Caesar's dead out on the coast road, Lysistrata's riders passed the gate an hour back! ***One-Ear*** *and six men in green cloaks with four urban*

*cohort soldiers just went up **Berenice's** seventy-eight stairs without lanterns, they threw her Hebrew stone through the sixth-floor shutter onto the cobbles, Mistress, and her wolf-pelt came down after it with blood on the fur! They're marching down the Sandaliarius cut toward your arch right now with iron crowbars!"*

For one single frozen breath between two revolutions of Number One lava stone, **sixty-four-year-old Berenice**—chewing roasted pine-nuts with one milky eye aimed at rafters, sliding hot goat's-fat across fifteen-year-old Corvus's torn shin, pressing Ascalon quicklime into Lucida's palm forty-eight hours too proud to leave sixteen hundred sesterces behind, died behind Lucida's unblinking amber eyes without Lucida daring to shed one drop of salt before the axes hit her gate.

She shoved two silver denarii through the spy-slit into the terrified cobbler-boy's fingers, *"Run across the Forum Boarium and hide in your aunt's loft till noon!"*—slammed the bronze plate shut, and whirled into the red cresset-lit courtyard.

"Marsians, unhook the four mules from the sweep-bars and drive them into the back stone stall behind the bar!" Lucida barked, her voice cutting clean as a legionary trumpet over the deep *grrrm* of grinding stone. "Sura, grab the waterproof oilskin ledger-bag, two wool cloaks, and unbolt the loft roof-hatch onto the fuller's pantiles! Barba—up the brick ladder right this heartbeat ahead of me, Scaeva's thirty paces up the lane with Repentinus's warrant and Berenice is dead!"

Four burly Marsian kneaders dropped wooden dough-paddles instantly, snatching oak carrying-poles out of wall-racks as seventeen-year-old **Sura** snatched the oiled ledger-sack off its peg and drew her curved six-inch steel baker's dough-scraper knife from her apron sheath.

Only sixty-five-year-old **Habinnas Barba** did not move one step toward the outside brick ladder.

Standing between the white-hot roaring mouth of Oven One and the narrow six-foot vaulted stone passage connecting the front street-postern to the inner mill-yard, the old one-eyed Cappadocian soldier-baker wiped a thin trickle of rusty pink foam off his grey moustache with the back of his forearm, planted both flour-white boots wide on the basalt flags he had swept for twenty-six winters, and lifted his **eight-foot, twenty-pound solid iron oven-peel** straight out of the glowing red coal-bed!

The broad twelve-inch flat iron blade at the end of the shaft glowed dull cherry-orange along both edges, hissing fiercely as stray drops of courtyard rain hit hot metal.

"Four wet Subura roofs between here and the Carinae steps, little Tyrian," Barba wheezed, and for the first time all winter his solitary black eye shone clear and steady, stripped of pain, back at thirty years old holding a Cappadocian mountain pass under Arrian's eagles. "Put my sixty-five-year-old lead lungs on slippery rain-tiles behind you and Sura, and Scaeva's hounds catch all three of us before the second gutter! That front passage is five feet ten inches wide, one iron shovel holds six bastards off that ladder for two hundred breaths while you clear the fullery ridge!"

"Habinnas, drop the peel and climb—that's an order from your co-*exercitor*!" Lucida shouted fiercely, lunging back across the yard to grab his flour-stiffened sheepskin sleeve,

CRASH!

Outside on the Fish-Market lane, a two-man iron-shod municipal felling-axe slammed square into the upper iron hinge-strap of the oak street-postern, splintering two-inch seasoned timber inward in a shower of white oak shards!

Through the jagged split echoed **Gaius Ummidius Scaeva's** harsh camp roar above rain and clanking military hobnails:

"Open in the name of Prefect Repentinus on capital Sullan veneficium *warrant! Save your breath screaming for Senator Priscus's pet surveyor, Tyrian bitch,* ***Cassius Corvus already lodged Treasury receivership seals shutting these hoppers down himself at dusk****! Your mill-count's dead meat from both ends of the street—bring her ankles out whole and smash the stones!"*

Cassius Corvus already lodged Treasury receivership seals shutting these hoppers down himself at dusk!

Scaeva had heard half a twisted clerk's leak off Quaestor Caecilius's preliminary docket-entry from afternoon, flinging Corvus's name through the splintered oak like a poisoned javelin purely to freeze defenders' hands, and down in the red oven-glare **both Habinnas Barba and Lucida heard every word**!

CRASH! CRACK!

The lower iron drop-bar socket sheared clean out of crumbling travertine mortar; the splintered oak gate burst inward off one hinge; and into the narrow five-foot-ten vaulted stone throat poured **four helmeted urban *stationarii* carrying hide shields and ash clubs** right behind **two bull-necked Cappadocian point-men** and **Scaeva's scarred mastiff-handler leading a hundred-pound brindled Molossian war-hound** straining silent and murderous on an iron chain!

Behind them in the rain-blurred torch-mouth towered **one-eared Scaeva** himself, swinging his leaded vine-wood *vitis* cane and pointing straight past Oven One at twenty-year-old Lucida!

"Loose the dog on the dark one—don't kill her till Hermippus gets Dorcas's safe-keys!" Scaeva yelled!

The handler dropped the iron chain-pin; hundred-pound brindled muscle launched in three silent, terrifying bounds down the wet flags straight for Lucida's throat while both Cappadocian point-men charged shoulder-to-shoulder behind it!

Lucida didn't step back; thumb already snapping the red pitch seal off **old Berenice's flat lead Ascalon horn-box**, she waited until the leaping Molossian mastiff and both charging Cappadocians were six feet out of the passage wind, dropped onto one knee beneath the dog's jaws, and **flung two full ounces of dry, unslaked Puteoli quicklime and caustic euphorbia-resin upward in a tight white fan straight across all three pairs of open eyes**!

Wet eyeballs and throat-mucus turned instant boiling white lye on contact!

The hundred-pound Molossian crashed sideways mid-leap snapping blind at empty air as foaming white lime burned its corneas shut; both Cappadocian point-men dropped their iron crowbars, clawing wildly at blistering, steaming eye-sockets with shrieks high enough to curdle blood —blocking the narrow passage mouth with writhing bodies!

Furious mastiff-handler **Bato** vaulted over his blinded dog swinging a short iron-studded billhook straight down at Lucida's unguarded neck while she knelt,

And out from beneath the shadow of Number One volcanic lava mill darted **seventeen-year-old mute Sura**, silent as river-mist!

Driving her razor-honed six-inch curved steel dough-scraper horizontally with both scarred hands straight across the taut hamstring tendons behind Bato's bare right knee, Sura **severed tendon to the bone** without making a sound! Bato pitched screaming face-first onto the stone kneading-trough, splitting his own forehead open on volcanic basalt while two of Lucida's brave Marsian kneaders swung heavy oak carrying-poles from the side, cracking an urban *stationarius*'s shield-arm before two more armored soldiers and Scaeva himself surged over the blinded men with iron crowbars and short-swords half-drawn!

"UP THE LADDER, GIRL, NOW!" roared sixty-five-year-old **Habinnas Barba**!

Before Lucida could lunge forward with her five-inch boot-knife against four armored men, old Barba caught the back of her woollen belt in one tremendous, flour-crusted left fist, hurled her bodily six feet backward onto the bottom brick steps beside waiting Sura, and stepped squarely into the narrow stone gap between Oven One and Number One lava mill—**swinging twenty pounds of cherry-hot eight-foot iron oven-peel in a whistling horizontal scythe chest-high across the arch**!

WHANG, HSSSSSS!

Glowing twelve-inch flat iron caught the lead *stationarius*'s hide shield square, charring leather in an explosion of stinking black smoke and knocking two soldiers flat back over groaning Bato!

"Come eat Cappadocian bread, Smyrniot whoresons!" Barba bellowed through bloody pink froth flying off his white beard, hooking a panful of live white-hot oak coals out of Oven One's mouth on the back-swing and showering three square yards of blazing orange embers straight across Scaeva's shins and cloak! "Climb, Lucida, by your mother's salt, if they catch you on my floor I curse your urn from Hades! CLIMB!"

Two Marsian kneaders grabbed Lucida under both elbows—she fighting for one ragged heartbeat like a madwoman to pull free as four soldiers with heavy iron crowbars rushed Barba from two angles at once while his lungs hitched in a terrible, strangling cough! and hauled her and Sura bodily up the ten outside brick steps through the loft door, slamming and wedging the oak stair-door with two hundred-pound flour-chests from inside while Sura shoved open the narrow wooden **skylight roof-hatch** above the rafters!

Freezing March rain hit Lucida's face as she hauled Sura out onto the sloped, mossy terracotta pantiles forty feet above the black alley, then paused flat on her belly for **three terrible heartbeats** along the wet clay ridge-coping directly above the open central courtyard opening, staring straight down through driving dark rain into the red pit of her life below!

Down on the flour-white basalt flags, sixty-five-year-old **Habinnas Barba** had taken an iron crowbar across his right forearm, dropping the heavy iron peel; even one-handed, he had snatched up a wooden *modius* measure to swing at **Scaeva**—until two soldiers drove iron-shod clubs together straight into the left side of Barba's barrel chest, **crushing old ribs inward with a dull wet thud audible forty feet up through the rain**, slamming his white head hard against the grey Orvieto stone of Number One mill!

While Barba lay gasping bright crimson foam across spilled white Sicilian flour, Scaeva wiped scorched ember-holes off his brown cloak, spat onto the old baker's chest, and barked at his four crowbar-men:

"Drive iron wedges straight between all four upper catilli *and crack the lava collars! Tip every rising trough into the sewer-drain and nail Prefect Repentinus's lead seal, plus young Cassius's Treasury tag! across both oven doors! Let's see her bake a hundred* modii *before midnight out of broken gravel!"*

CLANG. CRACK.

Six-pound sledges drove cold iron wedges deep into forty-year-old Orvieto volcanic stone, splitting Number One and Number Two hourglass bells clean down their flanks with twin thunderbolt cracks; three hundred pounds of warm, living white Sicilian bread-dough tipped sluggishly out of overturned stone troughs into black rainwater and blood swirling toward the gutter; and above Oven One, an urban soldier swung the butt of his club sideways across **Sura's black wall-slate**, smashing **ANNVS III · DIES CCCXXXI — MODII CXIV** (1,061 unbroken days, thirty-four sunrises from Roman liberty!) into ten wet black fragments in the mud!

"Check the upper loft, they went over the fullery roof!" Scaeva's voice roared below as axes bit into the wedged loft door.

Up on the slick, freezing terracotta pantiles, seventeen-year-old Sura clamped one scarred, trembling hand hard over her own mouth so no sob

escaped her throat, tears washing down through rain as she tugged with frantic silent fingers at Lucida's soaked hem.

Twenty-year-old Lucida did not make a sound.

Lying flat on freezing clay forty feet above her shattered stones, blood from scraping wet tile-edges blackening under all ten fingernails just as Mousa's blood had blackened under her fifteen-year-old nails on the afternoon of the October Horse, she watched two soldiers drag unconscious, bleeding **Habinnas Barba** by both heels toward the waiting Prefecture mule-wagon, still breathing shallow pink froth, taken alive as hostage to pull Lucida into the cells, while in her ears echoed Scaeva's shouted poison:

Cassius Corvus already lodged Treasury receivership seals shutting these hoppers down himself at dusk!

Three years of waking in pitch dark at the third watch. One thousand and sixty-one mornings without missing a single pound of clean wheat. Old Berenice strangled across a child's Hebrew gravestone; Habinnas Barba's ribs crushed beside his split lava stones; thirty-four remaining mornings smashed to wet black slate in the gutter, while **Lucius Cassius Corvus** put on his gold equestrian ring across the Forum on her patron's bones.

Lucida pressed one cold palm flat against the front of her soaked woollen bodice, feeling crisp, unbroken, dry inside oiled kidskin right over her steady, glacial heart **the thin shaved lime-bark leaf of Senator Quintus Servilius Priscus's Syrian treason, written in Corvus's own neat black hand**.

"Move your feet along the ridge-tiles, little thrush, heels sidewise on the mortar-overlap just like we practiced," Lucida whispered against Sura's wet flax ear, her voice devoid of tears, devoid of hurry, colder than the March rain sweeping out of the dark north-east from the **Castra Praetoria**. "Hold my belt. Before sunrise we buy four legions and an Emperor."

* * *

Across four interconnected tenement roofs above the sleeping Subura they moved like wet river-cats through pitch-black rain: straddling narrow brick party-walls sixty feet above reeking fullers' vats, dropping twelve feet down a wooden laundry-drying scaffold onto the outside stone stair of the **Carinae** retaining wall, and slipping barefoot—Lucida had sliced her heavy baker's

boots off on the second mossy gable so leather soles wouldn't skid off glazed clay, straight up the steep, dark laurel-lined lane of the **Clivus Scauri**.

Not once did Lucida glance across the wet black garden wall on her left where **Senator Quintus Servilius Priscus's** portico lanterns already burned pale behind closed shutters, and where twenty-year-old **Corvus** was doubtless arraying his clean white citizen wool for dawn.

Two hundred paces higher up the Caelian crest, four mounted couriers wearing **Praetorian Prefect Repentinus's** dark oilskin camp-cloaks already stood holding bridles in the sleet outside **Ceionia Fabia's** bronze garden postern.

When Lucida struck the bronze lion-head ring three fast times and one slow, the emergency night-knock **Claudia Dorcas** had taught her after Lorium—the spy-plate snapped back at once; grey-haired Dorcas took one look at twenty-year-old Lucida standing barefoot on freezing travertine with blood-streaked palms, soaked wool plastered to her ribs, and shivering mute Sura behind her shoulder, and swung the heavy oak wicket wide without wasting a syllable.

Inside the heated marble peristyle, lamps burned in every niche; thirty-three-year-old **Ceionia Fabia** stood fully dressed in deep mourning violet beside a steaming silver brazier, reading a wet Lorium dispatch-tablet while two Bithynian grooms strapped saddle-bags outside.

"Scaeva struck three hours ahead of his orders," Fabia said sharply, dark imperial eyes sweeping down from Lucida's drenched braids to her bleeding bare soles printing red water across white Luna marble. "Vedius Pollio bribed Repentinus's junior night-clerk before my brother Lucius even left Lorium's gate. Did Scaeva take your ledgers?"

"Scaeva took sixty-five-year-old Habinnas Barba with crushed ribs into the Lautumiae cells after murdering old Berenice on her stairs and splitting all four of my Orvieto stones on Day One Thousand Sixty-One," Lucida said, standing straight as an iron spear in dripping Subura rags on Caesar's sister's marble floor, refusing the goblet of hot spiced wine Dorcas held out until Dorcas wrapped a thick dry wolf-fur cloak around trembling Sura's shoulders first. "Tell Prefect Repentinus's rider right now to order the Lautumiae jailer not to lay one finger on old Habinnas Barba before noon, or what I brought inside my bodice goes straight into that brazier unread."

Fabia's nostrils flared once at hearing conditions spoken under her own roof; then she looked into Lucida's black-ringed, unblinking amber eyes, turned half an inch to Repentinus's waiting *optio* by the door, and snapped: *"Send word to the Lautumiae ward: keep the old Cappadocian baker alive till evening on pain of the vine-rod. Go!"*

Only when the soldier's hobnails clattered out into the rain did twenty-year-old Lucida draw her small boot-knife, slit the wet linen thread inside her soaked bodice, and hold up between two blood-rimmed fingers—without letting Fabia touch it yet! **the tiny oiled kidskin square stamped underneath with pale green Chian mastic**.

"Antoninus is dead," Lucida said quietly. "Tomorrow morning in the Senate your brother **Lucius** either takes equal purple beside Marcus, or Quintus Servilius Priscus locks Antioch's three legions behind Marcus's private ring before Lucius ever smells salt water. Give me clean ink and dry papyrus until noon to write out Priscus's five-place Greek shift, have dry Syrian silk ready by the ninth hour, and take me inside the **Castra Praetoria** behind twelve spears when your brother rides to the Guard. I don't hand this bark to stewards; I lay it in **Augustus's** own palm."

For three silent breaths Hadrian's heir's daughter stared at the barefoot, bleeding twenty-year-old baker standing on her marble, seeing every remnant of Subura mercy burned clean out of the girl's face, leaving something cold, imperial, and terrifyingly familiar behind it.

"Dorcas," Ceionia Fabia said softly, "heat rose-water in the corner bath and open my Coan silk chest. Tonight my brother dines with two Caesars' purple on his shoulders—and you, daughter of Tyria, walk out of that Camp as freeborn as I am."

Chapter XXIX

By Bronze and Balance

Nones of March, AD 161 · Corvus

Rome woke on the Nones of March to silent shutters, wet black travertine, and six hundred senators walking fast through thin grey rain toward the bronze doors of the **Curia Julia** without knowing whether one master waited inside or two.

Twenty-year-old Corvus stood bare-headed on the third marble step outside the open Senate vestibule—junior *cognitores* below senatorial rank waited outside the sacred threshold while listening unobstructed through the thirty-foot doorway, holding **Senator Quintus Servilius Priscus's** dry toga-cloak over one arm while five sworn Roman citizen witnesses led by pale, clean-shaved **Aulus Volusenus Niger** waited twenty paces across the Comitium beside the steps of **Saturn's Treasury**.

Nobody in Priscus's household had slept a wink since the fourth-watch beacon flashed off the Janiculum signaling that seventy-four-year-old **Antoninus Pius** had breathed his last at Lorium. Up on the Caelian before dawn, Corvus had handed Priscus the unopened green-mastic oilskin wallet from his satchel, Priscus slipping it directly into his confidential Eastern courier's saddle-pouch with strict orders not to break the outer green terebinth seal until the courier boarded ship at Brundisium, unless events inside the Curia required new instructions!—and Corvus had sent a runner down to the Fish-Market at first light to fetch Lucida's countersigned custody-sheet, assuming when the runner hadn't returned yet through the jammed Forum crowds that nervous holiday wagon-blocks around the cattle-market had slowed the boy down.

Inside the towering marble hall of the **Curia Julia**, tiered benches packed white from floor to gallery fell dead silent as forty-year-old **Marcus**

Aurelius walked down the central porphyry pavement wearing an unbleached dark *toga pulla* of filial mourning, accompanied two paces behind, sunburned, golden-curled, sober-faced today in matching dark wool, by thirty-year-old **Lucius Ceionius Commodus**.

Sitting in the front consular row beside **Quintus Junius Rusticus**, old **Senator Priscus** leaned forward with hands braced on bony knees, waiting to rise the instant the senior consul moved the *senatus consultum* conferring sole *imperium proconsulare*, *tribunicia potestas*, and the title *Augustus* upon Marcus alone.

The senior consul read the decree trembling; six hundred senatorial voices roared ritual acclamation—*"Dii te servent, Marce Auguste! Imperator unice!"*, intentionally shouting *sole Imperator* to drown out three hesitant voices near the door!

Marcus Aurelius stood up before the gilded Altar of Victory.

Thin, hollow-eyed from five sleepless nights holding a dying old man's swollen hand at Lorium, his quiet, slightly reedy Stoic voice carried clear as cold spring water out past the open bronze doors to where twenty-year-old Corvus stood in the drizzle:

"Conscript Fathers," Marcus said simply, "my deified father left me neither a private farm nor an undivided burden. Sixty million people from Caledonia to the Euphrates require four eyes, and fidelity begins inside one's own house. I accept neither the name of Augustus nor the command of the armies **save on condition that you vote this same hour every equal title, tribunician power, proconsular *imperium*, and the name *Imperator Caesar Lucius Aurelius Verus Augustus* to my brother Lucius standing beside me**, that Rome may be governed henceforth by two Augusti in one mind."

Out on the wet marble steps Corvus heard three nearby equestrians gasp aloud.

Inside on the front consular bench, **Quintus Servilius Priscus** went the exact grey-white color of old peperino tufa—half-rising three inches off his ivory stool to object before **Junius Rusticus** laid one iron-still ink-stained hand flat across Priscus's forearm to hold him down! Argue openly against Marcus's own filial generosity while **Cornelius Repentinus's** Praetorian cohorts waited under arms half a mile north-east calling for double donatives, and you split the Curia on Day One!

Instead thirty-year-old **Lucius, now Emperor Lucius Verus, invested in sixty heartbeats with half the Roman world, including supreme command of the approaching war in the East!**, stepped smoothly beside Marcus at the altar to speak graceful, resonant Fronto-polished thanks while across the Forum arcades **Publius Vedius Pollio** and **Ceionia Fabia's** partisans broke into open, triumphant embraces!

Ten breaths later Senator Priscus strode out onto the wet marble porch ahead of the crowd—chewing two dry fennel seeds so hard his jaw-muscles corded beneath cropped grey beard, and caught twenty-year-old Corvus by the shoulder inside the shadow of a travertine pillar.

"Marcus handed the boy purple out of sheer sentimental philosophy," Priscus hissed so low rain drowned every consonant beyond two feet. "Thank the immortal gods my Brundisium courier hasn't left the Capena Gate yet, he rides at sunset so **Antioch's three legions still answer solely to Marcus's private seal when Verus sails east**! And *you*, Lucius Cassius: Fiscal Praetor **Manius Acilius** just took his curule chair on the Treasury tribunal before the Senate adjourns to the Camp! Strike **Vedius Pollio** flat across Saturn's scales *right this hour* while Vedius thinks Verus's purple makes him untouchable—strip every silver denarius out of his chests before noon so he cannot put one gold piece behind Verus's Praetorian friends!"

Corvus's pulse beat slow, deep, and cold as Sublaqueum snow-water.

"Acilius's clerk already called our number, Senator," Corvus said. "Watch the scales."

* * *

Across the Forum pavement beneath the towering granite porch of the **Aerarium Saturni**, where public *quaestores* and the **Praetor Fiscalis** sat before open bronze vault-doors flanked by the ancient brass balance (*libra*) hung on an iron standard, **Publius Vedius Pollio** had just strolled out of the **Basilica Julia** surrounded by six fawning equestrian tax-farmers, smiling radiantly in chalk-white wool while **Hermippus** trotted behind him carrying an ivory dispatch-box.

Vedius had every reason under heaven to smile at the fifth hour on the Nones of March: his royal patron **Lucius Verus** had just put on Augustus's purple; his ally **Repentinus** commanded the Praetorian Guard; and six

hours ago before dawn Scaeva had smashed that troublesome Fish-Market Junian girl's lava mills to gravel!

Then a court *viator* stepped squarely across Vedius Pollio's path with an ashwood summons-rod and called out in loud brassy Forum cadence:

"Publius Vedius Pollio, equestrian, and Gaius Munatius, fiduciary holder: stand to the bar of Fiscal Praetor Manius Acilius on summary vindicatio aerarii *and quadruple* Lex Iulia *forfeiture prosecuted by* ***Lucius Cassius Corvus, son of Gaius, of the Crustumina tribe****!"*

Thirty spectators round Saturn's steps turned heads at once; inside five hundred breaths two hundred Forum idlers, bankers, and clerks had packed six deep round the stone balustrade smelling giant blood.

Vedius Pollio stopped walking, dark velvet eyes blinking once in genuine amusement as he took in the tall, black-haired twenty-year-old standing calm behind the prosecutor's oak rail flanked by **Aulus Volusenus Niger** and four grey-bearded Crustumina and Palatina citizens.

"Wait, Gaius Cassius's little Crustumerium ditch-orphan?" Vedius purred musically to Hermippus, loud enough to draw a nervous titter from two of his hangers-on. "Bringing country boundary-suits on the morning Rome hails two Emperors? Praetor Acilius, my advocate **Sulpicius Rufus** is dining up on the Palatine; grant thirty days' *dilatio* after the imperial funeral, "

"Under Augustus's and Hadrian's Treasury rules, no *dilatio* runs where an embezzler's sham *fiducia* shield is proved void *in continenti* by public archive rolls and sealed bronze," twenty-year-old **Corvus** cut straight across Vedius's velvet purr—his deep Fronto-chiselled baritone ringing off Saturn's granite columns like an iron maul striking bronze, silencing every titter in the square at one blow!

Praetor **Manius Acilius**, an austere Stoic friend of Rusticus, tapped his ivory wand once on the stone arm-rest: "The Treasury sits uninterrupted for public revenue even on interregnum mornings. Proceed on the archive rolls, Lucius Cassius; thirty-six hundred breaths on the clepsydra."

Corvus didn't need thirty-six hundred breaths; he killed six million sesterces in **nine hundred**.

Walking unhurriedly to the stone evidence-table without raising his voice once, scarred right thumb steady on every seal, Corvus laid down **Hammer One**:

The heavy four-pound circular bronze **signaculum** die of *Figlinae Subortanae* alongside Chest Nineteen's certified Treasury payment-vouchers (720,000 HS drawn out of Caesar's public works chest for 240,000 *bipedales*) and dead Procurator **Rufus's** five original notched pine kiln-tallies proving **only 60,000 bricks ever saw fire**—leaving **five hundred forty thousand sesterces of pure stolen public silver**, corroborated by two retired brick-kiln foremen Phileros had tracked down at Tibur!

Vedius Pollio's smile vanished as if wiped off oiled ivory with a rag; behind him **Hermippus** grabbed wildly for his wax pocket-notes, hissing *"Plead Gaius Munatius's separate* mancipatio *trust, Vedius's brick-company holds no assets!"*

Before Hermippus finished whispering, Corvus dropped **Hammer Two** straight onto Hermippus's fingers:

"Foreseeing this hour two summers back," Corvus said cleanly to the fascinated bench, "Publius Vedius Pollio conveyed his Subura commercial tenements, Ostian warehouse leases, and Puteoli patronal reversions *per aes et libram* into a protective *fiducia* shield-trust held by **Gaius Munatius**. Five Roman citizens signed that bronze-and-scales conveyance. Fifth down the spine stands **Sextus Vibius Balbus of Capua**, condemned four months *prior* in the Capuan public criminal court for malicious *calumnia*, certified here under the Praetorian archive seal! Under the Twelve Tables and the Perpetual Edict, a condemned *calumniator* is **infamis and intestabilis**—incapable of standing witness beside bronze and scales! Munatius's two-million-sesterce shield-trust never existed in law; **every brick, lease, and patronal claim stands naked inside Publius Vedius Pollio's personal chest today**!"

Gasps broke across the packed crowd of bankers round Saturn's steps, half the moneylenders on the Janus Medius held paper cross-collateralized by Munatius's trust!

"Sham beneficial enjoyment requires proof beyond a witness-error!" Hermippus shouted shrilly, losing thirty years of Smyrniot self-control as his own liberty tottered.

Corvus turned half an inch and nodded to **Aulus Volusenus Niger**.

Pale, dignified in spotless wide-striped patrician wool, twenty-three-year-old Volusenus stepped to the bar and laid down **Hermippus's own emerald-stamped collection-endorsement** directing eighty thousand

sesterces through Munatius's chest straight into *Publius Vedius Pollio's personal Caelian strongbox*, authenticated on oath by Senator Priscus's own nephew!

And before Vedius could draw breath to appeal to his Caelian friends, Corvus lifted out of a felt-lined basket **Hammer Three**: the dusty, four-year-old **Sidonian glass flask still one-third full of settled crimson Pontic Sinope ruddle-silt**, sealed under two equestrian water-witnesses' rings from January AD 157!

"And lest the accused plead honest accounting mistake to beg mercy on quadruple fiscal penalties," Corvus concluded, setting the red glass bottle gleaming in watery March sun beside the bronze brick-die, "here sits sworn proof under the *Lex Quinctia* and criminal *stellionatus* that this same Publius Vedius Pollio hollowed municipal masonry on the Caelian crest to solder **twin illegal fifty-digit lead *fistulae* behind forged twenty-digit imperial collars**, stealing fourteen *quinariae* of public water day and night! Quadruple restitution on five hundred forty thousand sesterces public brick-fraud: **two million one hundred sixty thousand sesterces**. Statutory *Lex Quinctia* water-forfeiture: **one hundred thousand sesterces**, plus summary criminal notation referring **Publius Vedius Pollio** for deportation *interdictio aquae et ignis*!"

Out in the packed Forum square nobody cheered with hired clappers today; two hundred hardened Roman merchants watched in awed, temple-still silence as fifty-one-year-old **Publius Vedius Pollio** reached blindly behind himself for a stool that wasn't there, plump depilated hands grey and shaking as wet dough while four public *lictores* stepped quietly up beside his elbows so he couldn't slip away toward the Palatine!

Praetor **Manius Acilius** consulted his three *assessores* for less than a hundred breaths, stood up before the open doors of Saturn's Treasury, and spoke judgment into bronze:

"Fraud on the *fiscus* proved; Munatius's *mancipatio* adjudged void *ab initio* for an *intestabilis* witness; immediate *missio in possessionem* and Treasury sequestration ordered upon all lands, tenements, warehouses, strongboxes—**including Castor Vault Forty-Two!**, and patronal reversions of Publius Vedius Pollio! Out of collected bullion and first-rank leases, the Quaestors shall pay over across Saturn's balance the statutory fifth-part prosecutor's *praemium* of **four hundred thirty-two thousand sesterces**

to **Lucius Cassius Corvus**, whom I hereby note qualified upon the equestrian census roll! Strike the bronze!"

CLANG.

The Treasury *libripens* struck the ancient copper ingot once against the hanging brass balance-pan.

Four and a half years after two starving fifteen-year-olds ran bleeding out of *Figlinae Subortanae* mud owing three thousand two hundred sesterces on a dead surveyor's bond, twenty-year-old **Lucius Cassius Corvus** stood on the marble steps of Saturn worth **over six hundred thousand sesterces**, enrolled among the **Roman Knights**, holding inside his scarred right hand the wet-sealed receivership decree that **canceled his dead father's debt, impounded Castor Vault Forty-Two unopened, AND vested Vedius Pollio's voided patronal claim over Junian Latin *Lucida* straight into Corvus's own hand so he could emancipate and release her free gratis before sunset**!

Then, just as Corvus stepped down off the tribunal surrounded by congratulating advocates to dispatch Quaestor Caecilius's clerk with Lucida's clean release-deed—a breathless, white-faced Marsian baker's kneader (**Marcus**, his left temple split and crusted with dried blood from last night's club-fight!) fought through the Forum crowd and grabbed Corvus's toga-sleeve with trembling flour-stained hands!

"Master Cassius, thank Jupiter I found you!" Marcus choked out in broken Greek. "Before dawn, two hours after midnight—**One-Ear Scaeva** and four urban *stationarii* axed down our Fish-Market gate screaming Repentinus's warrant **and shouting your name on a Treasury padlock**! They smashed all four lava mills with iron wedges, tipped the dough into the sewer, and **crushed old Habinnas Barba's chest** while Mistress Lucida and Sura went over the fullery roof! The soldiers dragged dying Barba into the **Lautumiae** Prefecture cells behind the Carcer!"

Every drop of six-hundred-thousand-sesterce triumph froze solid black inside Corvus's veins.

Screaming Repentinus's warrant and shouting YOUR name on a Treasury padlock! Smashed all four lava mills on Day One Thousand Sixty-One!

Leaving astonished Volusenus and four congratulating knights standing open-mouthed in the rain on Saturn's steps, twenty-year-old Corvus sprinted hundred-yard strides straight north across the slippery Comitium

flagstones toward the dark peperino arches of the **Urban Prefecture detention vaults** beside the Lautumiae quarry-wall!

* * *

Ten damp travertine steps below street-level inside the vaulted *custodia* holding-pen, stinking of wet rotten straw, iron rust, human urine, and cold winter stone, Corvus flashed Praetor Acilius's wet emergency seal past a sullen cohort jailer carrying Repentinus's keys, throwing two gold *aurei* onto the guard-table to drag the iron-grated cell door open.

Six battered street-prisoners huddled shivering along the far tufa wall; alone in the dark puddle beneath the narrow barred air-slit lay sixty-five-year-old **Habinnas Barba**.

Nobody had bound his broken ribs; nobody had wiped the caked flour and dried dark blood off his crushed white beard. Every shallow breath whistled wet and pink through ruptured lung-wall, his solitary clear black eye staring straight up at the dripping grey vault overhead so stubbornly he seemed to be holding Death off by sheer Cappadocian rage until someone walked down those stairs.

"Barba—it's Corvus! Asclepiades's litter is coming right behind me down the Forum steps with clean blankets!" Corvus rasped, dropping onto both knees in the filthy wet straw without caring a damn for his white equestrian-qualified citizen toga, slipping his left arm gently beneath the old baker's flour-stiffened shoulders while holding Praetor Acilius's wet-sealed emancipation-and-release tablet out where Barba's single eye could see the red wax! "Vedius Pollio is finished, ruined and exiled ten breaths ago at Saturn's scales! Look at the seal, old soldier, Castor's warrant is dead, and your courtyard comes back clean without a copper owed—"

Slowly Habinnas Barba shifted his solitary fever-bright black eye off the ceiling down onto twenty-year-old Corvus's face.

He did not look at the red wax seal. He looked at Corvus's clean white Forum wool, and then down at the Treasury receivership ribbon dangling beside Corvus's scarred right thumb.

With his last ounce of sixty-five-year-old soldier's strength, Barba raised his unbroken left hand an inch off the bloody straw, **spat a thick mouth-**

ful of bright crimson flour-blood square across the snowy front of Corvus's toga, and locked iron-cold dying fingers onto Corvus's wrist.

"Thirty-four... sunrises left on the little mute's slate," Barba whispered in Cappadocian Greek, every word bubbling wet red at the corners of his grey moustache while his black eye bored straight into Corvus's soul. "One thousand... sixty-one mornings... she lifted sixty-pound sacks with burned hands so my bad lungs wouldn't stop the count... and **One-Ear nailed *your* Treasury tag beside his crowbar across my broken stones before dawn, Sabine**..."

"Barba, by my father's grave, I never sent Scaeva or any padlock to your yard!" Corvus cried out hoarsely in the dark cell, gripping the old man's freezing, flour-crusted hand between both of his own. "Scaeva lied using a leaked docket-line to break your men's hearts, I came down on the fourth night begging Lucida to take my shield so your stones wouldn't stop! Tell me where she ran—did she go to Salvius's burial hall?"

A terrible, silent ghost of a grin stretched Barba's blood-stained grey beard.

"Begged her... to step inside *your* cage," Barba rattled softly, chest hitching once, twice, shallower against Corvus's arm as the light behind his solitary eye began drawing far back up the mountain pass toward Comana. "Too late for cages, lawyer... Berenice's dead on her stairs... my four Orvieto girls are split gravel... and **Lucida Tyria's daughter went north through the rain carrying green wax... to buy four legions and an Emperor who doesn't count flour**..."

One final long, wet sigh hissed out between broken yellow teeth; the knotted flour-white fingers slackened open off Corvus's wrist; and sixty-five-year-old Habinnas Barba lay still as dressed mill-lava against Corvus's blood-soaked chest.

For twenty heartbeats nobody in the dark stone cell moved while rain dripped *plink-plink-plink* through the iron street-grating overhead.

Kneeling motionless in wet filthy straw with a dead baker's blood soaking warm through his newly won equestrian-rich wool, twenty-year-old Corvus heard seven words echo backward through silence until every hair along his nape stood straight up in terror:

Went north through the rain carrying green wax... to buy four legions and an Emperor.

North-east, the Castra Praetoria!

And four nights ago up in that warm Fish-Market loft while Sura went downstairs for barley-water and Corvus knelt with his back turned warming Caecilius's wax over red coals, **twelve silent heartbeats beside his unbuckled satchel before Lucida kissed the scar on his thumb like a woman burying the dead**!

Slowly Corvus laid old Habinnas Barba's white head gently down onto his own folded dry cloak, closed the solitary black eye with two trembling blood-stained fingers, stood up out of the straw, and walked up the dark steps into the gathering dusk of the Nones of March knowing—ten hours before Senator Priscus's courier ever broke the blank linden-wood seal at Brundisium, that the sky was already falling.

Chapter XXX

Two Suns Over Rome

Dusk of the Nones to Dawn of the Eighth Day Before the Ides of March, AD 161 · Lucida

Twelve thousand iron-shod Praetorian spear-butts crashing in unison against curved oval shields shook grey rainwater off the red-brick battlements of the **Castra Praetoria** hard enough to ripple wine inside gold cups two hundred yards back inside the headquarters pavilion.

"IMPERATORES CAESARES — MARCVS ET LVCIVS AVGVSTI — VINCANT! VINCANT!"

Standing just inside the braided crimson velvet portiere of the *praetorium* council-hall beside **Ceionia Fabia**—washed clean of Subura roof-soot in warm rose-water, dressed in an ankle-length *stola* of unbleached Coan silk bordered with dark Tyrian purple, her blue-black braids pinned high with Fabia's six-inch emerald needle while raw crescent scrapes from last night's pantiles still burned invisible beneath her clean nails, twenty-year-old **Lucida** watched Rome divide in half under torchlight without a drop of blood spilled on marble.

Out on the high stone camp *tribunal* facing twelve massed cohorts in gleaming lorica segmentata, forty-year-old **Emperor Marcus Aurelius** stood silent half a pace back in dark mourning wool, stoop-shouldered, grey with exhaustion, visibly shrinking from the raw mercenary roar of twelve thousand swords—while beside him thirty-year-old **Emperor Lucius Verus** stood bare-headed in the torch-wind like gilded Apollo come down from Delos, flinging both sunburned arms wide as his rich, ringing baritone promised **twenty thousand sesterces, five thousand silver denarii per man!**, to every soldier on the Guard rolls!

Two hundred and forty million sesterces bought twelve thousand throats in ten heartbeats.

When the two new masters of the inhabited earth stepped back inside the heated brick council-chamber out of the wind—flanked by bull-necked **Praetorian Prefect Sextus Cornelius Repentinus** and soft-footed **Furius Victorinus**, Marcus Aurelius paused only long enough to sign the Guard treasury warrant before excusing himself back toward the Palatine to oversee dead Antoninus's embalming rites, leaving **Lucius Verus** behind at the camp map-table with Repentinus and his elder sister **Ceionia Fabia**.

The heavy oak doors swung shut behind four towering German bodyguards.

All lazy tavern warmth dropped off thirty-year-old **Lucius Verus's** handsome face the instant his adoptive brother's sandals receded down the stone corridor. Pouring himself unwatered Falernian from a silver camp pitcher without sitting down, the younger Augustus looked straight past Fabia at twenty-year-old **Lucida**.

"Vedius Pollio went down in flames at Saturn's scales before noon, stripped bare of six million sesterces by Quintus Servilius Priscus's twenty-year-old Sabine hound while I was standing in the Curia," Lucius Verus said sharply, golden curls damp with camp rain above his fresh imperial purple cloak. "Fabia tells me her Fish-Market friend climbed over four wet Subura roofs before dawn carrying something sharper than Vedius's brick-tallies. Put it on the oak, girl, before Repentinus rides to the Palatine."

Lucida stepped forward across the pegged legionary map of Armenia and Syria without lowering her eyes once before Caesar's purple.

From inside her silk belt-fold she drew two objects and laid them side by side beneath the five-nozzled bronze camp candelabrum:

First, **the razor-thin three-by-five-inch shaved lime-bark leaf (*philyra*)** lifted four nights ago out of **Lucius Cassius Corvus's** dispatch-satchel—covered in forty-two tight lines of shifted Greek letters written in Corvus's unmistakable upright secretarial hand and stamped at the bottom margin in pale green Chian mastic with **Senator Quintus Servilius Priscus's** personal terebinth ring!

Second, a clean strip of Egyptian papyrus on which Lucida had written out in clear Greek and Latin during her afternoon hours behind Fabia's bolted Caelian shutters **every word of the five-place Caesar shift**.

Praetorian Prefect **Cornelius Repentinus** bent his thick grey bull's neck over both sheets, moving one blunt scarred forefinger line by line from

cipher to plain Greek, and halfway down Paragraph Two a low, ugly whistle escaped his teeth.

"Read it out, Sextus," Emperor Lucius Verus commanded quietly.

Repentinus read aloud in clipped camp Latin:

"Quintus Servilius Priscus Consularis to Lucius Attidius Cornelianus, Legate Propraetor of Syria at Antioch, health. Should fortune compel Caesar Marcus upon Lorium's close to concede nominal purple or Eastern eagles to L. Ceionius out of domestic peace, let neither VIII Augusta's detachments nor III Gallica nor XVI Flavia Firma stir one standard beyond Zeugma upon any warrant bearing the younger hand alone, nor disburse Antioch's military chest above ordinary camp rations until counter-sealed under the inner Stoic ring known between myself and Rusticus..."

Silence fell across the brick headquarters hall so absolute the hiss of pine-resin torches sounded loud as surf.

Thirty-year-old **Lucius Verus** stared down at the pale green terebinth impression at the foot of the shaved bark, healthy sunburn draining white around his nostrils until he looked terrifyingly like his cold sister **Fabia** standing beside him.

"Before my father's corpse was cold at Lorium," Emperor Lucius Verus whispered, setting his silver wine-cup down on the oak table hard enough to dent the rim, "Priscus had already wired Antioch's three legions to treat **my proconsular *imperium* as painted theatre-wood** while Vologases masses forty thousand Parthian horse across the Euphrates! And how is Priscus's Brundisium courier traveling tonight, Prefect?"

"Stopped at the sixth milestone on the Via Appia twenty breaths ago by four of my mounted *speculatores* on Mistress Fabia's warning, Caesar," Repentinus answered grimly, teeth showing white through his cropped iron beard. "His green-sealed pouch held **nothing inside save blank linden-splint wood**, proving beyond ten thousand oaths that *this* bark leaf sitting on your table is Priscus's genuine master-sheet, written in his sworn *cognitor* **Cassius Corvus's** hand!"

At Corvus's name, Repentinus glanced flat and murderous across the map-table: "Say one word, Caesar, and my *speculatores* haul young **Cassius Corvus** off Saturn's steps in iron chains tonight right alongside old Priscus —newly enrolled Roman Knight or not!"

Inside twenty-year-old Lucida's ribs her heart gave not a single treacherous skip; she had calculated this exact sentence three hundred breaths ahead before stepping through the Castra gate.

"Arrest twenty-year-old Cassius Corvus tonight, Prefect," Lucida said coolly, speaking straight to **Emperor Lucius Verus** before Fabia could intervene, "and **Emperor Marcus Aurelius**, whose Stoic teacher **Junius Rusticus** stands named in Line Twelve! is forced to defend both Priscus *and* the clerk publicly in the Senate tomorrow morning to shield Rusticus's honor, turning your secret trump into an open civil brawl on Day Two of your reign! Lay this bark leaf privately before your brother Marcus alone at sunrise instead: Marcus will be so ashamed of Priscus's unauthorized Eastern cabal behind his back that **Marcus himself will strip Quintus Servilius Priscus of imperial *amicitia* before noon, banish Priscus silently to his Sabine hills for life, and sign your unrestricted supreme command over every legion east of the Aegean without a single senator daring to murmur**—while leaving young Cassius Corvus alive in Rome stripped of his great patron!"

Ceionia Fabia's dark eyes gleamed with sudden, fierce pride in her pupil; **Emperor Lucius Verus** stared across the candelabrum at the twenty-year-old Subura baker's daughter for five long heartbeats, then threw back his golden head in a short, delighted bark of imperial laughter!

"By Pollux, Fabia, you told me she ground clean flour, you didn't tell me you'd found Ulpian's daughter wearing Syrian silk!" Verus exclaimed, pulling his heavy imperial signet-ring from his finger and gesturing his *ab epistulis* secretary forward with wet purple murex ink and two prepared vellum diplomas! "Priscus goes to count Sabine cabbages before noon tomorrow, and Cornelianus answers to *my* lictors! Now name your three lines, daughter of Tyria—a Caesar who just gave five thousand denarii to every spearman in Rome doesn't short-weight the hand that gave him Syria!"

"Three lines, Caesar Augustus," Lucida said clearly into the torchlight:

"First: **full unconditional Roman citizenship (*civitas Romana optimo iure*) paired with imperial *restitutio natalium***, declaring me freeborn in law as **Lucida Tyria of the Palatina tribe**, extinguishing from root to sky every shadow of Junian Latinity or *ius patronatus* ever claimed by **Publius Vedius Pollio**, his heirs, or his Treasury receiver, together with an identical citizen charter for my mute assistant **Sura**."

Verus dipped the reed pen himself into dark purple murex ink and scrawled ***Imperator Caesar Lucius Aurelius Verus Augustus subscripsi*** across both heavy calfskin charters, stamping warm imperial vermilion wax so hard red tallow squeezed round his carved sapphire ring!

"Done and enrolled before sunrise," Verus said briskly. "Second?"

"Second: burn Prefect Repentinus's copy of **Castor Vault Forty-Two's** false poison-sheet in that brazier right now—and execute your Camp warrant before midnight on **Gaius Ummidius Scaeva**, who murdered an unarmed sixty-four-year-old Argiletum herb-woman and crushed veteran **Habinnas Barba**'s ribs before dawn under forged interregnum color."

Repentinus didn't even blink, pulling Myrtale's countersigned Prefecture warrant-copy straight out of his leather breast-case to drop it curling black and hissing onto the red oak coals, while nodding dryly: "My harbor watch already took **One-Ear Scaeva** in chains two hours ago at the Ostian Gate trying to board a Tunisian grain-ship with six bags of his ruined master Vedius's silver plate. Looting during an imperial interregnum carries summary camp sword outside the Esquiline ditch before midnight; his remaining ear stays on the post."

"And third, Lucida Tyria?" Emperor Lucius Verus asked, leaning both palms on the map of Syria and Mesopotamia with keen, sunlit appetite already turning east toward Antioch, Daphne's laurel groves, and Parthian gold.

"Third, Caesar," twenty-year-old **Citizen Lucida Tyria** answered, resting one calm olive forefinger right beside **Seleucia Pieria and Antioch** on the painted legionary map, "when you sail east to take command of the Parthian war, sixty thousand soldiers and five hundred court officers will need unrotted Sicilian wheat, unwatered Cilician tent-linen, clean purple dye, and a confidential household purveyor who knows every Greek freighter-captain from Ostia to Phoenicia and **cannot be bribed by senatorial contractors**. Issue my warrant as **Purveyor-in-Ordinary to the Household of Lucius Augustus**, backed by a two-hundred-fifty-thousand-sesterce Ostian credit line, and every loaf your vanguard breaks on the Euphrates will weigh full sixteen ounces."

"Make the credit **three hundred thousand**, Repentinus—she'll save me three million on rotten army biscuit before we sight Rhodes!" Verus

laughed, sliding both warm, purple-signed calfskin citizenship diplomas across the oak table straight into Lucida's hands!

Touching smooth calfskin and hot imperial vermilion wax—*CIVIS ROMANA · INGENUA RESTITUTA · LUCIDA TYRIA*—not one tear rose into twenty-year-old Lucida's dark amber eyes.

One thousand and sixty-one mornings of honest lava stone had failed thirty-four days short in blood and mud.

One stolen strip of shaved bark had bought sky, purple, and three hundred thousand sesterces in five hundred breaths.

* * *

By midnight the three-day March rain blew cleanly out to sea behind a sharp north wind off Soracte, leaving ten thousand icy winter stars blazing white above the black cypresses outside the **Porta Esquilina**.

Not far from the potter's ditch where slaves and paupers were tumbled nameless into lime, two hundred yards up the clean gravel road where **citizen guilds** burned honored dead on dry seasoned oak, blazed **two tall rectangular pyres of split Sabine holm-oak, sweet laurel, and twenty pounds of costly Syrian cinnamon-bark** paid in gold out of Citizen Lucida Tyria's purse.

Four silent Praetorian *speculatores* in dark cloaks stood guard fifty paces down the road beside her curtained litter; right beside the roaring orange heat stood only twenty-year-old **Lucida** and seventeen-year-old **Citizen Sura**, both bare-headed with black ashes streaked across their brows.

On the left pyre lay sixty-four-year-old **Berenice of Ascalon**, washed clean in warm myrrh-water by Lucida's own hands, dressed in fine Sidonian purple linen with **ten heavy gold *aurei*** tucked securely beneath her folded tongue so neither Charon nor any phantom Syrian perfume-factor could ever cheat her across dark water again.

On the right pyre lay sixty-five-year-old **Habinnas Barba** of Comana, veteran of XV Apollinaris and master baker of Rome—his crushed chest bound straight in spotless white wool, his burned baker's forearms crossed peacefully over a **freshly baked two-pound round crown loaf of purest Sicilian *siligo* wheat** Sura had baked that evening in Salvius's brick guild-

oven, and beside his right hand a full pitcher of **unwatered old Chian wine**.

Only one thing when Lucida's men claimed Barba's body out of the Lautumiae vestibule at dusk had made Lucida's fingers stop dead for three silent breaths:

Folded carefully as a pillow beneath dead Habinnas Barba's white head, soaked dark brown across the front folds with coughed lung-blood, had lain **a brand-new, costly Roman citizen's toga of finest Tarentine white wool**, stitched inside the neck-hem with the tiny red laundry-mark of the Carinae fuller three doors from **Lucius Cassius Corvus's** house.

Corvus had gone down into that filthy hole after noon. Corvus had held dying Barba's head against his own spotless triumph-day wool while Barba died cursing him—and left his own cloak behind under the old baker's skull in the dark.

Lucida had lifted Barba's white head gently, slipped Corvus's blood-stiffened toga out from beneath his neck without burning it on Barba's clean oak pyre, and folded the ruined white wool into a square bundle inside her litter floor.

Now, as twin pillars of fragrant cinnamon-and-oak flame roared thirty feet straight up toward the cold stars of March and white bone-ash settled singing into glowing red embers, Lucida poured the final ladle of unwatered dark wine hissing across the coals, spoke three ancient Phoenician words her mother **Lucida Tyria** had whispered over dying lamps in Subura winters, *peace upon salt, peace upon breath, peace upon iron*, and turned back toward the dark walls of Rome as faint grey light began thinning the eastern horizon behind Tibur.

* * *

At sunrise on the eighth day before the Ides of March, two hours before dead Antoninus Pius's funeral bier moved toward the Campus Martius, twenty-year-old **Lucida Tyria** rode down the empty, frost-glinting basalt cobbles from the Viminal toward Lot Fourteen to inspect her rebuilt commercial granaries before riding down to Ostia.

Right where the filthy, noisy flagstones of the **Argiletum and Subura** met the blinding white Carrara marble precinct of the **Forum of Augus-**

tus, Augustus's builders had erected a hundred-foot-high barrier wall of grey volcanic **Gabine peperino stone**—fireproof, windowless, massive as a mountain cliff, pierced only by three tall travertine-framed arches, built expressly to stop Subura tenement fires and Subura filth from ever staining imperial marble.

Just as Lucida's four Bithynian litter-bearers reached the Subura mouth of the central **Firewall arch**, her lead Praetorian outrider reined his bay gelding sharp back on ringing iron shoes.

Walking alone straight through the tall stone arch out of the white marble Forum dawn from the opposite side, flanked ten paces behind by two quiet freedman clerks carrying bound ivory *codicilli*—came twenty-year-old **Lucius Cassius Corvus**.

Cold crimson sunrise slanting across the Quirinal ridge struck him full across the shoulders as he stepped beneath the soot-blackened stone keystone.

Over his lean six-foot frame he wore no dark client's cloak today: across his crisp white woollen tunic ran for the very first time the **two-inch-wide crimson purple *angusticlavius* stripe of a Roman Knight**, and upon the fourth finger of his left hand, twin to the white crescent brick-stamp scar across his right thumb, gleamed the heavy **gold equestrian ring (*anulus aureus*)**.

One hour earlier up on the Palatine, **Emperor Lucius Verus** had laid a shaved strip of lime-bark privately across **Marcus Aurelius's** knee; twenty breaths ago a grim Palatine centurion had delivered Marcus's cold handwritten note banishing **Quintus Servilius Priscus** permanently from court and Curia to his Sabine hills—and **Junius Rusticus**, summoning twenty-year-old Knight Corvus straight out of Priscus's shattered atrium into **Emperor Marcus's own private fiscal secretariat**, had told Corvus in three spare Stoic sentences *whose hand had carried that green-sealed bark leaf into the Castra Praetoria*!

Lucida tapped twice on her cedar litter-frame, parted the dark wool curtains, and stepped out alone in her purple-bordered Coan silk *stola* onto the wet black basalt flags directly beneath the hundred-foot grey **Firewall**.

Behind her lay the smoky pantiles, bakeries, fulleries, and blood-alleys of the **Subura**.

Behind Corvus gleamed the soaring white Corinthian marble columns of **Mars the Avenger** in the **Forum of Augustus**.

Motioning both her Praetorian guards and his two clerks thirty paces back out of earshot with two identical, imperious flicks of twenty-year-old wrists, **Lucida Tyria** and **Lucius Cassius Corvus** stopped six feet apart inside the cold stone shadow of the arch.

Neither had slept in forty hours. Dark violet bruised the fine olive skin beneath Lucida's calm amber eyes; pale stone-grey pinched the lean planes around Corvus's scarred mouth. Four and a half Octobers ago they had run barefoot down an alley four hundred yards east of this exact stone, fifteen years old, soaked in horse-blood, owning between them one bronze hairpin, a dead surveyor's debt, and an oath never to let Rome cut them in two.

Without speaking a word, Lucida reached back into her litter, lifted out the **folded, blood-stiffened square of Carinae white Tarentine wool**, and held it out across the cold space between them.

Corvus took his dead baker-stained toga in one hand without looking down at it, his grey-green eyes locked cold and bottomless onto hers.

"You kissed the scar on my thumb while my back was still warm from your brazier," Corvus said quietly, no shout, no boy's crack in his deep Fronto-honed voice, quieter and deadlier than any blade drawn in Lot Fourteen's cellar. "Twelve heartbeats behind my shoulder while Sura went down for water, and a grave-libation on my hand to pay for old Priscus's neck."

"Old Priscus died in a sunny Sabine villa with forty slaves pouring his wine; **Berenice** died strangled across a child's stone and **Habinnas Barba** drowned on his own ribs while Scaeva split all four of my stones thirty-four sunrises short of April screaming *your* receivership docket through my splintered gate," Lucida answered just as quietly, chin level in the crimson dawn light. "You brought me a ten-day custody leash that erased three years of my blood so you could keep me safe inside your pocket, Lucius Cassius. Nobody puts me inside a pocket again while stars burn."

A muscle feathered once along Corvus's lean jaw, because he held inside his belt-pouch right this instant Praetor Acilius's useless, blood-late release-deed that would have handed her every stone free gratis yesterday noon, **and he refused out of sheer, cauterized twenty-year-old pride to pull**

it out and beg absolution from the woman who had just gutted his house and handed three Syrian legions to Lucius Verus!

"So you crowned a golden tavern-dancer over half the Eastern frontier while Vologases sharpens forty thousand lances beyond the river, **Citizen Lucida**," Corvus murmured, letting the new title drop off his tongue like weighed silver onto cold stone. "I heard at the Palatine gate what Verus signed in purple ink last night: *Lucida Tyria, ingenuo iure restituta, Purveyor to the Younger Augustus's Eastern Household*."

"Freeborn from the foundation of the sky by Caesar's rescript, Knight of Crustumina," Lucida said evenly, touching the green emerald head of her gold hairpin once against dark coiled braids. "Neither Publius Vedius Pollio on his rock in Gyaros nor Receiver Cassius Corvus at Saturn's scales holds one copper thread over my breath or my urn."

Corvus stepped one single pace closer beneath the towering grey peperino arch—until only four feet of cold, frost-filmed basalt separated crimson equestrian stripe from purple-bordered silk, close enough that warm mist from both mouths mingled white in the freezing dawn air just as their breaths had mingled in Berenice's freezing garret at fifteen, yet farther apart than Sicily and Syria.

"Enjoy your golden Emperor's banquets while Rome burns incense to old Antoninus, Lucida," twenty-year-old Corvus said softly, his grey-green eyes bright as winter steel above the pale scar her teeth had left on his lower lip. "**Emperor Marcus** and **Junius Rusticus** enrolled me an hour ago as Special Equestrian *Procurator ad Annonam Castrensem* auditing military grain, linen, and transport contracts from Ostia to Brundisium and Antioch. Every ship your Syrian captains load, every sack of wheat you bill to Verus's treasury, passes across **my bronze balance**. Short-weight Rome's legions by half a pound of meal between here and the Euphrates, and by my father's earth, I will strip your three hundred thousand sesterces down to bare Subura cobbles with my own hand."

For one breath, sharp, lightning-cold and breathless down the base of her spine—something terrifyingly indistinguishable from desire flashed black across the bottom of twenty-year-old Lucida's rage as she looked straight up into the lean, merciless face of the only equal she had ever met on earth.

"Bring true weights when you sail to Antioch, Lucius Cassius," Lucida whispered back, dark amber eyes unflinching in the rising red glare. "Every scale between the Tiber and the Euphrates already knows my thumb."

High overhead above the hundred-foot grey stone cliff of the **Subura Firewall**, pale March sun broke clear of purple winter cloud, catching simultaneously the gilded bronze chariot of Mars blazing atop Augustus's marble temple behind Corvus's shoulder and its blinding twin reflection glaring up out of the rainwater pool at Lucida's feet, **two fierce cold suns burning white between them across wet black stone**.

Neither bowed. Neither said farewell.

Lucida stepped smoothly back inside her curtained litter and rapped twice with emerald-and-gold toward the Ostian Gate; **Lucius Cassius Corvus** turned cleanly on iron-heeled equestrian boots and walked alone into marble light toward the Senate House, twenty years old, rich, untouchable, sworn enemies across a dividing world, with ten long years of fire, war, plague, and empire waiting before the dark came down.

Explicit Liber Primus

— ✦ —

Here ends ***By Bronze and Balance****,*
the first volume of The Ash and the Porphyry.

The chronicle continues in Book Two:
Two Suns in the West (AD 161–166).